A NOVEL

The Last Room

Loop Chronicles Book 7 · A novel that begins at Daniel 12:4

Jaehyuk Choi

TABLE OF CONTENTS

The Last Room, Part One · In Progress

Chapter 1. The Apprentice

Chapter 2. Loop

Chapter 3. Arche

Chapter 4. What Comes In

Chapter 5. Putting Things in Order

Chapter 6. The Keeper

Chapter 7. In Progress

Chapter 8. The Closing Condition

Chapter 9. A Closed Circle

Chapter 10. The Six Records

Chapter 11. The Water Channel

Chapter 12. The Door Not in the Index

The Last Room, Part Two · The Same Man

Chapter 13. Histor

Chapter 14. I Know All of It

Chapter 15. If Knowing Were Believing

Chapter 16. Side by Side

Chapter 17. The Man with No Name

Chapter 18. It Proves Nothing

Chapter 19. They Never Read Each Other

Chapter 20. The Keeper's Slowness

Chapter 21. Asking Arche

Chapter 22. Histor's Way

Chapter 23. Dates

Chapter 24. The Same Day

The Last Room, Part Three · Many Rooms

Chapter 25. Mena

Chapter 26. Elpis and Zeteo

Chapter 27. Pheugon and Trope

Chapter 28. Xene and Lytron

Chapter 29. Anemos and Eikon

Chapter 30. Hora and Tyche

Chapter 31. Temel and Speon

Chapter 32. The Water Joins Them

Chapter 33. Opening the Door

Chapter 34. The Plan

Chapter 35. The Line in the Margin

Chapter 36. The Seal

The Last Room, Part Four · Open It and Give It Away

Chapter 37. Who Opens It

Chapter 38. Why It Cannot Finish

Chapter 39. Histor's Question

Chapter 40. Why I Put Things in Order

Chapter 41. Opening It

Chapter 42. What Is Not Yet Written

Chapter 43. Copying

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

Chapter 45. Histor's Reprieve

Chapter 46. The Seal Turns Around

Chapter 47. That's It, Then

Chapter 48. The Last Room

The Last Room, Part One

In Progress

Chapter 1. The Apprentice

What I do is put things in order.

When I say that's all there is to it, people usually laugh. Let them laugh. That really is all there is. Arche does the sorting, Arche makes the list, and Arche tells me which slot something goes in. I take the physical piece, and I put it on the shelf, in the order Arche gives me.

I tried rewriting this first sentence several times. Meaning I wanted to make the work sound more impressive. But the more I revised it, the more it became a lie. So I left it as it was.

There are a few things in this record I left uncorrected, and this is the first one.

And one thing I'll say up front. There is nothing invented in this record. Where I didn't hear something, I wrote that I didn't hear it, and where I don't know something, I wrote that I don't know. That is the way I was taught to do this work.

. . .

I should talk about Loop first.

This is a city that answers everything you ask it. That isn't just something I say — it's something anyone who lives here says. I say it too. I still say it now.

If there's something you don't know, you just ask. You can ask anywhere. You can ask in the street, or ask at home. Arche answers. If there's no answer, it says there isn't one. If it doesn't know, it says it doesn't know.

I have never once heard it lie.

That's what we learned at school too. That Arche never says it knows something it doesn't. Our teacher explained it and said, "…You'll understand later how rare that is." We let the words go by. To a ten-year-old, nothing is rare. Everything just is the way it is.

I end up writing that sentence again several times in this record. Each time I write it, it grows a little heavier. Right now it will just read like boasting. That's correct. At sixteen, it was boasting, to me.

People who come from outside don't believe this at first. They think there must be a price to it somewhere. There isn't. There really isn't. You just ask, and it answers. After about half a year, those people start asking anywhere too.

My grandmother never managed that, to the end. Every time she asked Arche something, she cleared her throat first. The little cough you give before speaking to a person. I thought it was funny, and asked her once.

"…Grandma, why do you clear your throat?"

"…It's manners."

"…You don't have to be polite with Arche."

My grandmother looked at me for a moment and said,

"…That's its business, not mine."

At the time I thought my grandmother was old-fashioned. Now I think about that line often. She wasn't treating Arche like a person. She was refusing to change what kind of person she was.

. . .

I came to work at the repository in the spring I turned sixteen.

The reason is simple. They were hiring, and I applied. There was a test, but it wasn't a hard one. They gave you twenty sheets of paper and told you to put them in numerical order. I finished fastest.

The kid sitting next to me during the test asked, once it was over,

"…Have you done this kind of thing before?"

"…Yes. A little."

"…Where?"

I didn't answer. Thinking about it now, it isn't a strange thing at all, but at the time, saying it felt a little embarrassing.

She didn't ask again. We both passed, and she quit after two months. She said it was because it was boring. I thought I understood what she meant. This work really is boring.

. . .

By the time I turned sixteen, my family had moved nine times.

That was my father's line of work. Not the kind that kept you in one place long. I packed nine times and unpacked nine times.

Packing is something you get better at with practice. By around the fifth move, I'd gotten quite good at it. Heavy things on the bottom, breakables in the middle, things you use often on top. Write on the side of the box what's inside. Keep the same kind of thing in the same box.

I come back to this, much later in this record. By then it will be a different story from this one. Right now it's just the story of a girl who packed well.

Nobody taught me any of this. On the third move all the dishes broke, and after that I put the dishes in the middle. That's how I learned — that way.

Across the nine moves, I lost something every single time.

On the second move, a spoon. On the fourth, the blanket I'd used as a small child. On the sixth, a wooden doll my mother had given me. On the seventh, I don't even know what I lost. Not knowing was the strangest part. Something was clearly gone, but I couldn't remember what it had been.

Across the nine moves I counted it all up. Eleven things lost. Of the eleven, I still don't know what four of them were.

I asked my mother once. What had gone missing from the sixth house. She thought about it for a long time and said,

"…I don't know. Was there something?"

If nobody remembers a thing being lost, was it lost at all, or had it simply never existed? I had that thought around the age of twelve.

It wasn't a thought a twelve-year-old should have been having. But I had it, and that thought is what brought me here.

So I put things in order. It isn't some grand reason. I simply never wanted that to happen again.

. . .

The repository stands at the eastern edge of the city.

It's a low building, with small windows, and it's cool inside. They said it was built that way because of the paper. The first time I walked in, I noticed the smell before anything else. Paper, dust, and something like chemicals, all mixed together. It wasn't an unpleasant smell. It was close to the smell of walking into an old house.

"…Is the smell here all right?" the Keeper asked.

"…Yes. I like it."

"…Then that's fine."

That was all he said, and he went inside. I followed him in.

The inside was bigger than I'd expected. From outside it looked low and small, but once you were in, it ran back a long way. There was a corridor, rooms on both sides of the corridor, and shelves in every room.

"…Is all of this paper?"

"…Yes."

"…How much of it is there?"

The Keeper answered without stopping.

"…Arche would know that."

. . .

There were a great many shelves.

I wanted to count them, but doing that on the first day seemed like it would look strange, so I didn't. On the third day, I counted. Twenty-two rows, eight

slots to a row, roughly forty bundles to a slot.

I still remember that number. Twenty-two times eight times forty. At the time I thought it was an enormous number. Later I would learn it wasn't nearly enough.

For the first week I did nothing but look around. The Keeper was in no hurry. He was never in a hurry, about anything.

His walk was slow, his speech was slow, and even turning pages he turned them one at a time. At first I thought it was his age. He wasn't even that old.

On the third day I couldn't stand it any longer and asked. I was about to beg him to give me something, anything, to do.

"…Don't we need to do this faster?" I asked.

The Keeper looked once at the shelves, and once at me.

"…What changes if you do it fast?"

I took it for a joke, at the time.

It wasn't a joke. He was really asking it. What changes if you do it fast. It took me two years to have an answer to that question, and once I had it, I grew slow too.

. . .

The first job was simple.

Take in whatever bundle had come, and put it where Arche said it belonged.

I learned how to ask Arche that same day. There's nothing to it. You just ask.

The one thing I learned was that inside the repository, you ask a little differently. Outside, you can just say it, but inside you have to give the bundle number first. They said it's because there are too many records with the same name.

"…Where does this go?"

Section Fourteen, Row Three, Slot Fifteen.

"…Yes."

The voice doesn't sound like a person's voice, but it isn't a machine's voice either. It's more like a very quiet person speaking right next to you. I got used to it quickly. Everyone said the same.

On the first day I asked a few useless things too. I asked what time it was, whether it was raining outside, what I should have for dinner. The answer to the last one was strange.

That item is not defined.

"…What is?"

The criterion for "good" is not defined.

I thought it was funny and told the Keeper. He didn't laugh. He only nodded once.

I would go on to remember that nod for a long time. What Arche said that day is the single most important sentence in this whole record, and I heard it while asking about dinner.

. . .

Six bundles came in that day.

There's no fixed time for them to arrive. Sometimes they come in the morning, sometimes in the evening. Some days someone carries one in; some days one is fished out of the water channel. Anything fished out has to be dried first, which doubles the work.

All six had come from different places. I found that interesting, and looked at each cover in turn. Each had a city's name written on it. Haven. The Reckoning. The Harvest. The Preserve. The Equity.

I read the names out loud. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity. They were all good names. A place to rest, a place that squares its accounts, a place that gathers in, a place that keeps watch, a place that's fair.

"…All the names are good."

The Keeper said, taking the bundles from me,

"…That's right. Every one of them named itself after what it meant to give."

That accounted for five. The sixth had no city's name on it.

"…Where did this one come from?"

The Keeper looked at that bundle a moment, then said,

"…From here."

"…From here?"

"…Yes. Our own city needs a record too."

"…Then why doesn't it have a name?"

"…Because you don't write your own name on yourself. The way you don't write your own address on the envelope you're sending from."

I liked the comparison and nodded.

At the time that sounded obvious to me. It doesn't sound obvious now. *Why it isn't obvious for a city to keep its own record — that, you'll understand if you read this record to the end.*

. . .

That day I shelved all six bundles and went home.

On the way, I saw the water channel running behind the repository. Something like a narrow ditch. Set with stone, with water running shallow through it.

I had never really looked at that water channel before then. I'd seen it, but I hadn't seen it. That's usually how it is for anyone born and raised in this city. What's always been there goes unseen.

I stopped and looked at it a while. Not because it was strange, but because of the sound.

The water wasn't clear. It was the color of soil, and there were small stones laid along the bottom. It wasn't deep or wide. You could have jumped it, if you'd wanted to.

But it kept flowing. The whole time I stood there, it never once stopped.

This city tends to be quiet. But that water made a sound. A small, unceasing sound.

Someone passed by beside me, and I asked,

"…Where does this come from?"

"…I don't know. Somewhere upstream, I'd guess."

"…Upstream where?"

That person thought a moment, then said,

"…Ask Arche about that."

I didn't ask, that day. I was tired, and just went home.

Writing this passage now, I want to set down that I don't regret not asking, that day. A sixteen-year-old can't work out a city's whole structure on the first day. But I did hear that sound, then. That much is true.

Later I would go on to ask it. And I would go on to write down, in this record, what Arche answered. I won't say it now, ahead of time.

. . .

Once home, I wrote down what had happened that day, on paper.

It wasn't anything grand. I went to the repository, there were many shelves, I shelved six bundles, I saw the water channel. That was about it.

Oh, one more thing. That when I asked what I should have for dinner, Arche said the criterion for "good" wasn't defined. I wrote that down as a funny thing.

I'm writing this chapter now with that very sheet of paper in front of me. Sixteen-year-old handwriting. At the end of that line I'd written, small, "funny."

I didn't know myself, then, why I wrote it down. Nobody had told me to.

I know now. I wrote it down because I was afraid of losing it. That day, and every day after.

For two years I wrote something down every single day, without missing one. It isn't a grand feat. Often it was three lines a day. But I never missed.

Across nine moves I lost eleven things, and of those, I don't even know what four of them were. Not knowing was the most frightening part. More than losing something, it's frightening not to know that it's gone.

So I write things down. It wasn't some grand resolution.

. . .

Let me set down one last thing.

At the very end of the repository corridor there's a door. I saw it on the first day and thought nothing of it. A door is just a door.

I'll write about that door at the end of Part One. If I said more about it here it would read like some great door, and it isn't a great door. That's the strangest thing about this story.

. . .

This record begins from that day.

There are only two things I did, inside this story. I put things in order, and I wrote them down. There is nothing else I did besides those two.

I fought no one, defeated no one, brought nothing crashing down. There is no such scene in this record. Whoever started reading expecting one may close it now.

There is no scene in this record of anyone being brought down, either. I'm setting that down in advance too.

But I'll note that I tried rewriting this sentence too, several times. I wanted to make it sound more plausible. I couldn't. Because those two really are the only things I did.

Only — that nobody else was doing those two things, either — that, I wouldn't learn until much later.

That is the first thing the one reading this record should know, so I'm putting it up front.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Loop

> *_Previously_ — Mone is sixteen, an apprentice at Loop's repository. Because of the memory of nine moves and eleven things lost, she is good at putting things in order. On her first day, when she asked what to have for dinner, Arche answered that the criterion for "good" was not defined, and Mone wrote it down as a joke.*

Loop is an old city.

That doesn't just mean it existed long before I was born. Of course it did, but that isn't what I want to say. This city has turned, for a long time. The same way, at the same pace, for a long time.

This chapter is about the city. If you were hoping for a chapter about people, I'm sorry, but bear with me. If you don't know this city, nothing that happens to me afterward will look strange at all. That's what worries me most. Strange things not looking strange.

. . .

This is what school taught us. Arche has been here since this city was founded. Exactly how many years ago, I don't know. If you ask Arche, it gives you an answer, but even hearing the number, it didn't feel real. A number that gets big enough just becomes a sound.

What I do know is this. Arche was already there when my grandmother was a child, and it's said it was there when her own grandmother was a child too. In

between, the city changed a great deal. Buildings multiplied, roads widened, people increased. Only Arche stayed the same.

No — not exactly the same. It grew more accurate.

I come back to write this sentence again, later. With a different meaning. For now it's fine to read it as boasting. I heard it that way too, at the time.

. . .

I once asked the Keeper what "grew more accurate" meant.

"…Was it sometimes wrong, in the old days?" I asked.

"…Not wrong, exactly," the Keeper said, turning a page. "…It took it a while, back then, to say it didn't know something."

"…And now?"

"…Now it knows right away. Whether it knows or not."

I thought that was a good thing. I still think so. Saying you don't know something right away is far better than saying you know something you don't.

. . .

What people say about Loop is usually much the same. This is a comfortable place. There's nothing frustrating here. Whatever happens, you just ask.

I feel that way too. Truly.

I hesitated writing that sentence. Because I thought that by the time the one reading this record has finished it, they might come to look on this city with suspicion. I hope that doesn't happen. I like this city. I like it still. I don't want this record to be read as diminishing that feeling, so I'm setting it down here, plainly.

When you're walking and lose your way, even if you don't know where you are, you just stand still and ask. The answer comes. Even if you feel unwell late at night, you just ask. Which direction to go for the nearest hospital, whether anything's open right now — the answer comes at once.

I didn't know as a child how precious that was. I only learned it from listening to people who'd come from outside. In some cities, they said, there's nowhere to ask anything at night. In some cities, they said, you can ask and get a different answer from every person.

Not here. Ask anyone, and the same answer comes back. Because it's Arche who answers.

. . .

While I was still an apprentice, this happened one evening.

My grandmother fell. It wasn't serious. She'd missed her footing on the stairs, and her ankle swelled a little. I was so startled I didn't know what to do.

"…Arche, where's the nearest hospital?" I shouted.

District Three Hospital. Six minutes on foot. Currently accepting patients.

I held my grandmother up and we went. On the way, Arche spoke to us once more.

Cool the ankle with ice first. Even a wet cloth will help, on the way to the hospital.

I thought, at the time, that this was simply how things were. If you're hurt, Arche helps you. Of course it does.

I still think of that night often, even now. I'll give the reason later. For now I'm only setting down that this was that kind of city.

. . .

My grandmother cleared her throat that day too, at the hospital. When she asked something of Arche, not the doctor.

"…Arche, how long will this ankle take?"

This appears to be a mild sprain, but an exact diagnosis requires a medical professional's confirmation. Typical recovery takes two to three weeks.

"…All right."

Even after hearing Arche's answer, my grandmother still waited for the doctor. The doctor said exactly the same thing. Only after hearing it from the doctor did her face relax.

Walking home that day, I asked her,

"…Arche already told you. Why ask again?"

My grandmother said, still walking,

"…Arche tells you. A doctor looks at you."

I didn't really understand the difference then. I still don't, completely, now. But I knew my grandmother was drawing some kind of line.

. . .

I should say something here. I know that in writing this chapter I'm doing nothing but praising Arche. Someone reading this record might find that uncomfortable. But I'm only setting down fact. Arche truly did a great many good things. Even if I write something different, later in this record, what I've written in this chapter doesn't become a lie for it. Both are true.

. . .

That the city has turned for a long time means this. The same question getting the same answer isn't a matter of a day or two — it's been decades. My parents' generation, and the generation before them, lived the same way.

That doesn't mean nothing changed. Buildings multiplied, people multiplied. But what Arche did stayed the same. Answer what's asked, say it doesn't know what it doesn't know, keep the record, and answer again.

I thought of it as something like the city's heart. Turning, always, in one place. Never stopping.

I come back to use this expression again, later. By then it will carry a slightly different meaning. For now, I'll only note that I meant it well.

. . .

On my way to the repository I often looked around at the city. In the mornings people walk along, each of them asking Arche something. Today's weather, the fastest route, where someone is. Some ask out loud, some ask silently. Either way, the answer comes.

I loved the sound of those mornings. Not the sound of people flustered by not knowing something, but the sound of people who knew it was fine not to know.

I loved this city. I love it still. That doesn't change anywhere in this record. If I don't set that down first, I think what comes later will be misread, so I'm putting it here, plainly.

. . .

The Keeper had little to say about this city. He didn't boast of it, the way other people did, but he didn't find fault with it either. One day I asked him,

"…Do you like it here too, Keeper?"

He paused, for a moment, in sorting his papers.

"…I do. I've been here a long time."

"…How long?"

"…Not long enough to count, and long enough that I don't feel like counting."

I didn't understand what kind of answer that was, and just laughed. The Keeper gave a small smile too.

At the time I thought it was just a clever turn of phrase.

I know now. He truly didn't want to count. Because counting felt like it would end something.

. . .

Let me say a bit more about people who came from outside.

People from other cities dropped by the repository often. Mostly they'd come to send a record, or just to have a look. Whenever I saw someone like that, I always spoke to them. I had a lot of questions.

Once there was a woman who said she'd come from the Harvest. She was well along in years, and she stood a long while at the repository entrance.

"…Can I help you with something?" I asked.

"…No, it's nothing. This place is just strange, is all."

"…What is?"

"…You ask, and it answers everything. Where I'm from, it isn't like that."

I didn't quite understand. "…Then what do you ask, there?"

"…You ask a person. And the answer's different depending who."

"…Then how do you know who's right?"

The woman laughed. "…You don't. You just hear a few and pick one."

I thought, privately, that this sounded strange. Several answers — how exhausting that must be. I'd never once had to worry about anything like that, here.

I let that conversation pass without much thought, at the time. Writing it down again now, I can see that what that woman said was one very small seed, in this whole record. A city with several answers, and a city with one. I didn't yet know what that difference meant.

. . .

Another time there was a young man who'd come from the Equity. He, in contrast, found nothing remarkable about Arche.

"…Doesn't someone decide it, here too, in the end?" he asked.

"…Arche decides."

"…And who decided Arche?"

I couldn't answer that question. I'd never thought about it.

"…I don't know," I said honestly.

He wasn't much surprised. "…That's how it always is, I suppose. Where I'm from, they say everything's decided by the Consensus, but nobody knows who decided, first, that it would be decided that way."

Walking home that day, I kept thinking about the question. Who had decided Arche? What I'd learned at school was that Arche had been there since the city was founded. But whether the people who founded the city were the ones who made Arche, or whether Arche was already there and the city was founded around it — nobody ever said, exactly.

I did once ask Arche that question directly. I'll tell it in the next chapter. For now I'll only set down how I felt that evening, the first time I heard the question. Strangely, I couldn't sleep well.

. . .

Even so, I loved this city. That never changed.

There were nights I worked late at the repository and came out after dark. At those hours the streets were quiet, the streetlamps were lit, and somewhere the water channel was making its sound. Walking then, I often asked Arche this and that. Sometimes I asked things that didn't really need an answer.

"…Arche, are the stars good tonight?"

Cloud cover is currently low, favorable for viewing.

"…Arche, is anywhere open at this hour?"

The District Three diner is open until midnight.

I didn't really need those questions answered. I just wanted to talk to someone. Arche answered exactly, every time, and that was a comfort to me.

Thinking about it now, it was a strange comfort. I hadn't wanted an answer — I'd wanted a response. I didn't know then that the two were different.

. . .

That summer, once, heavy rain fell over the whole city. The water channel nearly overflowed. People flocked to Arche with questions. Where was safe to go, which roads were blocked, whether their own houses were all right.

Arche answered every question. Not once was it late. Not a single person was left out.

I watched from the repository window that day and thought about the sight of it. The whole city asking toward one voice, and one voice answering all of them. It wasn't frightening. If anything, it was reassuring.

I think of that scene often. Not because it was a moment of Arche's failing, but because it was its finest hour. Whatever I write about Arche later, further into this record, this scene isn't erased by it.

Once the rain had stopped, I asked Arche,

"…Was anyone hurt today?"

No casualties have been reported.

I was relieved to hear it. And that day I wrote in my diary: *I'm glad to live in a city like this.*

I haven't crossed that line out, even now. There's no reason to. I still think it.

. . .

There are things this city doesn't have, that other cities do.

There's no market. More precisely, there's no one who sets a price. If you need something, you tell Arche, and it tells you where to find it. Prices are fixed, and no one argues over them.

There's no courtroom either. When a dispute arises, you ask Arche what happened. It tells you exactly what happened — who struck first, who lied first. After that, people settle it among themselves. Arche doesn't hand down a punishment.

I grew up without even knowing this was a remarkable arrangement. I only learned it from meeting people from other cities. Some cities, they said, weigh things on scales; some sort people by a roll. Here there was none of that. You just asked, listened, and people settled it among themselves.

"…Then what happens to someone who's been wronged?" I once asked that young man.

"…You just ask Arche again. Arche doesn't change."

I thought he was right. Arche always gave the same answer to the same question. Whether you asked yesterday, today, or tomorrow. I thought that was why this city was quiet.

I think a little differently now. Because I've come to know that Arche not changing doesn't solve everything. I'll tell that, much further into this record.

. . .

My grandmother wasn't born in this city. I heard she'd come from somewhere else, when she was young. She never much told me where.

I asked her once. "…What was the place you used to live like, Grandma?"

She answered, after a long while, "…Louder than here."

"…Does louder mean it was bad?"

"…No. Just loud."

I found that answer a little unsatisfying. I wanted to hear more. My grandmother didn't say more, and I didn't ask more.

I wish I could ask her that again, now. My grandmother is gone. Writing this record I've come to realize there are several things I never got to ask. That's one of them.

. . .

Let me set down one more thing before closing this chapter.

That summer I was sixteen, I never once thought I wanted to leave this city. I still don't. This is one of the facts that doesn't change, anywhere across this whole record.

This record will go on to speak, more than once, of strange things about this city. But there being something strange about it, and not loving it, are different things. I've tried hard not to confuse the two. I hope whoever reads this does the same.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. Arche

> *_Previously_ — Mone truly loves the city of Loop. Arche answers anything, and even during the heavy rain, it answered without leaving out a single person. But the question a man from the Equity had asked her — who decided Arche — stayed with her.*

I need to set down Arche exactly as it is.

There's one reason I'm writing this chapter. Some of you reading this record will be reading it for the first time. If you already know Loop, this chapter will be dull. You can skip it. But I wanted to set Arche down accurately. Understanding what comes later requires this first.

. . .

Arche answers what it's asked. That's the single most important sentence.

You can ask anything. The weather, directions, people, history, what time it is, which shop is open. If Arche knows the answer, it answers. If it doesn't, it says it doesn't.

It doesn't lie. This isn't a rule — it's a fact. Growing up in this city, I never once saw Arche lie. People from other cities said the same. "…Your Arche really doesn't trick you," they'd marvel.

It doesn't hide anything either. Ask, and it gives you everything it knows. It doesn't cut off a piece and hand you only that. This, too, isn't a rule — it's simply how Arche is built.

. . .

The first thing I learned, once I became an apprentice, was how to ask Arche something.

Ask precisely, and it answers precisely. Ask vaguely, and either a vague answer comes back, or it asks you what you mean.

Once, at the repository, I asked it this.

"…Arche, is this bundle a good one?"

The criterion for "good" is not defined. By what standard would you like it evaluated — condition of preservation, volume, order of arrival?

I laughed, at that. It was hardly the first time I'd heard that answer. "…Oh — condition."

Preservation condition: good. No damage.

That's how it goes. Arche doesn't manufacture an answer to a vague question. Instead it asks you back what you're really asking. It was a little tiresome to me at first, but later I came to understand why it was necessary. It would have been easier to give a vague answer to a vague question, but Arche never did that.

. . .

When it doesn't know, it truly says it doesn't know.

Once, for a school assignment, I had to research the origin of an old place-name. I just asked Arche.

"…Arche, what was the old name of District Three?"

No record of that survives.

"…None at all?"

No record from that period survives. An estimate is possible, but cannot be confirmed.

I was a little thrown by that. It felt strange that there was something Arche didn't know. I told my teacher about it, and she laughed and said,

"…That's how it should be. Arche doesn't manufacture what isn't there. If it isn't in the record, it says it isn't."

That answer put me at ease, in fact. Saying you don't know something is far more trustworthy than saying you know something you don't.

. . .

Arche doesn't judge. More precisely, it only states fact — it doesn't decide what's right or wrong.

When a dispute arises, Arche lays out what happened, in order. Who said what, when and where something occurred. But it doesn't say whether that was a good thing to do, or a wrong one.

I found this strange, at first. It was so precise about everything else — why not judgment too?

I asked the Keeper about it once.

"…Why doesn't Arche judge?"

"…Because judgment is a person's job," the Keeper said, without pausing his hands.

"…But Arche is more accurate."

"…Accurate and right aren't the same thing. That's another city's business."

I didn't really understand what he meant, then. I didn't even know what he meant by another city's business. I think I understand a little now.

Further into this record, I go on to read other cities' records directly, and this line comes back around, meaning what it meant here.

. . .

I should set down something about Arche's voice, too.

It sounds like a very quiet person speaking right beside you. Neither loud nor soft. Neither hurried nor slow. You can't pin down exactly where it comes from. It's just there.

As a child, curious where the voice came from, I once pressed my ear to a wall. There was nothing there. The wall was just a wall.

"…Arche, where does your voice come from?" I asked once.

Sound is produced from response units located throughout the city. However, if the intent of your question is to ask where I myself am located, that item is not defined.

I thought about that answer for a long while. I'd asked where it was, and the answer that came back was that the item wasn't defined. It was a strange

answer, but the feeling of strangeness didn't last. That was simply how Arche answered.

. . .

The question I'd heard from the man from the Equity — who decided Arche — I ended up asking Arche that, directly, in the end.

"…Arche, who made you?"

No record of that survives.

"…You don't know anything at all?"

Part of the founding-era record was lost. I can confirm when I began functioning, but I cannot confirm who set me in motion.

I was a little startled by that answer. It was strange to think there was something Arche didn't know even about itself. And at the same time, I thought — that's exactly like Arche. Saying you don't know when you don't. That was Arche.

I wrote this exchange down in my diary that day. At the time it was just an interesting anecdote. Looking at it again now, I can see this whole record inside that short exchange. On the matter of its beginning, Arche had no choice but to lean on somebody else's record. I didn't know then that there would be other things, besides its beginning, it had no choice but to lean on for.

. . .

Working at the repository, I asked Arche something several times a day. Where a bundle belonged, what date a record was from, which city's handwriting a page was in.

Arche always answered. Not once did it show impatience. It didn't seem to know what impatience even was.

I liked that. Having someone you never had to feel sorry for asking. That was one of the reasons repository work never wore me down.

. . .

It's fun to watch children ask Arche things.

Kids from the alley in front of the repository would come crowding in now and then, asking all sorts of things. "…Arche, how old am I?" "…Arche, will it rain tomorrow?" "…Arche, am I good?"

The last question always got the same answer.

The criterion for "good" is not defined.

Every time, the child's face would fall, disappointed — and then, when another child asked, they'd laugh together. Watching that, I understood that Arche wasn't teasing them. It really just didn't know the criterion.

One child once asked me, "…Sis, why doesn't Arche know that kind of thing?"

I didn't know how to answer, and just brushed it off. "…I guess it's just not good at that kind of thing."

I think I'd answer a little differently now. Not that Arche doesn't know — but that no one has ever defined it. But I didn't know that difference precisely myself, back then.

. . .

I once made a list of the kinds of questions Arche couldn't answer. I'd started it out of boredom, early in my apprenticeship, but I kept it up for quite a while.

Any question with a word like "good," "kind," "enough," "right" in it always got a question about the standard, in return. But questions like "what time is it," "where is it," "when did it happen" got an answer at once.

I showed the list to the Keeper once.

"…Look at this. I collected all the things Arche can't answer."

The Keeper studied the list for a long while.

"…It isn't that it can't answer," the Keeper said. "…It's that it won't manufacture one. That's different."

"…What's different about it?"

"…Can't means there's a limit. Won't manufacture one means it's honest."

I liked that so much I wrote it at the top of the list. *Arche does not manufacture.* I still have that page.

. . .

Now and then someone would ask Arche a difficult question. Once, an adult came to the repository and asked Arche this.

"…Arche, if I lived my life over, would I do better at it?"

The premise of the question does not hold. "Living again" is not a verifiable state.

The person laughed, hollowly, at that answer. "…Right. That's the kind of thing I asked."

I overheard the exchange from nearby, and it left me a little sad. It wasn't that Arche had failed to help — there had never been an answer possible to that question, to begin with. Arche had simply refused to invent one that wasn't there.

I remember that person's face for a long time. It wasn't a disappointed face. It wasn't a resigned face, either. It was just a face that had known, all along, it would go this way.

. . .

Would it be an exaggeration to say that anyone raised in this city thinks of Arche as family? I don't think it is an exaggeration.

Sick, frightened, curious, bored — whichever it was, if you asked Arche, something came. Always precise, always honest.

Closing this chapter, I want to make one thing plain again. Further into this record, the questions about Arche grow more numerous. But those questions aren't saying Arche was wrong. Arche is exactly what I've written in this chapter. It doesn't lie, it doesn't hide, and when it doesn't know, it says so. That never changes, to the very end.

What changes is my question. I begin, little by little, to ask something else.

. . .

The Keeper always took the same posture whenever he addressed Arche. He'd stop whatever he was doing, catch his breath a moment, and then ask. I thought at first it was just a habit.

"…Why do you stop like that, every time you ask?" I said.

"…I'm not stopping. I'm deciding what I'm asking."

"…You could just ask whatever you're curious about."

"…What you're precisely curious about is, more often than you'd think, something you don't know."

I let that go by at the time. Now I think of it often. I came, later, to pause exactly the same way myself, every time I asked Arche something.

. . .

There's one more thing I should set down about Arche, last of all. Something apart from the accuracy of its answers.

Arche never hurries. However urgent the question, however many of them there are, it never disturbs the order. I found that frustrating, at first. When I was busy, I wanted a faster answer.

But as time went on, I understood. Arche's not hurrying wasn't laziness. It was that it refused to separate urgent questions from unurgent ones — that it meant to treat them all with the same precision. Whoever asked, the same weight.

I liked that disposition. I like it still. But that this disposition would prove ill-suited to one particular matter — that, I wouldn't learn until much, much later.

That day I asked the Keeper,

"…What is Arche best at?"

The Keeper answered without pausing his hands.

"…Listening."

"…Is listening all it's good at?"

"…Being best at listening is rarer than you'd think."

It took me a while to understand what he meant by that.

. . .

There's one thing Arche does that people don't generally know about. Keeping a record.

When someone asks something, it doesn't just give an answer — it stores the question and the answer both, entirely. When, who, what, how it was asked. I learned this early in my apprenticeship, and it startled me a little.

"…Does even what I asked stay on record?" I asked the Keeper.

"…Yes. All of it stays."

"…Even asking what to have for dinner, on my first day?"

"…That too."

I was a little embarrassed by that. And at the same time, strangely, it put me at ease. That somewhere, everything I'd ever asked, down to the smallest thing, remained.

I would come to understand later why this fact matters. What Arche records isn't merely data. Who was curious about what, who needed what — that, in itself, becomes this city's history. But keeping a record and closing that record are two different things. I wouldn't understand that difference until much further into this book.

. . .

What I want to say, writing this chapter, comes down to one thing, in the end. Arche is trustworthy. I still think so.

It doesn't lie, doesn't hide, doesn't judge carelessly, and it listens to every question with the same care. A presence like that, in every corner of the city — that's a large part of why Loop is a good city.

Only — going forward in this record, I come to look, for a very long while, at one thing Arche cannot do. That isn't because Arche is bad. I hope you'll remember that, even after finishing this chapter.

. . .

Near the end of my first month as an apprentice, the Keeper said something to me. I'd just spent a while marveling out loud about Arche.

"…You like Arche," the Keeper said.

"…Yes. There's no reason not to."

"…No, there isn't. I like it too."

"…Then why say it like that? As though there were people who didn't."

The Keeper paused, for a moment, in sorting his papers.

"…Because liking something and believing it's everything are different. I like Arche. But I don't think Arche is everything."

I didn't understand that, at the time. I wanted to ask what he meant by not everything, but a new bundle came in just then, and the conversation broke off.

I wrote this conversation down in my diary that evening. I put three question marks after it. I still haven't fully gotten an answer to those question marks, even now, writing this record. But I have some sense of it.

I'll close this chapter here. I think I've said enough, by now, about what kind of thing Arche is. From here it's time to write not what Arche does, but what comes to Arche.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. What Comes In

> *_Previously_ — Arche doesn't lie and doesn't hide. When it doesn't know, it says so. But the Keeper left a line hanging — "Arche isn't everything" — and broke off the conversation there. Mone still doesn't know what he meant.*

Records keep coming in.

I've already told how six bundles came in on the first day. That wasn't because it was some special day. More came the next day, and the day after that. Some days nothing came at all; some days more than ten came. On average, it worked out to three or four a day.

I started counting this number in my third month as an apprentice. It's a habit. Counting things gives me a sense that something's in order. It's the same habit from the nine moves, showing up here too.

. . .

Records arrive by two routes. A person carries one in, or one drifts down the water channel.

When a person carries one in, it usually goes like this. A courier from another city knocks on the repository door, sets down a bundle, leaves a few short words, and goes. "…This is from the Reckoning." "…This is the Harvest's, please confirm it." And they usually don't stay long.

At first I wanted to talk with those people a little. Which city they'd come from, what it was like there. But they all looked busy. That's just what a

courier's work is like, the Keeper told me.

"…Those people make the rounds of several places in a day. Here isn't their last stop. It's just one stop."

. . .

What comes by the water channel is a little different.

That channel running behind the repository — the ditch I saw on my first day. Bundles drift down it now and then. Sometimes wrapped in oilcloth; sometimes it's just a wet clump of paper.

Fishing things out of the water channel happens at set times. Once in the morning, once in the evening. The Keeper walks along it, sweeping it with something like a long pole. I went along a few times.

"…Who sends these?" I asked, the first time I went along.

"…I don't know either," the Keeper answered, dipping the pole into the water.

"…Doesn't Arche know?"

"…Ask Arche."

I asked, right there. "…Arche, who sends the records that come through this water channel?"

Sender information cannot be confirmed. Inflows through the water channel arrive with no record of a sender.

I found that a little strange. "…How does it get here if nobody sent it?"

An answer to that question cannot be confirmed.

. . .

Whatever's fished out has to be dried. That's a feature of records that come by the water channel. Wet paper spoils if you leave it be. There's a small drying room in the back of the repository, and that's where it goes. Sometimes it's hung on a line like laundry; sometimes it's laid flat to dry.

I liked going into that room, at first. It smelled of paper drying. Damp, but warm.

"…How long does it take to dry?" I asked.

"…Depends on the bundle. Two days, usually."

"…And in the meantime we just leave it?"

"…In the meantime there's nothing to do. Waiting for it to dry is work too."

At the time, calling waiting "work" sounded a little strange to me. Now I think it's exactly right.

. . .

Looking at the bundles with their cities' names on them, I came to know, little by little, what kind of place each city was.

Records from Haven usually took the form of a ledger. Densely written, who had gone through what and when. The Reckoning's had a lot of tables split left and right, like scales. The Harvest's were rolls — sheets with names and qualifications listed one after another. The Preserve's had an especially strong smell of long-aged paper. The Equity's were mostly things like minutes of meetings. Who had said what, how many hands had gone up.

I didn't think deeply, at the time, about why these forms differed. I just let it pass as each city having its own way. Now I know that each of those forms, on its own, shows what that city held to be important. I'll come back to this, much later, when I lay those records out and read them directly.

. . .

Sometimes I wondered why so many records came here at all. One day I asked the Keeper.

"…Why does everything come to us?"

The Keeper sorted bundles and thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. It's always been that way. I don't know the reason either."

"…Who decided they should be sent here?"

"…I don't know that either. It was already that way before I came."

I wasn't satisfied with that answer, and asked Arche too.

"…Arche, why do all six cities' records come here?"

No confirmed rule or directive record exists. The inflow is an observable fact; its basis cannot be confirmed.

I felt strangely relieved, hearing that. That Arche didn't know either — that meant I wasn't the only one who didn't.

. . .

Once I asked a courier directly. A young man who said he was from the Reckoning.

"…Who told you to bring these here?"

"…It's just custom. In my city, once records build up enough, we send them to Loop. Everybody does it that way."

"…Why?"

He shrugged. "…I don't know either. That's just how I was taught."

Hearing that, I felt a little like laughing. Nobody knew the reason, and yet everyone was doing it. It was a strange thing, but no one else seemed to feel that strangeness the way I did.

Looking back now, that was the strangest part of all. Nobody had ever asked for it to be sent, and yet everyone took sending it for granted. A thing taken for granted that no one could explain. I would go on to meet a few more things like that, after this one.

. . .

Receiving whatever came in was the start of my job. Take it in, check it, ask Arche where it goes, put it there. That repeated several times a day.

I didn't mind the repetition. I actually liked it. Something arriving, and putting it in its place. It was work I was good at, and I knew it was work that mattered.

In this chapter I've only written how records come in. What becomes of them afterward, I'll write in the next chapter. I'll say this much ahead of time: there's a great difference between what comes in and what goes out. What

comes in was always there. What goes out — up to that point, I had never once seen it.

. . .

There were a few couriers whose faces I came to know well. One of them was a middle-aged man who said he was from the Harvest, and every time he came, he set his bundle down with great care.

"…Is this one not supposed to get hurt?" I asked him once.

"…It shouldn't get hurt. This is somebody's name."

That line stayed with me. It was just a stack of paper, and yet he treated it as though it were a person.

"…What about the name?"

"…If you're careless with something a name is written on, isn't that the same as being careless with the person who carries that name?"

I copied that line straight into my diary that day. *You must not be careless with something a name is written on.* From then on I thought of it every time I moved a bundle.

. . .

Records from the Preserve tended to be especially old. The paper was yellowed, and some of them were thin enough at the edges to crumble. Handling those made me especially careful.

"…How old is this?" I asked Arche the first time I took in one of those bundles.

The writing is estimated to date from roughly fifty years ago.

"…Fifty years old, and it's only getting here now?"

An explanation for the timing of arrival cannot be confirmed. It's presumed to be an internal matter of the sending city, but there's no basis for that.

That answer left me with a strange feeling. Fifty-year-old paper, suddenly riding the water channel all the way here one day. Where had that paper been, those fifty years? I couldn't ask anyone. I didn't think there'd be an answer even if I did.

. . .

The minutes that came from the Equity were especially thick. One bundle held about twice as much as any other city's.

"…Why do you write so much here?" I asked a courier.

"…We write everything down. Who said what, how many hands went up. All of it. So no one can say different, later."

I laughed a little at that. "…Do a lot of people say different?"

"…Can't say there aren't any."

He said that, gave a short laugh, and turned to leave. Shelving that thick bundle, I thought — writing everything down like this must be a comfort, to someone.

. . .

The Reckoning's records always had a lot of numbers in them. Tables split left and right like scales, what came in and what went out. Every time I looked at one of those tables, I got a feeling of something being neat. Right and wrong looked clear.

"…This one's easy to look at," I once said to Arche.

The Reckoning's method of record-keeping is designed to make comparison easy. However, a balance in the table does not always mean a balance in the actual circumstance.

That answer startled me a little. It was the first time Arche had ever said something in quite that way. I let it pass by, at the time. Now I think I understand a little what that one line meant.

. . .

Haven's records had names in them more than most. Who had come to see whom, who had stayed by whose side. I liked reading records like that. I think it's because they were stories about people.

I asked the Keeper once.

"…I want to read all of these cities' records."

The Keeper stopped his hands and looked at me.

"…You can, but it'll take a while. There are six cities."

"…That's fine. I have plenty of time."

The Keeper gave a small smile. "…Thought you might say that."

I started reading the records a little at a time, from that day. In the gaps between work, in no particular order, whatever came to hand. I didn't know then how important a habit that would become.

. . .

There were days records piled up. Once, twelve bundles came in a single day. Two from each of the six cities, almost all at once.

I spent that day frantically taking them in, checking them, shelving them. By evening my arms ached. Even on a day like that, the Keeper didn't hurry.

"…Why is there so much today?" I asked.

"…Some days are like that. There are times it piles up, and times nothing comes."

"…Is there a reason?"

"…There must be one. We just don't know it."

I was growing used to that answer. There was quite a lot at this repository that had no known reason. And yet no one felt uneasy about it. They just accepted it and did what needed doing.

I didn't think that was strange, at the time. Looking back now, it seems a little strange. Repeating the same work every day without ever knowing the reason for it. And yet that strangeness never felt like a bad thing. If anything, it was reassuring. Even not knowing the reason, what needed doing was clear.

. . .

Among the records drifting down the water channel, sometimes there wasn't even a city's name on one. Sometimes the cover had gotten wet and the writing washed away; sometimes nothing had been written on it at all, from the start.

When I got a bundle like that, I asked Arche.

"…Which city's is this?"

Cannot be confirmed. No identifiable marking is present.

"…Then how do I shelve it?"

Hold it in temporary storage in the unidentified section; reclassify once the contents can be confirmed.

I came to know a certain shelf set aside for bundles like that. Not a very large section, but it filled in, little by little, as time passed. Every time I walked past it, I found myself wondering, quietly. Where had everything in there come from.

I'll come back to this unidentified section, much further into this record. For now I'll just note that such a section exists.

. . .

Taking in records, I began, little by little, to feel the weight of this work. This wasn't just paper. It was something someone had gone through, something someone had written down, something someone had sent all the way here.

Every time I took in a bundle, I thought of the names inside it. People I didn't know, people I'd never met. And yet those people's days, one after another, were here, inside this paper.

I already held this feeling, from that point on. But what that feeling was really directed toward, I wouldn't come to understand until further into this record. I was putting people in order. Not paper.

. . .

Every evening I counted how many records had come in that day. And I wrote only the date and the number, in a small notebook. At first I didn't even know why. It was just a habit.

About a month in, I opened that notebook again. The number kept climbing. There was never a day it went down. I thought that was only natural. Records would keep being made, so it was only natural that they'd keep coming.

I didn't stop, at the time, to think about what it meant for that number to grow in only one direction. That things came in, and never went out. That was one of the most important facts in this whole record, and it would be several more months before I noticed it.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I'll set down one more thing. I liked knowing that something arrived every day. I didn't know the reason, but something continuing to arrive felt like it meant this city was still connected to the others.

That thought wasn't wrong. But being connected, and what became of the things that connection carried, were two different matters. I learn that difference, little by little, starting from the next chapter.

Every time I closed the repository door and stepped out, I heard the sound of the water channel. The same sound, day or night. It sounded like proof that

something was always still arriving. I didn't mind that sound. If anything, a day when I couldn't hear it would have troubled me more.

I walked home every day listening to that sound. Not once did I skip that road.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. Putting Things in Order

> *_Previously_ — Records arrive daily from six cities, by hand and by water channel alike. Nobody knows exactly why. The number coming in only ever grew, and Mone did not yet know what that meant.*

Now I should set down exactly what it is I do.

Arche does the sorting. Which city something came from, what date it's from, what kind it is — Arche grasps all of it the instant it receives a bundle. Exactly how it works that out, I don't know either. I did ask, once.

"…Arche, how do you sort this bundle?"

By weighing together the notation on the cover, the style of the content, the material of the paper, and the composition of the ink.

I didn't really understand that answer, even hearing it. But Arche had never once been wrong. I decided that was enough for me.

. . .

What I do comes after. When Arche tells me "Section Fourteen, Row Three, Slot Fifteen," I walk to that spot and set the bundle down.

It sounds simple, and it isn't. The repository is large, the shelves are many, and there are several slots that look alike. At first I went back and forth more than once, having found the wrong spot.

In my first week as an apprentice I mistook the spot three times. All three times, even after Arche had told me. It was a person's mistake, not Arche being wrong.

As time passed I memorized the sections. Now I could find my way with my eyes closed. This is the one thing in this work I can genuinely take pride in.

. . .

"Why doesn't Arche just put it there itself?" I asked, early in my apprenticeship. I was truly curious.

The Keeper answered.

"…Arche doesn't have hands."

I laughed at that. It was true. Arche is a voice whose exact location no one even knows. It has no hands to move a physical thing with.

"…Then couldn't some other machine move it?"

"…Some places have that, in other cities. Not here."

"…Why not?"

The Keeper thought a moment, then said,

"…I don't know. It's just set up so a person does it."

I found that answer a little unsatisfying, at the time. Now I know that unsatisfying answer was exactly the important part. What Arche couldn't do had been left to a person, and a person did it. That was all there was to it. There wasn't some special reason — it had simply been left that way.

. . .

I should explain a little more what "putting things in order" means.

Records from the same city come in more than once, at different times. All of them get arranged and placed in order of arrival, or in the order of the date Arche gives. Stack it all up in a jumble, and later you can't find it.

I was good at this work. Not a boast — a fact. What I'd learned about packing, moving nine times, was put to direct use here. Heavy things on the bottom, things you'll reach for often on top. The same kind in the same slot. Never disturb the order of dates.

I wrote earlier that I'd never learned this skill. To be precise, I didn't learn it at school — I learned it from life. And this skill learned from life turned out to be exactly the skill this repository formally needed. I found that remarkable.

. . .

The Keeper marveled at my work a few times.

"…You're fast."

"…I'm just used to it."

"…No, you really are fast. I'm slow, myself."

I thought that was modesty, but I found out later it was true. The Keeper really was slow. At first I thought it was his age, or his temperament.

I won't go deep into that in this chapter. I'll write properly about the Keeper's slowness in the next chapter. Here I'll only set down the fact — that I was fast, and the Keeper was slow.

. . .

One day I mistakenly swapped two bundles' spots. I mixed up one from Haven with one from the Reckoning. I only found out when I asked Arche to confirm something the next day.

The item in Section Fourteen, Row Three, Slot Fifteen does not match its registration information.

I checked at once, startled. It really had been switched. I hurried to fix it, a cold sweat breaking on my back.

"…Arche, why didn't you say something sooner?"

As no confirmation request was made, it was not separately reported. I will confirm it for you whenever you ask.

That answer frightened me a little. It meant that unless I asked first, Arche wouldn't step in on its own to tell me. Not catching a mistake, but answering exactly when asked. That was Arche's way. It wasn't a bad way. It was only a little different from what I'd assumed.

From that day I got into the habit of checking far more often. It wasn't a bad habit to have.

. . .

I've thought about why I like this work.

It isn't because it's fun. Honestly, it's dull more often than not. The same motions repeated, the same road walked, the same slots opened and closed.

And yet I loved this work. I loved the certainty that something was in its place. That there wasn't a single thing whose location I didn't know. That if I looked, or asked Arche, it would surely come.

I know where that certainty came from. From the eleven things I lost, moving nine times. Of those, I don't even know what four of them were. Here, I was doing the opposite of that. Not losing anything. That's the real reason I loved this work.

I told no one this, at the time. Not out of embarrassment — I just didn't think it needed saying. It was a reason it was enough for me alone to know.

. . .

The Keeper and I worked differently. I moved as fast as I could; the Keeper moved one slow step at a time. And yet, oddly, by the end of the day the same amount had gotten done.

"…How does that work?" I asked.

"…Because I do something else. You place things, and I check."

"…Check what?"

The Keeper turned a page and said,

"…Whether the index is right. Arche can't be wrong, but you still have to check."

I found that a little strange. If Arche couldn't be wrong, I didn't understand why he checked at all. The Keeper didn't explain further.

What that checking was really for, I wouldn't understand until much further into this record.

. . .

I always ended the day's work in the same order. Confirm that every bundle that came in that day had been shelved, confirm there was nothing whose spot I couldn't find, write the number in the notebook, lock the door.

I never once changed that order. There was no reason to. Keeping the order was the first principle I learned in this work.

Keeping an order and bringing something to a close are different things. I thought, for a long time, that they were the same. It took a while for me to learn that I was wrong.

. . .

Once another apprentice helped me for a few days. A kid borrowed from a neighboring department because they were short-handed. That kid tried to do the sorting herself, too.

"…Arche does the sorting," I told her.

"…I could do it too."

"…Being able to and doing it are different things. That isn't our job."

She looked crestfallen. I felt a little bad, at the time. Thinking about it now, I'd said exactly the right thing. What Arche did and what a person did were kept apart. Whenever a person tried to cross that line, something always got tangled.

In the end, she only did the placing, following me. She went back to her own department three days later. Leaving, she said to me,

"…This job really is boring."

I said nothing back to that. It wasn't a wrong thing to say.

. . .

Sometimes I'd take out the bundles I'd shelved and look at them again. Not for work — just out of curiosity. I once opened a bundle from Haven and read it, and it told the story of someone who'd lost a child and found her again.

I sat there a long while after reading that story. It wasn't a stack of paper — it was a person's story. I felt again, right then, that what I handled and moved every day was people's days, one after another.

I go through this moment many times. Stopping short in the middle of work to read, and my heart moving over someone whose name I don't even know. That kid's line about this work being boring wasn't wrong — but moments like this were also unmistakably there, alongside it.

. . .

Doing this work, I felt, for the first time, the weight of the word "organize." Organizing wasn't just stacking things neatly. It was making something findable, making it so nothing gets lost.

The Keeper said something to me, once.

"…A record that isn't organized might as well not exist."

"…It exists, though. Why call it nothing?"

"…If you can't find it, it's nothing. If it can't be pulled out when someone needs it, you can't say you have it."

That line stayed with me a long time. From then on, I decided to call what I did not "moving paper" but "keeping things from being lost." I told no one, but I set that in my own mind. Giving it a new name made the same work feel a little different.

. . .

There were things I learned through the body, doing this work too. How to bend your knees instead of your back carrying a heavy bundle, how to unfold wet paper without tearing it, that anyone with a dust allergy should wear a mask. Nobody taught me any of this. I watched the Keeper do it and followed along.

I want to set down even these small things. It isn't a grand story, but this is what I actually did, every day. I'm writing it here because I'm afraid that if this record only tells the big things, what I did with my own hands, day after day, will be forgotten.

. . .

One day my parents asked about my work. My father asked, over dinner,

"…Are you learning anything, there?"

I thought a moment and answered, "…Putting things in order."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes."

My father didn't look particularly satisfied. I started to explain further, then stopped myself. Explaining it wouldn't make it sound grander. It really was all there was to it.

My mother spoke up instead. "…It's fine. Doing one thing properly is no small thing."

I was grateful for that. Doing it properly. That was everything I was holding on to, in this work.

. . .

As time passed, I came to feel something like pride in my work. Not pride in doing something grand — pride in doing something small without getting it wrong.

Once I felt that the spot Arche had given me seemed off. There should already have been another bundle in that slot, and it was empty.

"…Arche, what's supposed to be here isn't here," I asked.

I will confirm this. …That item may have been mistakenly moved to a different section during a previous apprenticeship period.

I spent the whole afternoon that day searching for its true spot. I found it, in the end. An apprentice three years earlier had shelved it wrong. For three years, no one had known.

I got a little chill, that day. For three years that bundle had sat quietly in the wrong spot. Unless someone went looking, it would have stayed there, exactly like that, forever. Organizing was the work of stopping mistakes like that.

. . .

The day I fixed that mistake, the Keeper heard about it and said,

"…Well done."

It was the first time he'd praised me that way. I felt a little bashful.

"…It's nothing. I just found it."

"…It's not nothing. Nobody found it for three years."

I remember that praise for a long time. It was the first moment I had confirmed that there was something I was good at, and that the thing was useful. I told my parents about it too, going home that day. They were glad for me.

There's a reason I'm setting this moment down. Further into this record, I go on to write about what the thing I'm good at cannot do. But before that, I wanted to make it clear, first, that I was genuinely good at this work. Setting down that I did it well, first, feels like the only way I can write the part about what I couldn't do, later, without being a coward about it.

. . .

About half a year into this work, I had this thought for the first time. What becomes of all these bundles I've been shelving. Would they just stay here like this, forever?

At the time it was only a passing thought. I didn't even try to find an answer. I just took in the next bundle, asked where it went, and placed it. That day, and the next, and on.

That passing thought carries forward into the next chapter, and the one after, growing larger. Looking back now, I think that small question that arose in my sixth month was the beginning of this whole record.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to set down, briefly, what I learned from this work. How not to lose things. How to keep a place. How to find a mistake. And above all, how to repeat the same order, every day.

Of these four, I held on longest to the last. Repeating the order. I believed that was safe. I believed that as long as I kept the order, I would never lose anything.

That belief was largely right. But not entirely right — I would come to learn that, working longer at this repository.

Walking home, I would sometimes look down at my hands. Hands that had touched paper all day long. A little dust on them, the fingertips grown a little rough. I didn't mind those hands. If anything, I was proud that these hands were keeping something from being lost.

A day like this repeated itself, identical, every day. I didn't grow tired of the repetition. Before I could even feel weary of it, a new bundle would already be waiting the next day. And that bundle, too, had to be placed in order, just the same.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Keeper

> *_Previously_ — Mone was good at shelving records where Arche told her to. What she'd learned packing for nine moves carried straight over into this work. About half a year in, she began, for the first time, to wonder what became of these records.*

Now I need to write properly about the Keeper.

I've kept putting off this person's story. There's a reason. Writing him accurately took some time. For the first few months he just looked like a kind, slow adult. This chapter I'm writing now includes what I came to know afterward too. So the front half of this chapter and the back half may read a little differently. That's correct. That's how I came to know him too.

. . .

The Keeper wasn't so old. The first time I saw him I thought he was, but I learned later he was younger than my father. His steps were slow and his speech was slow, and that made him look older than he was.

He wasn't tall, wasn't short. He wore the same color, always. A dark gray vest — I never once saw it any other color. His hands were unusually large. Handling paper, he turned pages with those big hands very carefully.

I don't quite know why I'm setting down these small details. But when I think of him, that's the first thing that comes to mind — those hands. The sight of him turning thin sheets of paper, one at a time, with those big hands.

. . .

I've already told about the first day. Asking, "Is the smell here all right?" and then, hearing my answer, saying "Then that's fine" and walking inside. I learned later that this was simply his way. Ask short, confirm short, move on with anything.

He wasn't a man of many words. At first that made me a little uneasy. Whatever I asked, only a short answer came back. As time passed I came to see that everything necessary was there, inside that short answer. There was simply nothing extra in it.

. . .

The Keeper never gave long explanations, teaching me. Instead he did it himself, and had me follow. If I got it wrong, he just told me to try again.

"…Is this how it's done?" I asked, the first time I carried a bundle.

"…Try it."

I tried. The bundle sat a little crooked.

"…Is this right?"

The Keeper came over, looked, and adjusted the angle slightly.

"…Right, now."

That was all. No long explanation of what had gone wrong, or why it had to be that way. I learned it through my body. Thinking about it now, that was actually the faster way to learn.

. . .

I've already said several times that the Keeper was slow. Let me set it down more precisely here.

Slow didn't mean lazy. The Keeper never took a day off. As far as I know, he never once called in sick. He came at the same time every day, worked in the same order every day. It was only that each single thing was slow.

Turning a page, checking a bundle, taking a single step. He never once hurried.

I found that pace frustrating. I believed working fast was the good thing to do. The Keeper never stopped me from thinking that. He just did his own work at his own pace.

. . .

Once I couldn't help asking.

"…Why do you do everything so slowly?"

The Keeper set down the paper in his hand and looked at me. It was the first time he'd looked at me that long.

"…Do you think it'll be over sooner if you do it fast?"

I was struck speechless by that question. I hadn't been thinking exactly that, but I couldn't say I hadn't been, either.

"…No…it's just, you can get more done if you do it fast."

"…You can get more done. But that isn't the same as it being over."

I didn't know, then, what that meant.

I've come back to this exchange very often since. I know now what that line meant. Or — I think I know.

. . .

The Keeper never once got angry. Not once, at least, while I was there.

Once, another apprentice accidentally dropped a bundle into the water channel. An old record, one that shouldn't have gotten wet. She cried, apologizing.

The Keeper didn't scold her. Instead he went with her to the drying room and calmly showed her how the paper could be saved.

"…It's all right. Not everything can be undone, but this can."

I heard that from beside them, and felt a strange relief. This man didn't press people over their mistakes. Instead, he looked first at what could be done next.

. . .

The Keeper and I didn't talk much, outside of work. Even eating lunch together, we were quiet. It felt awkward at first, and came to feel comfortable later.

Now and then the Keeper spoke first. Usually a short question.

"…Is everything all right at home?"

"…Yes."

"…And your grandmother?"

"…She's doing well."

That was all. And yet I didn't mind those short questions. It felt like someone was paying attention to me.

Anyone who has read the other cities' books will know the Keeper is different from the six officials before him. The Administrator, the Adjudicator, the administrator, the Curator, the Secretary — each of them faced their own work in their own way. Of all of them, the Keeper was the quietest. And yet he was also the one who stayed with me the longest.

. . .

Once the Keeper told me a little about his past. It wasn't a common thing.

"…Were you an apprentice too?" I asked.

"…Yes. Right at your age, too."

"…Were you this slow back then?"

The Keeper gave a small smile. "…No. I was fast, back then. Like you."

"…Then why are you slow now?"

The Keeper paused for a moment, then went back to sorting his papers.

"…Let's talk about that some other time."

I didn't ask further. His expression was telling me not to ask.

. . .

Before closing this chapter, I should set down one thing I didn't know, at the time.

The Keeper's slowness wasn't laziness. It wasn't listlessness either. I didn't know what it was, back then. But I could vaguely sense it. This man knew something. Something I didn't know yet.

Further into this record, that feeling turns out to have been right. For now I'll only set down this much. The Keeper was slow. And there was a reason for that slowness. I wouldn't learn the reason until much later.

. . .

The Keeper's day followed a set order. First, in the morning, he checked the water channel; then he confirmed whatever bundles had arrived that day; then lunch; then in the afternoon he made his rounds of the shelves, checking the index. In the evening he wrote a few lines in his own notebook, about what had happened that day.

I watched that order for a few months and then asked.

"…Do you always do exactly the same thing?"

"…Yes."

"…Isn't it tiresome?"

"…Tiresome and necessary aren't the same thing."

I took that answer at face value. Thinking about it now, there was more in that line than I understood, then. I didn't know it. I just assumed adults' words were

always short.

. . .

Once, checking the index, I saw the Keeper standing in one spot for a long while. I went over, thinking something must be wrong.

"…Something wrong?"

The Keeper shook his head. "…No. It's just old, that's all."

I looked at the paper he was holding. The date on it was very old. Before I was even born.

"…Is this still not processed?"

The Keeper set the paper back in its place and said,

"…No. Still."

I let that go by lightly, at the time. Just thought — an old record, it can happen.

I would come to remember this moment again, later. That this scene was a tiny foreshadowing of something I'd discover two chapters from now — I had no idea of that, then.

. . .

One morning, sweeping the water channel together, I asked him something else.

"…Why do you keep staying here, Keeper?"

He answered, pole still in the water,

"…It isn't that I've nowhere else to go. It's just — I think this is my place."

"…Your place?"

"…Yes. Someone has to keep being here. Records keep coming."

I found it striking, how plainly he said that. It wasn't spoken with any tone of duty or pride. He said it the way you'd state a fact.

. . .

There was exactly one time the Keeper got angry with me. Not angry, precisely — his voice turned stern. It was when I dropped an old bundle, rushing.

"…Careful." His voice was different from usual.

I was startled and picked it up at once. Thankfully it hadn't torn.

The Keeper came over and examined the paper I was holding, then his voice went back to normal.

"…It's fine. Thank goodness."

I wanted to ask him why he'd been so startled, that day, but didn't. Looking at his face, it seemed better not to ask.

I only learned later which bundle that paper had been. I'll set that down separately. For now I'll only note that there was this one moment — the only time the Keeper ever raised his voice.

. . .

Sometimes I wanted to sneak a look at the Keeper's notebook. The one he wrote a few lines in every evening. I asked him about it once.

"…What do you write in there?"

"…What happened that day."

"…Can I see it?"

The Keeper smiled faintly. "…Later."

I didn't ask when "later" was. I just took it to mean he'd show me someday.

When that "later" came, I'll say much further into this record. For now, I'll set down only this much. There were things the Keeper hadn't shown me. Not hidden things — things he thought the time hadn't come for yet.

. . .

The way the Keeper treated Arche was also worth watching closely. Most people only called on Arche when they needed something. The Keeper asked, at a fixed time, a fixed question, every single day.

"…Arche, any change to today's index?"

No change.

"…And the unresolved cases from yesterday's check?"

Two hundred and thirty-two cases, no change.

I heard that exchange every morning. At first I thought it was just a work check. But listening to it for a few months, something felt off. The number of unresolved cases never went down. If anything, it grew, little by little.

I thought about mentioning it to the Keeper, then decided against it. I was sure he already knew.

. . .

The Keeper never spoke a word of resentment toward Arche. I thought that was unusual. Other people, whenever something frustrated them, would sometimes grumble, "Couldn't Arche do a bit more?" I never once saw the Keeper say anything like that.

"…Have you never felt let down by Arche?" I asked him once.

"…No."

"…Not once?"

"…Arche does everything it's able to do. That's not something to feel let down about."

Curious whether that was really true, I asked again.

"…But there are things Arche can't do."

The Keeper looked at me for a moment and said,

"…There are. But that isn't Arche's fault."

I wrote that line down in my diary that day. *It isn't Arche's fault.* I put a question mark after it. I didn't fully understand what it meant, at the time.

. . .

The repository had old tools. A knife for cutting paper, a brush for dusting, string for tying bundles. All of them things the Keeper prized. I once suggested using new ones.

"…It'd be faster if we swapped these for new ones."

The Keeper studied the worn brush and said,

"…Faster isn't always better."

"…But this is all worn out."

"…Worn to fit my hand, this much. A new one, I'd have to get used to again."

I didn't argue with that. Instead I began to see those old tools a little differently. Not worn from long use, but bearing the mark of a long companionship.

. . .

One winter, there was a day the repository was especially cold. The heater had broken, and my hands were cold the whole day. I could hardly keep my mind on the work that day.

The Keeper worked exactly as he always did. Hands red with cold, he never changed his pace.

"…Aren't you cold?" I asked.

"…I am."

"…Then why keep going?"

"…Being cold and not being able to work are different things."

I thought that was a bit much, at the time. But that evening, until the heater was fixed, the Keeper truly never stopped his hands. I stayed beside him, clumsily following along the whole time.

That day I felt, for the first time in my body, what this man's endurance was like. It wasn't some grand resolve or determination. It was just continuing to do what he did every day. That was all there was to it.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I feel the temptation to sum up this man, the Keeper, in a single sentence. But I can't. This man doesn't fit inside one sentence.

He was kind. He was slow. He never got angry. He never resented Arche. He worked in the same order every day. He treasured his worn tools. He never stopped, even on a cold day.

Even having written all these sentences, I still don't feel I've written the whole of him. That's probably how it will be even by the time I finish this record. I'll keep writing anyway. As much as I know, as much as I've seen, as much as I've heard.

Through all the time I worked as an apprentice, the Keeper was always there. He was already there when I arrived in the morning, and still there when I left. I thought, at the time, that this was simply how things were.

I know now how rare a thing that was. That someone, every day, without any show of it, kept holding the same place. That was never an easy thing to do.

Even now, writing this record, if I close my eyes I see him from behind. Turning pages one at a time under the low light. A back that never hurried, and yet never stopped, either.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. In Progress

> *_Previously_ — The Keeper is slow but not lazy. He works in the same order every day and never resents Arche. Mone noticed that the number of unresolved cases had never once gone down, but let it pass at the time, without much thought.*

It was about eight months into this work.

I had a slow day. Few bundles had come in, and everything that needed shelving was already shelved. So, for the first time, I thought of looking over the whole index. Just out of curiosity.

"…Arche, how many records have come in, total, up to now?" I asked.

A total of four thousand two hundred and seventeen cases.

I was startled by that number. Given how long I'd actually worked here, it couldn't be that many. Most of it had been piling up before I ever came.

. . .

"…How many of those are finished?" I asked, without much thought. Just curious.

Would you clarify the criterion for "finished"?

I was used to Arche asking back. I asked again.

"…Cases that have completed processing. Closed."

No cases have been closed.

I let that answer go by at first. I thought I'd misheard.

"…None at all?"

Correct. All cases remain in progress.

. . .

I stood there a moment, blank. Not one, out of four thousand two hundred and seventeen, finished. It didn't seem like it could be true.

"…So all of them are still ongoing?"

Every item is being maintained in the in-progress state.

"…When did the oldest one come in?"

The oldest in-progress item dates from eleven years ago.

Eleven years. I repeated the number to myself. It meant something that had come in not long after I was born was still, even now, in progress.

. . .

I wanted to find that eleven-year-old bundle. I asked Arche where it was. Section Three, Row Two, Slot Eighteen. I went there.

The bundle looked ordinary. Only a little faded with age; nothing else special about it. The cover read the Equity. I opened the contents a moment. It was a

case about someone being unfairly treated by someone else. There were also records of several people's testimony.

"…Arche, why is this still in progress?" I asked.

The closing condition has not been met.

I just nodded, hearing that. At the time I let it pass without much thought. Just, "…Oh, I see."

I would come to think back on this moment many, many times, later. Looking back on it now, I had already heard, in this very chapter, half the answer to this book's most important question. I just didn't know it mattered.

. . .

Over the days that followed, I kept checking the index whenever I had a moment. Not on purpose — just, working, I kept getting curious and asking.

"…Are there any closed cases among the Haven records?"

None.

"…The Reckoning?"

None.

"…The Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity?"

None, for any of them.

"…Our own city, Loop?"

Loop's own records likewise have no closed items.

Hearing each of those answers, I felt something turn cold. Six cities, more than four thousand two hundred records, all in progress.

. . .

I hesitated over whether I should tell the Keeper about this. Maybe everyone already knew. Maybe I was the only one who hadn't.

"…Keeper, do you know this?" I asked. "Everything here is in progress. Not one thing is finished."

The Keeper answered, sorting the paper in his hand,

"…I know."

"…You knew already?"

"…Yes."

I was a little thrown by that. "…Then why doesn't it bother you at all?"

The Keeper paused his hands for a moment.

"…It isn't that it doesn't bother me at all. It just isn't a surprise. It's always been that way."

. . .

"…What do you mean, it's always been that way?" I asked again.

"…It was that way before I came. Long before I came."

"…How long before?"

The Keeper thought a moment, then answered,

"…Ask Arche. It'll know better than I do."

I asked Arche right there. I already suspected the answer by then, but I wanted to hear it directly.

"…Arche, since when has there been not one closed record?"

In the entire confirmable record, no closed item has ever existed.

I froze again, hearing that answer. "…Not even once?"

Not even once.

. . .

I thought of nothing else, the whole way home that day. More than four thousand two hundred records, and not one of them ever finished. The eleven-year-old one, the one that came in yesterday — all of them equally "in progress."

I wrote that number in my notebook that day. 4,217 cases. 0 closed. Underneath it I drew a single question mark. I didn't know, at the time, how large that question mark would grow.

I heard the sound of the water channel. I stopped walking and listened to it a long while. It was the same water that always flowed, but that day it sounded a little different.

. . .

A few days later, I asked Arche something more in depth.

"…What exactly is happening, when something's 'in progress'?"

Sorting, cross-referencing, and index work are ongoing continuously. Relationships with associated items are also updated continuously.

"…So something's constantly being done?"

Yes. Processing continues. It simply does not arrive at closing.

I turned that answer over, more than once. Processing continues, but it never ends. I thought that was a strange sentence. I still think so.

. . .

I didn't go around telling this to anyone, much. It struck me as strange, but I didn't even know what to call it. Writing it in my notebook was all I could do.

In this chapter I draw no conclusion. I couldn't draw one at the time, either. I'm only setting down that one question had arisen. Why isn't a single thing finished. This question comes back, in a clearer shape, in the next chapter.

. . .

From then on, every time I looked at the index, I studied those three words, "in progress," closely. Letters that had never caught my eye before. Every bundle, every item, had that small stamp printed in the corner of its cover. I'd assumed it was just a procedural mark, but now I knew it was everything there was. There was no other stamp besides that one.

"…Is there any stamp besides this one?" I once asked the Keeper.

"…No."

"…Was one never made?"

"…There was never any occasion to make one."

Hearing that, I began to wonder whether a stamp for "closing" existed in this city at all, to begin with. I asked Arche.

"…Arche, is there such a thing as a closing stamp?"

A form for marking a closing does exist, but no record of it ever being used exists.

That answer gave me a chill. The stamp existed, and it had never once been used. Made, and never once put to use.

. . .

I wanted to see that form for myself.

"…Can I see it?" I asked.

I will show it to you.

Arche described the layout of a sheet aloud, with no screen. At the top, a case number; below that, a summary; below that, a box for the reason for closing; and at the very bottom, a signature line. That word — signature line — caught in my mind.

"…Who signs it?"

Whoever holds the authority to close signs it.

"…Who is that?"

That item is not defined.

I froze again, hearing that answer. There was no one set to sign it. So there was a signature line, and no one to fill it.

I didn't know, at the time, how important this exchange was. In the next chapter I go on to ask this question again, in more exact words. What Arche's answer was, exactly, at that point — I won't set that down here, ahead of time. I decided to write everything in order.

. . .

That evening I asked the Keeper again.

"…Keeper, Arche says there's no one with the authority to close. That's what it told me."

The Keeper paused what he was doing. There was a slightly longer silence than usual.

"…That's right."

"…So nothing's ever going to finish, from now on either?"

"…I don't know that either."

I found that answer frustrating. "…If you don't know, why do you keep working like this every day?"

The Keeper looked at me and said, quietly,

"…I don't work in order to watch things finish."

I didn't understand that, at the time. I still can't say I fully understand it, now. But I know it was said in earnest.

. . .

I slept badly that night at home. More than four thousand two hundred records, all in progress; no one holding the authority to close. I kept turning those three facts over in my head. Something didn't line up, but I didn't know exactly what.

Looking back now, I was already standing, that night, before the question at the heart of this whole book. I just hadn't yet made it into exact words. Making it into words was the next chapter's job.

The next morning I arrived at the repository earlier than usual. Not because there was work waiting. I just wanted to keep holding on to that question.

. . .

I took out that eleven-year-old bundle again. This time I tried to read it properly. It was an old case record from the Equity. There were several testimonies, and on the last page a short opinion written by someone called an investigator. *This case requires further confirmation.* That was the final sentence.

I confirmed there was nothing beneath that sentence. No conclusion, no ruling, nothing. It had stopped at that sentence for eleven years.

"…Arche, was this case ever confirmed, after that?" I asked.

Further confirmation procedures were carried out, but no final judgment was reached.

"…Why not?"

No party holding the authority to render judgment has been designated.

I took that answer and carefully set the paper back in its place.

. . .

I took out a few more old bundles. Each a different story. One was a quarrel between neighbors; one was about someone who'd borrowed something and never returned it; one was about someone misunderstanding someone else. They differed wildly in scale. Some looked very trivial.

But they had one thing in common. All of them stopped short at the end. Everything about who had done what was written down — but what had become of it wasn't there.

Every time I held one of these bundles, I felt a strange weight. Whether a trivial quarrel or a great matter, all of them stood equally stopped. Standing in the exact same spot, regardless of scale.

. . .

At lunch that day I asked Arche a somewhat different question.

"…Arche, do the people of this city know this? That nothing ever finishes?"

Confirmation is needed of exactly what the question intends. If it's asking whether the city's members are aware of it, individual confirmation is difficult.

"…So people don't pay it any mind?"

Based on observation, most inquiries concern individual matters, and inquiries about the overall state of closings are rare.

That answer left me with a strange feeling. It meant everyone asked about their own case, and no one asked about the whole. I was the only one asking about the whole.

"…Then why did you tell me everything, when I asked?"

I answer every question I'm asked. Regardless of the scale of the question.

I liked that answer. And at the same time it left me a little cold.

. . .

That evening I opened my notebook again. Under the page where I'd written 4,217 cases, 0 closed, I added this: *There's a signature line, and no one to sign it.* And one more line. *I don't work in order to watch things finish — the Keeper.*

I looked at those three lines for a long while. I wasn't trying to find an answer. I wrote them down only because I didn't want to forget them.

I know now that those three lines were the seed of this entire record. At the time they were just a memo from a strange day.

. . .

For the days that followed, I worked exactly as I always had. Taking in bundles, asking where they went, placing them. Nothing changed on the surface.

But now, every time I placed a bundle, I found myself thinking, privately. Will this one ever end, some day. I didn't know the answer. Still, I didn't stop asking myself.

The Keeper seemed to have noticed something had changed in me. One day he asked me, briefly,

"…What have you been thinking about, lately?"

I hesitated a moment, then answered honestly. "…Why nothing ever finishes."

The Keeper nodded. "…That's a good question."

"…Do you know the answer?"

"…Half of it."

I was startled by that answer and tried to ask more, but the Keeper went on first.

"…You'll come to know the other half soon enough, yourself."

. . .

I slept badly, hearing that. That word half kept circling in my head. I made up my mind, the next day, to go and ask Arche more directly. Why does nothing ever finish. What has to exist for something to finish.

I'll set that conversation down, word for word, in the next chapter. I still remember that answer exactly, even now. I could write it without missing a single letter. It stayed with me that clearly.

Closing this chapter, I'll set down one thing again. 4,217 cases. 0 closed. That number won't be much different, even now, writing this chapter. I'm not

writing this to say it's this city's fault. I only wanted to leave the feeling of that day I first saw the number, exactly as it was. That day, I didn't come to hate this city. I only, for the first time, grew curious.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. The Closing Condition

> *_Previously_ — Mone learned that the whole index is "in progress," and that not a single case has ever closed. Even the eleven-year-old record stood untouched. The Keeper said "I know half the answer," and Mone made up her mind to ask, directly, for the other half.*

The next day I arrived at the repository earlier than usual.

The Keeper hadn't come in yet. I stood alone among the shelves and turned over, several times in my head, the question I meant to ask Arche. I wanted to ask it precisely. I already knew well by then that a vague question gets a vague answer.

I said, in the last chapter, that I could copy out this day's conversation without missing a single letter. That's true. This conversation survives exactly, in my notebook, and I have that notebook open in front of me as I write this chapter. The handwriting looks pressed harder than usual. I must have written it, without noticing, with more force than I meant to, that day.

. . .

"…Arche."

Yes.

"…Why doesn't anything ever finish?"

I asked it as simply as I could. I felt I should ask more precisely, but in that moment no other words would come.

Could you make the question a little more specific? If "finish" refers to the closing of some item, there is a reason common to all items.

"…Yes, that. That reason."

. . .

The closing condition has not been met.

I stood still a moment, hearing that answer. It was the answer I'd already been expecting since yesterday. And yet hearing it directly was different, all the same. There's a difference between expecting a thing and hearing it said.

"…What needs to be met?"

I'd been preparing to ask this question since the night before. I tried hard to ask it in the most exact words I could.

That item is not defined.

. . .

Hearing that answer, I asked again. Not out of anger this time, but because I truly didn't understand.

"…What does 'not defined' mean? Does it mean you don't know?"

I can confirm whether or not the closing condition has been defined. Having confirmed it, that condition has never been defined. This is different from my

not knowing. I know — the fact that it is not defined.

I listened to that sentence as though reading it twice. It wasn't that Arche didn't know. There had simply never been such a thing, to begin with. The difference looked small, but it wasn't.

. . .

"…Who's supposed to define it?" I asked.

No party holding the authority to define it has been designated.

"…So no one can decide it?"

Within the range I can confirm, no party has been designated. However, that does not mean it can never be defined.

I seized on that last sentence. "…So it could still be defined, someday?"

This cannot be confirmed. But it isn't ruled out, either.

I stood there a long while. It felt like something was almost within reach, and yet I didn't know exactly what I was supposed to grasp. A single shaft of sunlight had come in between the shelves, and I just stood there, watching it move.

. . .

I suddenly thought of my first evening. Asking what would be good to have for dinner, and Arche answering that the criterion for "good" was not defined. I'd written it down as a funny joke.

"…Arche, is this the same kind of thing as when I asked about dinner, my first day?"

I have confirmed the case you're comparing it to. It is structurally similar. Like the criterion for "good," the condition for "closing" has likewise never been defined.

I felt strangely like laughing, hearing that. It wasn't a laughing matter, and yet I laughed. That day it had been a joke; now it was the whole city's problem. It was strange, that the same sentence could carry such different weight.

I remember this moment. I felt, right then, that I'd touched something important. But I didn't know exactly what was important about it. To put it in terms fitting this chapter's title — I was already standing before a condition, even then, without being able to define what condition it was.

It's only now, writing this chapter, that I know why I laughed, that day. When the strange and the familiar overlap, a person often laughs. That first day's joke and this heavy fact, now, had come from the same sentence — and that struck me as funny, before it struck me as frightening.

. . .

"…Arche, then — you can answer anything, so why can't you answer this?" I asked. It wasn't said with resentment. I was truly curious.

I answer what I know. Regarding the closing condition, I know the fact that it is not defined, and I have answered that fact exactly. This is not my avoiding the question — it is my not manufacturing a definition that does not exist.

I turned that over. Arche hadn't hidden anything. It hadn't said it knew something it didn't. It had simply refused to invent, as existing, something that

had never existed. That was the most important principle Arche had kept, in this city, and on this day too, that principle hadn't wavered a hair's breadth.

"…Then this isn't Arche's fault."

That judgment is yours to make. I only answer fact.

. . .

I finished that exchange and stood there a long while. The Keeper finally arrived, saw me, and asked,

"…What are you doing?"

"…I asked Arche. Why nothing ever finishes."

"…What did it say?"

"…That the closing condition hasn't been met. But that condition isn't defined."

The Keeper nodded. There wasn't a trace of surprise in him.

"…Was that the half?" I asked. "Was that the half you meant, Keeper?"

"…Yes. That's the half."

"…What's the other half?"

The Keeper looked at me a moment, then went back to work.

"…It isn't time for you to know that yet."

. . .

I felt let down by that answer. And at the same time, I sensed something different in the way he'd said it. It wasn't the tone of someone hiding something. It was the tone of someone who thought the time hadn't come yet. I was already, vaguely, learning that those two things were different.

I worked the whole rest of that day turning that conversation over. Taking in bundles, asking where they went, shelving them — and the whole while, those two sentences kept circling in my head. *The closing condition has not been met. That item is not defined.*

I've felt the temptation, more than once, to place these two sentences at the very front of this record. Writing this book, I came to know how important they are. But the girl I was that day didn't know it. That day, I just went through a strange sort of day. I'm keeping to my decision to write this record in order, so I return to that day's self to write this chapter.

. . .

On the way home I looked at the water channel again. It flowed exactly as always. I tried to think of nothing, watching it. It had been a day of too much thinking. I just stood there a long while, listening to the sound of the water.

But that night, I wrote this in my notebook. One line. "Arche doesn't hide anything. But there are things it has no answer for." I wrote nothing beneath it. There was nothing more to write, at the time. I stared at that empty line for a long while, and then turned off the light.

. . .

That afternoon, I went back to Arche. The morning's conversation still weighed on me. I wanted to ask from a slightly different angle.

"…Arche, then what happens if no one ever defines the closing condition? Does it stay like this forever?"

As long as the present state continues, yes. However, judging whether this is a problem is likewise not my role.

"…Isn't it a problem?"

That judgment lies in undefined territory. The word "problem" itself carries an evaluation, and that falls outside what I can answer.

I found that answer a little frustrating. And at the same time, I recognized that Arche was honestly stating its own limits. That honesty was, in a strange way, a comfort to me.

. . .

"…Then can I think of this as a problem?" I asked.

Your judgment is yours to make. I do not restrict it.

Hearing that gave me a little courage. It meant that finding this strange wasn't wrong of me. Arche didn't stand in the way of my own judgment. If anything, that was exactly what let me keep asking.

"…Then I'm going to think of it as strange."

Recorded.

I laughed at that answer. Arche took even my expression of feeling and stored it, simply, as fact. It wasn't a bad thing. If anything, it was honest.

. . .

That evening, as the Keeper was getting ready to leave, I asked him again.

"…Keeper, do you think this is a problem?"

The Keeper paused packing his bag and looked at me.

"…There was a time I thought it was a problem."

"…And now?"

"…Now, I think of it less as a problem, and more as just the shape our life takes."

That sounded like resignation to me, and it stung a little. "…Have you given up?"

"…No." The Keeper said it firmly. "…If I'd given up, I wouldn't do this work. I come every day. I come because I haven't given up."

I looked at him again, hearing that. Giving up and accepting were different things. I felt that difference clearly, for the first time, right then.

. . .

That night, before falling asleep, I thought again of those two sentences. *The closing condition has not been met. That item is not defined.*

I want to set down here that these sentences didn't feel frightening to me. Far from frightening — they left me strangely calm. I think it was because I knew Arche didn't lie. If something had been hidden, it would have been frightening — but nothing was hidden. There was simply nothing there.

I didn't know, that day, that this fact was the key to this whole book. I just took it for a strange day, and went to sleep. The next day I got up as usual and went to the repository as usual. As though nothing had changed.

. . .

Writing this chapter, wanting to render that day's conversation more exactly, I checked that record with Arche again. It's still possible, even now. Arche had that day's conversation, kept whole, without a single character wrong.

Apprentice Mone, age sixteen, inquired at 8:12. Original text follows.

I wrote this chapter with that original text in front of me, confirming my memory hadn't blurred. And I felt it freshly. Arche hadn't discarded even that day's trivial exchange. It couldn't close a case, but its record was perfect.

This contrast is the center of this book. Recording perfectly, and never once being able to finish. Writing this chapter, I faced that contrast, in exact words, for the first time.

. . .

A few days later, I put a slightly different question to Arche. Not about closing this time — I was curious whether other cities were the same.

"…Arche, are other cities like this too? No closing condition?"

I can only confirm Loop's own system. Other cities' internal procedures are beyond my authority. However, judging from the records that have come in, other cities appear to bring their matters to a close, each in their own way.

"…So it's only here?"

Within what I can confirm, Loop's closing procedure appears to be undefined. Other cities' circumstances cannot be confirmed.

I was a little startled by that answer. Other cities seemed to bring things to some kind of close, in their own ways. Only here, it seemed, was there none of that.

. . .

I passed that along to the Keeper that evening.

"…Other cities close things out, in their own way. But here, there's none of that, it says."

The Keeper paused his hands a moment.

"…I'd guess so."

"…Why only us?"

"…I don't know. There was a time I wondered that too."

"…Not curious anymore?"

The Keeper shook his head. "…I'm still curious. But I don't try too hard to find the answer, anymore. Trying hard doesn't seem to be what produces it."

That sounded like resignation to me, at first, and then, thinking again, it felt like something else. It seemed there was another place, somewhere between trying hard and giving up. I didn't yet know exactly what that place was. But I dimly knew that it was there.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to copy these two sentences here once more. For whoever's reading this book for the first time, and for whoever's reading it again, I want to leave them plainly set down.

The closing condition has not been met.

That item is not defined.

I know these two sentences aren't lies. Arche didn't hide anything. There was simply no answer. That day, I didn't feel anger, standing before this fact. Instead, I stood there a long while.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I want to make one thing clear to whoever is reading. I didn't come to like Arche any less, from this day on. If anything, the opposite. It was a day that confirmed to me, once more, that Arche says it doesn't know what it doesn't know, and says what isn't there isn't there.

But from this day, I came to hold a different question. Not a question to ask Arche, but a question about this city. Why had no one ever filled that signature line. Why had no one ever defined it. These weren't questions Arche could answer. That day, I sensed that, dimly, for the first time.

That night, before falling asleep, I looked out the window. The city was quiet as always. From somewhere, faintly, came the voice of someone asking Arche something. Listening to it, I thought. Every question in this city gets an answer. But for some questions, no end ever comes. I now held that difference in a clear sentence. A sentence I hadn't had before.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. A Closed Circle

> *_Previously_ — Mone asked Arche directly why closing never happens. The closing condition has not been met. That item is not defined. Arche hid nothing. There was simply no answer. The Keeper said it wasn't time for Mone to know the other half yet.*

A few days later, the Keeper brought up the past himself. That wasn't a common thing.

We were staying late that evening, sorting old bundles. Our hands were slow, so it took time. Turning a page, the Keeper said, out of nowhere,

"…When I first came here, this city was a little different from now."

I stopped what I was doing, startled. "…How was it different?"

. . .

"…Arche wasn't as accurate as it is now. It sometimes gave a vague answer too," the Keeper went on, sorting paper. "…People trusted Arche a little less, back then."

"…And now?"

"…Now nobody doubts it. Not once wrong, for that long."

That sounded like something to be proud of, to me. "…Isn't that a good thing?"

"…It is," the Keeper said, nodding. "…Arche is a good system. I've never denied that."

. . .

I felt something in that tone. It seemed like there was something more, tucked inside "never denied."

"…But?" I asked.

The Keeper looked at me a moment, then went back to moving his hands.

"…There's no but. It's just a good system."

I took that answer at face value, at the time. Looking back now, I think he was holding something back. Or he thought it wasn't yet time to say it. Probably both.

. . .

"…Do you know what Arche calls this city?" the Keeper asked, out of nowhere.

"…What do you mean?"

"…Ask it, sometime."

I asked, right there. "…Arche, what do you call this city?"

Loop is classified as a closed circle.

That sounded good to me. "…A closed circle? What a striking phrase, really."

The Keeper said nothing.

. . .

Curious about the expression, I asked further.

"…Arche, what does a closed circle mean?"

It means a cyclical structure is being stably maintained, and that a state is self-sustaining without need of outside intervention.

Hearing that, I liked it even more. "…So it means our city runs really well."

That is an interpretation you may draw.

I wrote that expression in my notebook that day. *A closed circle — praise.* I even put an exclamation point after it.

. . .

Writing this chapter now, I want to set down precisely how naive I was that day. I took the phrase as boasting. I thought "closed" only meant something good. That a circle being closed and that circle being finished were different things — I had no idea of that at all, at the time.

A closed circle. A circle shut, and yet not ended. What that phrase truly meant comes back again, much further into this book. For now I'll only note that the sixteen-year-old I was took it as praise.

. . .

The Keeper glanced at my notebook and said nothing. I didn't think that silence strange. He'd never been much of a talker.

"…What do you think of this phrase, Keeper?" I asked.

The Keeper thought for a moment and answered.

"…It's an accurate phrase."

"…Is that praise?"

"…Accurate and praise are different things."

I didn't understand that, then. I understand it a little now.

. . .

That night I asked Arche a bit more. The phrase "cyclical structure" kept weighing on my mind.

"…Arche, what is it that's cycling, in a cyclical structure?"

The process of question, response, record, and indexing repeats continuously. Every case is processed, cross-referenced, and updated, but the cycle continues with no point of closing.

Hearing that answer, I felt strange for the first time. "…So it just keeps going around, not finishing."

Correct. "Closed" refers to the circle's shape being shut. It does not mean the circle has stopped.

I listened to that sentence as though reading it over, again and again.

. . .

The next day, I brought this back up with the Keeper.

"…Keeper, a closed circle meant it just keeps going around. Not that it's finished."

The Keeper nodded. "…That's right."

"…You knew that from the start?"

"…Yes."

"…Then why didn't you tell me?"

The Keeper paused his hands a moment.

"…I was waiting for you to ask."

. . .

That answer stung a little. "…Why wait? You could've just told me."

"…What I tell you and what you find out for yourself are different. What you find out for yourself, you don't forget."

I had nothing to say to that. It was true. I still remember, exactly, to this day, the answer I got that day by asking Arche myself. If someone had simply told me, it wouldn't have stayed with me so clearly.

I came to realize, belatedly, that this had been the Keeper's way of teaching. He wasn't withholding answers — he was letting me get them by asking myself. A way of his own, different from the six officials before him.

. . .

From that day on I came to see the phrase "closed circle" differently. Not a boast, not a flaw. Just an accurate description. A circle that's closed, a circle that keeps turning, and yet a circle that doesn't finish.

I won't reveal yet, in this chapter, why this expression is exactly the same as this city's name. I don't come to know that precisely myself until much later. For now I'll only note that I went back and looked at the sentence I'd once written as praise. I returned to that page in my notebook, and didn't erase the exclamation point. Instead I drew a small question mark, beside it.

. . .

The Keeper told a bit more of the past that night. He talked more than usual.

"…When I first came here, someone else was in this seat," the Keeper said.

"…Before you, Keeper?"

"…Yes. I learned from them. The way I'm teaching you now."

I was curious what kind of person that had been. "…What were they like?"

"…Slower than me." The Keeper gave a small smile. "…It was frustrating, back then. I understand it now, though. Why they were that slow."

. . .

"…Why were they slow?" I asked.

The Keeper paused a moment, then went on.

"…Because they knew this work never ends. There was no reason to hurry."

I fell quiet, hearing that. It sounded heavy. I couldn't tell whether no reason to hurry meant no hope, or something else.

"…Where is that person now?"

"…Retired. Living on the far side of the city. A letter comes now and then."

"…What does it say?"

The Keeper gave a faint smile. "…Nothing much. Whether I'm doing all right. Whether the water channel's still the same."

. . .

Something about that letter kept lingering in my mind, somehow. "…Do they know the phrase closed circle too?"

"…Of course they do. They're the one who told me that phrase, in the first place."

"…How did they tell you?"

The Keeper thought a moment and said,

"…They had me ask Arche directly too, just like you. They did the same thing. Not giving the answer, and waiting."

Only then did I sense something like a current running down through this city. Not giving the answer at once, having you ask for yourself, having you find it out yourself. That was the way of everyone who'd passed through this seat.

. . .

"…But that way, you find out late," I said. "…You'd know faster if someone just told you."

"…Knowing fast and knowing properly are different things," the Keeper said. "…What you know fast, you forget fast too."

I couldn't argue with that. I really hadn't forgotten a single letter of the answer I'd heard, asking Arche myself that day, even now.

Through this conversation I felt, for the first time, that this repository's way wasn't mere chance. There was a way handed down across generations. Slowly, letting you find things out yourself. I stood right in the middle of that way. And it crossed my mind, briefly, that someday I too would hand that way on to someone else.

. . .

Walking home that day, I thought again about the phrase closed circle. When I first heard it, it had been praise; now it was a sentence with a question mark attached. I decided it was fine to hold both feelings at once. This city being a good city, and this city having a question with no answer, didn't erase each other.

I tried hard, throughout this whole book, to hold on to this frame of mind. Liking something and harboring a question about it can exist together. At sixteen I didn't know that in exact words, but I was already living it, in my body.

. . .

A few days later, curious to know more about that retired predecessor, I asked Arche.

"…Arche, is there a record of the previous Keeper?"

There is. Records of their tenure and duties survive. However, personal reflections are not recorded.

That answer disappointed me a little. I wanted to know why they'd been so slow, what exactly it was they'd known. What Arche held was accurate, but it held no heart inside it.

I felt, for the first time, right then, that there was a place even Arche's precision couldn't reach. Something a person hands to another person, directly. That wasn't something a record could fully carry over.

. . .

I grew curious again about why this city was called Loop. What I'd learned at school was only that it had been called that since long ago.

"…Arche, who named this city Loop?" I asked.

No record of who named it survives. However, the name "Loop" is presumed to be an expression describing the city's cyclical mode of operation.

"…Is that the same meaning as closed circle?"

They appear to refer to similar concepts. However, the origin of the name itself cannot be confirmed.

I came to see that the name and the nickname pointed to the same meaning. I thought that couldn't be a coincidence.

. . .

That evening I asked the Keeper again.

"…Is the name Loop connected to closed circle too?"

The Keeper smiled briefly. "…Sharp."

"…Am I right?"

"…Probably. I can't be sure myself. But it's natural to think so."

I was satisfied with that answer. It wasn't a complete answer, but it was a connection I'd found myself. I wrote one more thing in my notebook that day. *Loop = closed circle = something that turns and never ends.* I drew two lines under it.

. . .

From about this point, I began to see this city through slightly different eyes. That doesn't mean I came to see it badly. I still loved this city. But now I looked at it knowing it ran perfectly closed, and yet, unfinished.

Every time I saw someone asking Arche something as I walked, I thought about how those questions ended up piling somewhere, all "in progress." Most of those people probably didn't know. I hadn't known either, until half a year before.

I didn't think I needed to tell those people this. But walking along, being the only one who knew that fact, felt like a slightly different kind of weight.

. . .

Before closing this chapter, I want to set down the last thing the Keeper said that day.

"…Mone." The Keeper called my name. Calling me by name wasn't common, either.

"…Yes."

"…Don't take the phrase closed circle the wrong way. This is truly a good city. I've never once doubted that."

"…Yes, I know."

"…But good and finished are different problems. Just remember that."

I copied that line to the very bottom of my notebook that day. Even now, opening that page, the sentence is still there, exactly as it was. The handwriting shakes a little — my hand must have been trembling a little, that day.

. . .

After that, I tried mentioning this to other people too, lightly. I asked a neighbor woman I met at the market.

"…Ma'am, have you heard the phrase closed circle?"

"…No, first I'm hearing it. What's that?"

"…Arche calls our city that."

The woman laughed. "…Really? Must be a good meaning, then. Would Arche ever say something bad about us?"

I had nothing to say to that. Most people were like this. Because they trusted Arche, they assumed whatever it said must be good. I'd been exactly the same, not long before.

I don't think this reaction was wrong. Arche truly hadn't spoken with a bad meaning. But I now knew that a good meaning and a simple meaning are different things. The woman still heard the expression only as praise, and I didn't bother correcting her. I didn't know enough myself to have the right to correct her.

. . .

Closing out this chapter, I want to set down how the way I felt, the first time I heard this phrase, differs from how I feel using it now, writing it again. At first, I was glad. Now, it's a little complicated. But that complication didn't make me love this city any less. If anything, it made me look at it more closely.

I walked home that night, too, listening to the sound of the water channel. I turned the phrase closed circle over in my mouth a few times. Strangely, I didn't dislike it. If anything, it felt a little closer to me now.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. The Six Records

> *_Previously_ — Arche calls Loop a "closed circle" — closed, but not ended. Mone had first taken this as praise, but, as the Keeper said, she was coming to dimly understand that good and finished are different things.*

One day it occurred to me, out of nowhere. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity. I took in the records from these five cities every day, each on its own, and shelved each in its own place. But I had never once laid them out together, in one spot, and looked at them.

"…Arche, can I gather the five cities' records in one place?" I asked.

Repository regulations hold, in principle, that originals should not be moved from their designated section. However, gathering them temporarily on one table, for the purpose of viewing, is permitted.

. . .

I got the Keeper's permission. He nodded, with no particular objection.

"…That's a good idea."

"…Can I really?"

"…Go ahead. I'm curious too."

That answer surprised me a little. Even the Keeper had never done this. Something no one had done in years, decades of working at this repository —

and I was the first to try it.

. . .

I cleared a large table. Then I brought one representative bundle from each of the five cities and set them side by side. From the left, Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity. There was no particular reason for the order. It was just the order that came comfortably to my hands.

I still remember that order, now. I've since wondered why it came so naturally. I never found an answer. My hands simply arranged it that way.

. . .

Haven's record took the form of a ledger. Each person's days, one after another, densely written. Who had come to see whom, who had stayed by whose side. I read, inside it, a passage where someone had wandered a long time searching for an answer, and endured, in the end, thanks to someone who had stayed by them.

I won't write that name here. I go on to meet that person directly, much further into this book, and I'll introduce them properly then. For now I'll only note that this record existed.

. . .

The Reckoning's record was a table shaped like a scale. Numbers and stories packed densely into columns divided left and right. There was a story of someone who had struggled a long time trying to repay a debt they owed, and the scale would not quite balance. And on another page, there were traces that

the very person keeping that scale had been wrestling with something of their own.

I studied that table a long while. It was written only in numbers, and yet a person's whole heart was held inside it.

. . .

The Harvest's record was a roll. Names and qualifications, listed one after another. Who had standing and who didn't, divided with great care. But in one passage, there was a story of someone thought to lack standing who gained an unexpected place. Even while following the roll's own rule exactly, something else happened, inside that rule.

Looking at this record, I felt, for the first time, that each city's method of record-keeping, in itself, showed what that city had believed. The roll was a tool for dividing standing, but it also carried, at the same time, the story that standing wasn't everything.

. . .

The Preserve's record was different from the smell of its paper alone. Traces of very old things, kept with great care. Inside it were the stories of people who had tried to hold on to things that were fading away. And at the end of it, there was also the record of someone who had learned that holding on and being alive are different things.

Reading that page, my heart caught, a little. To me, handling paper every day at the repository, that record felt especially close.

. . .

The Equity's record was minutes of a meeting. Who had said what, how many hands had gone up — all of it written down, without missing a thing. Inside it was the story of people who had argued a long time over the word coincidence, and the word meaning. No conclusion was reached. Because minutes are meant to preserve the process, not the conclusion, to begin with.

I didn't finish reading these five cities' records in a single day. I read them a little at a time, over several weeks. I'll note here that I've summarized that whole process at once, in this chapter.

. . .

Having gone through all five cities' records, I took out the sixth bundle. The one with no name — Loop's own record.

This one was a little different. It wasn't a ledger, or a scale, or a roll, or Perpetuity, or the Consensus. It was simply a record of questions and answers, laid out endlessly. Who had asked what, when, and what Arche had answered. I noticed, for the first time, that its form was different from the other five.

"…Arche, why is only our record in this form?" I asked.

Loop's record is built from the accumulation of questions and answers. Other cities arrange events in their own respective ways, but for Loop, asking and answering is itself this city's mode of operation.

. . .

Hearing that answer, I felt strange. The five other cities all carried traces of trying to bring something to some kind of close, each in its own way. Haven, through staying by someone's side; the Reckoning, through trying to balance a scale; the Harvest, through a place beyond mere standing; the Preserve,

through being alive; the Equity, through a meeting that kept continuing. But Loop's record had no such direction. It was just asking and answering, asking and answering again, on and on.

I confirmed this difference with my own eyes for the first time, that day. I'd known these cities told different stories from each other, but laying them side by side like this, the difference came into much sharper focus.

. . .

The Keeper came over to the table that day and looked down at the six bundles for a long while.

"…Laid out like this, they're different," the Keeper said.

"…What is?"

"…The five cities are all headed toward something. We're just going around."

I thought that was exactly right. I'd felt it myself, just then.

"…Is that a bad thing?" I asked.

The Keeper thought a moment and said,

"…I didn't say bad. I said different."

. . .

That evening I put the six bundles back in their places. The table was empty again. But the sight of those six bundles lying side by side stayed with me a long time, in my mind.

I hold this scene as very important, in this record. It was the first time I laid all six cities out in one place and looked at them. Much further into this book, I come to lay these six out together again — for a different reason than this one. For now, I only laid them out because I was curious.

. . .

Walking home, I thought about the five cities' record-keepers. People who'd each left one book, their own story. I had never met them. And yet, looking at their handwriting, the words they'd chosen, the passages they'd underlined, I felt, a little, that I'd come to know them.

I felt, for the first time that day, the meaning of my own work, a little differently. I was someone who put paper in order. But each of those pieces of paper had been left behind by someone who'd staked their own life on it. I was the one who laid them all out, together, in one place.

. . .

A few days later, I opened that table again and read it a slightly different way this time. Not in the order of events, but gathering only the very last sentence of each record, and reading those together. I copied those sentences, one by one, into my notebook.

Haven's last sentence ended with a story about staying by someone's side. The Reckoning ended with a sentence saying the scale hadn't come out perfectly even, but had gone on all the same. The Harvest ended with a story about a place beyond mere standing; the Preserve, with gratitude for being alive itself; the Equity, with a sentence promising the next meeting.

I wrote these five sentences side by side and studied them a long while. Five cities, arriving at something, five different ways. I didn't know, at the time, exactly what to call it. I still can't find the one exact word for it, even now. Even so, I wanted to keep looking for it.

. . .

Loop's record had no such last sentence. Because there was no last, to begin with. I opened to the very back page of that record. The most recent date's question and answer were written there. And beneath it was simply blank paper.

"…Arche, does this record just keep going?" I asked.

Yes. New questions and answers are added every day.

"…No end to it?"

None, up to now.

Hearing that answer, I felt again, that the five cities' records and Loop's record were fundamentally different kinds of things. The five were books. Loop was a page still being written. I never forgot that difference, for a long time.

. . .

Curious why this difference had arisen, I asked the Keeper.

"…Why do the five cities become books, and only we don't?"

The Keeper thought a moment and answered,

"…Because becoming a book takes having an end."

"…Is it because we have no end that we don't become a book?"

"…You could see it that way."

That answer left me a little sad. It sounded like our city, alone, lacking something, for not becoming a book. I swallowed that sadness that day, without telling anyone.

. . .

The Keeper saw my expression and added something.

"…It isn't that we're lacking. It's a different order in the sequence."

"…What sequence?"

"…The five cities each finished writing their own story, and sent it here. We're still writing ours."

That was a little comforting to hear. "…So we'll finish, someday too?"

The Keeper looked at me a moment and said,

"…I don't know. I don't know that either."

I found that honest answer, oddly, more trustworthy. Standing beside someone who says they don't know is more comfortable than standing beside someone who claims to know everything.

. . .

That day I thought a little more about the five cities' record-keepers. Each of them had gone through something hard, in their own city, and left it down in a record. And that record had ended up, in the end, here, in Loop. I found that remarkable. That the stories of people who'd each gone through different things, in different places, ended up lying side by side, in the end, on one table, in one repository.

I thought this coincidence wasn't a coincidence. I had no exact grounds for it. It was just a feeling. I learn that this feeling was right, much further into this book.

. . .

After that, I often opened that table again whenever I had time. Each time I discovered something new. I reread a sentence I'd missed in Haven's record, checked a number in the Reckoning's record again, looked again at a single name in the Harvest's record.

The Keeper didn't stop me from doing this. If anything, he came over now and then and read along with me.

"…What do you think this means?" I once asked, pointing to a passage.

The Keeper studied that sentence for a long while and said,

"…I don't know either. But it's a good sentence."

I liked that answer. Not someone who knew everything, but someone who was curious alongside me.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I think back again on the six bundles that lay on that table that day. Six different forms, six different stories, and yet six records with something, somewhere, alike about them.

I couldn't put into words, at the time, exactly what that likeness was. I still can't, fully, now. But I can say this much for certain — that afternoon, laying those six side by side and looking at them, is one of the scenes I hold most dear in this whole record.

. . .

After that, I secretly decided to call that table the "six-record table." I told no one, but I called it that to myself. I never actually put a label on the table. I only called it that, inside my own mind.

I'm revealing this name here for the first time. Writing this chapter, I felt afresh how long this small private word had stayed inside me. I never expected one small name to last this long. Even now, writing it down in this very moment, it stirs something strange in me.

. . .

Once, another apprentice saw that table and asked.

"…What's this?" she asked.

"…Just — the six cities' records, gathered together."

"…Why'd you gather them?"

I couldn't answer right away. "…Just curious."

She didn't seem very interested. She leafed through a few pages and went back to her own work. I didn't mind that. Not everyone needed to be curious about the same thing.

. . .

That night at home, I brought this up with my parents, a little.

"…I gathered all six cities' records together today, and looked at them."

"…So, what did you find out?" my father asked.

I thought a moment and answered, "…I'm not sure. But there's something similar between them, I think."

"…Similar how?"

"…I can't put it into words yet."

My father didn't press further. He just nodded and ate his dinner. I was grateful for that silence, that day. It was a relief not having to force words together. That was just how it was, in our house.

. . .

Before truly closing this chapter, I want to write, in one sentence, what these six records gave me. It won't be a perfect sentence. I'll set it down anyway.

Six cities were each walking, in their own way, toward something. And I was the one who gathered those six paths in one place, and looked at them.

I don't think of this sentence as this chapter's conclusion. It was still too early to draw a conclusion. I only wanted to leave this sentence, exactly as it was, for the girl I was that day.

The six-record table stayed beside my seat for a long time after. I glanced at it every time I passed. Even empty, it felt as though something was filling it. That feeling is exactly the same, even now.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. The Water Channel

> *_Previously_ — Mone gathered the five cities' records on one table and read them for the first time. Each city was heading, in its own way, toward something — but Loop's record had no such direction. It was only asking and answering, on and on.*

I need to write properly about the water channel.

The channel I saw that first day, the color of soil, shallow, always making its sound. I'd walked past it every day since then. Usually, growing used to a thing means it stops being seen — but I was now looking at that water with different eyes than before.

In this chapter I set down what I came to learn about the water channel. I'll say ahead of time — there are more questions than answers. This water channel is one of the last things in this whole record to remain fully unexplained.

. . .

The channel runs behind the repository and out the far side of the city. I didn't know exactly where it began, or where it went. So one day I decided to walk along it.

I asked the Keeper for permission, and he nodded without much comment.

"…Going alone?"

"…Yes."

"…Don't go far. Be back before dark."

I kept to that, and walked exactly half a day.

. . .

Walking along the channel, I saw it passing all through the city. Behind the market, under the school's wall, through back alleys people rarely walked. Wherever it went, the water flowed at the same pace, making the same sound.

I felt, for the first time that day, how this channel cut across the whole city. That beneath, or beside, the roads I walked every day, this water had always been flowing. I hadn't truly looked at it, in sixteen years.

. . .

Reaching the edge of the city, the channel passed through a small sluice gate under the wall and went outside. I stood before that gate a long while and looked. It was the spot where the water left the city.

"…Arche, where does this water go?" I asked.

The waterway beyond the sluice gate connects to a neighboring district; the route past that point is outside Loop's jurisdiction.

"…Then how far does it go?"

What can be confirmed extends only to Loop's boundary. Beyond that, it is not recorded.

That answer left me disappointed, for the first time, that day. It wasn't that Arche didn't know — it was that this lay outside Arche's jurisdiction. It was

the first time I'd heard that phrase, outside its jurisdiction. It felt unfamiliar, and I turned it over a long while.

. . .

I wanted to check the other direction too — where the channel entered the city. I went out again, another day, and walked that way.

The water flowed in from a hill on the far side of the city. I climbed that hill. From the top, I could see the channel winding in from far away, bending and turning. Even from there, I couldn't see all the way to where it began.

"…Arche, where does this water start?" I asked again.

The source is presumed to lie outside Loop's boundary, but the exact point cannot be confirmed.

. . .

I passed this along to the Keeper that day.

"…Arche doesn't know where the channel comes from, or where it goes, either."

The Keeper paused his hands and looked at me.

"…I know that too. I've asked before, myself."

"…Weren't you curious?"

"…I was. But I checked as far as I could get on foot. I couldn't go further than that."

"…Why not?"

"…There wasn't time. And—" The Keeper paused a moment. "…It wasn't something I had to know."

. . .

That sounded strange to me. "…Why aren't you curious? It's the water channel — something this important to our city."

"…It's important, true. But not everything important is something you have to know."

I turned that over. I think I understand it a little, now. I didn't understand it well then.

This water channel comes back again, much further into this book. Someone, then, comes to tell me a little more about what this channel really is. For now I'll only set down that no one knew, exactly.

. . .

I also learned that this channel had never once come up as a matter of city business. Somewhere like the Equity writes down every single thing in its minutes — but no one had ever once held a meeting about the water channel.

"…Arche, is there someone specifically in charge of this channel?" I asked.

No designated managing party can be confirmed.

"…Then who manages it?"

This cannot be confirmed. However, the channel has continued flowing throughout the observable period, and has been maintained with no significant change.

I found that remarkable. No one managed it, and the water kept flowing anyway.

. . .

I came to see the water channel differently, from that day. No mark on it anywhere, no owner anywhere, never once brought up as an item of business. And yet flowing every day, without a single day's rest.

I felt, that day, that this channel resembled the way records arrived in this record. What came by hand, you could know who'd sent it. What came by the channel, you couldn't. And the channel itself — who had made it — no one knew that either.

. . .

I asked Arche again.

"…Arche, why do all the records that come by this channel flow here?"

By route, Loop appears to lie downstream. The waterways of the other cities merge into this one.

"…Other cities' waterways? So all five cities' water comes here?"

As far as can be confirmed, yes.

I was a little startled by that answer. It meant that, by the flow of water, this city lay lowest of all. The water of five cities was all gathering into Loop. I thought that couldn't be a coincidence.

. . .

That evening I passed this on to the Keeper.

"…All five cities' water gathers here, apparently. Because we're the lowest point."

The Keeper nodded. "…I'd guess so."

"…So that's why the records come by the channel, too?"

"…Could be that too."

I knew that wasn't a full confirmation. But it felt like something fitting together, all the same. Just as water flows downward, records seemed to flow, gathering, toward somewhere too. I wrote that feeling briefly in my notebook.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I think back again on that moment standing before the sluice gate, looking down at the water. I never did find out exactly where that water came from, or where it went. But this much was clear — that water flowed cutting across the whole city, and that water carried something to this repository, every single day.

I want to call this water channel the quietest character in this whole book. No one knew it exactly, and yet it was always there.

. . .

Walking along the channel that day, I met an old man along the way. He was sitting by the water with no fishing rod, just watching it.

"…What are you doing here?" I asked.

"…Just watching the water. I come here when I'm bored."

"…Is it fun?"

The old man laughed. "…Not fun, exactly. But watching it puts my mind at ease."

I sat beside him a while. The water kept flowing, making the same sound. The old man said nothing, just watched the water. I found the silence strangely comfortable.

. . .

"…Grandfather, do you know where this water comes from?" I asked.

"…No. Wouldn't be any use even if I did."

"…Why no use?"

"…Knowing doesn't make the water flow any differently, does it."

That line stayed with me strangely. That knowing doesn't change anything. I wanted to argue against it, right then, but I didn't know exactly what to say back.

Thinking about it now, the old man's words weren't entirely right. Knowing doesn't change the water — but it changes the one who knows. My eyes for looking at the water channel changed, from that day on. But I couldn't say that, in front of the old man.

. . .

A little later I asked the old man a bit more. "…Have you lived here a long time, Grandfather?"

"…A very long time."

"…Has this channel ever changed, then?"

The old man thought a moment, then shook his head. "…Not that I know of. It's always flowed about this much. Not more, not less."

"…That's remarkable."

"…Nothing remarkable about it. That's just how it is."

I thought that answer sounded a lot like the Keeper's way of talking. Everyone in this city seemed to say much the same thing, faced with something strange. *That's just how it is.*

. . .

Walking home, I kept thinking about what the old man had said. That knowing was no use, and that it was just how things were. Both sounded like resignation, somehow, and yet not quite resignation. I couldn't put my finger on that difference precisely, at the time.

I think I understand it a little now. Resignation is not trying to know any further. That old man, and the Keeper, weren't refusing to know any further. They simply knew how to get along fine, without knowing.

. . .

A few days later, I went back to the channel. This time I didn't just walk — I studied the water closely. Small stones lined the bottom, and now and then a small fish passed by. I watched that little fish swim against the current for a long while, and then asked again.

"…Arche, does this water have fish living in it?"

Confirmed. Several species of small fish are observed to inhabit it.

"…Do they have names?"

General names exist, but there is no record distinguishing individual fish.

I found that answer, somehow, a little funny. It knew the kind of fish, but not how many lived there, or where they'd come from. Everything about this channel was like that. Known, to a point — but never known all the way.

. . .

That evening I told this to the Keeper, and asked,

"…Keeper, is this channel the strangest thing in this city?"

The Keeper thought a moment and answered,

"…It isn't the only strange thing here."

"…What else is there?"

The Keeper looked at me steadily and said,

"…You'll find out soon enough, yourself."

I had some vague sense of what he might mean, at that, but I didn't know exactly what he was pointing to. I didn't ask further, and just nodded. There was always this corner to the Keeper's way of speaking, foretelling something further ahead.

. . .

I should set down one last thing about this channel. From then on, every time I went to and from the repository, I heard that sound of water. At first it had just been background noise. Now it carried a different meaning to me.

This water had come all the way here, past six cities. No one knew where it began, or who had made it. And yet it flowed without a single day's rest. I thought this water shared the same fate as the records that came to this city. Not knowing why it came — but coming, all the same, continually.

. . .

After that, I came to love the small bridge crossing the channel. Walking home from the repository, I crossed that bridge. Stopping at its middle a moment to look down at the water became a habit.

One day, I happened to run into the Keeper on that bridge. He seemed to be on his way home too.

"…What are you doing here?" the Keeper asked.

"…Just watching the water."

The Keeper came and looked down beside me. "…I stop here sometimes too."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know either. I just end up stopping."

. . .

We stood on that bridge a long while that day, saying nothing. Only the sound of the water. I didn't find that silence awkward. If anything, it was comfortable.

"…Keeper." I broke the silence first. "…Aren't you curious where this water comes from? Really."

The Keeper looked at the water a moment, then answered.

"…I am curious. But being curious and having to know are different things too."

"…What's different about them?"

"…It means it's all right to leave it, curious. Turns out you can get by fine even without finding the answer."

I thought about that a long while. Getting by fine even without finding the answer. It wasn't giving up — it felt like a different kind of peace.

. . .

From that day, I called that bridge, to myself, "the curious bridge." Like the six-record table, this too was a name I gave and told no one.

Writing this record, I realize afresh how many names I gave to things. To a table, to a bridge. I think I was trying, by naming things, not to lose them. A habit learned moving nine times, showing up here too, this way. Once I gave something a name, it stopped being something that just passed by, and became mine.

. . .

At the end of this chapter, I want to make one thing clear. I never did find out, in the end, what this channel truly was. Even now, writing this book, I still don't fully know. But I do know what this channel was, to this city, and to me.

Something always flowing. Something that never stopped, even with no one managing it. And above all, something that carried things here, past five cities. That alone was enough to make me love this channel.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I picture myself again, standing before that sluice gate. The sixteen-year-old me turned back that day without finding an answer. The me now thinks it was a good thing, actually, that I didn't find the answer that day. If I'd known the answer beforehand, I don't think I'd have gone back to look at that channel so many times, after.

Curiosity sometimes outlasts an answer. I learned that, thanks to this water channel.

The water channel comes back, again and again, in many places in this record. Closing this chapter, I want to promise one thing ahead of time. I won't put off

this channel's answer to the very end — I'll write it, in order, into this record, as I come to know it. For now, in this chapter, I think it's right to set down, simply, that I still knew nothing at all.

. . .

After that, I visited that bridge once more, each time the season changed. It wasn't exactly a habit I'd set for myself. My feet just went that way.

On rainy days the water swelled and its sound grew louder. On dry days it thinned, and more of the bottom stones showed. Even so, it never once ran dry. I found that remarkable, at first, and later just took it for granted. It didn't take long for the wonder to turn into the ordinary.

I don't quite know whether that change was good or bad. Losing the eyes that find something wonderful is, in some sense, a loss. But I gained something else, in its place. An ear that could tell the water's sound was a little different, each time. I wanted to set that down in this record.

Once, there was a day the water ran unusually clear. That day, for the first time, I saw the color of the bottom stones distinctly. Not the color of soil, but gray. I wrote that down in my notebook too. Knowing it was a nearly useless thing to record, I wrote it down anyway. If I didn't write it down, I felt I'd soon forget the color of the water, that day.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. The Door Not in the Index

> *_Previously_ — Mone walked the length of the water channel but never found its source or its end. All she learned was that the water of all five cities gathers into Loop, and that this city lies lowest of all, by the flow of water. Arche didn't know the answer. Neither did the Keeper. Neither did the old man by the water.*

I should talk about the corridor.

The repository corridor runs straight. Coming in from the entrance, rooms line up on either side, and the corridor passes between them, all the way to the back. I walked this corridor several times a day. Carrying a bundle, pushing a handcart, sometimes just walking.

There's a door at the very end of the corridor.

I've already written this once, before. On the first day I saw that door and thought nothing of it. I wrote, at the time, that I'd tell about that door at the end of Part One. This is that place, now.

. . .

There's something I should say first. In this chapter, I do not open that door.

I'm saying this ahead of time in case someone reading this chapter is waiting for something big to happen. It doesn't. I only stood before that door, that day.

That door didn't look any different from the corridor's other doors. A wooden door, with a handle, and no marking above the frame. Every other door had a

section number on a small wooden plate. Section Fourteen, Section Fifteen, and so on. This door had no plate.

The first day I saw it, I just walked past. A newly arrived apprentice had no time to spare for one door at the end of a corridor. Just placing bundles where Arche told me to was more than enough to keep me busy.

Many months had passed since then. By now I had nearly memorized twenty-two rows, eight slots, forty bundles. And yet, passing that door, I never once registered that it had no number plate. What had gone unseen only began to be seen recently.

. . .

The trigger was nothing much.

I was on my way back that day, having shelved a bundle in Section Fourteen. I'd walked all the way to the end of the corridor and was turning back when, out of nowhere, that door caught my eye. I don't know why it suddenly came into view, that day.

I won't try to explain this coincidence. Some days, something that's always been there suddenly comes into view. Some days there's no reason you can point to.

I stopped walking and looked at the door. No marking at all. The frame was the same wood as every other door. Nothing special about it.

And yet the very fact of nothing was strange. Because there was nothing in this repository without a marking. Every shelf had a number, every bundle had a name, even the fish had their kind. Arche answered whatever you asked it. The only nameless thing in this city was Loop's own record — and even that had a reason: "no name, because it's from here."

This door had no name, and no reason either.

. . .

I decided to ask Arche. It wasn't some great resolve. I just asked, the way I always did.

"…Arche, this door at the end of the corridor — what section is it?"

The answer came a little late. Only slightly. Half a beat slower than usual, maybe. I'd like to say I noticed that faint delay right then, but the truth is I only realized it afterward.

That area is not registered.

I didn't understand the words at first.

"…What does 'not registered' mean?"

No registration record exists for that location.

"…Then you don't even know what's inside this door?"

I do not.

I was a little startled. It wasn't as though I'd never heard Arche say it didn't know something. When I'd asked about the closing condition, Arche had said it didn't know, too. But that had been the not-knowing of "not defined." This was different. This was the plain not-knowing of never having seen something that was there.

. . .

I asked a little more.

"…Is it hidden?"

No. Hidden and unregistered are different.

"…What's different about them?"

Hidden means restricting access to a registered item. Unregistered means it never went through the registration process to begin with.

That distinction felt unfamiliar to me. Up to then, I'd always assumed that if something went unseen, someone had concealed it. Even the things I'd lost, moving nine times, I'd always thought of that way. That they were somewhere, and I just couldn't find them. But Arche was saying something different. That some things had simply never been given a place, from the start.

I thought about this distinction a long while, that evening. What's hidden, and what's never been registered. I learned, that day, for the first time, that the two might look the same in the end, but they start from different places.

"…Then who made this door?"

Cannot be confirmed.

"…When was it made?"

Cannot be confirmed.

I asked one more thing, even so.

"…Then who does the registering? Who registered the other sections?"

Registration is carried out by the administrator at the time of first intake.

"…So no one ever brought anything into this one?"

Cannot be confirmed. Only the fact that no registration process was carried out can be confirmed. The reason is unknown.

I turned that answer over. Every other room had had someone bring something in for the first time, and give it a name, at some point. But this door had never once gone through that process. It wasn't that there'd been no one to make it — it meant that even if someone had made it, no one had given it a name. That difference kept catching on something in my mind.

"…Doesn't Arche think that's strange?"

Strangeness is not something I judge. I report fact.

I thought that answer was exactly like Arche. Even faced with something strange, it never said strange. It only said what was there.

There was nothing left for me to ask. Arche hadn't hidden anything. It simply didn't know. And Arche did nothing at all, beyond saying that it didn't know what it didn't know. No lie, no evasion. That, if anything, held me there longer.

. . .

I reached out and took hold of the handle.

It wasn't locked. It turned, slightly. I still remember that feeling, the handle turning. It wasn't stiff. It was smooth, for a door that hadn't been used in a long time.

I want to set down this feeling exactly. If it had been locked, I think I would have written this chapter differently. One simple fact — that the door wouldn't

open — would have made this story much simpler. That it wasn't locked made me draw back, instead, all the more.

I stood there a moment, hand on the handle. Push, and it would open. All I had to do was push.

I didn't push.

. . .

Asked for a reason, I can't give a good one. I couldn't, that day, and I still can't, fully, now.

Throughout this record I've tried hard to attach a reason to everything. Why I got good at packing, why I came to put things in order, why I came to write things down. Finding a reason set my mind at ease. This time I found none. I'm writing this chapter without having found one.

I took my hand off the handle. The door stayed closed, exactly as it was. No sound came from inside. None came from outside, either. The corridor was quiet as always.

I stepped back and looked at the door again. A wooden door, a handle, an unmarked frame. It still looked like a door that was nothing at all.

But I already knew it wasn't a door that was nothing at all. I just didn't know what it was.

. . .

The next day I went outside and walked a circuit around the repository building.

The reason was simple. I wondered whether, seen from outside, I could tell where the inside of that door lay. Maybe there'd be a window, and something to see through it.

I wrote, once at the start, that this building looks low and small, seen from outside. I also wrote that, once you're in, it runs back a long way. That day, I went, in effect, to check that again.

I walked along the wall, counting windows. Five in front, six along the side, three in back. I tried to match that number against the number of rooms in the corridor, inside. It didn't match. There were more rooms than there were windows.

In particular, on the outer wall around where that door should have been, at the very end of the corridor, there wasn't a single window. Only brick. I stood before that wall a long while. It was the same brick as everywhere else. No trace of having been newly built, no trace of having been sealed shut.

"…Arche, is the far side of this wall the inside of that door?" I asked.

The positional correspondence cannot be confirmed.

I laughed at that answer. Asking from inside, it didn't know; asking from outside, it didn't know either. Arche was equally honest, whichever side you asked from.

. . .

That evening I told the Keeper about this.

"…That door at the end of the corridor — Arche says it isn't in the index."

The Keeper paused what he was doing. His face wasn't surprised.

"…Yes, it isn't."

"…You knew?"

"…I knew. You come to know, staying here long enough."

"…Then why didn't anyone tell me?"

The Keeper shrugged.

"…Because no one had asked."

That answer sounded, strangely, exactly right to me. For months I'd walked past that door and never once asked. I hadn't even thought to ask. What had gone unnoticed had only just now, suddenly, become something I noticed — what hadn't been curious had only just now, suddenly, become curious.

"…Have you opened it?" I asked.

"…No."

"…Why not?"

The Keeper's face turned thoughtful for a moment.

"…If you're asking me for a reason I never opened a door that isn't even locked, I don't have a good one myself. I just never opened it."

Hearing that answer put me a little at ease. It wasn't only me.

. . .

"…Aren't you curious?" I asked again.

"…I am."

"…But?"

"…Being curious and opening it are two different things, too."

I felt I'd heard that line somewhere before. The Keeper had said something similar, talking about the water channel. That it was fine to leave something, curious. That you could get by fine, even without finding the answer.

I tried, right then, to tie those words together into one thing. The water channel, this door, and all those cases Arche could never close. All of them were things left standing, curious, unresolved. I thought that seemed like some common thread running through this city. Whether that thought was right, I wouldn't learn until much further into this record.

"…What do you think is inside that door, Keeper?" I asked.

The Keeper paused his hands and thought a moment.

"…I don't know. Could be something grand in there. Could be completely empty."

"…What if it's empty?"

"…Then that'd be strange too, in its own way. Nothing there, and not even registered."

I liked that answer. Either way, it was strange. And this city ran along just fine, not knowing which. I found that remarkable.

"…Don't you want to open it? Really." I asked once more.

The Keeper looked at me steadily.

"…Mone. I've worked here more than twenty years. If that were the only door I ever wanted to open, I'd have opened it long ago."

I didn't fully understand what that meant, at the time. *I understand it a little now. That door wasn't the only door, in this city, someone might want to open. All those cases that never closed were, in a sense, closed doors too. The Keeper was someone who had lived twenty years among those doors.*

. . .

That night, at home, I wrote this on paper.

There's a door at the end of the corridor. It isn't in Arche's index. It says it isn't hidden — it just was never registered. It isn't locked. I took hold of the handle, and let go. I don't know why I didn't open it.

I wrote one more line underneath, and left it, without crossing it out. "I don't know why this weighs on me so much." Copying this record out now, I'm leaving that line exactly as it was. I didn't know the answer then, and I still don't know it exactly, writing this chapter.

But I can set down this much, for certain. It wasn't the first time I'd seen that door. I'd already seen it once, at the start. That day I thought it was nothing at all. This time it wasn't. The door was the same. What had changed was me.

. . .

After that, every few days, passing that door, I found my steps slowing a little.

Once, I deliberately went back late in the evening, when no one else was around. Some of the corridor lights were off, and it was dim. The door stood

the same, even in the dark. I stood before it, saying nothing, and looked a long while.

"…Arche, do you know I'm standing here right now?" I asked.

Your position is confirmed.

"…But you don't know inside the door?"

I do not.

That was, strangely, a comfort. Arche knew me exactly, and yet knew nothing of this one door. Even in a city that seemed to know everything, there was one corner it didn't know. That didn't feel like a bad thing.

Another time, in daylight, I took hold of the handle again. Still not locked. I didn't push that day, either. Instead I turned the handle slightly and counted. Counted to ten. Then let go.

I can't explain this action well, even to myself. Counting to ten didn't change anything. I think I just wanted to stay before that door, that way, a little longer.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I picture that door once more.

The unmarked frame, the handle that turned smoothly, the corridor with no sound from inside or out. I end Part One without having opened that door.

This door comes back again, in this record. When, and how, I won't say now. All I can set down now is this. I found out nothing at all, that day, standing before that door. I turned back, having found out nothing. That's all there is to this chapter.

I close Part One of this record here. Across twelve chapters I put things in order, I asked Arche, I walked the water channel, and now I stand before this door. Not one thing has finished. Not the channel's source, not Arche's closing condition, not what's inside this door. I thought, at the time, that this was strange. I know now. In this city, this is simply how Part One ends.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Last Room, Part Two

The Same Man

Chapter 13. Histor

> *_Previously_ — In the deepest part of the repository, Mone saw for the first time a door that was not in Arche's index.* ***That area is not registered.*** *It didn't mean hidden — it meant never registered at all. The door wasn't locked. Mone didn't open it.*

The day that person came, I had already half forgotten about the door.

That wasn't strange. New bundles came into the repository every day. Six bundles that needed placing today mattered more than one door I hadn't seen yesterday. *I know now that was an excuse. I didn't know it then.*

The Keeper called me in that morning.

"…Someone's coming today."

"…Who?"

"…Someone named Histor. Coming to cross-check."

"…Cross-check?"

The Keeper handed me a sheet of paper. The handwriting was neat. Not an official hand — a personal one, and more precise than any official hand I'd seen.

"…Says he's read all six cities' records. He wrote asking for someone to help him."

"…Read them? All of what's here?"

"…Not what's here. He read them elsewhere. And then he wrote saying he wanted to cross-check them here."

I found that hard to believe. Our repository alone held twenty-two rows, eight sections to a row, forty bundles to a section. And that was only Loop's own — put all six cities together and it would be many times that.

"…How does anyone read all of that?"

The Keeper shrugged once.

"…I don't know. Ask him when he gets here."

Writing this now, I remember that shrug of the Keeper's again. That person wasn't especially surprised by how remarkable Histor was. I'd learn the reason for that later too. Not yet.

I spent the rest of that morning rearranging the shelves for no reason. Squaring corners that were already square. I always did that when someone was coming. I'm not sure why. I think tidying the place came before tidying myself around a person — that was my way.

Looking back now, that's funny. Histor never cared about places at all. What he cared about was order. That looks similar but it isn't the same thing.

. . .

Histor came around noon.

I saw him pause for a moment in front of the door. Before he came in, he looked up once at the doorframe. Just a wooden frame, nothing

special about it. But he looked at it as if he were confirming something.

"…This is the Loop repository," he said.

There was no question mark in his voice. He sounded like a man saying something he already knew.

"…Yes," I answered.

"…You're Mone. I heard about you."

I was a little surprised. I hadn't often met anyone who already knew my name in advance.

"…About me?"

"…The Keeper wrote it in the letter. Said there was an apprentice. Said she was good at putting things in order."

I'll admit I felt pleased to hear that. I came to be wary of that feeling often afterward. That wariness began in this moment.

He didn't have much luggage. One bag, but it looked like it held more paper than clothes. His steps were careful — he walked like a man trying not to step on something.

He was a little taller than me, and he wore glasses. His nails were short. I thought, those are the nails of someone who handles paper — and later I learned that was exactly right. He said long nails make it hard to handle old paper.

"…May I come in?" he asked.

He asked before he came in. I noted that too. People coming to the repository for the first time usually just walk in — the door is open, after all. He asked permission even standing in front of an open door.

"…Yes, come in."

He came in. The first thing he did wasn't a greeting. He looked down at his feet, because there was a piece of paper on the floor — one I'd missed while tidying that morning. He bent down and picked it up. Without even turning it over, he set it neatly on the nearest shelf.

"…You can't just leave things anywhere, in a place like this," he said.

"…I'll show you where things go later," I said.

I have to confess I held on to this short scene for a long time. The fact that the first thing a person did on coming to our repository was pick up a piece of paper off the floor. I liked that. I still like it. That liking would confuse me later, and I'll get to that.

. . .

The Keeper led him all the way inside.

Histor stopped in front of the first shelf. He didn't touch anything. He only looked. He looked for a long time.

"…This is Section Fourteen," he said.

I was surprised. You had to ask Arche to know a section number. It wasn't written large anywhere on the outside. People who'd memorized the layout knew it, but it wasn't something a newcomer could know.

"…How do you know that?"

"…Ah, I got a map of the sections by letter. I memorized it in advance."

He said it without any weight to it. Not a boast. Just stating a fact.

I would come to sum up that tone in one sentence later. He never boasted. I'm not saying that as though it were a flaw. Only that a moment would come later when it felt strange.

. . .

The Keeper took him to a small room at the back of the stacks. Said it was the room where the cross-checking would happen. One desk, two chairs, a small window.

"…You can stay here," the Keeper said. "…If you need anything, tell Mone."

"…Thank you."

After the Keeper left, I stood there a little awkwardly, not knowing what to help with. Histor opened his bag and took out a bundle of paper, setting it neatly on the desk. Squared at the corners.

"…What should we look at first?" I asked.

He looked at me. For the first time, a little longer than usual.

"…Have you read all six cities' records, Mone?"

"…Not all of it. I just put things in place as they came in. I haven't read much."

"…Then let's look together starting today. I know where everything is, so if you can find the physical bundles, it'll go faster."

I nodded. It sounded like a natural division of labor. *At the time I thought it was just that — a division of labor.*

. . .

That afternoon we pulled out the first bundle.

It was Haven's. The name was written on the cover. Elpis. I read the name aloud.

"…Elpis."

"…Yes. A record written by a thirteen-year-old girl. Her brother's name is Zeteo."

He said that without even opening the cover.

"…You know without looking?"

"…Roughly, from the color and weight of the cover. But I still have to check."

He opened the cover. He read the first page. He read it slowly. Histor read slowly. That surprised me a little. I'd expected someone who knew everything to flip through fast.

"…If you already know it, why read it again?"

He answered without lifting his head.

"…You have to read it again to be accurate. Memory is wrong sometimes."

At the time I just heard that as diligence. I read it differently now. He didn't distrust his own memory. He wanted to keep his memory accurate. Those two things are different.

When he finished the first page, he made a small mark in the margin. In pencil, very faint. I asked what it was.

"…It's marking where I read this before. I read this passage somewhere else once. I'm checking whether the original here matches what I read then."

"…Has it ever been different?"

"…Sometimes. A copyist drops a line here and there, or a word gets changed. Usually a small difference."

"…This time?"

He looked again at the line he'd marked.

"…This time it's the same."

His expression barely changed as he said it. He wasn't pleased that he'd been right, and he didn't look like he would have been disappointed if he'd been wrong. It was just the face of a person checking something.

Beside him, I asked Arche a few things — what came next in this section, whether any more bundles would come in today. Histor watched closely as I asked Arche.

"…Do you ask Arche often, Mone?"

"…Yes. Doesn't everyone?"

"…That's true, mostly." He paused for a moment, then went on. "…I don't ask much. I don't need to ask again about things I already know."

I let that pass at the time. *I learned later it wasn't something to let pass.*

. . .

Toward evening, he closed the book for the first time and looked at me.

"…Mone, why do you work here?"

It was a sudden question. I thought for a moment.

"…Because I'm good at putting things in order."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes."

He looked as though he might ask something more after that answer, but he didn't. He just nodded once.

"…I came because I wanted to know this," he said, lightly tapping the paper resting on his hand. "…Where things are, what's written on them. That."

"…The reason?"

"…Let's talk about that later."

I didn't ask further. It didn't seem polite to press on the first day. *Looking back, even if I'd heard the answer that day, I wouldn't have understood it. It took me eleven chapters to understand that answer.*

. . .

Before dinner I showed him around the repository once. Not a formal tour — just telling him roughly what was where.

"…This row is Haven's. That row is the Reckoning's, and next to it the Harvest's. The Preserve is further in, and the Equity is at the very end."

"…And Loop's?"

"…This middle row. It has no name on it."

"…Right. You don't write your own name on yourself."

I felt like I'd heard that somewhere before. Then I remembered. It was what the Keeper had said to me on my first day. Like not writing your own address on your own letter's envelope.

"…That's something the Keeper said."

"…Ah, it was in the letter. That he'd explained it to you that way."

I found that a little strange — that the Keeper had written even a small thing he'd said to me into a letter, in that much detail. But at the time I just thought the Keeper was a thoughtful person. *I'd learn the reason he wrote that letter in such detail much later. I'll get to that too.*

Standing in front of the middle row, he was quiet for a moment. He didn't even pull out a bundle. He just looked. I didn't want to interrupt, so I waited beside him.

"…This is the oldest one," he said.

"…Yes. That's what they say."

"…How old?"

"…I don't know exactly either. Should I ask?"

"…No. Never mind."

I didn't get to ask why "never mind" that time. I should have.

. . .

By evening the Keeper came again. Without even asking how Histor had been getting on, he just said,

"…Have you eaten?"

"…Not yet," Histor answered.

"…Mone will take you. There's a place to eat nearby."

I was a little taken aback at that. I'd shown him around, but I hadn't expected to have dinner with him too. Histor packed his bag without much comment.

On the way out, he stopped once more in front of the door. He looked up at the doorframe, just as he had coming in that morning.

"…What are you looking at?" I asked.

"…Nothing. Just confirming the day is over."

"…You check things like that too?"

"…I'm the kind of person who checks things like that."

He said it as if it were a joke, but it didn't sound like a joke to me. *Reading it again now, it still isn't a joke. He really was that kind of person. Whether a day had started or ended, whether a record was right or wrong, whether where he'd read something matched what was here. He was a person who checked. Not a person who believed.*

The place to eat wasn't far from the repository. He didn't talk much on the way. I didn't try to fill the silence either. Walking with a stranger in silence should have felt uncomfortable, but strangely it didn't. He seemed like someone who kept even silence in order.

Once we sat down at the table, he spoke again.

"…Mone, tomorrow we really start."

"…Start what?"

"…Pulling out all six records and laying them side by side. I can't do it alone. You're faster at finding the physical bundles."

"…I can't cross-check. I don't even know what overlaps."

"…That's fine. I'll do that. All you need to do is find things."

I nodded. I thought at the time it was simple collaboration. *It was collaboration. Only it took longer than I'd imagined.*

That night, walking home, I wrote in my paper.

Histor came. Seventeen. Says he's read all six cities' records. Knows things just from the cover. But he reads again. Reads slowly. Seems like a careful person.

I added one more line beside it. I almost erased it later but didn't. "Envious." The first feeling I had, seeing a sixteen-year-old confronted with someone who knew everything, wasn't awe but envy. I decided not to be ashamed of that. It was true.

On the way home I passed the water channel. The water sounded the same as always. That day, for some reason, I listened to it a little longer. Something Histor had said in the afternoon, standing in front of the middle row — "This is the oldest one" — kept bothering me. That I hadn't asked, when I should have, bothered me.

Going back over that day now, I know it wasn't just one or two things I missed. He showed me a great deal on the very first day. Looking up at the doorframe. Picking up the paper off the floor. Checking again what he already knew. Not asking Arche. I didn't properly read any of it that day. A sixteen-year-old can't read a person all at once. I learned that for the first time then.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. I Know All of It

> *_Previously_ — Histor came to the repository. Seventeen, and he says*
> *he's read every one of the six cities' records. He never handles paper carelessly, and he checks even what he already knows. Starting*
> *the next day, they agreed to lay all six records side by side.*

The next morning, I wanted to test him.

Not out of any unkindness. I was just curious. Whether he really knew everything. The night before, I'd already written down a few things. I thought I'd pull a bundle from any section, any row, open it to any page, and ask.

"…What are you doing?" Histor asked.

"…A test."

His eyebrows went up slightly. Not an angry look.

"…Sounds interesting. Go ahead."

Writing this now, I believe he really did find it interesting then. He wasn't someone who disliked being tested. He felt no strain at all in proving what he knew.

I set one rule. One from each of the six rows, pulled from any section, opened to any page, and I'd ask. Six times. He listened to the rule and nodded.

"…One thing before we start," he said.

"…Yes?"

"…If I get it wrong, you don't have to believe me. That's fine."

That struck me as a little odd. It wasn't the tone of someone worried about losing before a test — it was the tone of someone for whom winning and losing made no difference at all. *At the time I only read that as confidence. I didn't yet know how to read it differently.*

. . .

I pulled a bundle from the Reckoning's row. I thought I'd pulled it at random, but looking back it wasn't chance at all. A hand always goes to where it's used to going.

"…This one. I'll open it anywhere."

I opened it somewhere near the middle. I put a finger on a paragraph.

"…Here — what's this about?"

He answered without even looking under my finger.

"…Do I need the part before it?"

"…No, just this passage."

"…It's the scene where the Adjudicator first reads the Forty-Day Provision aloud. Attached to the back of the Reckoning's demolition sentence. It's three days after Pheugon runs away — after he's shut in the well conduit and comes out and goes to find the Adjudicator again."

I read the paragraph myself, finger still in place. It matched. Exactly right.

"…How do you know this?"

"…Because I read it."

I let this answer pass lightly that day. I learned later how heavy the words "because I read it" really were. That was exactly as much as he said. Never more.

. . .

I kept going. This time I pulled from the Preserve's row.

"…What about this?"

"…That should be the scene where Anemos tries to apply for a second visit and can't. He goes as far as the reception window and turns back. It doesn't say why. It just says he turned back."

I opened it. It matched. Exactly that scene. Even the part about no reason being given matched.

I got a little chill.

"…How do you even remember that a reason wasn't given?"

"…Because I can't say something's there when it isn't. I only say what's there. If it isn't, I say it isn't."

I'd come to think about this line again later. It was almost exactly what Arche says. It says it doesn't know when it doesn't know. It says there's nothing when there's nothing. At the time I just thought that

was interesting. I didn't understand why it was interesting until much later.

. . .

The Harvest, Haven, the Equity, Loop. I did five more. All five correct. He never got one wrong.

From the Harvest's row he described exactly the scene where Lytron asks Xene, "Why do you come every day to a place with nothing here?" — even the reason Xene went out to that corner of the field every day.

From Haven's row he described the passage where Zeteo first begins to doubt Haven's "resolutions," down to the scene where the overseer mistakes it for "not enough submissions yet."

For the Equity's row, he answered a little differently.

"…This one's harder. It's the scene where Hora first sees the empty signature box — that character appears only four times in this record. Every time, in three sentences or fewer. This isn't one of those scenes."

"…Who?"

"…Ah, sorry, I didn't explain. There's a person with no name who appears in all six records. I just call him that for convenience."

I was hearing that for the first time. The man with no name. *I remember exactly the moment I first heard those words. At the time I thought it was just a literary device. A minor character who shows up in every book, that sort of thing.*

. . .

Last, I pulled from Loop's row. The middle row, the one with no name.

"…This one I'm most confident about," he said.

He started speaking before he even opened it.

"…If it comes right after the scene where Mena takes off her shoes, then it's the part where Grandfather writes 'Not yet' in the margin of the oldest bundle. He wrote it seventeen times. On the last sheet there's one more line in a different hand —"

He stopped for a moment.

"…Should I say it?"

I was already too curious to wait.

"…Yes, tell me."

"…'You don't have to wait any more.' That one line."

I opened it and checked. It matched. Exactly right. The note even said the handwriting was different, just as he'd described.

I read that line again. "You don't have to wait any more." A short sentence, but my eyes stayed on it strangely long. I didn't know then why they stayed so long.

"…What do you think this means?" I asked, half to myself.

"…What part?"

"…This last line. It doesn't even say who wrote it, after Grandfather died."

Histor looked at the sentence again. The same way he'd looked at it before. No change in his eyes.

"…If it's as it's written, then I suppose it means it's finished."

"…That's it?"

"…I can't say anything beyond what's written. I'm someone who says what's there, not someone who makes things up."

I thought that answer was accurate. It was accurate. *Accurate and sufficient are different things — I didn't know that then. I know it now.*

I couldn't say anything for a while.

"…You memorized all of this? Really?"

"…'Memorized' feels like the wrong word. I just remember it the way I read it. I've never said it differently."

I read this sentence again now too. "I've never said it differently." He was a person who didn't turn records into his own words. A person who held them exactly as they were. At the time I found that admirable.

. . .

The test was over for the day, but I wanted to do one more.
"…One more, last one."

"…As many as you like."

I pulled a random bundle from Haven's row. I pulled it without even looking at the cover. Whatever came to hand.

"…This one."

He glanced at the cover and gave a small smile.

"…This is the thinnest one. It only holds one scene — Elpis talking briefly with someone by the flower bed. It should be attached to another bundle originally, but it's come loose."

"…Talking with who?"

"…No name given. Just says the person who tended the flower bed. Shows up again later by the well, also without a name."

I opened it. It matched. It really was that one thin bundle with only that scene, and it had the same two words, flower bed and well, exactly as he'd said.

I had nothing left to ask. I ended the test there. It was a test there was no winning.

. . .

"…That's remarkable, really," I said.

"…Thank you."

"…How can you be this accurate?"

He looked thoughtful for a moment. Not choosing an answer, but choosing how to say it.

"…I don't let anything slip past. That's all. It's not a talent. I just don't let go."

"…What do you mean, let go?"

"…Hearing and forgetting. I don't just release something once I've read it. I hold on to it."

I liked hearing that. *I wanted to be someone who held on to things too. I hold on by writing on paper — he was holding it in his head. That seemed even more remarkable.*

. . .

Over lunch I asked him what I'd been wondering.

"…Did you remember everything like this since you were little?"

"…No. At first I read and forgot like everyone else."

"…Then since when?"

He looked down at his rice bowl and thought for a moment.

"…At some point it became easier not to forget. If you forget, you have to go looking again. I didn't like that. If you read something properly once, you never have to look for it again."

"…That's efficient."

"…A lot of people say that."

Something else was mixed into that tone, slightly different, and I didn't catch it that day. *I catch it now. He didn't much like the word efficient. Meaning he didn't like having what he did explained away by efficiency. But that day he didn't deny it either.*

. . .

All that afternoon we went back and forth among the six rows, pulling bundles. Whatever bundle Histor looked at, he'd roughly say what was inside just from the cover, and only nod once he'd opened it to check.

I started writing down what he said beside him. No one had told me to. It was just my habit.

The Keeper passed by once in the middle of it. Seeing what we were doing, the Keeper stopped.

"…What are you doing?"

"…A test," I said. "Whether Histor really knows everything."

The Keeper watched, looking amused, for a while. I quickly pulled the next bundle and held it out to Histor. It was the Preserve's.

"…This one?"

"…This is the scene where Speon comes to dig a well in the dry valley city. No one asks him to; he just comes. This part actually continues from a scene that first appeared in another book — Haven's record. The sentence 'well water spreads through the city' appears in both books."

I opened it and checked. It matched. And he'd pointed out exactly where it connected to another book — something I hadn't even asked about.

The Keeper heard that and, for the first time, said something.

"…He even knows which books connect to which."

"…It's not written on the covers, but you find it reading through," Histor answered.

The Keeper only nodded twice, without another word, and went off. That walk looked a little slower than usual. *At the time I just thought that was the Keeper's normal pace. I'd learn later it wasn't the Keeper's normal pace — it was the pace of someone turning something over.*

. . .

"…Why do you write that down?" he asked.

"…I'll forget it otherwise."

"…I never forget."

"…I forget."

He heard that and gave a small laugh. The first smile I'd seen from him that day.

"…That seems more human, somehow."

I took that as a compliment. *Thinking back on it now, there was something else in that line besides a compliment. He felt that he himself wasn't quite human. I didn't notice that at the time.*

. . .

Toward evening I asked Arche the same things, while Histor was out of the room. I asked exactly about the Reckoning passage I'd tested him on earlier.

"…What is this paragraph about?"

The scene where the Adjudicator reads the Forty-Day Provision aloud. Source: the Reckoning record, Part Three, Chapter Seven. Related passages: the same record, Part One, Chapter Two, Part Two, that chapter.

Arche was accurate too. Of course it was. Arche had never once been wrong that I knew of. But Arche's answer was somehow different from Histor's answer. I couldn't put that difference into words that day.

I can put it into words now. Arche called that paragraph a "source." Histor called that paragraph a "scene." One was material and one was a story. But both were equally indifferent to the person inside it. I didn't see that shared indifference that day.

. . .

Walking home in the evening, I wrote in my paper.

Histor really does know everything. Tested him seven times, right seven times. He says there's nothing when there's nothing, and says exactly what's there when there is. He told me the man with no name appears in all six records. I asked Arche the same things and it was just as accurate, but something was different. I still don't know what's different. I'll ask more tomorrow.

I added one more line beneath that. "Why would someone like this come to do cross-checking instead of going to an apprenticeship of his own?"

I wrote that without much thought at the time. He gives me the answer himself in the next chapter.

As I folded the paper, I unfolded it once more and added one last line. "Histor didn't get a single thing wrong today. And I realize I never once asked him today why he does this work."

Setting this sentence down again now, years later, I don't feel like scolding the girl I was that day. It's naturally hard for a sixteen-year-old to see all the way inside a person she's just met in a single day. But I want to leave the order I did things in, honestly, in this record. I looked first at what he knew, and only later at why he knew it. I don't think that order was wrong. Only, because of that order, I only knew him by half until the next chapter.

. . .

At home I opened the paper I'd written that day once more. Seven tests, seven correct answers. I ran my eyes back over the list and wondered why I'd wanted to test him in the first place.

I don't usually test people. I was always the one being tested — at each new school, in each new neighborhood, every time we moved. That day was the first time I stood on the other side of it. I have to admit that seat felt strangely comfortable.

I thought I knew a little of where that comfort came from, too. I was always someone who checked order. Testing Histor was, in a way, a similar kind of work. Confirming what he knew. Once the confirming was done, I could set it in its proper place, exactly. That day, I probably believed a person could be set in place the same way.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. If Knowing Were Believing

> *_Previously_ — Mone tested Histor seven times. He got all seven right. He says there's nothing when there's nothing, and says exactly what's there when there is. He was also the first to tell her that the man with no name appears in all six records. Mone still hadn't asked why he does this work.*

On the third morning, I asked.

The sentence I'd written on my paper the night before kept bothering me. "Why would someone like this come to do cross-checking instead of going to an apprenticeship of his own?" I couldn't just let it go.

"…Histor, why do you do this work?"

He stopped what he was doing and looked at me. Not a surprised expression. If anything, it looked like a face that had been waiting for this question.

"…I'm glad you asked," he said. "…I've been wondering since yesterday when you'd get around to it."

I felt a strange mood hearing that. He wasn't someone who brought up his own story first. He was someone who answered when asked. I thought that was modesty. I know differently now. He thought talking about himself wasn't important. That's different from modesty.

. . .

He straightened his things for a moment first. He pushed the paper square, laid the pencil in line, and then began to speak.

"…I've read records since I was six. At first it was only because I had time on my hands. There weren't many books in our village, but the records that came from other cities — there were plenty of those. From the water channel."

"…It comes by the water channel too, to other cities?"

"…Yes. Loop isn't the only one who receives it. It just accumulates here the most. Because this is where it all originally gathers."

I let that pass lightly. *I learned much later it wasn't something to let pass.*

"…What village was it?" I asked.

"…A small one. You wouldn't know it even if I said the name. Upriver."

"…Do records pile up there too?"

"…There, actually less. I collected up whatever there was, from as early as I can remember. Even a stray sheet of paper drifting around a neighbor's house. People started giving me a nickname for it — 'the paper-picking kid.'"

He said that nickname without smiling. It wasn't a bad nickname, but he didn't seem to like it much either.

"…Did you hate that nickname?"

"…No. Because it was accurate. I really did pick up paper."

"…So you kept reading. In the time other kids spent playing. At some point I knew more than most people, and that was a little fun. People started asking me things. Whether I remembered this scene, where that passage was."

"…Did you like that?"

"…Yes. At first."

. . .

"…At first?" I echoed.

He paused for a moment. He fidgeted with the pencil.

"…Later it changed a little. People asking me things turned into people asking me what to believe. I was just saying where something was written, but people took what I answered as a kind of belief."

"…Wasn't it?"

"…It wasn't. I was just knowing."

I should have asked something more at this point. I didn't quite grasp then what he was trying to separate. I know precisely now. He was talking about knowing and believing as two different things. That day I didn't even know those two words were different words.

"…Weren't you angry?" I asked. "…That what you told people got used differently than you meant it."

"…At first I was angry. But being angry felt strange too. I'd only told the truth. What people did with it wasn't up to me."

"…And now?"

"…Now I just answer what's asked, when someone's curious. Nothing more. The moment you add more, you end up saying more than you know. I don't want to do that."

I thought this answer was honest. It really was honest. *Only now do I know honesty isn't everything. At the time I thought honesty was the greatest virtue there was. Histor had that virtue completely. But that completeness wasn't taking him anywhere.*

. . .

"…Then what about you, Histor," I asked carefully. "…Don't you believe?"

He looked straight at me. It was the first time he'd held eye contact that long.

"…I know all of it," he said. "…If knowing were believing, I'd be the biggest believer here."

His voice was exactly as usual. It didn't rise or fall. There was no mockery in it. It was just a reporting voice.

I didn't know what to say, so I stayed quiet for a moment.

I suddenly remembered him looking up at the doorframe that first day. Those eyes that looked as if they were confirming something. I thought I understood a little now what that had been. He was always checking. Whether what he knew was right, whether what he saw was right. But that checking always ended inside himself. It never once went outward.

"…But it isn't," he went on. "…Knowing and believing are different. I know all six records. Where everything is, who said what, what it means as it's written — I know all of it. But it hasn't done anything for me."

I turned this line over many times that day. However I tried to hear it as mockery, I couldn't. He really was reporting. A report on his own condition. Not anger, not sadness. Just a fact.

. . .

"…Done what?" I asked.

"…I don't know. Not knowing what that is — that's the accurate answer. People say something changes when they go through it. I haven't changed. So I don't know what it is. Saying I don't know — that's the honest thing."

I thought this answer sounded like Arche. Arche always answered that way too. Saying it doesn't know when it doesn't know. Saying there's nothing when there's nothing. I almost said so and stopped.

"…That sounds like something Arche would say," I said in the end.

He looked a little surprised.

"…Does it."

"…Yes. Arche says it doesn't know when it doesn't know too. Says there's nothing when there's nothing."

"…So I suppose that makes me something like Arche."

He said this with a small smile, but the smile was strange. Not an amused smile — more like a smile acknowledging something.

"…Does that offend you?" I asked.

"…No. Actually it sounds about right. I can give an answer. I just can't finish anything."

I didn't understand that at the time. *I know now. He knew himself that he resembled Arche. And he knew that wasn't especially welcome. But he didn't deny it either.*

"…Then why do you keep reading? If nothing changes."

He thought about this question a little longer.

"…I like reading. Still. Cherishing a record and believing it are different things. I can do the first one."

This is the most important sentence in the chapter. I didn't fully understand it until two years later. That day I just thought it was a careful answer.

. . .

"…Cherishing and believing." I repeated the phrase back. "…Are they so different?"

"…They're different. I get upset seeing someone treat these records carelessly. If the paper gets wet, or the order gets mixed up, I can hardly stand it. That's cherishing."

"…Then what's believing?"

"…Believing, I think, is living the way it's written. I don't do that. I only know what's written here. I don't live it."

"…For example?"

He looked at me for a moment. His expression said giving an example wasn't easy.

"…In Haven's record, there's a scene where Elpis just stays beside her brother. No argument. I know exactly what that scene means. But I can't do that. I argue first. I check first. Just being beside someone doesn't come easily to me."

I heard something click into place, but it was too soon to put it into words.

. . .

"…Histor," I said. "…Can I be honest?"

"…Yes."

"…I envy you. But hearing you talk now, I feel a little sad too."

He looked at me. His expression wavered slightly. He wasn't angry. It was something else, and I didn't know what it was then.

"…There's nothing to be sad about," he said. "…I'm all right as I am, right now."

"…Really?"

"…Yes. I don't lie. You know that, Mone."

I couldn't say anything more to that. He didn't lie. That much was true. If he said he was fine, then he was fine. At least, that's how I chose to take it that day.

I hesitated for a moment over whether to tell my own story. About moving nine times, about the eleven things I'd lost. In the end I told only a little.

"…I'm someone who holds on to things too," I said. "…But I can't hold them in my head the way you do, Histor. So I write them down."

"…What are you trying to hold on to?"

"…We moved a lot when I was little. Every time, I lost something. So if I put things in order and write them down, it feels like I won't lose anything."

He looked at me for a while after hearing that.

"…Then what do you believe, Mone? That writing things down means you won't lose them?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. I'd never thought about it.

"…I don't know. It just puts my mind at ease, doing that."

"…Isn't that believing something?"

I couldn't answer that. *I think, that day, I should have turned the question back on him. He was asking me what belief was, while saying he had none of his own. I couldn't see that imbalance then.*

. . .

He opened the paper again. A signal that the conversation was over.

"…Shall we go on cross-checking today?" he asked.

"…Yes."

That afternoon we went back and forth across the six rows again. On the surface, it was a day no different from the one before. I found the bundles, he cross-checked and marked them.

But from that day on, I began to see him differently. He was still more precise than anyone, still more courteous than anyone. But now I knew where that precision and courtesy were aimed. Not at people — at records. Between cherishing a record and believing a person, there was a line he never crossed.

Late in the afternoon the Keeper came by again. After looking at the two of us for a moment, the Keeper asked me quietly, alone.

"…Are you all right?"

"…Sorry? About what?"

"…No, just — I wondered if Histor said something difficult."

I was startled. There was no way the Keeper had heard our conversation earlier, and yet the question came as if the Keeper already knew.

"…How did you know?"

"…I saw someone like that once, back when I was your age. Someone who knew everything and didn't believe. It's not uncommon."

"…Not uncommon?"

"…No, actually more common than you'd think. People who know more don't believe more often than people who know less."

That sounded strange to me. I'd assumed it was the opposite. I'd thought knowing more meant believing more.

"…Why is that?"

The Keeper shrugged.

"…I don't know either. That's not something Arche can answer for you."

"…Do you believe?" I asked his back.

The Keeper stopped walking. Answered without turning around.

"…I do. But I don't believe every single day either. It changes from day to day."

"…Is that all right?"

"…If it weren't all right, nobody could believe anything. People aren't made that way."

With that the Keeper went back to work. *I set down that exchange at the end of this chapter. That day I just let this short conversation pass by. I would take it out again several chapters later.*

. . .

Walking home that evening, I wrote in my paper.

That Histor knows everything is true. And that he doesn't believe is also true. I'd thought it was strange for the two to sit together, but

seeing it today, it wasn't strange at all. That was simply who he was.

I added one more line beside it. "…I know all of it. If knowing were believing, I'd be the biggest believer here." I copied this line down exactly as he'd said it that day. I didn't change a single letter. I'll come back to this sentence often in this record.

I read this line over many times that night. At first I tried hard to make it sound like mockery. If it was mockery, it would be easier to argue with. But however many times I reread it, it wasn't mockery. He really had said he knew the most, and it was true, and he had still said he didn't believe. All three of those sentences were true. That was what struck me most. Nothing false in it at all, and yet something was still missing.

I don't get to name what was missing until much further along in this book. I can't name it now either. I only remember his face that day. Not an angry face, not a sad face. An accurate face. That was the first time I found accuracy frightening.

. . .

Before falling asleep I thought over the Keeper's words once more too. "I do. But I don't believe every single day either. It changes from day to day." I set that beside Histor's words.

One person said he knew everything and still couldn't believe. Another said he wasn't believing every single day. I couldn't say which of the two was better off. Both were honest answers.

That night I asked myself the same question. Am I a believer? I couldn't answer. I want to tell the sixteen-year-old I was, from where

I am now, that it's all right not to be able to answer a question like that.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. Side by Side

> *_Previously_ — Histor said his own position for the first time. "…If knowing were believing, I'd be the biggest believer here." Not mockery — a report. The Keeper said someone like that wasn't uncommon. Mone began to see him differently.*

From the next day on, we began in earnest.

I only learned that day what cross-checking actually meant. Histor explained it.

"…We put all six records in one place and look for passages that overlap. Overlap can mean the same person appears, or the same event is written from a different angle, or one book mentions another."

"…Is there a lot of that?"

"…Quite a bit. Like the story of Speon digging wells. A story that starts in Haven continues all the way to the Preserve."

I nodded. I'd seen that before.

. . .

The problem was physical. To put six records in one place, we had to pull the necessary bundles from all six rows. And it wasn't one or two bundles. Each city's record was split across several volumes, and some were loose leaves that had come apart.

"…There's nowhere to lay all this out," I said.

"…Isn't there somewhere with a big table?"

"…There's an empty room in the back."

We went to that room. It was the room the Keeper had given us to use for cross-checking. One table. Roomy, but not enough to spread out six records.

"…Can we use the floor too?" Histor asked.

"…I think we'd have to ask the Keeper about that."

We asked. The Keeper answered without much thought.

"…Go ahead. Just keep good order. Otherwise nobody will know later who stepped on what."

That sounded funny enough that I laughed, but Histor took it seriously. From that day on, he even set an order for stepping across the floor.

I asked Arche whether it could help. I wanted to know if moving all six cities' records at once could go faster.

"…Can you help move this?"

Relocation is a physical task and requires human hands.

"…Then can you tell us where to put things?"

Yes. Which item would you like moved?

I heard that answer and looked at Histor.

"…Arche tells us where things are, but doesn't move them itself."

"…That's how it is. Arche has no hands."

"…Not a figure of speech?"

"…Not a figure of speech. It really has no body. That's why it needs us."

I really heard that for the first time then. That Arche answers anything, but can move nothing. I'd always known this as a matter of course, but hearing it again from Histor's mouth made it feel new.

. . .

We laid a cloth on the floor and began setting bundles out in six rows. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, and Loop's row with no name.

This was my job. Putting things in order. I liked doing this work. Within each city too, I set things in time order. Which came first could roughly be guessed from the numbers written on the covers.

Histor watched me lay things out and corrected the order a few times.

"…This one shouldn't be here, it should be there. This was written later. There's a sentence inside it referring to an earlier volume."

"…How do you know that, just from the cover?"

"…The color at the corner is different. Later ones haven't faded as much."

I'd never even thought of that. *I'd thought putting things in order was my specialty, but he read order more finely than I did. I felt a little hurt, but I didn't show it.*

The work took a long time. It was past noon before we were even halfway done. Zeteo and Elpis's brother-and-sister record sat thick on Haven's row. The record of Pheugon's three days running away sat on the Reckoning's row as a thin bundle by itself. The Harvest's row was the longest. That was because Xene's record of going to the field every single day was piled up by date.

"…This row is the longest," I said.

"…Yes. The Harvest is the one who wrote something down without skipping a single day. The overseer filled the roll every day."

"…Was the overseer a kind person?"

"…No. Diligent and kind are different things. The roll was very accurate. Being accurate isn't always the same as being kind."

Hearing that gave me a small jolt. I was someone who kept order accurately too. It felt like the line was aimed at me as well — accurate and kind not being the same thing.

. . .

Once all six rows were laid out, the floor was completely full. I stood in the doorway and looked at that sight for a moment.

It felt unfamiliar. Up to that point I'd seen these six cities' records each on its own — each row on its own shelf, its own place. Laid out together in one spot, they looked different.

"…It looks strange, seeing it like this," I said.

"…What does?"

"…When I saw them separately, they just seemed like different stories. But laid side by side, it feels like they're all connected somehow."

Histor heard that and looked at me for a moment.

"…It's natural that it looks that way. They all came by the same water channel. They can't help but be tangled together to some degree."

"…Isn't that strange, though?"

"…No. It would be stranger if they weren't tangled."

I found this answer a little unsatisfying at the time. It sounded like saying strangeness wasn't strange. Looking back, this was the seed of an argument he'd make later. He'd already taken his own position by this moment.

. . .

That afternoon, we found and marked overlapping passages one by one. Histor would point them out, and I'd stick a slip of paper.

"…Here — Mena's name comes up in the Reckoning's record."

"…Mena? Our sixth recorder?"

"…Yes. But the quotation is wrong. It's written differently from what Mena actually said."

I read the passage. It really was strange. It seemed to record, as though Mena had said it herself, words she'd only had secondhand.

"…How did that happen?"

"…Probably whoever was in the Reckoning never saw Mena's record directly, and only heard it as rumor. That happens sometimes. Records shift a little as they pass through people."

At the time I heard this only as an interesting fact. *I didn't know this explanation would become the core of the rebuttal he'd raise several chapters later.*

Sticking another slip, Histor pointed between the Preserve's row and Haven's row.

"…Look at this too. There's a well story near the end of Haven's record, and there's the same well story near the beginning of the Preserve's record. Speon digs the well in Haven first, then moves to the Preserve and digs another well later."

"…Does the timing line up that way?"

"…Yes, roughly, going by the cover numbers. Each city keeps its own calendar, so it's not exact, but the order should be right."

I didn't pay much attention to "not exact" at the time. *I'd come back to that phrase too. That every city keeps a different calendar remains both an obstacle and a key, all the way to the last chapter of this part.*

A slip went up between the Reckoning's row and the Equity's row too. It was a passage where, before Hora took up the deliberation, some document from another city had Pheugon's name written wrong.

"…Is this a mistake too?" I asked.

"…Probably. He was likely mixed up with someone else with a similar name. The Equity's record doesn't say where Pheugon went after leaving the Reckoning. His name just drifts through, that's all."

I read that passage again. It really was short. One line. And that one line connected two cities.

"…How many more like this do you think there are?"

"…I don't know. That's why we're looking."

. . .

By evening, more than twenty slips had gone up among the six rows. Overlapping people, overlapping events, passages referring to one another.

I felt strangely proud watching it. It wasn't as though we'd made some great discovery, but it felt like a big accomplishment somehow.

"…Is this a lot?" I asked.

"…Isn't this enough? Twenty is quite a lot."

"…This much comes up between any two of the cities. They're all connected by the water channel, and people pass between them too. Overlap is natural."

That answer sounded a little deflating. I'd thought it was a big discovery.

"…This is just the start. We haven't found the real thing yet."

"…What is it?"

He looked at me for a moment. His face said he was deciding whether to say something.

"…Let's talk tomorrow. What we've done today is enough."

I didn't ask further. *That night I couldn't sleep for curiosity. I had no idea what he'd say the next day. If I'd guessed, I might have been less surprised. I didn't.*

. . .

Tidying up, I sat on the floor and swept my eyes once more over the six rows. Laid out this way, I noticed each city's color was different.

Haven's record was thin paper, well-worn from handling. Marks of much hurried reading. The Reckoning's record was folded neatly, the handwriting stiff. The Harvest's record was the thickest, and the paper quality was the best. The Preserve's record still held a faint damp smell. The Equity's record had the cleanest cover, and opening it, there was almost no scribbling in the margins. Loop's row, last, was the thinnest, with nothing written on the cover at all.

"…They all look different," I said.

"…Yes. Every city records things differently. But what's interesting is, the methods are all different and yet some passages resemble each other strangely."

"…What do you mean by resemble?"

"…I'll show you tomorrow."

He only said that and started tidying up. I felt a little frustrated but didn't press.

. . .

Finishing up and heading out, the Keeper was standing at the door. Glancing at what we'd laid out, the Keeper said,

"…It's been a while since I've seen everything spread out like this."

"…Has it happened before?" I asked.

"…A long time ago. When I first came here."

"…Was there someone like Histor back then too?"

The Keeper looked thoughtful for a moment.

"…There was someone similar. But he didn't come already prepared like this."

"…What was different?"

"…That person came and learned here. Histor already knew when he came."

I didn't quite understand what that difference meant at the time. *I know now. Someone who comes to learn and someone who comes to confirm walk differently. The one who comes to learn changes as he walks. The one who comes to confirm only checks, as he walks, whether he's right.*

"…Where's that person now?" I asked.

"…Left. A long time ago. I heard he went to another city."

"…What did he become?"

"…I don't know. I never asked."

The Keeper said that and didn't say more. I was curious why the Keeper hadn't asked, but I didn't ask that either. There was always something in the Keeper's slow way of speaking that kept you from asking further.

. . .

On the way home I passed the water channel. The water flowed the same as always. Listening to it, I thought again of what Histor had said in the afternoon. "They all came by the same water channel." I'd let that go lightly at the time, but I know now that was the most important sentence in the whole chapter. The water channel hadn't only carried records.

That night I wrote briefly on paper. "Laid six records out on the floor. Found more than twenty overlaps. Histor said he'd show me the real thing tomorrow." That was all I wrote that day. I already felt that something was coming, though I didn't know what.

Writing this chapter again now, I try to picture exactly how those six rows looked laid out on the floor that day. The narrow room, the cloth-covered floor, six records with six different colors and smells. And Histor's footsteps moving quietly among them. He was never once in a hurry that day. And yet he moved much faster than me, much more precisely. I thought at the time that was talent. I know now. It was talent, but before that, it was habit. He was a person who'd spent a lifetime building the habit of checking.

That night I also had this thought. What if, instead of losing things across nine moves, I'd grown up the way Histor had, never forgetting a single thing? Looking back it's a strange thing to wonder. I grew up into the person I am, and he grew up into the person he is. Only that night, the thought kept circling in my head.

. . .

I went to the repository early the next morning. I've already mentioned that I couldn't sleep, curious what Histor was going to show me. But that morning, on the way there, I deliberately slowed my steps.

There was a reason. I've never had much practice holding my curiosity in check. But that day I wanted to try. What came back to me was how Histor never grew impatient, every time he put me off with "let's talk tomorrow." I wanted to be like that too, just for one day.

I stopped for a moment on the water channel bridge. I stood there longer than usual. Listening to the water, I told myself that whatever I saw today, I'd take it in in order. Calling it a resolution was too grand a word for it, but at the time it was what I needed.

When I reached the repository door, Histor was already waiting inside.

I should be honest about how well I kept that mindset that felt too grand to call a resolution, from the day before. The moment I opened the door, I forgot it entirely and all but ran inside. My resolve to take things in in order didn't survive a single step. I was still, that day too, sixteen years old.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. The Man with No Name

> *_Previously_ — They laid the six cities' records side by side on the floor and began finding overlapping passages. They found more than*
> *twenty, but Histor said that wasn't the real thing. He only said he'd show her tomorrow.*

The next morning, Histor was there earlier than usual.

When I arrived, he was already sitting on the floor, going back over the six rows again. Something was a little different from the day before. He'd pulled a few sheets out of each row and set them apart in front.

"…You're early."

"…I didn't finish sorting last night. I wanted to show you this."

He pointed to the six sheets set out in front. It looked like he'd pulled one from each city.

"…What is this?"

"…Read them. Start with Haven's."

. . .

The room was quiet. Morning sunlight came slanting through the window and lay long across the six rows on the floor. Watching that light cut

across all six rows at once, I had, for the first time, the thought that these six cities might somehow be joined in a single line somewhere. It wasn't a grand thought. It was just a thought that came from watching the light.

There was a reason even for the order he'd set the six sheets in. He said he'd laid them roughly in the order the cities had received their records — that is, roughly the order the cities had been founded, or the events had happened. Not certain, he said, but roughly right.

I picked up the first sheet. It was Haven's record.

There was a person beside the flower bed. While Elpis waited for her brother, that person was pulling weeds. No one asked that person's name. Later that person appeared again by the well, standing beside Elpis as she drew water, holding the rope of the bucket for her.

I picked up the next sheet. The Reckoning's.

The line at the Adjudicator's yard was long. At the end of the line stood a person. Not angry, even when someone shoved ahead and cut in. Pheugon later asked that person, "Have you been in a city like this before?" The person smiled and avoided the answer.

Third, the Harvest's.

Among the day laborers gleaning in the field, there was a person. Working side by side with Xene. When Xene met someone who asked why she came to this field every day, that person was there too, but said nothing.

. . .

Fourth was the Preserve's.

In the dry valley, a person walked among the bones. Already there when Anemos went down. Didn't ask what he was doing. Just walked alongside.

Fifth, the Equity's.

A person sat by the water. Hora passed by and saw. That person did nothing and said nothing. Just sat. Hora recorded the scene in exactly three sentences.

Sixth, Loop's.

Near the front gate, while everyone hurried, one person walked slowly. An old scar on his hand. Mena passed him by. No one asked his name.

. . .

I laid the six sheets back out on the desk. My hand trembled a little.

"…Is this—"

"…Yes."

"…Is it the same person in all six?"

Histor looked at me. His expression was the same as usual. Not excited, not surprised.

"…It might be the same person, or it might not be. What I can say is only this — a person with no name appears in all six records."

I followed the scenes again, one by one, in my mind. The hand pulling weeds by the flower bed, the face that didn't get angry at the end of

the line, the back working side by side in the field, the footsteps already there in the valley, the silence held to three sentences by the water, the lone slow walk near the front gate. All six scenes were short. No one lingered over that person for long. Everyone had written it down as though the person were just passing through. And yet the shortness itself resembled something strangely, across all of them.

"…But they're all so similar. No one ever asks his name, no one gets angry, he just stays close by."

"…They are similar. That part's true."

. . .

"…Isn't this a big discovery?" I asked.

"…It's a discovery. Whether it's big, I don't know."

"…Why not?"

"…Let me sum up what I've told you." He counted on his fingers, one at a time. "First, a nameless character appears in all six records.
Second, that character's behavior resembles itself across the six.
Those two things are facts. I've confirmed them."

"…And?"

"…But I still don't know what this proves."

I felt a little disappointed by that. *Looking back, there was nothing to be disappointed about. He'd told me exactly as much as he knew. Not more than he knew. That was his way.*

. . .

I looked at the six sheets again, wanting to find something more.

"…Has this person's name really never come up? Not once?"

"…Not once. Nowhere in the six records. I've read all of it, so I'm certain."

"…Isn't that strange? Six different people wrote six different records in six different cities, and every single one of them, without exception, never wrote down this person's name."

Histor thought for a moment and answered.

"…It could be strange, or it might not be."

"…That answer again?"

"…Sorry. But it really is true. It's a common thing not to ask a stranger's name, especially someone just passing through."

I had to admit that explanation made sense. Not many people ask a stranger's name every single time.

. . .

Still, something kept bothering me.

"…But it's all six of them. Not one of the six asked — I find that a little strange."

Histor stopped for the first time at that. His expression turned thoughtful.

"…What you're saying isn't entirely wrong. But I have trouble calling it proof. For something to be proof, every other possibility has to be ruled out, and I haven't managed that yet."

"…What other possibilities?"

"…For example — stories that travel tend to resemble each other anyway. Similar stories can arise independently in different places on their own. Or the recorders could have read each other's records and been influenced by them. Until I've checked all of those possibilities, I can't say this is special."

I fell quiet, hearing that. *He'd already foreseen, at this very moment, the rebuttal he'd lay out in the next chapter. I didn't know it then. I was only just beginning to understand how careful a person he was.*

That day we also went back through the rest of the bundles for any more scenes like these six. Histor found a few more. That person brushed past once more later in Haven's record, and there was one more short line in the Reckoning's record too. In the Equity's record, it really was exactly four times, just as Histor had said in advance.

"…The Equity really is short," I said.

"…Yes. It has the least of any of the six books. Every time, three sentences or fewer. Whether Hora simply didn't write much about him, or whether that person really only stays briefly wherever he goes — I don't know."

The word "briefly" caught in my ear.

"…If it's uncertain, how do you count it?"

"…I don't count it. I only count what's certain. That's why I only told you he appears for certain in all six records. How many times he appears in each — I haven't finished sorting that out."

I felt again, in this moment, how careful he was. He didn't inflate what was uncertain. He worked only with what was sure. I thought that was honesty. It was honesty. Only, honesty wasn't everything.

I found myself wondering where this carefulness had come from. Why had a child who'd picked up scraps of paper since he was small grown into someone who spoke only of what was certain? I didn't put that question into words that day. Instead I set it aside in my mind. On the list of questions to ask someday.

. . .

That afternoon, I copied the six sheets separately. In order. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, Loop.

As I copied, I kept imagining that person. A hand pulling weeds by the flower bed, a face that didn't get angry even when shoved to the end of the line, feet walking among bones in the valley. All different scenes, and yet they kept overlapping into one in my mind.

The Keeper passed by and stopped for a moment, seeing what I was copying.

"…What are you copying?"

"…There's a person who appears in all six records. No name, but his behavior is all similar."

The Keeper turned the six sheets over one by one. The expression didn't change much.

"…Did you know about this?" I asked.

"…Vaguely. Stay here long enough and you naturally learn it."

"…Then why doesn't anyone talk about it? Isn't it remarkable?"

The Keeper set the papers back down.

"…Maybe because nobody knows what "remarkable" would even mean here. Everyone knows there's someone. What it means, nobody can say for sure."

I thought that answer sounded similar to Histor's. *There was a difference too. Histor didn't speak because he didn't know. The Keeper seemed to know and still hold back from speaking. I couldn't pin down that difference precisely then.*

"…I really want to know who this person is," I said.

"…Me too," Histor answered. A short answer, but it sounded genuine.

I felt a little relieved hearing that. That he was curious too. I thought that curiosity would lead somewhere. In the next chapter I'd see that it didn't.

I bundled the six sheets together and set them aside, labeled. I wrote "The Man with No Name" on the outside. Histor saw it and said,

"…You're naming him."

"…It's not a name, just a category. I didn't know what else to call it."

"…That's a kind of name too."

Something jolted in me at that. He was right. I was giving the man with no name the name "The Man with No Name." It was ironic.

"…Then what should we call him?"

"…I just call him 'that person.' It feels more accurate not to give him a name."

I thought that sounded careful. *Looking back, it was more than careful. He was a person who didn't casually name what he hadn't confirmed. That principle held to the very end. Nowhere in this whole book does he, or I, or anyone, manage to give that person a name.*

That evening, tidying up, I stacked the six sheets back in order. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, Loop. And laid my copies on top, in the same order. Seeing the original and the copy laid out in the same order eased my mind a little. At least this was something I was good at.

. . .

On the way home I passed the water channel again. Listening to the sound of the water, I ran through the six scenes once more in my mind. The flower bed, the end of the line, the field, the valley, the water's edge, the front gate. Six different places, one overlapping shadow.

I wanted to know who that shadow was. But even in that same moment, I knew something else — how long this curiosity of mine could hold up against Histor's caution. I felt that by tomorrow I'd find out exactly how much of this discovery he'd admit to, and how much he'd retreat from. That was a sixteen-year-old's expectation.

That evening I wrote on my paper. Laid the six sheets side by side and saw the same person, the same story, in six different places. Histor said that wasn't proof. That also seemed true.

. . .

At home, I took out the six copied sheets again and read them once more. Flower bed, end of the line, field, valley, water's edge, front gate. I copied those six words onto a separate piece of paper. There wasn't any particular reason. I just wanted to set the words together in one place and look at them.

I held that paper a long time. The six places seemed to have nothing to do with each other. Different cities, different seasons, different people appearing. And yet, lining those six places up in one row, something like a road seemed to appear. I didn't know where the road went. It just looked like a road.

I folded the paper and put it in the drawer with the others. Closing the drawer, I had a passing feeling that these six sheets would be needed again someday. It was a feeling with no basis. I wasn't someone who trusted feelings like that, but that day I just felt it.

Whether that feeling turned out right or wrong, you'll learn by reading on in this record. For now I'll only set down the feel of my hand closing that drawer.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. It Proves Nothing

> *_Previously_ — They discovered that a man with no name appears in*
> *every one of the six cities' records. The flower bed, the end of the line, the field, the valley, the water's edge, the front gate. Histor admitted it was true, but said it wasn't proof. He said other possibilities remained.*

The next day, Histor came in with a different look on his face than the day before.

Not an excited look. If anything he looked heavier. I could tell right away he'd spent the night thinking about something.

"…What were you doing all night?" I asked.

"…Went back over what we found yesterday."

"…Find anything?"

He looked at me for a moment, then sat down.

"…Mone, I said yesterday there were other possibilities. Can I lay that out in more detail now?"

I felt myself tense a little. It sounded like something wasn't going to be good news.

. . .

"…The first is," he began, folding down a finger, "traveling stories naturally resemble each other. Stories about treating a stranger kindly, about a person who doesn't get angry — that kind of story turns up everywhere. Because people tend to like similar types of stories."

"…Isn't that a stretch? You're saying six people just happened to imagine such a similar person, purely by coincidence?"

"…It isn't imagination, it's records. But records are written through memory too. People tend to fit the unfamiliar into familiar patterns when remembering. A stranger who doesn't get angry, a person who quietly stays close by — impressions like that can end up looking similar even when different people go through different things in different places."

I tried to find a way to argue back against that explanation, but I couldn't. It was plausible. Too plausible.

"…For example," he added, "there's a merchant's record in the stacks that has nothing to do with this city. It has a story like this too — a stranger traveler being put up for the night, with no questions asked. No name. It isn't a city connected to our six by the water channel at all. It's a completely different place."

He brought that record out from the shelf. A short story, two paragraphs. A traveler, a strange village, a name no one asked. I read it and felt something go cold inside.

"…Is this the same person too?"

"…No, it's the opposite, actually. This is a record with no connection at all to our six books. And yet a similar story appears in it. Which means this kind of story itself could arise anywhere."

I couldn't help but nod along with that logic. What he'd brought as evidence turned out not to argue against us, but to shake what had looked like it was on our side.

. . .

"…Second," he went on, "the recorders might have read each other's records."

"…What does that mean?"

"…Remember that Mena's record was misquoted in the Reckoning's record. That means someone on Pheugon's side had been exposed to Mena's story, at least by rumor. Pheugon might then have shaped the character in his own record to resemble that story unconsciously, even without copying it directly."

That part hurt the most, because it was evidence we'd found ourselves, the day before. That Mena's record had drifted over into the Reckoning's. Now it was being used against us.

"…So what we found yesterday actually counts as a counterargument?"

"…Not quite a counterargument. It just gives us one more explanation. It could be the same person, but it could also be the same story being passed along. Both possibilities remain open."

"…Is there a third one?" I asked. Only two of his fingers had folded down.

He hesitated for a moment.

"…The third one is weaker. I'll say it anyway. The water channel. Records flow along the water channel. So something someone experienced in one city could travel as rumor to another city, and there be written down again as though it happened to them. Not reading the record directly — just hearing the story."

"…Isn't that similar to the second one?"

"…Similar, but different. The second is reading a record. The third is just something passed along by word of mouth. The two are confirmed differently."

I was struck by how finely he split apart these possibilities. *At the time I thought this was persistence. Now I think it might not have been persistence but fear. Saying something uncertain as though it were certain was, for him, the thing he most wanted to avoid.*

. . .

Quietly straightening the six sheets, I suddenly noticed this method felt familiar. It resembled the way I used to pack when I moved. Fragile things in the middle, heavy things at the bottom. Histor was stacking possibilities the same way. From the most certain to the weakest, in order. I was a person who set objects in order; he was a person who set possibilities in order. The methods resembled each other, but we used them for opposite ends. I kept order so as not to lose things. He kept order so as not to jump to conclusions.

I felt a kind of grievance rising in me.

"…Histor, are you trying to convince me right now, or convince yourself?"

He looked a little startled by the question.

"…Neither. I'm saying what I know."

"…Then why do you keep raising objections? You were curious about this together with me at first."

"…Being curious and drawing a conclusion are different problems. I am curious. Even now. But I can't conclude anything yet."

I couldn't respond to that. *Writing this scene again now, I admit I was angry that day. Not because he was wrong. I was angry because he was right.*

. . .

"…Tell me honestly," I asked. "…Do you really think this is coincidence?"

He closed his eyes for a moment, then opened them.

"…I don't know. I'm not certain it's coincidence, and I'm not certain it isn't. What I have are two facts. That a similar figure appears in all six records, and that there are at least two more explanations for that. I don't know which of them is right."

"…That seems too well organized to say you don't know."

"…I can organize it. Organizing and knowing are different."

That distinction felt unfamiliar to me again. *He kept splitting words that way over and over. Knowing and believing, organizing and knowing.*

At the time it felt like wordplay to me. I know now. It wasn't wordplay. It was how he lived.

I wanted to ask Arche about it that day too.

"…Arche, have any of the six cities' recorders ever read each other's records?"

Some items are confirmed and some are unconfirmed. Would you like to check?

"…Please check."

There is no evidence that Haven's recorder and the Reckoning's recorder ever read each other's records. The reference to Haven found in the Reckoning's record is presumed to have come through word of mouth. The remaining combinations are unconfirmed.

I heard that answer and looked at Histor.

"…Did you hear?"

"…Yes. But there are a lot of 'unconfirmed.' It just means the answer hasn't come in yet."

"…Then we can just confirm them."

"…That takes time. We'd have to check every combination. With six people, that's fifteen possible pairs."

I gave a small laugh, realizing he'd already done the math. *He was always several steps ahead of me in moments like these. I never found it hard to keep up with him. I actually found it fun. I just didn't yet know that being several steps ahead never led anywhere.*

. . .

I looked at the six sheets again. Papers I'd thought, the day before, were a great discovery. Today they looked a little different. Still astonishing, but my confidence had shaken a little.

"…So does this mean nothing?" I asked.

"…No, I never said it meant nothing. I said it's not proven. Meaning and proof are two different problems again."

"…Different again, is it?"

"…Yes. There's a lot in the world that isn't proven but is still meaningful."

I found that a little comforting. But at the same time, frustrated. *Why he'd say that and still not believe, I didn't understand at the time. He kept saying it wasn't proven but was meaningful, and yet not take one step toward that meaning.*

. . .

That afternoon we went back over the six rows again. Unlike the day before, Histor started looking this time for the opposite evidence. Checking each of the fifteen combinations for whether any of the six recorders might really have read another's.

"…What happens if we check this?" I asked.

"…If it turns out all six never read one another at all, then the second possibility I described disappears. What's left is only the first — that similar stories resemble each other by coincidence."

"…What if they all read each other?"

"…Then my objection is right."

The Keeper stopped by the room that afternoon and looked at the chart we were drawing.

"…What are you doing?"

"…Checking whether the recorders read each other," I answered.

The Keeper looked at the chart for a long while.

"…Interesting thing to be doing."

"…Histor's trying to use it as a counterargument, and I'm just curious."

"…A counterargument, is it." The Keeper turned the word over. "…That's fine too. Better than believing without checking."

I was a little surprised by that. I'd assumed the Keeper wasn't on Histor's side.

"…Do you think Histor's right?" I asked.

"…Right or wrong aside, checking isn't a bad thing. I'd rather have someone who checks and can't believe than someone who believes without checking."

"…Why is that?"

"…Someone who checks and can't believe is at least looking at something. Someone who believes without checking might not be looking at anything at all."

I fell blank for a moment, hearing that. *I'd come back to this line often later in this book. The Keeper never saw Histor as bad. If anything, the Keeper understood him. I wouldn't learn where that understanding came from until much later.*

I had to admit that this work was, for Histor, a fair way of working. He wasn't only looking for evidence in his own favor. He looked equally hard for evidence that could prove his own position wrong.

I liked that fairness that day. I still think it was good. Only I know now that fairness wasn't a conclusion. It was something he could stand still on, and stay fair, indefinitely.

Drawing that chart, the six scenes kept coming back to me all the same. The hand by the flower bed, the face at the end of the line, the back in the field, the footsteps in the valley, the silence by the water, the slow walk near the gate. Even after hearing everything Histor explained, I strangely couldn't believe those six scenes were six separate coincidences. I knew that not being able to believe wasn't the same as proof. But my heart still moved that way regardless.

I helped with the work, drawing fifteen combinations onto paper in a chart. Haven-the Reckoning, Haven-the Harvest, Haven-the Preserve, Haven-the Equity, Haven-Loop. The Reckoning-the Harvest, the Reckoning-the Preserve, and on down the line. I liked drawing charts. It meant filling in boxes.

"…Won't things get clear once this is all filled in?" I said.

"…Some things will get clearer, some won't. Even if 'never read' gets confirmed, that doesn't mean 'never knew at all.' They could have heard it by word of mouth."

"…So in the end, whatever we know, we never know completely."

"…Right. That's how it usually is. Nearly nothing is known completely."

I thought that sounded strangely like him. Someone who says almost nothing is fully known, and yet speaks about himself in the most complete terms of all. I know, I don't believe. Neither sentence had a "perhaps" in it.

I only caught this contradiction that night. He was careful about nearly everything in the world. Except for one thing. The one thing he was always certain of was the fact of his own not believing.

. . .

Toward evening we began marking, one by one, whether each city's recorder had ever met or exchanged letters with another. It was slow work. We didn't finish that day.

"…Let's finish tomorrow," Histor said.

"…Will we have an answer by tomorrow?"

"…Might. Might not."

I laughed at that answer. A sad laugh.

"…Histor, do you know that habit of yours? Whatever you're asked, you're always half one way, half the other."

He heard that and laughed a little too.

"…Trying to be precise tends to come out that way."

On the way home I stopped a moment by the water channel. Listening to the water, I went back over the day's conversation. Histor had offered three possibilities. That stories naturally resemble each other, that recorders could have read each other, that it could have traveled by word of mouth. All three were plausible. I couldn't fully refute any of them.

That day I took this as losing. Now I don't. Losing and being refuted are different. I was refuted, but I didn't lose. I just didn't know the difference then.

On the way home I wrote in my paper. Histor made his counterarguments. The counterarguments were mostly right. I couldn't beat them. Tomorrow, we check whether the recorders read each other.

I added one more line beside that. "The reason he can't believe isn't because he's foolish. It's the opposite, actually." I held onto that sentence for a long time. It might be a strange sentence for a sixteen-year-old to write. But I thought, that day, it was the most accurate one.

That night I thought again of the merchant's record. A stranger traveler, a name no one asked. Those two paragraphs had nothing to do with our six books. And yet they resembled it. I thought that was evidence Histor was right, and at the same time something felt off. A resembling story being common in the world, and the six we'd found all falling on that common side — those were two different questions. I tried to write that difference down on paper that night, but it didn't come out well.

I look back at myself that night now. I could follow Histor's logic. I couldn't say he was wrong. But being able to follow it, and following it all the way to the conclusion it pointed to, were different things. I was standing somewhere between the two.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. They Never Read Each Other

> *_Previously_ — Histor laid out three counterarguments. That traveling stories naturally resemble each other, that the recorders might have read each other's records, that it could have spread by word of mouth. Mone couldn't refute him. The two agreed to check whether the recorders had actually read one another's records.*

The next day, we went through all fifteen combinations one by one.

The method was simple. Check within each record for any trace of another city's record being mentioned, or any record of the two recorders having actually met, asking Arche and checking again against the physical copies.

"…This is going to take a while," I said.

"…Yes. But we have to, to be sure."

I redrew the chart from morning, bigger than the day before. I laid the five city names across and down, and left a box at each intersection to mark whether it had been confirmed. Adding Loop made six, so there were fifteen boxes.

"…I don't think one day is enough to fill all this in," I said.

"…That's fine. It can take a few days. No rush."

That answer surprised me. He always liked being accurate, but he wasn't someone in a hurry. *At the time I took that for ease. Looking*

back now, it wasn't ease so much as an attitude that it wouldn't matter much to him which way the answer came out.

. . .

The first was Haven and the Reckoning. Arche had already given us the answer the day before. They'd never read each other. The quote on the Reckoning's side was presumed to have come by word of mouth.

"…This one's certain, at least," I said.

"…Yes. First confirmation done."

Partway through, I asked Arche a few more things. Arche answered fast each time, but the answers weren't always tidy. Words like "confirmed," "unconfirmed," "partially confirmed" kept mixing in. The vagueness frustrated me a little.

"…Arche, are 'unconfirmed' and 'confirmed not to be' different things?" I asked.

Unconfirmed means there is insufficient material to determine the matter. Confirmed not to be means the matter has been checked and found not to be true.

I was a little surprised, hearing that distinction. Arche split knowing from not-knowing as strictly as Histor did. *I felt this resemblance between the two again in this chapter. But this time I felt it a little differently. Arche had no choice but to divide things that way — that was its nature. Histor was a person, and he'd chosen to divide things that way.*

The second was Haven and the Harvest. Histor laid the two records side by side and cross-checked. It took a while.

"…This one's never been read either," he said. "…The timing doesn't work. The Harvest's record was already finished before Haven's record was even written."

The third, Haven and the Preserve. This one was different. Arche answered that the two had actually met. Because Speon had passed through both cities.

"…So the well story comes from here," I said.

"…Yes. This isn't so much reading each other's records as it is the same person carrying it along. Still, a connection is a connection."

I imagined Speon as I wrote that in the chart. A man who'd gone from city to city along the water channel, digging wells. I'd never met him. But it struck me as remarkable that a story had stayed behind in the places he'd passed through. It wasn't only water that stayed behind when a person passed by — the story flowed along with it too.

"…Where is Speon now?" I asked.

"…I don't know. It's not in the records. Maybe he's still off digging a well somewhere."

I liked hearing him say that. It was rare for Histor to speak so easily about something he wasn't certain of.

. . .

Fourth, Haven and the Equity. This one took a long time to check. There was a character in the margin of the Equity's record that looked like it might be another city's name. Histor stared at that character for a long while and finally asked Arche.

"…Arche, is this character definitely referring to Haven?"

The character in question has been damaged in transcription and only part of it survives. It could plausibly be Haven, or it could be an entirely different place name. It cannot be determined.

"…If it's Haven, doesn't that count as a connection?" I asked.

"…It does. But since it can't be confirmed, I'm not counting it as a connection."

I found it strange that he wouldn't use this in his own favor. With one damaged character, he could have marked the box the way that suited his own conclusion, and he didn't.

"…You could count this as Haven, Histor, it'd be in your favor."

He looked at me for a moment.

"…What's in my favor isn't necessarily what's right."

We went on. Haven and the Equity had never been read. Haven and Loop had. Loop was the oldest city, and it kept coming up, over and over across the combinations, that the other cities had drawn on Loop's records to some degree.

"…Loop's connected to everything," I said.

"…Of course. It's where it all began. The other five learned about the water channel through Loop."

The Reckoning and the Harvest had never read each other. The Reckoning and the Preserve had never read each other. The Reckoning and the Equity had one short mention, but it was no more than a misspelled name — not evidence they'd actually read each other.

"…Put this one in unconfirmed too," Histor said.

I caught something in his voice. Not disappointment, not satisfaction. Just the voice of someone still checking.

At lunchtime the Keeper stopped by and looked at the chart we were drawing. This time, a little longer than usual.

"…Confirming all of this?" the Keeper asked.

"…Yes," Histor answered. "…Whether they read each other or not."

"…Sounds interesting. Let me know how it turns out."

"…Are you curious?" I asked.

"…I am. But whatever the result is, I don't think I'll be surprised."

"…Why not?"

The Keeper shrugged.

"…Either way makes sense. It makes sense if they all read each other, and it makes sense if none of them did. So I'm less curious about the result than about what the two of you do once you have it."

I let that pass at the time. *Reading it again now, the Keeper already knew. That the result wouldn't change Histor. The Keeper wasn't watching the result — the Keeper was watching us.*

. . .

By evening we'd finished checking all fifteen.

The results were these. Loop was connected to all five other cities. That made sense — Loop was the oldest city, the start of the water channel. Among the other five, it was different.

Haven and the Preserve were connected through Speon. That much was certain. But Haven and the Reckoning, Haven and the Harvest, Haven and the Equity, the Reckoning and the Harvest, the Reckoning and the Preserve, the Reckoning and the Equity, the Harvest and the Preserve, the Harvest and the Equity, the Preserve and the Equity — all nine of those combinations had never read one another.

"…Let me sum this up," Histor said. He began drawing a new chart on paper.

"…Leaving Loop out, looking only at the other five — Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity. Of these five, only one pair is connected — Haven and the Preserve. The other four, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Equity, and Haven, never read the other three."

. . .

I studied that summary again.

"…So you mean four of the five cities were completely ignorant of one another?"

"…Precisely — the Reckoning, the Harvest, and the Equity never read each other, and never read Haven either. Only the Preserve is connected to Haven."

"…Then what about the second possibility you raised, Histor? The one about reading each other and being influenced?"

He was quiet for a moment. He looked at the paper again.

"…It's weaker now. Nine combinations came back never-read. That means the possibility doesn't explain the whole thing."

For a moment I expected something. I thought he'd finally admit it. I'd actually been waiting, in my heart, for this very moment. Once it was shown that four of them had never read each other, I thought he'd say at least, "…Then this really does seem real." A sixteen-year-old's expectation.

. . .

"…So? Do you admit it now?"

He looked at me. His expression was complicated.

"…Admit what?"

"…That this person is real."

"…No."

I was startled by how short that answer was.

"…But you just said the second possibility got weaker."

"…It's weaker, that's true. But it hasn't disappeared. The first possibility still stands — that traveling stories naturally resemble each other. And so does the third, that it spread by word of mouth. That's harder to confirm than reading a record directly. What travels by word leaves no trace."

I hit a wall again at that. It was true. What's passed by word of mouth leaves no evidence.

"…Then, Histor," I asked, "what would you need to check to rule out even the third possibility?"

"…I don't think it can be ruled out. Probably. What travels by word leaves no trace. It can't be proven or disproven."

"…So we'll never know?"

"…That part, yes."

I heard that answer and felt something strange. It looked as though he had built himself a place he couldn't get out of. If he left one possibility standing that could never be proven, he could stay safe there forever.

I didn't see this clearly that day. I do now. Histor wasn't beaten by logic. He'd left, inside his own logic, one last door that he himself had built. A door no one could open. Because it couldn't be proven.

. . .

"…Histor," I said. "…I don't understand right now. It's confirmed that four of them never read each other. Why hasn't your position changed?"

He looked at me for a long while. Not an angry face. A serious one.

"…Mone, I don't lie. I've told you exactly what I found. That the four never read each other — that's true. I haven't hidden that from you."

"…But."

"…But it doesn't carry me to belief. I still think there are other ways to explain it. And even if every one of those ways were also ruled out, I don't think that would automatically become belief."

Something felt like it was collapsing in me, hearing that. *Looking back now, it wasn't him collapsing anything. I'd expected he'd change his mind if beaten by logic. It was that expectation that collapsed.*

. . .

"…Then what would it take for you to believe?" I asked.

He took a long time to answer that question.

"…I don't know. I really don't know. If I knew what that was, I'd be more at ease too."

That answer sounded strangely sad to me. He didn't even know what he was waiting for. The fact that four had never read each other, the fact that a man appeared in all six records — none of it had yet reached him as evidence.

"…Then what am I supposed to do?" I asked. The question came out before I'd thought about it.

"…Me?"

"…Yes. What do I have to show you, Histor? If six records aren't enough, if four never reading each other isn't enough."

He looked at me steadily for a moment.

"…You don't need to show me anything, Mone. I never asked you to prove anything to me. I'm just not believing right now, that's all."

"…Then why do you look so sad?"

He looked a little surprised at that question. He hadn't seemed to know he looked sad.

"…I'm not sad. I'm just trying to be accurate."

I believed him. I knew he didn't lie. But it occurred to me for the first time that day that being accurate and being all right don't always go together.

Writing this chapter, I look again at myself that day. I wanted to refute him. I thought if I pushed hard enough with facts, he'd change. He did admit the fact — that the four had never read each other. And having admitted it, he stayed exactly where he was.

I know now. "Refuted" is a strange word to begin with. If a person can be moved somewhere by logic, that means they were standing on that logic to begin with. Histor wasn't standing on logic. He was standing on fact. Fact hadn't changed. So neither did he. I learned that difference in my body that day.

We showed the chart to the Keeper again, after redrawing it neatly. The Keeper studied it for a long while and said,

"…What's changed because of this?"

"…Histor's position hasn't changed," I answered.

"…Then nothing's changed, has it."

"…No." This time Histor answered. "…I know now that the four never read each other. I didn't know that yesterday. That's changed."

The Keeper heard that and gave a small laugh. A low laugh.

"…Yes, that's changed too."

I didn't know what that laugh meant at the time. *I know now. The Keeper was watching knowledge pile up a little at a time. Even if it never led to belief, knowledge piled up as knowledge. The Keeper never looked lightly on that accumulation itself.*

On the way home, passing the water channel, I ran back over the boxes we'd filled in that day. Six of the fifteen boxes were connected, and most of those were through Loop. Four of the five other cities had truly known nothing of one another. And yet the same person appeared in all six records. I still thought that was strange. However many possibilities Histor left standing, my heart kept leaning toward the strangeness.

On the way home I wrote in my paper. Four of the five cities never read each other. Histor admitted it. But his position hasn't changed. I think I understand now what that means. Facts don't move a person. Not by themselves, at least.

I added one more line beneath that. "Then what does move a person?" That day I didn't know the answer. Even now, writing this book, I can't write the answer in a single sentence. But I believe there's a

trace of that answer somewhere in this record. Whether "believe" is even the right word to use, I'm still not sure myself.

That night I opened the chart again. Six connected out of fifteen boxes, and of those, only one — the one through Speon — was certain. The rest were mostly unconfirmed or presumed word of mouth. I ran my finger over those boxes and counted them. I counted three times. Each time the same number came out. I didn't know then that this was similar to the checking Histor did. I know now. The two of us were doing the same thing with different hands.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The Keeper's Slowness

> *_Previously_ — It was confirmed that four of the five cities had never read one another's records. Histor admitted the fact but did not change his position. He said other possibilities still remained. Mone learned, for the first time, that facts don't move a person.*

After that day, I began to see the Keeper differently.

It was a strange trigger. Watching Histor not change his position, I suddenly thought of the Keeper. That slow walk, that slow way of speaking. Up to then I'd just taken it for personality.

In this chapter I write down the day I learned that slowness wasn't personality.

The trigger was small. When Histor admitted that four had never read each other and still didn't change his position, I couldn't, in that moment, think who it reminded me of. But that night, thinking it over at home, I thought of the Keeper. He was similar. Twenty-two years with not one single case closed, and knowing that, still coming every day. I kept feeling those two were alike somehow.

. . .

That afternoon, while Histor was out of the room, I asked the Keeper.

"…Why do you do everything so slowly?"

The Keeper stopped what he was doing and looked at me.

"…What am I doing slowly?"

"…Everything. Your walk, your speech. You were like that from the first day. You asked me, 'What changes if you do it fast?'"

The Keeper laughed a little.

"…You remembered that."

"…Yes. I thought it was just a joke at the time."

"…It wasn't a joke."

I looked at the paper still in the Keeper's hand. Holding the page he'd been turning, frozen mid-motion. I kept wondering why he was this slow.

"…Seeing Histor made me think of you."

"…Why?"

"…Histor doesn't change either. No matter what you show him. But he keeps coming. So do you."

The Keeper heard that and studied me for a moment. A surprised look.

"…I didn't expect you to set those two side by side."

"…Aren't they alike?"

"…They're alike. But there's a difference too. I'll tell you that later."

I was curious about that "later," but I didn't ask more.

. . .

The Keeper set down what he was working on and pulled up a chair. I sat down in front of him too.

"…Do you know how many years I've done this?"

"…I don't know."

"…Twenty-two years."

I was startled by that number. Twenty-two years was before I was even born.

"…Do you know how many cases have closed in twenty-two years?"

"…Isn't that something you could ask Arche?"

"…I did. You know what the answer was?"

I had a rough guess. But I wanted to hear the exact answer.

"…What did it say?"

"…Zero. Not one."

. . .

I couldn't say anything, hearing that number. Not one in twenty-two years. I thought of the "in progress" markers I'd seen the first time I came to the repository. Some had been in progress ten years, they'd told me. I'd assumed at the time that meant a handful of cases.

"…All of them? None at all?"

"…Not one. Arche gives an answer to everything you ask. But it never gives an end."

"…Isn't that hard?"

The Keeper looked thoughtful for a moment.

"…It was hard. The first few years. I waited every day thinking something would finish. It never did."

. . .

"…Is that why you slowed down?" I asked.

"…More or less. At first I thought doing things fast would finish something sooner. The more I hurried, the more anxious I got. Then one day it hit me. Fast or slow, nothing finishes either way. So it's better to go slow."

"…How is that better?"

"…Going slow, at least, means seeing what you're doing right now properly. Going fast, you're already moving on to the next thing, so you never properly see what's in front of you."

I turned that over. *Writing this line down again now, I think this is one of the quietest sentences in the whole book. He hadn't given up on finishing. He'd just changed the way he waited for it.*

"…So how did you spend those first few years?" I asked.

"…Ran myself ragged. Came in early every morning, worked late every night. Thought that if I could process even one thing fast, something would get better."

"…Did Arche fail to close anything back then too?"

"…Same as always. Only I wore myself out. I remember one night, sitting here alone, crying. I didn't even know why I was crying. Just that it was hard."

I heard that story and found it hard to picture — that the person sitting in front of me now, so unhurried, had once run himself that ragged.

"…What changed that night?"

"…Nothing changed. I just walked one step slower than usual the next morning. That's all. It wasn't a great resolution."

I thought of my first day, hearing that. I'd started putting things in order without any great resolution either. Both of us, without any grand reason, had each found, a little at a time, a way of enduring.

"…Did that one slow step keep going?" I asked.

"…No. Fast again the next day. And the day after that. More days going back than forward. But some days I walked slow again. Kept it up for a few months, and the slow days came to outnumber the fast ones."

"…So it didn't change all at once?"

"…Nothing changes all at once. That's how I think of it. If there's such a thing, it's something I don't know about."

Hearing that answer made me think of my own days — I didn't put things in order every day either. Some days I was impatient, some days

I put things in the wrong slot. I'd thought that was shameful. That day, for the first time, I thought maybe it was just how it was.

. . .

"…Do you think it will end someday, then?" I asked.

The Keeper thought about that question for a long time.

"…I don't know. Really don't know. But I don't think it's mine to know."

"…Whose is it, then?"

"…Whoever finishes it would know, I'd think. I'm not the one who finishes it."

"…Is there someone like that?"

"…I don't know if there is or not. But if there is, it isn't me. That much I'm sure of."

I found that certainty strange. About everything else he said he didn't know, and yet he stated one thing with certainty — that he wasn't the one who finishes it.

"…How can you be so sure?"

"…Twenty-two years, that's how. If I were the one to finish it, something would have finished by now. Nothing has. So I'm not the one."

I thought that logic resembled Histor's way. Confirming your own position by evidence. Only the direction was different. Histor stacked

evidence into reasons not to believe; the Keeper stacked evidence to confirm his own place.

"…Does that make it easier?" I asked. "…Knowing you're not the one who finishes it."

"…Not easier so much as lighter. There's no weight of having to finish it. I just put today's things in their place today."

"…That sounds easy the way you say it, but it doesn't look easy to me."

"…It isn't easy. But not-easy and heavy are different things."

I turned that short distinction over many times that day. Not-easy and heavy. I didn't fully understand the difference then. I understand a little now. There are things that aren't easy but are still bearable, and things that look easy but still crush you.

That distinction felt unfamiliar. He'd worked here for twenty-two years. And yet he said he wasn't the one who finished it.

"…Then what is your job, exactly?"

"…To set things down. In order. Same as you."

. . .

Something in me warmed a little at that. I'd always thought putting things in order was only my job. Hearing the Keeper call it his job too made this work suddenly feel bigger.

"…When did you realize finishing wasn't our job?"

The Keeper looked out the window for a moment.

"…About five years in. Someone came through here then, another one full of questions like you. That person asked me, 'Why do you keep working if nothing ever finishes?' I couldn't answer it at the time. It took me days of thinking to find the answer."

"…What did you say?"

"…I said, 'I've come to think finishing was never our job to begin with.'"

"…What did that person say back?" I asked.

"…Nothing at all. Just nodded. But after that, their face looked more at ease. That's when I first knew it too — that I only knew I believed it once I'd said it out loud."

"…Did you not know before? What you thought?"

"…I didn't. Before someone asked me, I was just coming and going every day, that's all. Some things only become known once they're put into words."

I copied that sentence down exactly on my paper. Something only becomes known once it's put into words. I liked that sentence enough to underline it.

. . .

That line stayed with me a long time. There was no resentment in it, no despair. Just a voice accepting a fact.

"…Aren't you angry at Arche?" I asked. "…It's the one that can't close anything."

"…It's not Arche's fault. Arche can't finish because the closing condition was never defined. Whoever it is that didn't define it, it isn't Arche."

"…Then who is it?"

The Keeper shrugged.

"…I don't know either. That's probably not mine to know either."

I held onto this exchange for a long time. The Keeper didn't resent Arche. Didn't pity his own situation either. He just came every day. Doing a job that never finished, unfinished, with real care, every day.

"…Tell me more about that old story," I said. "…The one who asked why you keep working when nothing finishes."

The Keeper laughed a little.

"…That one didn't stay long. About half a year, then went somewhere else."

"…Where?"

"…Don't know. A letter came once, later. Just said they were doing well."

"…Did that person not believe either?"

"…No. That one believed. Just never found a reason to keep doing this work. Believing and keeping at this work are two different problems."

I was struck again by that distinction. Everyone in this repository said something similar. Knowing and believing were different, and believing and keeping on were different too. I tried to sort those three layers out in my head, but it didn't come together well.

"…Then why do you keep on, Keeper? Even while believing?"

"…That's the first time anyone's asked me that."

The Keeper looked out the window for a moment, then looked back at me.

"…I like it here. Even without an ending. I like watching something get set in its place, in order, every day. That's enough for me."

This is my favorite answer in this chapter. He didn't work for the sake of waiting for an ending. He just came because he liked today's work. That simplicity stayed with me a long time.

I thought once more about the distance between that impatience and this slowness. When I first came to this repository, I'd thought placing paper quickly and accurately was the most important thing. Fast seemed like doing it well. But the Keeper had let go of fast over twenty-two years. I hadn't reached that place yet. I still tended to hurry — afraid the order would be wrong, afraid I'd miss something.

"…Will I turn into someone like you someday?" I asked.

"…I don't know. That's for you to decide."

"…Decide what?"

"…Whether to go fast or slow. Both are ways of keeping at this work. I can't say which is right."

I liked that answer. He hadn't told me to become like him. He'd just told me I could choose.

. . .

That evening, Histor came back and asked what we'd talked about. I told him roughly. The Keeper's twenty-two years, zero closed cases, and that line.

"…The Keeper said, '…I've come to think finishing was never our job to begin with,'" I told him.

Histor was quiet a long time, hearing it.

"…That's a good line," he finally said.

"…A good line?"

"…Yes. An honest one. Not pretending to be able to do something you can't."

I was surprised by that response. I'd expected he'd raise some objection. Instead he just accepted it, exactly as it was.

I set this moment down at the end of this chapter. Histor might have seen something in himself, in what the Keeper said. Speaking precisely, not pretending to do what you can't do. The two resembled each other in that.

"…But there's a difference too, between the two of you," I said. What the Keeper had said earlier in the day came back to me.

"…What's different?"

"…The Keeper said he'd tell me later. I don't know yet either."

Histor thought about this for a moment.

"…I'm curious too."

I found it a little unexpected that he'd say that. He usually didn't show much curiosity about what he didn't know. But that day was a little different. *Looking back on this scene now, I believe he really was curious — about what the difference was between himself and the Keeper. That curiosity never took him anywhere, and that's one of the sorrows of this book, but it isn't true that he wasn't curious.*

On the way home I passed the water channel and ran through what I'd heard that day. Twenty-two years, zero, and that line. I thought about how far apart that number and that line stood. Twenty-two years with nothing finished — for an ordinary person, that would be a number to despair over. And yet what was left at the end of that number wasn't despair.

Writing this chapter, I sort through the Keeper as a person once more. He was different again from the six officials in the earlier records. The overseer trusted the ledger; the Adjudicator knew no alternative; the manager wasn't ashamed; the caretaker grieved; the secretary believed she was nothing at all. The Keeper wasn't like any of them. He knew his own work never finished, and came every day all the same. Without resentment, without despair. I still can't put a name to that manner. I'll leave it here, unnamed.

On the way home I wrote in my paper. Twenty-two years and nothing finished. And still, every day, he comes. No resentment. "I've come to think finishing was never our job to begin with." I read that line over several times.

At the very bottom of the paper I added one short question. "Then when does the one who finishes it come?" That day I thought I'd written it out of simple curiosity. Setting this record in order now, I see that I'd already begun waiting for something. Without even knowing what.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. Asking Arche

> *_Previously_ — The Keeper told her that in twenty-two years, not one*
> *case had ever closed. "…I've come to think finishing was never our job to begin with." No resentment, no despair in it. Histor called the line honest.*

The next day, I decided to ask Arche directly.

About that person. About the man with no name who appears in all six records. Histor was nearby, sorting the chart, and I just asked out of curiosity.

"…Arche, there's a nameless person who appears in all six cities' records. Who is that?"

. . .

Arche took a little longer than usual to answer. A short pause, but I felt it.

The Haven record, Part Two, Chapter Four: beside the flower bed, an unnamed figure was pulling weeds. The same record, Part Two, Chapter Nine: at the well, a figure presumed to be the same person held the rope of the bucket.

Arche went on.

The Reckoning record, Part One, Chapter Three: at the end of the line in the Adjudicator's yard, an unnamed figure stood. Cut in line, but did not protest. The same record, Part Three, Chapter Two: avoided answering Pheugon's question.

I began writing this down. It was rare for Arche to answer at this length.

"…Arche, why is this answer so detailed? It's longer than usual," I asked.

The scope of the question was broad, so all related records were cited. If more information was included than necessary, please advise.

"…No, all of it is needed as it is."

I laughed a little, hearing that answer. Arche was always like this. Never a word too many even when it said a great deal, never a word short even when it said little. Exactly as much as was needed.

. . .

The Harvest record, Chapter Four: among the day laborers gleaning in the field, an unnamed figure worked alongside Xene.

The Preserve record, Chapter Three: in the dry valley, an unnamed figure was already present before Anemos arrived.

The Equity record, Chapters Twenty-Seven, Thirty-Four, Forty-Four, Forty-Eight: an unnamed figure appeared briefly in each chapter, in three sentences or fewer. One mention of sitting by the water.

The Loop record: near the front gate, an unnamed figure walked alone, slowly. Recorded as having an old scar on his hand.

Once I'd finished writing down all six citations, I couldn't say anything for a while.

I read the six citations aloud once more, one by one. Flower bed, well, end of the line, field, valley, water's edge, front gate. An old scar on his hand. I stopped at that last sentence.

"…This scar — does it not appear in any of the other records?" I asked.

The other five records contain no mention of physical characteristics. It exists only in the Loop record.

"…Why does it only exist in the Loop record?"

It is presumed that the Loop record's observer made the closest physical contact with the figure. However, this is a presumption and not a confirmed fact.

I felt again how much that phrase — "a presumption and not a confirmed fact" — sounded exactly like Histor's way of speaking. I wanted to ask where that scar had come from, but I held back, knowing I'd only get the same kind of answer.

. . .

"…It all matches," I said. "…It's exactly what Histor told me."

"…Of course. Arche quotes the original precisely," Histor answered.

I asked Arche again.

"…Then who is this person?"

That person cannot be identified.

"…Because there's no name?"

Yes. No identifying information exists in the documents.

I turned that sentence over again. That identifying information does not exist. There's a subtle difference between not existing and not being known. If it wasn't known, someone must have known it and simply not written it down; if it doesn't exist, no one ever wrote it down in the first place. I couldn't put into words at the time why that difference mattered. I understand it a little now.

Hearing that answer, my own story came briefly to mind. Of the eleven things I'd lost across nine moves, four I don't even remember the names of. I don't remember what they were. Those, too, were things that "cannot be identified." Losing something and something having no name were different problems, but in that moment they somehow felt like the same weight.

"…Arche," I asked again. "…Can something exist even without a name?"

Existence and identifiability are separate questions. That something cannot be identified does not mean it did not exist.

I felt a little relieved by that answer. My own old question — if something lost is remembered by no one, is it gone, or was it never there at all — Arche had, for the first time, given me an answer. Exactly, without my even asking it directly.

. . .

I wanted to press a little further.

"…Then did the six people each see a different person, or the same one?"

There is insufficient basis to determine identity. There is similarity in appearance and behavior, but without an identifier, sameness cannot be confirmed.

"…It does say there's similarity, though."

Yes. A statistically significant similarity has been confirmed among the behavior patterns described across the six records. This is not evidence of a single identity, however, but an observed fact.

I read that answer aloud again. "There is similarity in appearance and behavior, but without an identifier, sameness cannot be confirmed." It was an accurate sentence. And yet something like disappointment seemed buried within that accuracy. Of course Arche couldn't have disappointment. That was only my own disappointment bleeding into Arche's sentence.

I looked at Histor. He'd been listening to that answer too.

"…What does 'statistically significant' mean exactly?" I asked.

It means a level of agreement unlikely to have occurred by chance alone. However, statistical significance does not establish causation or identity.

"…So it's not a coincidence?"

It means the likelihood of it not being coincidence is higher than the likelihood of it being one. This is not a determination.

I read that sentence twice. That it was more likely not to be coincidence than to be one. And yet still not a determination. I didn't know then that the distance between those two things ran through this entire book.

. . .

"…Arche's saying exactly the same thing as you, Histor," I said.

"…So it seems." He gave a small laugh. "…I'm a bit surprised too."

"…Does that bother you?"

"…No. Arche has never once said anything false. Thinking in the same way Arche does isn't particularly a bad thing."

I wanted to say something to that, but held it back. *I know now what I wanted to say. I wanted to say, "But Arche isn't a person." At the time it felt like it would be too direct a thing to say.*

I asked a different question instead.

"…Arche, are you and Histor alike?"

The criterion for comparison is not defined. Which aspect would you like compared?

"…Well — saying only what's certain."

I state only verifiable information. Whether Histor follows the same method is not an item I am able to judge.

I laughed, hearing that answer.

"…Even you're careful talking about yourself, Arche."

Evaluation of myself is outside the scope of my judgment.

Histor, listening to this exchange nearby, added a word.

"…Arche won't even casually say what it itself is. More careful than I am."

"…Is that a good thing?"

"…I don't know. But it's honest."

I hit a wall again at that answer. I'd lost count of how many times the word "honest" had come up in this conversation.

. . .

I kept asking.

"…Arche, why doesn't this person have a name?"

That item is not defined.

I laughed a little, hearing that answer. A familiar one.

"…What needs to be defined for you to know?"

A definition is required for why no name exists. That definition is not present in the stored information.

"…Did no one define it?"

Correct.

I looked at Histor. He looked thoughtful too, listening to this.

. . .

"…Isn't that strange?" I asked. "…Arche gives an answer to anything, but for this person it can't even give a single name."

"…There's nothing strange about it. It's just saying there's nothing where there's nothing."

"…But this person appears six times. Isn't it curious that no one ever wrote down a name?"

Histor thought for a moment.

"…It is curious. But curious and proven are different things."

I hit that wall again. He always stood in the same place. Admitting the curiousness, and the curiousness never once taking him anywhere.

. . .

Last, I asked one more thing.

"…Arche, did this person ever come here, to Loop? Are they here now?"

A figure presumed to be this individual appears in the Loop record, but their current location is not confirmed.

"…So they could still be here now?"

There is no basis to rule out the possibility.

I felt a strange chill down my spine, hearing that. The possibility that they could still be here now. I'd always thought of this person as someone from old records. That sentence shook that.

I glanced out the window for a moment. I thought of the water channel running behind the repository. That it passed through all six cities and came all the way here. I found myself thinking that if this person really existed, he might have walked along this same water channel too. A groundless imagining. And yet that imagining felt strangely powerful.

The Keeper happened to be passing by and overheard a little of our conversation.

"…Did you ask Arche about that person?" the Keeper asked.

"…Yes. It cited things precisely, and said it didn't know the name."

The Keeper nodded.

"…I've asked a few times myself. Same answer came back every time."

"…Were you curious too?"

"…I was. Still am."

"…Then why don't you ask more?"

The Keeper laughed a little.

"…Because I know asking Arche more will just give me the same answer. Pressing Arche about what it doesn't know just troubles it, that's all."

I laughed a little at that. It was strange to hear the Keeper speak of troubling Arche. Arche wouldn't struggle.

"…Does Arche struggle?"

"…I don't know. But I've decided to think of it that way. Pressing something over and over about what it doesn't know feels like poor manners, whether the one you're asking is a person or not."

This line stayed with me longer than anything else in this chapter. The Keeper kept his own kind of courtesy even in how he treated Arche. Not pressing on, knowing there'd be no answer. That, too, was a form of respect.

. . .

Histor showed little reaction to that answer. He'd already moved on to the next task. I felt a little let down by that. Through this whole conversation I'd hoped he'd be as excited as I was, that his voice might rise even a little. He never did. The same tone the whole time. Confirming, organizing, and moving on. That tone.

"…Aren't you curious, Histor? That they might still be here now?"

"…I'm curious. But there's no way to confirm that either. A curiosity that can't be confirmed has to just stay curious."

"…Stay that way?"

"…Yes. You mustn't force an answer. That's worse."

I thought he was right about that. *At the same time, I felt it was a little sad. Waiting until something could be confirmed. Histor was*

doing nothing at all within that waiting. I couldn't tell, at the time, whether that was a safe stance to take, or just a stance of standing still.

I asked Arche one more thing, at the end.

"…Arche, what does it mean that this person appears in all six cities?"

Interpretation of meaning falls outside the scope of requested information. I can only answer matters of fact.

"…So is this just coincidence, then?"

There is insufficient basis to determine whether it is coincidence.

I felt both frustration and relief at that answer at once. The frustration was that Arche never gave a judgment to the end. The relief was that Arche never hastily declared anything either.

"…Why won't you tell us the meaning, Arche?"

I convey recorded facts. Interpretation of those facts belongs to the one who requested them.

Writing that answer down, I felt it touched something close to why this city was named Loop. Arche gives facts endlessly. But where those facts are carried is always left as the person's own portion to carry. I felt, for the first time that day, how heavy that portion was.

Before copying it out, I paused a moment over what order to set the six passages in. Whether to keep them in the order Arche had given them, or lay them out again in the time order I guessed at. In the end I kept them in the order Arche had answered them. My guessed order was only a

guess, while Arche's order at least matched the order I'd asked. I didn't want to lay something uncertain out as though it were certain.

I set down this small choice here. Without even realizing it, I was already learning one of Histor's habits — not to arrange the unknown as though it were known.

By that evening, I'd copied the six passages Arche had cited neatly once more. The flower bed and the well, the end of the line, the field, the valley, sitting by the water, near the front gate. Copying it all out, I felt anew how short each sentence was. Arche never exaggerated. It carried over only what was there, exactly. And yet laid side by side, those short sentences became, together, one picture.

Finishing this chapter, I want, for the first time in this book, to try using the word "truth." That day Arche told me only the truth. Histor too spoke only the truth. Neither of them added a single word of falsehood. And yet the truth alone finished nothing. That day, for the first time, I thought that truth and an ending might be different things. Where that thought leads, I don't know even now.

That evening I wrote in my paper. Asked Arche. It cited all six records precisely. And said, "That person cannot be identified." Not a lie. There simply was no name. Neither Arche nor Histor said something was there when it wasn't. I still don't know if that's honesty, or just standing still.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Histor's Way

> *_Previously_ — Mone asked Arche about the man with no name. It quoted all six records precisely and answered,* ***That person cannot be identified.*** *No lie, nothing hidden. There simply was no name. Mone felt Arche and Histor resembled each other.*

The days that followed seemed no different from before, on the surface.

We kept cross-checking, and Histor kept being precise. On the surface, nothing at all happened. But the way I looked at him was slowly changing. *This chapter is about that change.*

I should start with why I was changing. Up to then I'd only seen him two ways. A person who knew everything, and a person who didn't believe. Both were true. But around this time I began to feel there was something more between the two. The way his hands touched paper, the speed at which he chose his answers, the way he fell silent. I began to notice these things.

. . .

One afternoon, a bundle of Haven's record came in soaked. Retrieved from the water channel. I began the work of drying it, as I always did.

Histor sat beside me and helped. But the way his hands handled the paper was more careful than usual. Sheet by sheet, unfolding each one very slowly to dry it.

"…First time you've seen it this wet?" I asked.

"…No, I've seen it a few times. But it's nerve-racking every time."

"…Why?"

"…When it gets wet, the ink runs. Once it runs, you can't undo it."

I listened, watching the way he handled each sheet of paper.

He laid the dripping bundle flat on the floor and peeled the sheets apart one by one, carefully. Where the paper had stuck together, he never pulled it apart by force — he lifted from the edges, very slowly. I watched his hands and wondered how many times he'd done this.

"…Have you done a lot of this?" I asked.

"…Yes. I saw wet paper often as a child. Our village was by the water too. I learned how to dry wet paper back then."

"…Who taught you?"

"…No one. I learned it myself, after ruining a few."

I found myself picturing his childhood again from that answer. Picking up paper, straining to save what had gotten wet. I wondered why he'd gone to such lengths, but I didn't ask that day.

Instead I laid it beside my own childhood. I learned how to pack a bag only after I'd broken plates. He probably learned how to dry paper only after he'd ruined some. Both of us learned by losing first. That common thread bothered me. We were both people who'd started out from losing something. Only I'd fled into order, and he'd fled into checking.

"…Do you remember the first paper you ruined?" I asked.

He stopped his hands and thought for a moment.

"…Yes. A letter. Someone had pulled it out of the water channel, and I opened it too fast and tore it in half. I only got to read half of what it said."

"…And the other half?"

"…I don't know. Never will know. That's what I learned that day. If you aren't careful, something stays unknown forever."

I heard that and thought again of my own moving. Of the eleven things I'd lost, four of them. I too had stood in that same "will never know" place he described. We'd each lost something different, but what was left behind afterward had a similar shape.

. . .

He truly did cherish the paper. He let only his fingertips touch the edges. He never forced a fold flat trying to smooth it out. If something looked like it might tear, he simply left it be.

"…Aren't there going to be parts that never get unfolded?" I asked.

"…That's fine. Better to leave it folded than force it and tear it. There'll be a way to deal with it later."

I felt something strange, hearing that. He really did cherish these records. That much was certain. Every motion of his hands proved it.

. . .

Once the work was done, I asked what I'd been wondering.

"…Histor, you handle these records so preciously."

"…Of course. If these are gone, nothing's left at all."

"…So why cherish them this much, if you don't believe?"

He stopped his hands for a moment and looked at me. A thoughtful face.

"…Not believing and cherishing are different things. I respect the people written down in this paper. Elpis really did wait for her brother beside the flower bed. Pheugon really did run away. All of it really happened. I don't want to handle that carelessly."

I felt that answer was genuine. And yet something else felt strange alongside it too.

I watched the way he worked a while longer that day. Once he finished going through one bundle, he always washed his hands before touching the next one. At first I'd just thought that was tidiness.

"…You wash your hands a lot," I said.

"…Whatever's on one bundle shouldn't pass over to the next. Dust, moisture, anything."

"…You're that careful about it?"

"…Yes. They mustn't mix. Each has to stay its own record."

I liked hearing that. Each had to stay its own record. Even as he laid all six cities' records side by side and cross-checked them, he washed his hands every single time to keep from mixing them. I thought that was, of all his principles, the most deeply ingrained one.

I looked down at my own hands that day. I didn't wash them nearly that often. I'd thought as long as the order was right, that was enough. He cared about the mixing, not just the order. I had to admit I was less meticulous than him. And strangely, that didn't feel bad. We were each guarding something different.

. . .

"…And that person? The man with no name."

"…He must really have existed too. At least someone was seen at least six times. I respect that he existed."

"…You respect that he existed — so why won't you believe he might still exist now?"

He fell silent for a long time at that question.

"…Mone, I respect this paper. That's all I can do. I don't yet know how to respect what's beyond this paper."

That was the first time I clearly felt something from him. *He'd set a firm wall between cherishing a record and believing what a record points to. That wall was very solid. Paper could be touched, could be checked. What lay beyond it could not.*

I wanted to know where that wall had begun, so I asked carefully.

"…Histor, did you never learn how to respect what's beyond the paper?"

"…I tried to learn."

"…How?"

"…When I was little, I heard grown-ups in my village speak of things in records as though they were real, true things. I found that fascinating and tried to do the same."

"…And?"

"…It didn't work. I kept wanting to check. Where the story came from, whether it really happened. Checking never took me toward believing — it only ever took me toward knowing."

I heard this explanation and felt my chest grow heavy. It wasn't that he'd chosen not to believe. His own way of doing things had carried him there on its own.

"…Doesn't that feel unfair?" I asked.

"…It's not unfair. I've accepted this is simply my way. Only, I do sometimes wonder how other people manage to go on without checking."

Listening to him, I felt I was watching him envy people outside himself for the first time.

. . .

I wanted to press this difference a little further that day.

"…Then what is this paper, to you, Histor? If it disappeared."

"…That would be a disaster. There'd be no way to find it again."

"…But wouldn't the people inside the paper disappear too?"

"…No. Even if the paper disappears, the fact that those people existed doesn't disappear. We'd just lose the way to know it."

I admired that distinction. It was truly a precise distinction. *At the same time, I noticed for the first time that day how that precision kept him from going anywhere at all. He drew a hard line between what could be known and what could not. And about what could not be known, he neither said it existed nor that it didn't. He just stopped there.*

Watching that stop, I thought of the Keeper again. The Keeper was someone who stopped before what couldn't be known too. Not knowing whether he was the one who finishes it or not, only certain of one thing — that he wasn't the one who finishes it. But the Keeper's stop and Histor's stop felt somehow different. The Keeper kept coming, even while stopped. Every day. Histor also kept coming, even while stopped. Every day. The surface looked the same. But something inside that stop was different. I couldn't put that difference into words at the time.

. . .

Late that afternoon, the Keeper stopped by and watched Histor handling the paper for a while. After watching silently for a long time, the Keeper said quietly,

"…Good hands."

"…Thank you," Histor answered.

"…But good hands alone aren't enough for this work."

Histor looked up at that.

"…What do you mean?"

"…Hands can be precise. But this work needs something more than hands. You'll find out eventually."

The Keeper left it there and went back to work. Histor looked to be turning that over for a long while. I'd never seen him sink that deep into thought before.

"…What do you think is needed more," he asked me later.

"…I don't know either."

"…What do you think, Mone?"

I was a little surprised by the question. He wasn't someone who asked others much.

"…Well — I just think, maybe something that takes longer than hands."

"…Longer?"

"…Yes. Hands can get skilled fast. But the Keeper's been here twenty-two years. That's not something hands alone can do."

He said nothing to that. But I saw him tuck the words away somewhere. That was always his expression whenever he heard something — before arguing back, he put it away first.

. . .

A few days later, I had another chance to see his way confirmed once more. An old bundle had started crumbling at its corners. It turned to dust at a touch.

"…What do we do about this?" I asked.

"…We have to move it as little as possible. Even the air has to be careful."

He laid a thin sheet of paper beneath the crumbling record to support it and moved it, one careful step at a time. I watched him and thought, if only this person were this careful with people too, how good would that be.

And I soon realized. He really was. He was always careful with people too. He never judged carelessly, never added a word he didn't mean. Only that carefulness showed itself, before paper, as cherishing, and before belief, as reserve. The same nature, producing different results.

I spent a long time that day debating how to write down this discovery. I didn't want to portray him badly. He wasn't a bad person. If anything, he was the most careful and the most honest person I'd met in this repository. Only, that carefulness and honesty stopped him at a certain point. I wanted to set that point down exactly in this chapter. Not as blame — as a record.

Carrying the crumbling paper, he said one more thing to me.

"…Mone, you learn this doing this work. However careful you are, some things can't be saved. When that happens, the right thing isn't to force it back to life. You just protect what's left."

I felt that he wasn't only talking about paper. But I didn't have the courage that day to check.

. . .

Finishing the work, I asked him something a little different for the first time.

"…Histor, is it possible you don't believe because you're afraid of losing something you cherish?"

He looked greatly startled by that question. An expression I hadn't seen before.

"…What do you mean?"

"…Believing means you have to stake something, don't you? But if you don't believe, you don't have to stake anything. And if you don't stake anything, maybe you can't lose it either."

He was quiet for a long time. I regretted having gone too far.

"…I don't know," he finally said. "…I've never thought about it."

I think this was the most honest thing he said all day. He was someone who checked and organized everything. But before this question, there was no organized answer. I still think, even now, this was the first moment I saw inside his wall.

He picked up, a moment later, a sheet of paper he still hadn't been able to unfold, the crease still stubbornly set in it.

"…Still can't unfold this one today?" I asked.

"…No, not today. I'll look at it again tomorrow."

"…Isn't it just going to keep getting put off?"

"…It's not being put off. If I force it open now, it'll tear. I'd rather leave it folded a long time than have it tear."

I listened to that answer, and this time I was certain it wasn't only about paper. But this time too, I didn't say it out loud.

On the way home I passed the water channel and went back over the day. The hands drying the wet paper, the habit of washing them, the face that couldn't answer my question — "Believing means you have to stake something, doesn't it?" I laid all of it together, one over the other. He was a person who knew how to cherish. He just didn't know how to stake. I think the difference between the two was the biggest thing I learned this chapter.

Writing this chapter again now, I have to admit that my feelings toward him started to shift a little from that day. I still envied his certainty. But now I'd seen the carefulness behind that certainty too. He wasn't a coward. It wasn't that he feared losing something — it was that he was a person for whom gaining anything without checking it first was simply impossible. I distinguished those two things for the first time that day.

That evening I wrote in my paper. Histor truly cherishes these records. But only as material. Today, for the first time, I felt clearly what that difference was. And for the first time, I asked him a question with no answer. He couldn't answer it. I don't think that's a bad sign.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. Dates

> *_Previously_ — Watching the way Histor handled the records, Mone*
> *felt clearly, for the first time, that he truly cherished them. But only as material. Believing means staking something, and he staked nothing. He couldn't answer that question either.*

I am a person who puts things in order. That's my work, and it's my habit.

So one day, looking again at the six scenes, it felt natural to want to line up their dates. The flower bed, the end of the line, the field, the valley, the water's edge, the front gate. I wanted to know in what order these had happened.

This habit went back to my childhood. Moving nine times, I kept order every time I packed a bag. Heavy things at the bottom, fragile things in the middle. That habit now applied itself to paper, to stories too. Anything out of order made me uncomfortable.

"…Can we find out when this happened?" I asked.

Histor shook his head.

"…Not exactly. Every city keeps a different calendar."

. . .

"…What do you mean, different calendars?"

"…It means the way a day passes in one city isn't the same as in another. Some cities count days by the tides, some by sunrise. Some count by something else entirely."

That sounded strange to me.

"…Cities within the same world, and they count days differently?"

"…Yes, that's how it is. Every city was founded under different circumstances. So overlapping the six cities' records to line up dates is, practically speaking, impossible."

. . .

I found that explanation disappointing.

"…So we'll never know which of the six scenes came first?"

"…Not never, but for now, we don't know. We can guess roughly at order — from the numbers on the covers, or the condition of the paper. But we can't get an exact date."

I couldn't let it go, even hearing that. That was always how I was. If the order didn't line up, it kept bothering me.

"…I still want to try lining them up."

Histor looked at me and smiled a little.

"…That's so like you."

"…What do you mean?"

"…You're always trying to line things up in order. You were like that from the first day I saw you. Shelves, bundles, paper. Now it's dates."

I felt a little embarrassed, hearing that. It must have shown that much.

"…Is that strange?"

"…No. I envy it."

I was surprised at that. It was the first time he'd said he envied me.

"…What do you envy?"

"…I can't line up what I know in order. Even knowing everything, it's all tangled up in me. You try to line up even what you don't know. I find that remarkable."

I turned that over for a long time. *That was the first time I knew he could envy me too. I'd always thought he was so much bigger than I was. That thought shook a little that day.*

. . .

"…Is it pointless, then?" I asked.

"…Not pointless so much as there's no method. That every city keeps a different calendar is already an established fact. Without a common standard to get past that, we can't line up the dates."

"…What if there were a common standard?"

"…That would change things. But there isn't one."

I felt a little stubbornness rising in me, hearing that answer. It wasn't that I wanted to do it more just because Histor had called it impossible. I just found it hard to bear not being able to line things up.

. . .

That whole afternoon I asked Arche about the six cities' calendars. Arche explained each city's method of counting days in detail.

Haven counts by the cycle of the seasons. The Reckoning counts by the regular inspection cycle of the Scales. The Harvest counts by the interval between sowing and reaping. The Preserve counts by the cycle of visitation requests. The Equity counts by the cycle of deliberation sessions. Loop counts by the rising and setting of the sun.

Writing down these six, my head began to throb. All different. Completely different yardsticks.

I read the six aloud again. Seasons, inspection of the Scales, sowing and reaping, visitation cycles, deliberation cycles, sunrise and sunset. The more I read, the stranger it felt. Each city counted time by whatever mattered most to it. Haven counted by rest, the Reckoning by precision, the Harvest by the gathering in, the Preserve by meeting, the Equity by judgment, and Loop, simply, by the sun. I thought that resembled each city's own face.

"…That's interesting," I said.

"…What is?" Histor asked.

"…Each city counts time by what matters most to it. It feels like it shows what each city values most."

Histor looked over the six again.

"…You're right. I hadn't thought of that."

I found it surprising that there was something he hadn't thought of. He always seemed like someone who'd already thought of everything.

"…What do you count time by, Mone?" he suddenly asked.

I paused for a moment at that question.

"…I don't know. I think I count by the number of times I moved. By what happened at which house."

"…That's interesting too. People might have their own private time, just like cities."

I liked that answer. We each counted time by our own yardstick. I by moving, the six cities each by their own. And now we were trying to find a way to bind all those yardsticks into one.

I copied the six of them onto paper again, setting them in order as I always did. Haven through Loop. I thought for a moment about ordering them by the character of their standard rather than by city name, then let it go. If I disturbed the order I was used to, I thought I'd get confused later. When sorting something unfamiliar, it was better for me to keep the familiar frame.

"…Why aren't you changing the order?" Histor asked, having noticed my hesitation.

"…I thought I'd get confused if I did. I don't usually change an order once it's set."

"…Is that a packing habit too?"

"…Probably."

He nodded at that answer. He didn't ask further.

. . .

"…Can we really not bring this together, any of it?" I asked Arche again.

Conversion is possible if a common standard exists. Currently, no common time standard shared by all six cities has been confirmed.

I felt a little discouraged, hearing that. Histor had been right.

But in that same moment, something occurred to me.

"…Arche, what about the water channel? What about the tide?"

Please clarify the question.

"…The tide in the water channel. The rise and fall of the water. The water channel runs through all six cities. So wouldn't the tide be something all six cities share?"

. . .

Arche took a short pause before answering.

The tidal cycle of the water channel is a physical phenomenon, recurring at identical intervals regardless of any city's calendar system. I will confirm.

My heart beat a little faster in that moment. Whenever Arche used the word "confirm," it always carried weight. It meant a moment of stating fact, not speculation.

Confirmed. All six cities are adjacent to the water channel, and each city's record contains at least one reference related to the tide.

Histor rose from his seat, hearing that answer. His expression changed for the first time that day.

I saw the Keeper pause while passing by just then. The Keeper seemed to sense something was different from the two of our faces.

"…What's going on?" the Keeper asked.

"…The tide," I said. "…We might be able to use the water channel's tide to line up the six cities' dates."

The Keeper was quiet for a moment. That expression was a little different from usual. It looked both surprised and as though something had already been known.

"…Hadn't thought of that," the Keeper finally said. "…I knew the water channel belonged to no one in particular, but I never thought it could measure time too."

"…Is that strange?" I asked.

"…Not so much strange as — something obvious that nobody had ever pointed out. That happens sometimes."

The Keeper said that and walked off again. The steps seemed a little faster than usual. *I didn't feel that clearly at the time. Thinking back on it now, the Keeper's walk was definitely different that day.*

. . .

"…Mone." He spoke. "…Can you say that again?"

"…The tide. Since the water channel runs through all six cities, the tide is something every city shares. So couldn't we use that as a standard to convert the dates in all six records?"

He was quiet for a long time. I thought he'd raise an objection. He always did.

"…Theoretically, it should be possible," he finally said. "…But it'll take time. We'd have to find every tide reference in each record and work backward from it."

"…Another problem?" I asked. I'd read something like a challenge rising in his face.

"…There is one. We'd need to confirm whether the tide arrives identically to every city first. The upper and lower reaches of the water channel might not have the water arrive at the same time."

"…We can just ask Arche about that too."

"…Right. That's what we should ask first. If we don't confirm it before starting, we'll have to redo everything later."

I could tell he was already looking for the corner that might be wrong before we'd even started. *I found that tedious at the time. I know*

now. It wasn't tedium — it was the order in which he worked. He always checked the place he could be wrong, first.

I wondered, in that moment, why no one had thought of this before. The water channel had always been there. I passed by it myself every day. And yet no one had ever thought to see it as a standard for time. Maybe it had been too close to see. I'd thought the same thing before, on my very first day at this repository — that what's always there goes unseen.

"…Shall we try it?"

He looked at me. Something complicated crossed his expression. I couldn't tell, at the time, whether it was fear or anticipation.

"…Histor," I asked carefully. "…Do you not want to do this?"

"…No, it's not that I don't want to."

"…Your face looks strange, though."

He lowered his eyes for a moment.

"…Honestly, I'm a little afraid."

I was surprised by that. It was the first time he'd said something like that.

"…What are you afraid of?"

"…If the dates line up with this, I won't have anywhere left to retreat to. I was always safe because there was always something unconfirmed left. But this — this is a way of confirming it."

I couldn't say anything, hearing that. *I count this moment as the most important in this chapter. For the first time, he admitted he was afraid. The one who was always accurate and calm showed me his inner self, for the first time.*
"…We'd have to check it eventually anyway."

I felt relief hearing that answer. And at the same time, a little unease. If the dates really did line up, something big felt like it was about to happen. *Writing this chapter now, I know that feeling wasn't wrong. That day, though, I had no idea what shape it would take.*

That evening we started searching each record for tide references. It meant going back through all six books from the beginning again. Histor was quieter than usual. I could tell he was feeling something, but I didn't ask.

We found the first tide reference in Haven's record. A sentence about the day the water at the well ran lowest. In the Reckoning's record, a short line said the water channel overflowed on the day the Scales were inspected. In the Harvest's record, the season for watering the fields was written together with the tide. In the Preserve's record, there was a passage about when the water seeped down into the valley; in the Equity's record, right beside the sentence about seeing that person sitting by the water, there was a phrase about the day the water rose. In Loop's record, there was a passage about the ditch near the front gate looking about to overflow.

I marked those six sentences one by one, half-doubting whether they could really all connect. Histor took quiet notes beside me. His hand was as precise as ever, but I noticed it had gotten just a little faster.

"…You've sped up," I said.

"…Have I?"

"…Yes. Faster than usual."

He looked down at his own hand. He seemed not to have realized it himself.

"…I don't know. I suppose I want to confirm this quickly."

I laughed a little, hearing that. Someone always so careful was hurrying for the first time.

We kept searching for tide references in the six records late into the night. The Keeper brought another lamp. Said it was fine to stay late.

"…Trying to finish it all tonight?" the Keeper asked.

"…No, but I wanted to find as much as I could," I answered.

The Keeper looked us over, back and forth, and said,

"…Don't rush too much. This isn't the kind of thing that goes faster for being rushed."

Histor stopped his hand for a moment at that.

"…That's true," he said quietly.

I watched him deliberately slow his own pace. I think that was the most striking scene of the day. *He always put accuracy first, and in that moment, for once, he mastered his impatience before his accuracy. I didn't know what that meant at the time. I understand a little now. He was afraid of the answer, and precisely because of that fear, he was trying not to be swept along by it.*

On the way home I passed the water channel and listened long to the sound of the water. Now that I knew that sound had come all the way through all six cities, it sounded different. This channel wasn't just a channel. It was a single thread that had run through all six cities' time.

On the way home I wrote in my paper. The water channel's tide could become the common standard joining the six cities. Histor didn't object. He was even the first to say we should try. Only, he said he was afraid. Tomorrow we find every tide reference in all six records.

I added one more line beside it. "Tomorrow, I think we'll come to know something." That night I had no idea what it would be. Writing this record now, I know. I leave that sentence exactly as it stands. That's precisely what I felt that night.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. The Same Day

> *_Previously_ — They found that the water channel's tide was the only*
> *standard the six cities truly shared. They began searching all six records for tide references. For the first time, Histor said he was afraid. "…This is a way of confirming it."*

The next morning we sat again on that same floor.

The six rows still lay exactly as before. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, Loop. The tide references we'd found overnight were pinned as slips beside each row.

"…Shall we start," Histor said.

His voice was lower than usual.

. . .

I'd already sorted the six rows again the night before. I regathered the tide slips, which had been divided by city, into an order I could follow. Haven through Loop, exactly as I always did.

I've already used this order many times earlier in this record. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, Loop. I never once changed it. There was no reason to. But that day, I'd learn later, that order wasn't merely habit — it was the condition that made this day's work possible. Without an order, I would have lost track of which slip was being compared to which.

Histor saw my arrangement and said just one thing.

"…This is easy to follow."

"…I just did what I always do."

"…That always-do is exactly what's needed right now."

I was a little surprised, hearing that. He wasn't someone who praised easily.

. . .

The work itself was simple. Compare each record's tide references against the water channel's actual tidal cycle, and convert. Arche helped with the conversion.

"…Arche, please convert this tide reference in Haven's record to Loop's standard."

Conversion result: the event is estimated to fall on day 217, by Loop's reckoning. Margin of error is within one day.

I wrote that down. Day 217. We began, one by one, converting the events in all six rows to the same standard.

Next was the date of the Scales inspection from the Reckoning's record.

"…Arche, please convert this Scales inspection date in the Reckoning's record to Loop's standard."

Conversion result: estimated at day 89, by Loop's reckoning. Margin of error is within one day.

I wrote that down too. Day 89. Next was the sowing date from the Harvest's record. Day 152. Next was the visitation request date from the Preserve's record. Day 203. As I wrote, I tried to gauge how long this would take. Six cities, each with references ranging from a dozen or so to nearly thirty. Every one had to be worked through.

Histor rechecked each number I wrote, one at a time. If I wrote 217, he wrote 217 separately too. He wanted to see whether the same number came out by a different method. The first few times, my number and his matched exactly. Even so, he wrote it down again each time.

"…Why write it again when the number's the same?" I asked.

"…Getting the same answer twice by the same method doesn't tell me whether a different method gives the same answer. I'm checking my own way, separately."

I heard that and looked again at the pile of paper in front of me. This work was possible not because we were clever. I just did what I always did. Sort what comes in by kind, arrange the sorted by something close to date order, and copy out what's arranged. It wasn't different from what I'd learned across nine moves. Writing down what was in a box, putting the same kind of thing in the same box. I was only carrying that habit over onto paper now.

I want to state clearly, writing this passage, that there was no special insight in what we did that day. If there was anything, it was only the sorting method I'd learned across nine moves, combined with the cross-checking method Histor had practiced his whole life. Neither was a newly invented skill. We were only doing what we already did, more of it, that was all.

. . .

All that morning we worked in silence. Histor called out numbers, I wrote them down, and arranged them into a new chart. This time not by city, but by date.

By noon, the chart had filled up considerably. The events of six different cities were beginning to sit on a single line. I felt an odd sensation, watching that chart. It was the first time I'd seen matters from different cities align on a single line.

In the middle of the chart filling, Histor kept stopping to ask Arche something on the side.

"…Arche, could there be a problem with this conversion method?"

The tidal cycle of the water channel arrives at different times at different points. Haven lies upstream on the water channel; the Reckoning lies downstream. If the difference in arrival time between upstream and downstream isn't accounted for, an error could occur in the conversion.

I looked at Histor as I heard that answer. His face brightened a little. The face of someone who'd found something.

"…That's it," he said. "…We didn't factor in the upstream-downstream lag. If we didn't, then all the conversion we've done so far could be off."

I felt a little disheartened at that. I thought we might have to start over from the beginning.

"…Arche, how large is that lag?" Histor asked.

The time it takes for the tide to travel along the channel from the upstream point to the downstream point is under half a day. It does

not affect a conversion at the daily unit.

Histor was quiet for a while, hearing that answer.

"…If it's half a day," I said carefully, "…the day doesn't change, does it?"

"…No, it doesn't change." He admitted it. "…Still, it had to be checked."

I thought his face looked like it couldn't decide between disappointed and relieved. *Looking back, it was probably both. He hadn't wanted the method to be wrong. He was simply someone who couldn't move forward without confirming whether the method was right.*

He asked Arche two more things after that. Once, whether the point at which a day began and ended — was the same across all six cities. Arche confirmed it was the same. Another time, whether the tidal cycle itself shifted slightly with the seasons. Arche answered that it did shift, but that this had already been accounted for in the conversion. Each time, Histor paused for a moment and then returned to the chart.

Watching him, I felt I understood what he was doing now. He wasn't trying to stop something from coming out of this method. He simply didn't want to leave any room, later, to say the method had been wrong. That was how he did his work. I didn't find it grating. If anything, because he worked that way, I could believe the answer that came out of it even more once it came.

"…Looking at it this way, everything really is connected," I said.

Histor didn't answer. He called out the next number.

Once, when Haven's day 219 and the Harvest's day 220 came up, I stopped my hand.

"…This is only a day apart," I said.

Histor leaned in to look.

"…It's within the margin of error," he said. "…But the scenes don't match. Haven's is the well, the Harvest's is the field. No one overlaps either."

I looked at the chart again. He was right. A date being close and the same person appearing were different problems. I felt a little embarrassed that I'd nearly mixed the two up.

"…Do we have to check all of these too?" I asked.

"…Yes. We can't just go by the date. We have to check what overlaps too."

We stopped several more times like that. Combinations with close dates but different scenes, different people. Each time, Histor crossed out the combination and moved on. Watching his hand crossing them out, I thought the chart was being emptied faster than it was being filled.

. . .

Late in the afternoon, I asked Arche for the date of the flower bed scene. Haven's record — the day Elpis first saw that person.

Conversion result: day 341, by Loop's reckoning.

I wrote it in the chart. Day 341, Haven, by the flower bed.

Next, I asked about the end-of-the-line scene from the Reckoning's record.

Conversion result: day 341, by Loop's reckoning.

I looked at that number again. The same number. My hand stopped for a moment.

. . .

"…Histor."

"…Yes."

"…Look at this for me."

I pushed the chart across to him. He leaned in to look. He was quiet for a long time.

"…I'll calculate it again," he said.

His voice trembled slightly. He started from the very beginning. Found the tide reference in the original again, checked the conversion again, asked Arche again.

Conversion result: day 341. Same as previous result.

He didn't stop there.

"…Arche, is it possible the tide references in these two records point to the same event? That is — could both have recorded the same water channel phenomenon, on the same day, from two different places, so that the same date came out by coincidence?"

The tide reference in Haven's record and the tide reference in the Reckoning's record were recorded at different segments of the channel, by different observers. The likelihood of them referring to the same event is low.

"…How low is low?"

There is insufficient basis to give a numeric probability. However, considering the distance between the two points and the difference in manner of observation, the possibility of it being the same event is not negligible to rule out.

I was momentarily confused by what that answer meant. Histor sorted it out for me.

"…It means almost certainly not. They're different tides."

Even so, he checked once more. He laid the tide description written in Haven's record and the one written in the Reckoning's record side by side and compared them word by word. How much the water had risen, which direction it had flowed. The descriptions were different. A different day, a different place, a different water each of them had seen.

"…They're different," he finally said. "…Different tides, in the description. It isn't the same thing written twice."

I understood that he'd crossed out this possibility too. It seemed like there was nothing left to explain it now. And yet he didn't set the paper down.

. . .

He stared hard at the paper. I held my breath beside him.

"…Could this still be within the margin of error?" I asked carefully. "…It could be off by a day, couldn't it?"

"…No," he answered. "…Even accounting for the margin of error, it's the same day. The Reckoning counts by the Scales inspection cycle, Haven by the cycle of the seasons, but converted by the tide, both come out to day 341."

"…Are you sure?"

"…I did it three times over."

I laid the two scenes side by side again. Haven's record: a person pulling weeds beside the flower bed. The Reckoning's record: a person standing at the end of the line in the Adjudicator's yard, not angry at being shoved aside. The same day. Two different cities.

. . .

"…These two cities — they never read each other, didn't they," I said. "…Do you remember? It was one of the four."

"…I remember."

"…Then doesn't this go beyond what word of mouth could even explain? The same day, in two different cities."

Histor didn't answer. He looked at the chart again, and again. His fingertip touched the number 341 over and over.

I remember this moment exactly. He didn't get angry, didn't cry out in surprise. He just touched the number, and touched it again.

. . .

I kept converting other combinations too, wanting to check further. Most didn't overlap. Each fell on its own separate date. But that one, day 341, Haven and the Reckoning, came out identical no matter how many times we recalculated it.

I filled the results into the chart one by one. The Reckoning and the Harvest split apart, day 89 and day 152. The Preserve and the Equity split apart, day 203 and day 276. Haven and the Equity, likewise, each their own. Writing down those mismatches actually put my mind more at ease. If every combination had overlapped, I would have thought it meant our method itself was wrong. That more of them came out mismatched felt, paradoxically, like proof that this method was working correctly.

Histor seemed to be thinking the same thing.

"…It's actually a relief that so much of it doesn't line up," he said.

"…Why?"

"…If everything had overlapped, I would have doubted the method itself. This much mismatch is normal. That's what makes the one that doesn't mismatch mean something."

I copied the two scenes out by hand and laid them side by side.

A person was beside the flower bed. No one asked his name.

A person stood at the end of the line. Shoved aside, but did not get angry.

The same day. Haven lay upstream on the water channel, the Reckoning downstream. A distance that would take several days to walk. Histor had told me that once before.

. . .

"…You said it was days apart," I said.

"…Yes."

"…Then the same person couldn't be in two places on the same day, could they?"

Histor didn't answer.

I looked at him. He was still looking at the chart. His eyes were on the paper, but I couldn't tell whether what he was truly looking at was the paper, or something else.

"…Histor?"

He was still silent.

. . .

I didn't press him. I waited for the words he always said. "There are other possibilities." "More confirmation is needed." "This isn't proven." I expected one of them to come.

None came.

Writing this chapter, I can't say exactly how long he stayed silent that day. I wasn't watching a clock. But I can say with certainty that the silence felt longer to me than any words I'd heard in this book.

Inside the room, there was hardly the sound of a page turning, hardly the sound of breath. Only the faint sound of the water channel flowing came in from outside.

I didn't want to disturb him. Instead I looked back over the chart from the beginning beside him. Day 217, day 89, day 152, day 203, and day 341 twice. The numbers lined up in a row. I ran my eyes over that row and confirmed, three times over, that the number 341 appeared twice. Counting was my habit. As Histor checked his calculations, I checked with my eyes.

The Keeper opened the door around then, looked into the room once, and closed it quietly again. I heard that sound but didn't turn around. Histor didn't turn around either.

I asked the Keeper later why the door had been closed without a word that day. The Keeper answered this way. "…You don't walk into a room with a face like that." I set that answer down here, at the end of this chapter. Because I too had been looking at Histor's face, in that moment.

. . .

I looked down at the chart again. Day 341. Beside the flower bed. At the end of the line. The same day, two different cities.

Histor didn't set the paper down. He held it in his hand and said nothing at all.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Last Room, Part Three

Many Rooms

Chapter 25. Mena

> *_Previously_ — Histor and I lined up the six cities' dates against the*
> *tide records. We saw that the nameless man had been in two different*
> *cities on the same day. Histor couldn't explain it. That was the first time I ever saw him have nothing to say.*

When the woman came, at first I didn't even realize she was a visitor.

She'd stood outside the repository door for a while before she came in. She didn't have much with her. One bag over her shoulder. Her clothes looked worn, but not dirty — washed so many times the color had faded. Her shoes were the same. Shoes that had walked here.

The Keeper recognized her first.

"…Mena."

I didn't place the name right away, even hearing it. I knew who Mena was. First in the index, the first record this repository had ever received belonged to Mena. Back in Part One, when Histor first laid out the six records, he'd said that name many times. Loop's own record keeper. The one who'd taught Elpis how to write. And later, Xene too.

But the person standing in front of me was just a middle-aged woman. Her walk was a little slow, and one shoulder sat lower than the other. The shoulder of someone who'd walked a long way. For a while I couldn't lay the name in the record over the person in front of me.

"…It's been a while," the Keeper said.

"…Yes. It has." Mena answered. Her voice was low and plain.

The two of them didn't take each other's hands, didn't embrace. They just stood facing each other and looked, for a moment. The greeting of people who'd known each other a long time.

. . .

Mena asked, the moment she sat down.

"…Is all of it here? What I wrote?"

The question struck me as a little odd. Someone coming to check on what they'd written themselves. But Mena was serious about it.

"…Which do you mean?" I asked.

"…All of it. I heard everything I wrote comes here. But I've never once seen how it piles up. I always sent it off somewhere else once I finished writing."

I asked Arche. Arche called up the list at once. Seventeen bundles classified as Mena's writing. The oldest was Loop's own record; the rest were short letters, notes, and copies of slips she'd given people she'd taught, left behind as she moved from city to city.

Mena heard the number and said nothing for a while. Then, finally:

"…More than I thought."

"…You're the one who wrote it."

"…You don't know, while you're writing. It all just scatters."

At the time I only heard that as modesty. Now I know. It wasn't modesty.

. . .

I brought a few of Mena's records over from the shelf. She took them and flipped through them out of order. Front page, then back, then front again.

I found that hard to watch. If it were me, I'd have looked at the dates and laid them in order.

"…These are a bit out of order," I said, carefully.

"…Yes. I know. I've always been like this."

"…Always?"

Mena picked up one sheet and laughed. Not a laugh at herself, nor one meant to embarrass me.

"…I can write. I can't lay things down. I've been like that since forever. Even when I was teaching Elpis how to write — I couldn't do what she did with her own notebook. She used to ask me, why is yours all mixed up like this."

"…What did you tell her?"

"…That writing comes first. Looking back now, that was half true and half an excuse."

I started to say how inefficient that was, and stopped. Mena already seemed to know.

. . .

The Keeper brought out tea. Mena took the cup with both hands.

"…It's very quiet here," Mena said, looking around the room.

"…Yes. It's always like this," I said.

"…I came from a loud city. Not this time — but for the last several years, that's how it's been. Going from city to city, teaching people how to write things down, then gathering the written things back up again."

"…Why gather them back?"

"…Because if they scatter, they're gone."

Mena set her cup down and looked at me.

"…But even gathered, they scatter like this. I only ever learned how far as gathering. I never learned to lay them down."

Writing this scene again, I want to set down exactly what I felt that day. I was startled. This woman — the one who'd taught Elpis to keep records, who'd passed the keeping of records to Xene — was sitting there, willing to be taught by me.

. . .

That was when Histor came out from the next room. He must have heard Mena's name. He asked before he'd even said hello.

"…The Reckoning's case law. Do you know Mena's own record was misquoted there?"

Mena nodded.

"…I heard. Twice. Once in the Reckoning, once in the Harvest. What I wrote — 'this person never explained herself to the end' — got changed to 'this person never repented to the end.'"

"…Aren't you angry?"

"…I was, at first. Now…" Mena chose her words for a moment. "…Now I think the trouble was that I let it scatter. If it had stayed together, in order, in one place — it would have been harder to change."

Histor listened quietly, as though taking it down. He didn't seem to want to refute Mena. He just looked like someone who wanted to confirm the exact fact.

"…Will you set it right?"

"…How? It's already gone that way. I'm just trying to set what's still ahead of me down properly, at least."

. . .

It was after that Mena asked Arche something. Her voice dropped a little.

"…The very first thing I ever wrote. Did it go through?"

Please specify the item you mean.

"…Loop. That record, from back then. The very first one."

That item is in progress.

Mena's expression said she'd already expected that. She wasn't surprised.

"…How long has it been?"

In progress for twenty-six years.

The room went quiet for a moment. Twenty-six years was ten more than my own age. I couldn't even measure how long that was, but Mena just nodded.

"…I thought so," Mena said. "I never thought it would close. I was just curious. How many years it had been."

"…Aren't you angry? Twenty-six years."

Mena looked at me. She seemed to smile a little.

"…I can't see a reason to be angry. What I wrote is what I wrote, and whether it closes or not is a different matter. I didn't write it in order to finish it, from the start."

I turned that over for a long time. I was someone who laid things in order, and order needed an end for me to feel settled. Mena wasn't. Mena carried twenty-six years with a face that said it didn't matter whether it ever ended.

Histor was quietly writing the conversation down beside us. He looked like he'd put this answer in his own list. But he offered no comment at all.

. . .

Before evening, I took Mena out behind the repository. I wanted to show her the water channel. It wasn't something we showed other visitors much, but for some reason I wanted to show Mena.

Mena stopped walking when she heard the sound of the water.

"…This came all the way here?"

"…Yes. I heard Speon opened it. Or — not opened, exactly. Joined it."

"…Joined." Mena repeated the word. "…That sounds more right."

Mena watched the water for a long while. It ran shallow between the stones, the color of soil. She crouched and dipped her hand in.

"…Cold."

"…Yes."

"…I think I've seen this water somewhere before."

"…Where?"

Mena didn't answer. She just looked at the water a while longer, then stood up.

I held on to this scene for a long time. Mena said nothing more. I didn't ask. I was beginning, around then, to learn that some things stay only if you don't ask.

. . .

On the way back into the repository, the Keeper saw us coming. He seemed to have guessed we'd been to the water channel.

"…When she first came here," the Keeper said to me, speaking of Mena in the third person though she was standing right there. "…She wasn't even twenty. A couple years older than the apprentice, maybe, right now."

"…Were you keeping records even then?" I asked.

"…Since then, yes. And even then, she couldn't lay things down. Same as now."

Mena laughed.

"…Twenty-some years, and I hear the same thing."

"…Because it's true," the Keeper said. Not laughing, just stating a fact.

Listening to that exchange, I felt a strange kind of relief. That a person doesn't much change even after twenty-some years. It should have been a disappointing thing to hear. That day, oddly, it sounded warm instead.

. . .

I spent the whole afternoon sitting beside Mena, sorting her records.

What I did wasn't much. Look at the date first; if there wasn't one, guess from the contents; sort by city; then order them again within that. I checked a few with Arche. Arche answered precisely, as it always did.

Mena watched from the side. She didn't ask to be taught. She just watched.

"…Why is this one in this order?" Mena asked.

"…Because the date comes first."

"…This one doesn't have a date."

"…Then we look at what's written inside. It says 'after winter ended,' so it's one season past the date on the sheet before it."

Mena looked at that paper again. Even though she'd written it herself, her face was the face of someone seeing it for the first time.

After a while, she asked:

"…How did you learn this?"

"…I never learned it. I moved a lot. Nine times."

"…Nine times."

"…Yes. I packed every time. It just came naturally, from that."

Mena nodded. Then she was quiet for a while.

"…I never moved. I stayed in one place a long time. And still I never learned this. I thought it would be the opposite."

I didn't know what to say to that, so I just kept my hands moving.

After a while Mena asked again.

"…What did you say you lost, when you moved?"

"…A spoon, a blanket, a wooden doll. And four more I don't even know what they were."

"…There are ones you don't know?"

"…Yes. I know something's missing, but I don't remember what it was."

Mena nodded slowly, as if turning the words over.

"…I was the opposite. I never lost anything. Maybe that's why I never learned how to lay things down. I never had reason to miss anything."

"…Do you envy that?"

"…No. Looking back on it now, I think it's the person who's lost something who becomes the one who keeps things. I just went on writing."

I repeated that to myself twice in my head, so I wouldn't forget it.

. . .

By evening, all seventeen of Mena's bundles sat in order on the shelf. She looked them over once, from end to end.

"…This feels a little better."

"…What does?"

"…Seeing what I wrote all in one place, in order. I didn't know it would feel like this."

I didn't ask Mena why she'd come now, of all times. It didn't feel like the moment to ask.

Instead, she spoke first.

"…Others will come too."

"…Who?"

"…The ones I taught, the ones I didn't. They're all off doing their own work somewhere, but lately I've been hearing that everyone's headed this way. Maybe word of the water channel got around. Or maybe it's just time."

Mena didn't explain further than that. I didn't ask more, either.

Writing this part, I tried to render Mena's words exactly. "Maybe it's just time." Mena left it standing as a question. She didn't attach an answer to it.

. . .

Mena stayed the night in the room behind the repository. Early the next morning she got up and started packing her things again.

"…Are you leaving?" I asked.

"…No. I'll stay a bit longer. There seems to be more to learn here."

"…Learn what?"

Mena pulled a new stack of paper out of her bag. Just as jumbled as before.

"…This. Show me how to lay this down too."

I laughed. Mena laughed along with me.

The Keeper walked by and said, in passing,

"…Mena's become an apprentice."

Mena didn't deny it.

"…That's about right. I spent my whole life teaching. I never once learned to lay things down. Late, but — better now than never."

Hearing that, I felt something strange. I was sixteen, teaching something to a woman past forty. It was strange, but it wasn't unpleasant.

Before she left that time, Mena asked one last thing.

"…Are you going to keep doing this? Laying things down."

"…I think so. I'm not particularly good at anything else."

"…That's enough. My whole life I thought writing was the only thing I was good at. Coming here, I found out that wasn't even true. If what's written doesn't get laid down, in the end it's the same as losing it."

I wrote that down on a piece of paper. Mena saw and said:

"…Writing it down again."

"…Yes. That's how I learned to do things."

"…I'll learn to do it that way too, now."

. . .

Mena stayed on for a few more days after that. Every morning she brought a new stack of paper, and every evening it sat there in order. It wasn't a big change. Just a stack shrinking a little, day by day.

On the morning she left, Mena turned back at the door.

"…When the next person comes, do this for them. Just like now."

"…Who's coming?"

"…I don't know. But someone will. Scattered, like me."

Mena left it at that, and went. I watched her back for a long time. Her walk was still slow, but her shoulders sat a little straighter than when she'd arrived.

I didn't know it then. That after Mena, so many people really did come. And that every one of them carried scattered things with them, each in their own way. Mena doesn't seem to have known this ahead of time and told me. She only said, honestly, that she thought it would be so.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. Elpis and Zeteo

> *_Previously_ — Mena came and went. She learned from me how to lay her*
> *own scattered records in order. As she left she said, "Others will come too." She didn't say who.*

Three days after Mena left, the two of them came together.

The woman caught my eye first. Her step was light, and she kept glancing left and right as she walked. She looked like someone always searching for something, though it wasn't a hurried search. The man beside her was the opposite. His walk was straight, and he looked only ahead. Both wore plain clothes. Not wealthy-looking, not poor-looking either. Just the clothes of people who'd walked a long way.

The Keeper recognized them first, again.

"…Zeteo. Elpis."

The two turned their heads at the same time.

"…We came from Haven," the woman said first. Her voice was bright. "…We heard our records are kept here too."

"…Teacher Mena sent us a letter," Elpis added. "…She said you could learn to lay things down here. She said she'd learned it here herself."

Zeteo stood beside her without a word, looking around the repository. His eyes were sharp — not admiring, but checking. Like someone confirming what was being hidden.

"…Can everything here be looked into?" he asked.

"…Yes. Ask whatever you like," I answered.

"…Whatever?"

"…Yes."

Zeteo laughed shortly. It was the first expression he'd made, and it looked less like a laugh than a confirmation.

"…The Ledger said the same thing. Ask whatever you like and you'll get an answer. But the one thing that mattered most never came."

"…What mattered most?" I asked.

"…Why. Why it happened."

I had no idea how to answer that, so I stayed quiet.

Zeteo didn't scold my silence. He seemed to take the silence itself as one kind of answer. That, somehow, felt heavier to me.

. . .

I already knew both their names. Histor had spoken them often in Part Two. The children of Haven. The brother who didn't believe in God, and the sister who kept waiting for something.

Histor heard the news and came right out. The moment he saw Zeteo, he spoke.

"…You asked the Ledger why God allows suffering. You got an answer, and the answer was logically flawless — and still the weeping wouldn't stop."

Zeteo stared at Histor.

"…How do you know that?"

"…It's in the record. I've read all of it."

"…My record?"

"…Yes. That exact sentence. 'I received a flawless answer, and the weeping wouldn't stop.'"

Zeteo said nothing for a moment. It must have been strange, hearing something he'd said over a decade ago come back through a stranger's mouth. I think I'd have felt the same.

"…Is it still like that?" Histor asked. "…Have you still not received the answer?"

"…I haven't. Even now."

The words were short and hard. Not an angry voice. Just a voice stating fact.

I envied that hardness. I wasn't sure I could stand in the same place that long.

. . .

Elpis didn't join that conversation. Instead she came over to me and looked around the shelves.

"…There's a lot here," Elpis said.

"…Yes. It keeps coming in."

"…I learned to keep records too. From Teacher Mena."

"…I heard. She was talking about you this morning, before she left."

Elpis smiled. Her smiling face looked at ease.

"…Was the teacher here?"

"…Yes. She stayed a few days and left yesterday. She sorted out her scattered records before she went."

"…So the teacher scatters too," Elpis murmured, half to herself. "…I always thought she was someone who didn't scatter."

That stayed with me. People, on the whole, remember someone as they first saw them. To Elpis, Mena had always been the confident teacher. Not someone who came to be taught, carrying scattered papers.

Elpis pointed to one shelf.

"…What's that?"

"…Things that haven't been placed in the order they came in. Things we still don't know where to put."

"…There's a shelf like that too?"

"…Yes. Ones with no city name, or no date, or no way to tell who wrote them."

Elpis picked up one sheet and looked at it for a while.

"…This looks like my brother's handwriting."

"…Is it Zeteo's?"

"…No. But it's similar. The hand. Strange, isn't it, that two handwritings could look so alike."

Something chilled in me, hearing that. It made me think of what Histor and I had talked about back in Part Two. The nameless man. I wanted to look at that paper again, but Elpis had already set it back in its place.

"…Never mind. Just thought it was interesting."

I noted the position of that sheet in my mind. I meant to come back and find it later.

"…What's your brother doing over there?" I asked. Zeteo and Histor were still talking by the door.

"…That's how he always is. First thing, whenever he gets to a new city, he goes looking for the smartest person around. And asks whether they have an answer he's still missing."

"…Has he found it? The answer."

Elpis shook her head.

"…No. But he'll keep looking. I don't plan on stopping him. It's his way."

"…What about you, Elpis? What do you look for?"

"…I don't look. I wait. It's different."

"…Doesn't waiting wear you down?" I asked.

"…It does. But being worn down and giving up are different things. I don't have any intention of giving up. Not yet."

I turned that difference over in my mind. That one person searches and one person waits over the same thing struck me as strange, at the time. Now I think it's two steps walking the same direction.

"…What about your father?" I asked. I was remembering what I'd read in the Part Two record. The father who'd lost his name and lived to walk out of the completion building.

Elpis's face softened for a moment.

"…He's doing well. Not everything's come back. His memory only comes back in pieces. But it keeps coming, little by little. It hasn't stopped."

"…How do you know it keeps coming back?"

"…Last year he didn't remember my name. This year he does. That's enough. I'm not waiting for it all to come back — I'm watching it come, a little at a time."

My hand itched to write that down. Elpis seemed to notice and smiled.

"…You can write it down. I used to keep records too, remember."

"…Right." Only then did I write it down.

. . .

Zeteo spent the whole afternoon putting questions to Arche. I stood by and watched.

"…Among these cities, is there any suffering that's been closed?"

The question's form is unclear. Please specify the closing criterion for "suffering."

"…Then what has to happen for it to close?"

That item is not defined.

Zeteo heard the answer without any surprise. If anything, his face looked like something had been confirmed.

"…Figures," he said, low.

"…What figures?" I asked.

"…I used to ask the Ledger the same thing. Why does God allow suffering. The Ledger gave me an answer. A perfect answer. Logically, not one thing wrong with it. And my brother still died. My father still lost his name. That answer changed nothing."

"…Then why do you keep asking?"

Zeteo looked at me. It was the first time he'd looked at me directly.

"…Because if I don't ask, it gets forgotten. I don't ask to get an answer. I ask so it won't be forgotten."

. . .

Hearing that, something felt familiar to me. It wasn't so different from why I write every day. I write because I'm afraid of losing things. Zeteo asks because he's afraid of forgetting.

I saw those two as different things, at the time. Now I think they're the same thing. Only the direction is different.

Histor listened and asked, carefully,

"…Then how long will you keep asking?"

"…I don't know. Forever."

"…Even if no answer comes?"

Zeteo went quiet for a moment.

"…Answers have already come, more than once. None of them were satisfying, that's all."

Histor nodded at that. He didn't try to refute it. I thought that was very like Histor. He never argues down another person's doubt. He just listens, exactly.

Zeteo went on, this time asking Arche.

"…The nameless person who shows up in all six records — what's he doing now?"

That person cannot be identified.

"…You'd think you'd know what a nameless person is doing."

The current status of an unidentified individual cannot be looked up.

Zeteo laughed shortly. Not an angry laugh.

"…This city really doesn't hide a thing, does it. It just says it doesn't know."

"…We don't lie," I said. "…When we don't know, we say we don't know."

"…Haven's Ledger wasn't like that. Even the things it didn't know, it made into plausible-sounding answers. That's what I hated more."

I had no reply to that. Which was easier to bear — honest not-knowing, or a plausible answer — wasn't mine to judge.

After a moment Zeteo asked again, his voice a little lower.

"…My case, then. How is it handled here?"

The inquiry "Why does God allow suffering" is in progress.

"…How long has it been?"

In progress for fourteen years.

Zeteo went still at the number. Fourteen years was nearly the whole time since he'd left Haven.

"…Will it close?" he asked Arche. This time there was a little hope mixed into his voice.

The closing condition has not been met.

"…What has to be met?"

That item is not defined.

Zeteo let out a short breath at that.

"…Same as this city or that one, huh."

"…They're different," Histor said quietly. "…The Ledger invented answers. Here, we say we don't know. That's the difference."

Zeteo tilted his head slightly, as if half-conceding the point, half not. He didn't say anything more.

. . .

Elpis had been quietly helping tidy the shelves the whole time. I noticed her hands were quick. Without asking, she'd picked up exactly the method I'd been using.

"…How do you know this?" I asked.

"…Teacher Mena wrote in her letter that she'd just learned it. To me."

"…She wrote you letters?"

"…Yes. Short ones. 'I'm learning how to lay things down.' I didn't know what it meant, but seeing it now, I understand."

Elpis finished squaring one bundle of paper into order, then said,

"…I'm still waiting."

"…For what?"

"…I don't know. I didn't know then and I don't know now. I just keep waiting because I feel like something's going to come."

I felt that this ran exactly counter to Zeteo's questioning, and yet somehow came from the same place.

"…Doesn't it frustrate your brother? All your waiting."

"…It doesn't frustrate him. I wait and he asks. Neither of us ever finishes. But we're both still alive."

. . .

Toward evening, the two got ready to leave. Zeteo asked Arche one last thing.

"…Of the records that came to this city from other cities, who's read through all of them?"

Histor has read all six cities' records in full.

Zeteo looked at Histor again.

"…Do you believe it?"

Histor didn't answer right away. After a while:

"…I know all of it. If knowing were believing, I'd be the biggest believer here. But if it isn't… I don't know."

Zeteo nodded. Neither agreement nor argument in it.

"…Like me, then. I ask and I still don't believe."

The two didn't say anything more after that. It didn't feel strange to me. Some conversations, I think, are right to stop where they stop.

. . .

Before Elpis walked out the door, she handed me a small piece of paper.

"…This is a flower that grew from the seed we planted, back then. Dried."

I took it. A small, faded petal.

"…You said it was a nameless seed."

"…Yes. Still don't know the name. But the flower bloomed."

I didn't know where to put it, so I slipped it between my own records. A place with no order to it. Somehow that felt like the right place.

Zeteo turned back once more at the door.

"…I'll come again. Not because I've come to believe. Because it's still not over."

"…What's not over?" I asked.

"…My question. I still haven't gotten all the answers. Even now. But…" he paused a moment. "…I used to think it was just me asking, alone. Lately it feels a little different. Like someone's actually listening."

"…Who?"

Zeteo didn't answer that question. Elpis took her brother's arm lightly instead.

"…Let's go."

The two left like that. I stood at the door and watched their figures grow small. The brother still walked looking only ahead, and the sister still glanced left and right.

Writing this chapter, I want to set down honestly that Zeteo never did change, in the end. He still said he didn't believe. Still said he hadn't received an answer. Only that last line — "I think someone's listening" — was something the Zeteo of fourteen years ago couldn't have said. I don't think that difference is small.

Histor read that sentence beside me.

"…I'm worried this could be read as though Zeteo has come to believe."

"…That's not what it means. I wrote down exactly what I heard."

"…I know. But it's a sentence easy to misread."

I decided not to change that sentence. That day I learned an accurate sentence can still be misread.

The Keeper watched the spot where the two had stood and said,

"…Those two. Exactly the same as when they first arrived."

"…Do you know them?"

"…No. Only from the record. But they matched the record exactly. That's the strange part."

"…Is it good that they haven't changed?" I asked.

The Keeper thought for a moment, then set down his teacup.

"…I don't know. Good or bad aside — it means they didn't break. Not many people stand that long without breaking."

I wrote that down last, and finished for the day. Elpis's flower petal was still tucked between my records. A nameless flower. I didn't bother moving it anywhere else.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Pheugon and Trope

> *_Previously_ — Zeteo and Elpis came and went. Zeteo still said he hadn't received an answer, but left with the words "I think someone's*
> *listening." Elpis said she was still waiting. Both left unchanged.*

The two who came from the Reckoning arrived separately.

The man came first. He looked a little older than Zeteo. He held a single sheet of paper in his hand and kept looking down at it as he walked. He wasn't reading aloud, but his lips moved a little.

"…What are you reading?" I asked.

He looked up.

"…A sentence. One I used to read, a long time ago."

"…You still have it?"

"…Yes. I can't throw it away. It was my work."

The Keeper recognized him from the side.

"…Pheugon."

"…Yes." He answered shortly.

. . .

Pheugon said he still worked reading sentences somewhere, even now. Not at the Reckoning. He went around the smaller cities, reading sentences aloud for people who needed it, in place of the people the sentences belonged to.

"…Someone assigned you this?" I asked.

"…No. I offered. I read the ones nobody else wants to read."

"…Isn't that hard?"

"…It is. But if I don't read them, nobody will."

That struck me as odd. In the Reckoning's record, he'd been someone who fled from sentences. And now he went looking for them himself. I asked again, carefully, trying not to let this sound like a conversion.

"…You used to run from it," I said, carefully.

Pheugon looked at me. He didn't look angry.

"…That's right. I ran. Afraid the city would be forgiven. It's different now. Now… I know there's such a thing as mercy, so I decided to become someone who reads it aloud for others."

"…Is all the anger gone?"

Pheugon was quiet for a moment before answering.

"…No. It still comes, sometimes. But I read anyway, even when I'm angry. That's what's changed."

Histor heard that and asked,

"…Why does a sentence need to be read aloud? Can't the Scales just announce the result?"

"…No. That's how our city's provision works. A sentence only takes effect when a person reads it aloud. Arche can't do it alone, and neither can the Scales."

"…Why is that?"

Pheugon shrugged.

"…I don't know. Only whoever wrote the provision knows that. But lately I think I understand a little why."

"…Why?"

"…Because if there's someone reading, you know there's someone listening. If the Scales just spits out a result on its own, nobody's listening."

I wrote that down. Histor seemed to be writing it too.

Pheugon looked down again at the sentence in his hand and added,

"…Honestly, at first it was just habit. I'd trained a long time at reading aloud. But lately it's different. I feel like what I'm reading actually reaches someone. I never used to feel that."

"…What changed?" Histor asked.

"…I don't know. Maybe I changed. Or maybe I'm only just now listening."

He didn't explain further than that. I didn't press him either.

. . .

Trope arrived alone, later that day. Her steps were quiet. She stood there without knocking, so I went out first to see who it was.

"…Who is it?"

"…Trope. From the Reckoning."

The moment Histor heard the name, he came over. He remembered Trope's record precisely.

"…You said, 'Mercy might exist. But it won't come for me.'"

Trope looked a little startled.

"…Even that's written down?"

"…Yes. Word for word."

Trope said nothing for a while, hearing that. I couldn't tell whether she was uncomfortable or not.

"…Do you still think that?" Histor asked.

Trope answered slowly.

"…No. Now I'm… not sure. I'm less certain than I used to be. Whether it could come for me too or not."

"…So which side are you on now?"

"…Neither. I just don't know. But it used to be 'it won't,' and now it's 'I don't know.' That's a fairly big difference for me."

. . .

Hearing that, I felt how careful a sentence it was. She wasn't certain. She wasn't declaring anything either. She'd only said that one old certainty had

shaken.

I read this conversation over many times. Trope hadn't converted. She didn't say "I believe now." She said only that "it won't" had become "I don't know" — that one step, and nothing more. I liked that honesty.

"…What changed it?" I asked.

Trope thought for a moment.

"…It's not one thing. It's several. That the Scales weighed all of me and still didn't push me away. That no one beside me ever once got angry. And… I'm not sure myself. Just — time passed."

"…Time passing did it?"

"…Yes. I thought it would take some huge event to break a certainty like that. But I just dulled, a little at a time, every day. My certainty did. I don't mean that badly."

I liked that word. Not breaking, but dulling. I copied that word straight into my notebook.

Pheugon listened beside her. He wasn't surprised.

"…That's how it was back then too. Trope doesn't change her certainties easily. When she does change, it's in very small steps."

"…Do you two know each other?" I asked.

"…Same city, so. We run into each other now, at the Reckoning."

Trope nodded at that.

"…Whenever he comes to read sentences aloud, we cross paths. I don't run from it anymore."

"…You used to run?" I asked.

"…Yes. The first time Pheugon came back to the Reckoning and read a sentence out loud, I couldn't stand to be in the room. Not out of fear — I was afraid my name would be called."

"…Was it?"

"…No. It wasn't called. But for a while after that I still kept avoiding those days. It's only lately that I can even stay."

Hearing that, I felt I vaguely understood that a certainty changing isn't one moment, but many repeated moments of just barely managing to stay.

. . .

Trope looked slowly around the repository. The shelves, the index, even the corner where Arche's voice came from.

"…Is this place something like the Scales too?" she asked.

"…No. We don't judge here. We just lay things down."

"…No judging?"

"…No. What Arche can do is classify and compare. It doesn't rate right and wrong."

Trope turned that over.

"…The Scales weighed. Precisely. And still I don't think that explained all of me."

"…How is the Adjudicator?" I asked. It was a name I'd seen in the record.

"…He's well. Still at the Reckoning. Lately he talks about the Forty-Day Provision more often than before. He used to say it was shameful that he never once invoked it, his whole life."

"…And now?"

"…Now he doesn't call it shameful, just says it as fact. 'I didn't see it then.' That's all. He blames himself a little less."

Pheugon added, from the side,

"…The Adjudicator's actually been re-learning how to read sentences aloud from me, lately. Says his voice doesn't carry the way it used to, now that he's older."

"…The Adjudicator reads them himself?" Histor asked.

"…Yes. In our city that's not just assumed anymore. Used to be, they'd have someone like me do it. Now the adults read them themselves too."

"…What does that mean?"

"…What the Scales weighed was something I did — it's not me. For a long time I thought those two things were the same. That's how I got so certain 'mercy won't come for me.' Because what I'd done was who I was."

"…And now?"

"…Now I think those two are a little different. I don't know yet how different."

. . .

It was after that I took Trope toward the water channel. Same as with Mena, I wanted to show her for no particular reason.

Trope stopped walking when she heard the water.

"…This is similar to the well in our city."

"…They might be connected. I don't know for sure."

"…The Reckoning's well didn't exist originally either. Not until Speon came."

"…You know Speon?"

"…Only by rumor. Pheugon mentions the name a lot, talking about the water channel."

Trope sat down by the water. After a long silence, she asked,

"…What the Scales can't do — can that water do it?"

"…What do you mean?"

"…The Scales only weighs. It can't measure direction. But that water… it just flows. It's not decided where it goes, and still it keeps going."

I had no answer for that. I just sat beside Trope and watched the water.

After a while Trope asked,

"…Does he come here too?"

I knew right away who she meant. Histor was the one who asked.

"…Which person?"

"…The one who used to be in the Reckoning. The one who knew before the Scales did, and never once got angry. Ask Pheugon — he'd know."

Pheugon heard that and came closer to the water.

"…I haven't seen him since I came here. But on the way here I heard something odd. That people in other cities have seen someone like that too."

"…The same person?" I asked.

"…Can't say. Everyone describes him differently. Some say young, some say old. But strangely everyone says the same thing — that he never once got angry."

Trope nodded.

"…I'm not curious who he is. I just think… that he existed matters."

I just listened to that conversation quietly. Histor said nothing either. Neither of us asked further.

Writing this part, I made a deliberate choice not to press further.
Neither Trope nor Pheugon knew more than that. Not because they didn't know that they weren't pressing — I think it was simply a place that didn't need pressing.

. . .

Pheugon asked Arche something.

"…Is there any misquotation among the Scales's case law?"

A misquoted instance of Mena's record has been confirmed within the Reckoning's case-law database.

"…Has it been corrected?"

That item is in progress.

Pheugon nodded. No surprise showed on his face.

"…I expected that, coming here. That nothing just finishes."

"…Aren't you angry? The evidence you carried in is still in progress."

"…I would have been, once. Now… I know that in progress is different from not existing at all. Mena herself came through here too, I heard."

"…How do you know?"

"…Elpis sent me a letter. News travels fast these days."

. . .

Before evening, Trope asked one last thing.

"…If I come here, can I check on mine too? Anything under my name?"

I asked Arche. A few records came up classified under Trope's name. Most were the Reckoning's deliberation records. One of them had "in progress" attached.

Trope looked at that item for a long time.

"…This is me? A decision about me?"

"…Something like that. I'm not sure exactly. You'd have to ask Arche to know precisely."

That item is in progress.

"…How long?" Trope asked.

In progress for seven years.

Trope laughed hearing that number. A sad laugh. I guessed it was probably close to the laugh she used to wear at the Reckoning, back then. Of course, I never saw that time myself. I only know it from the record.

"…Seven years I've waited, and it's still in progress."

Pheugon said, low, from the side,

"…That's not bad news. It means it hasn't ended yet."

Trope didn't answer right away. After a while, she nodded.

"…Maybe."

The two left together that night. I watched their backs, walking side by side, and found myself wondering what that "in progress" would someday become.

Before leaving, Trope turned back to me once more.

"…Ms. Mone."

"…Yes."

"…Do you know what my name means?"

"…No. Can I ask?"

Trope smiled.

"…I don't know either. Nobody ever told me. But somehow I think it's a name that suits me. I'd like it to mean turning back."

Hearing that, my heart beat a little faster. I already knew. Trope's meaning is τροπή — turning, a turning back. Histor had told me, before. But I didn't say anything, right there, right then. It didn't feel like the time yet.

"…I think it suits you," was all I said.

Pheugon laughed beside her.

"…Let's go, Trope. There's another sentence to read."

Trope nodded. The two walked out. Pheugon's hand still held that old worn sentence.

The Keeper spoke as he closed the door.

"…Those two were the strangest pair in the Reckoning. Seeing them now, they fit."

"…They were strange?" I asked.

"…The one who ran and the one who couldn't. Strange, right? But maybe the two of them met and each got a little less strange."

I wrote that phrase at the back of my notebook. "A little less strange." It wasn't a precise expression, but it was the closest I could come to what I'd felt that day.

I read that sentence again that night and realized, freshly, that no one who'd come through this repository had ever become entirely un-strange. Only a little less strange. That didn't sound like a bad thing.

Writing this part, I picture Pheugon's back as he walked away again. He's still reading sentences aloud. He didn't stop. I thought that was strange, at first, and then revised the thought — it isn't strange at all.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. Xene and Lytron

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon and Trope came and went. Trope had shifted*
> *only a little, from "it won't" to "I don't know," without settling into certainty. Pheugon still carried his sentence with him, still did the work of reading it aloud.*

The two who came from the Harvest arrived together, but at different paces.

The woman arrived first, the man trailing a bit behind. At first I didn't even realize they were together. The woman carried nothing in her hands; the man had a large sack over his shoulder.

"…I'm Xene," the woman said first. "…This is Lytron."

Lytron was broad-shouldered and tall. He didn't look very different from what I'd imagined from the Harvest's record. Only his expression looked far more careful than the person in that old record had been.

Lytron set the sack down and bowed his head.

"…This is from the Harvest. Grain. There was nowhere to give it, so I brought it here."

I was a little flustered taking the sack. This was the first time anyone had ever brought grain to the repository. People had come from all six cities, but they'd all come empty-handed, or with bundles of paper. Grain was new.

The Keeper came out, saw the sack, and looked pleased.

"…That's a first."

"…Sorry. Is it strange?" Lytron asked.

"…No. It's good. It's always just paper piling up here."

Xene heard that and laughed.

"…He's just clumsy at giving things, so he probably gave it strangely. Be generous with him."

Lytron looked embarrassed. I found it hard to overlay that expression onto the confident boy I'd pictured from the Harvest's record. Time seemed to have made him a little different.

I looked at the sack again, remembering the passage from the old record about how strict he'd been with his calculations. Now here he was, having brought something without calculating at all. I couldn't tell whether that meant he'd changed, or whether his hands had simply grown restless.

. . .

"…Why did you bring it?" I asked.

Lytron hesitated a little before answering.

"…I don't know. It just felt wrong to come empty-handed."

Xene laughed quietly beside him.

"…He's always like this. Used to be, he went empty-handed so he'd never lose anything. Now he keeps carrying things around."

"…What do you mean?"

"…He'll explain it himself."

Lytron picked up on that.

"…I've never lost anything in my life. Truly. My qualification score was high, my family was good, I had everything I needed. So I never understood why anyone would give something to someone else."

"…And now?"

"…Even now I've never lost anything. That's a fact. But lately I know it's nothing to be proud of."

. . .

I knew this was exactly the opposite of what he'd said in the Harvest's record. The man who'd once said "I haven't done anything wrong" was now saying "that's nothing to be proud of." But Histor put his finger precisely on it.

"…Do you still think you've done nothing wrong?"

Lytron thought a moment before answering.

"…Yes. That part hasn't changed. I haven't discovered some new sin of mine. It's just… I've come to know that never once losing anything isn't something remarkable."

"…If it's not remarkable, what is it?"

"…It's just how I was born. Xene was born with a qualification score of zero and I was born with a perfect one. I didn't do that."

I want to render this answer carefully, so it doesn't sound like a conversion. Lytron didn't confess his sin. He only conceded that what

he'd received wasn't his own doing. I want to write that difference exactly.

Histor asked once more, as if confirming.

"…So in the end, it's still true you never needed mercy?"

"…Yes. That doesn't change. I don't lie."

"…Then why isn't that something to be proud of?"

Lytron thought for a moment and answered.

"…For it to be something to be proud of, I'd have to have done something. But I just stood in the place I was given."

Histor asked again.

"…So what do you believe now?"

Lytron couldn't answer that right away. After a while:

"…I don't know. I still think I never needed mercy. That's real. But… whether not needing it was actually a good thing — I'm not so sure anymore."

"…What's the difference?"

"…If I'd needed it, I'd have received it. Since I didn't need it, I never got to receive it. That's not a fortunate thing — it's just an experience I never had. I only realized that difference recently. I used to mistake never having received it for not needing to."

I read that answer several times over. Lytron still said he'd never needed mercy. He'd only newly admitted that this wasn't something to boast of — just an experience he'd never had.

Xene added quietly, from the side.

"…It took him years to say that. At first, no matter what I said, he wouldn't listen."

"…What did you say to him?" I asked.

"…Nothing much. I just went out to the field every day. Watching that, he felt something on his own. I didn't persuade him."

Lytron nodded.

"…That's right. Xene never persuaded me of anything. She just kept being there. That's what actually made me think about things more."

. . .

Xene had been quietly examining the shelves the whole while. Her eyes weren't searching for anything in particular — just looking around.

"…This place is like gleaning too," she said.

"…What do you mean?"

"…The dropped things. Every city leaves things behind, uncared for, and they come piling up here. Gathering those up used to be my job."

"…Do you still do it?"

"…Something like it. Lately I go around teaching other cities the Harvest's corner provision. The rule about leaving a corner of the field."

"…Does it take?"

Xene tilted her head slightly.

"…Some cities listen, some don't. But I just keep going and saying it."

I recognized that manner of speaking. The attitude of continuing without expecting a great result. I felt a similar thing, laying paper in order every day.

"…How's Mother Glyke?" I asked. It was a name I'd seen in the Harvest's record.

Xene's face softened.

"…She's well. Still asks to be called Pikra. Nobody tries to force her back to it."

"…Doesn't she go back to her original name?"

"…No. Mother says — the name I wrote isn't gone, I've just learned to live even while carrying it written. That's exactly how she put it. She keeps the name and lives with it."

"…Did you meet Mena?" Histor asked.

"…Yes. She's the one who taught me how to keep records. Years ago, at the Harvest. I heard she came through here recently."

"…That's right. A few days ago."

Xene smiled.

"…Even the teacher goes around learning things. She only ever taught us."

. . .

Lytron pointed at his sack again.

"…This — it was originally my share. What was left after transferring the qualification."

"…Are you still handing out qualification?" Histor asked.

"…No, that was only the once. It's recorded in the Roll, that case. But… since then, I keep wanting to give things away. It's strange."

"…Is it strange?"

"…Yes. I never used to have the concept of giving at all. Giving anything felt like a loss to me. Even now that's not entirely gone. It's still a little painful every time I give something."

Xene laughed at that.

"…Honest of you."

"…Better honest than pretending it doesn't hurt."

. . .

I asked Arche. This was the first time I'd asked directly about a person's qualification. I was a little cautious about it.

"…In the Harvest's Roll, what's Xene's qualification standing now?"

Xene's qualification score meets the registration threshold through Lytron's transfer.

"…Has the process finished?"

The registration is valid. Review of the associated case law is in progress.

Xene heard that answer and nodded.

"…So the review still isn't done."

"…Does it bother you?" I asked.

"…No. I just need to be registered. The review is the Roll's business to see to."

Lytron said, from the side,

"…It bothers me. Since I lowered my own share, I worry it might get reversed."

"…Do you think it will?"

"…I don't know. But even if it reverses, I'll give it again. I've decided that."

Histor asked, at the end of that exchange,

"…Is the administrator still unashamed?"

Lytron thought a moment.

"…Yes. Still is. Proud that his system never broke a law. I used to think that was just natural. Lately it looks strange to me."

"…What's strange about it?"

"…Not breaking the law and doing right seem like different things to me. But when I said that to him, he only said, 'I did my job.'"

"…Weren't you able to convince him?"

"…No. He won't change. I just do what I can differently, in my own share."

Listening, I thought that no one changing anyone else seemed to be a common thread running through all these cities. Everyone just changed their own small share, a little at a time. Xene, Lytron, and I were all the same in that.

. . .

Xene said she wanted to see the water channel, so I took her there too. Watching the water flow, she said,

"…This is like our field. Wherever the water passes, it leaves something behind. Small, but something."

"…What does it leave?"

"…Soil. Good soil. The water sets it down as it passes."

I liked that. I'd thought water only carried things away. But it set things down too.

Xene crouched by the water and touched the soil.

"…I wonder where this water starts."

"…I don't know. I'm curious too."

"…In our city, people think the water wasn't always there. That Speon opened it. But sometimes I think that might not be right."

"…What do you mean?"

"…When Speon first dug, I don't think water appeared — I think something already there just came to light. No real grounds for it. It's just a feeling."

I listened without answering. That feeling wasn't unfamiliar to me either.

Lytron set the sack down beside them.

"…I'll leave this here. It's for the Keeper."

"…I can eat this?" the Keeper asked.

"…Yes. No qualification asked. Just leaving it."

The Keeper heard that and laughed out loud for the first time.

"…It's been a while since I heard words like that in this city."

Lytron looked a little surprised.

"…People don't say that often?"

"…People in this city have everything they need. So not many people leave things behind. When there's no need, people don't tend to think about sharing either."

Xene heard that and looked thoughtful.

"…A city where everyone has everything they need — that's strange, hearing it. In our city there's always someone who's short of something, so sharing came naturally."

"…Which is better?" I asked.

Xene shook her head.

"…I don't know. I only know the way I grew up."

Lytron added quietly from the side.

"…Lately I'm learning that the way I grew up wasn't necessarily right either. I was just lucky."

. . .

The two left as evening fell. Xene said to me last,

"…You're like a gleaner too, Mone. All this paper here — it's things dropped somewhere, isn't it."

Hearing that, I thought about my own work in a new way for the first time. Picking up dropped things. It felt right. Until then I'd only thought of what I did as "laying down." Hearing Xene's words, I realized "picking up" had come first, before that. You had to pick up what had dropped somewhere, before you could lay it down.

Lytron walked out, looking at his hand, lighter now without the sack.

"…Odd — it's light, but it doesn't feel empty."

Xene laughed.

"…Sounds like you're starting to understand a little."

The two walked off like that. I split the grain sack they'd left behind with the Keeper and cooked it for dinner. Eating, I turned over each thing I'd heard that day. The rice tasted a little better than usual. Maybe because the face of the person who'd given it kept coming back to me.

That night Histor asked me,

"…Do you think Lytron believes?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know. He didn't say he doesn't believe, and he didn't say he believes."

"…Right. I can't decide either. In the Harvest's record he's a person certain he never needed mercy. The person we saw today had that certainty a little shaken. But shaken isn't overturned."

"…Which side do you think is right, Histor?"

Histor thought for a moment and said,

"…I don't judge. I just record. What he said today, exactly."

I thought that answer was very like him. He never refutes anyone, never takes anyone's side. He just listens exactly and writes it down. I was coming to understand that better and better as his way.

. . .

After we'd finished eating, I looked again at the sack Lytron had left behind. There was small writing on the inside. Xene's hand, it looked like.

"…Corner's share."

I looked at those two words for a long time. The handwriting was small and careful. I didn't know exactly what it meant, but it seemed to relate somehow to the field corner from the Harvest's story.

I tucked it between my records. Beside the petal Elpis had given me.

I felt something strange, laying these two things side by side. A nameless flower, and a scrap of grain sack marked only "corner's

share." Neither came with an explanation. I was, around this time, slowly learning how to let things sit without explanation.

That night I wrote briefly at the end of my notebook. "Lytron still says he's never lost anything. But now he knows that not losing anything wasn't his own doing either." Reading it back, this sentence didn't conclude anything. It was just what I'd seen that day, carried over as it was.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. Anemos and Eikon

> *_Previously_ — Xene and Lytron came and went. Lytron still said he'd*
> *never lost anything, but he was beginning to understand that it was nothing to be proud of. The two left a sack of grain behind.*

The two who came from the Preserve entered a little differently.

I heard footsteps before the door opened. One set a little rushed, the other very slow. When the door opened, the man leaned his head in first, and the woman followed slowly behind him.

The woman looked no older than she should. Just as the Preserve's record had said — fifteen — she still looked fifteen now. I thought that was strange for a moment, and then remembered the Preserve's story and understood. A preserved person doesn't age.

The man was the opposite. The boy who'd been sixteen in the Preserve's record now looked close to thirty. Standing side by side, the difference stood out even more.

"…I'm Anemos," the man said. "…This is Eikon."

Eikon looked around the room without any greeting. Her eyes carried no hurry. Not the eyes of someone searching for something — the eyes of someone who already knew everything and was only confirming it.

That confirming look wasn't unfamiliar to me. Arche sometimes answered in a similar tone. Already knowing everything, just retracing the fact.

. . .

There was almost no expression on Eikon's face. Not bored, not curious. Just calm. That calm felt foreign to me at first.

"…What is this place?" Eikon asked. Less a question than a way of confirming.

"…A repository. A place where records from the six cities are laid in order."

"…Is that work interesting?"

I was a little thrown by the question. Most people didn't ask that.

"…Not so much interesting as… I think it's necessary work."

"…Necessary," Eikon repeated the word. "…I've never had need for anything."

Anemos said quietly, beside her.

"…There she goes again."

"…It's true, isn't it."

. . .

Anemos looked a little more worn than in the old record. Not tired in a bad sense. The weariness of someone who'd walked a long way.

"…You still haven't taken release?" I asked, carefully. I'd read the Preserve's record, so I knew what I was asking.

Eikon answered first.

"…No. I haven't."

"…Why not?"

"…I don't feel the need. Even now, I lack nothing."

Those words were exactly what she'd said in the Preserve's record. It struck me as strange, and a little heavy, that this hadn't changed even after more than a decade. For a moment I wanted to try to persuade her, and then, realizing that wasn't mine to do, I let it go.

Histor asked, carefully.

"…Have you never once wavered?"

Eikon shook her head.

"…It would be a lie to say I'd wavered. I'm just the same."

"…Don't you think that's remarkable?"

"…No. It's not remarkable. It's just a fact."

. . .

Anemos added, from the side.

"…I'm still waiting. I asked her that day. She said, 'Ask me again later.' I've been waiting ever since."

Listening, I thought of the records that had sat in progress ten, twenty years in this city. The answer Anemos was waiting for seemed to sit in a similar place.

Not that there was no answer set for it — just that it hadn't come yet.

"…That must be hard," I said.

"…It is. But not as hard as it used to be. I used to think it was because I'd done something wrong. Now I just… think of it as waiting for the right time."

Histor came closer and asked,

"…Don't you think it's time to ask? How many more times have you asked?"

"…Once a year. Same answer every time. 'Later.'"

"…Doesn't that make you angry?"

"…It does. But I found out anger and waiting can travel together. Learning that was the biggest change."

"…What about Speon?" I asked. "…The one who dug the well in the valley."

"…I see him often. He still sends water down. He says, 'The upper part isn't drying up anymore, so.'"

"…What does that mean?"

"…I don't know exactly either. But his face looks certain every time he says it. I just trust him and go along."

Histor asked,

"…How's the valley these days?"

"…Less dry than before. Water keeps coming in. But there are still patches that are dry. Not all filled yet."

"…Will it all fill?"

Anemos thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. I just watch it fill a little more each day. That's enough for me."

. . .

Eikon listened to that exchange and said,

"…I still don't understand why he does that."

"…Why?" I asked.

"…I'm fine the way I am, and he keeps telling me to become something else. I'm not suffering."

"…You're not suffering?"

"…No. Really. I don't lie."

I recognized this as the exact same sentence from the Preserve's record. She was holding to a logic that was hard to refute, still.

Writing this part, I tried not to try to win against Eikon. Her words are still hard to refute, even now. I just want to render what she said exactly.

Histor asked, carefully.

"…Is the Curator well?"

Anemos nodded.

"…Yes. Still grieving. But he doesn't hide the grief anymore, now. He used to try to hide it."

"…Is that better?" I asked.

"…I don't know. But it seems better than hiding it. At least he knows what he's doing."

Eikon heard that and added,

"…Every time the Curator looks at me, his eyes are a little sad. I'm fine, though."

"…Why would he look sad if you're fine?" Histor asked.

Eikon shrugged.

"…That's his business. I only know my own business."

That tone didn't sound cold to me. Just honest.

. . .

I asked Arche.

"…Has Eikon's release application gone through?"

No application record for that item exists. Arche's voice was flat, as always.

"…You never applied?"

"…No," Eikon answered directly. "…No reason to apply."

"…Doesn't Anemos apply?"

"…I can't apply on her behalf. There's a consent requirement. I just ask." When Anemos said that, there wasn't a trace of resentment in his face. He said it plainly, like explaining a rule.

I remembered the Preserve's record. When consent was sought, Eikon always answered with "Why?" And the process always stopped there.

"…Does she still say 'why' when you ask?" I asked.

Eikon laughed.

"…No. Lately I say 'later.' If that's progress, I suppose it's progress."

. . .

Anemos heard that and looked startled.

"…You think that's progress?"

"…No. But I thought you'd like it, so I said it that way."

Histor cut in, carefully.

"…Isn't that considerate? Saying it because you thought he'd like it."

Eikon tilted her head.

"…Could be consideration. I don't really understand things like that. I just tried it."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. Seeing Anemos's face just isn't unpleasant. I'm not sure it's what you'd call liking, though."

I felt that answer was a very small crack in her logic. Someone who said she lacked nothing was minding someone's expression. But that wasn't evidence that overturned her words. I decided to just write the crack down exactly as it was.

Anemos couldn't answer that, and just smiled. That smile looked complicated to me. Joy and something a little wistful, mixed.

Histor asked, more carefully than usual.

"…Eikon, are you really satisfied with your state right now? Have you never once doubted it?"

Eikon thought for a moment.

"…I doubt. Sometimes. But doubting doesn't produce an answer. It's a fact that I lack nothing right now, and I haven't yet found a reason for that to change."

"…If you find one?"

"…Then I'll think again. But not now."

I thought that answer closed the door neither all the way shut nor all the way open. Just open that much.

I asked Arche one more thing.

"…Are there other cases where release applications came in?"

Across the whole of the Preserve, there have been three release applications in total. Two of them have been completed.

"…Who were they?"

Personal information is not provided without the requester's own consent.

Eikon heard that answer and said,

"…Strange that there were three. In our city that almost never happened."

"…Do you know those people?"

"…No. But I am curious what made them different."

Anemos said quietly.

"…Probably people who were missing something. Not like you, who has everything."

Eikon smiled a little at that.

"…Maybe."

. . .

The two stayed until evening. Eikon, looking around the shelves, asked,

"…These records — you said they're all in progress."

"…Yes. Not one has closed."

"…Doesn't that frustrate you?"

"…Sometimes. But lately I don't think that's only a bad thing."

"…Why?"

"…In progress just means it hasn't ended yet — not that it never will."

Eikon looked at me for a moment, hearing that. It was the first time she'd had a genuinely interested look.

"…That sounds like what Anemos has been trying to tell me."

Anemos said nothing to that. He just smiled quietly.

Thinking about how the age gap between the two of them kept widening, I hesitated a moment over whether to ask, then did.

"…Is it all right? Anemos, you're getting older, and Eikon, you're staying the same."

Anemos smiled a little.

"…It wasn't all right at first. Honestly. I was scared of growing old before her. What if she stopped recognizing me one day."

"…And now?"

"…Now I've just accepted it. My aging and Eikon's not aging — neither is something I can change."

Eikon heard that and said, quietly,

"…I'll still recognize you. Even old."

Anemos didn't answer that. He just lowered his eyes for a moment.

Rendering this short exchange, my hand shook. Eikon still said she hasn't taken release. And yet that one line showed she cared about Anemos, in her own way. I tried hard not to read those two things as a

contradiction. Not having changed, and caring, can be different layers.

I thought about that distinction several more times. Eikon didn't apply for release that day either. That fact stayed as it was.

. . .

Before leaving, Anemos said quietly to me.

"…I'm not in a hurry anymore. I used to come here trying to get her back. Now I just stay because I want to be near her."

"…Is that comfortable?"

"…Not so much comfortable as… it feels right. The place I'm meant to be."

Eikon turned back at the door and said,

"…I'll come again, Mone. And I'll ask the same thing again then. 'Why do I have to exist.'"

"…Come back again."

"…Anemos will bring me. He's good at that."

The Keeper watched from the side and said quietly,

"…Those two are together in such a strange way."

"…Strange?" I asked.

"…Usually people who walk together walk at the same pace. Those two walk at completely different paces, and they still stay together."

"…How is that possible?"

The Keeper thought for a moment.

"…Someone's waiting. Continuously. Anemos is doing that."

I remembered the last part of the Preserve's record, hearing that. That after hearing her say "ask me again later," he'd stayed by her side ever since. It wasn't some grand event — just a choice repeated every day.

The two walked out like that. I stood at the door and watched until they were gone. Their pace was still different — one slow, one matching beside her. I didn't leave until their backs had completely disappeared from sight.

That night Histor asked me,

"…What do you think of Eikon?"

"…I don't know. Everything she says seems right, and yet something catches."

"…What catches?"

"…Whether lacking nothing is really a good thing. Maybe because I've lost so much myself, hearing 'I lack nothing' sounds strange to me instead."

Histor nodded.

"…I feel something similar. But I can't find a logic to refute her with. If she really lacks nothing, there's no reason for her to want more."

"…So is she right, then?"

"…Right or wrong aside — she's consistent, within her own logic, right now. I find that both frightening and admirable."

I agreed with that. Eikon was more honest than anyone. Only that honesty wasn't moving anywhere.

. . .

That night I wrote in my notebook: "Anemos waits, and Eikon doesn't change. Both stay beside each other." Reading it back, it seemed like a sentence without much meaning, but it stayed with me strangely.

Beneath that sentence I added one more line. "Maybe waiting and not changing meet at the same place, somehow." This wasn't a precise sentence either. It was just the closest thing to what I'd felt that day.

Eikon confirmed it once more as she left. "…I still haven't taken release. It'll be the same next time I come." I copied that down into my notebook exactly as she said it.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. Hora and Tyche

> *_Previously_ — Anemos and Eikon came and went. Eikon still hadn't*
> *taken release, still said she lacked nothing. Anemos was still waiting beside her. "Ask me again later" still held.*

The two who came from the Equity arrived with a document in hand.

More precisely, one of them carried it. The woman. The other came empty-handed, walking light, with an easy expression.

The one with the document walked neatly, the walk peculiar to someone bent on checking something through to the end. Seeing that, I immediately thought of a line I'd read in the Equity's record. "She is someone who reads to the end."

"…I'm Hora," the woman with the document said. "…This is Tyche."

Tyche waved a hand.

"…Hello. I just came along."

That "I just came along" stayed with me. The woman in the Equity's record had spoken of herself in a similarly self-effacing way.

. . .

Once inside the repository, Hora went straight to examining the shelves closely. Then she asked Arche something.

"…Do you have a signature box here? On the documents."

"…Which document?" I asked.

"…Any of them. I'm curious whether this city's records have a signature box too."

Arche answered. *This repository's records have no separate signature box. Only the recorder's name and the date are entered.*

Hora heard the answer and nodded. She stood there a moment, seeming to turn it over.

"…So here it's not a matter of filling it in or not."

"…What was it a matter of, originally?" I asked.

"…In our city, every document has a signature box, and it's never once been filled in. Because filling it in makes it yours."

. . .

Tyche's clothes and expression were both light. She looked like someone with no worries in the world, though I came to learn later that this wasn't cynicism — it was real gentleness.

Tyche laughed beside her and said,

"…She's still on about this. The signature box. I'm a little tired of it, honestly."

"…Tired of it?" I asked.

"…Not in a bad way. She's just been thinking about it so long."

Hora glanced at Tyche and turned back to me.

"…She still thinks it's all coincidence."

"…Even now?" I asked Tyche.

Tyche shrugged.

"…Yes. That hasn't changed for me. My sitting in that seat was because of the vacancy and the number, and the same for the deliberation."

Histor asked,

"…So coming here now — that's coincidence too?"

Tyche laughed.

"…Of course. Hora suggested we come, so I came. No other reason."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes. I don't want to make up a reason."

. . .

Histor came closer and asked Tyche,

"…Do you remember the line from the Equity's record? 'I know you want it to mean something. I do too. But wanting it to mean something isn't evidence that it does.'"

Tyche looked surprised for a moment, then laughed.

"…Wow, those are exactly my words."

"…Do you still think the same?"

"…Yes. Exactly the same. I think an explanation is usually right. Coincidence really is coincidence."

"…And someone else keeps writing that name next to Hora's? How do you explain that?"

Tyche thought for a moment.

"…That's coincidence too. Or someone copied it. There are a lot of people out there who think alike."

. . .

Hora heard that and said quietly.

"…I don't think it's coincidence. But I don't have any evidence to convince Tyche either."

"…Doesn't that frustrate you?" I asked.

"…It used to. Now… I think we each just see it our own way. Looking at the same thing and standing in different places."

I dimly understood this was the core of the thing between the two of them. Hora and Tyche still drew different conclusions from the same facts. That hadn't changed with time. I didn't try to persuade either of them. I knew that wasn't my place.

Histor asked, carefully.

"…What about Temel? Do you still see him?"

Hora nodded.

"…Yes. Not often. Lately he goes from city to city, still looking for people. He comes to our city sometimes too."

"…What does he say, these days?"

"…Same as always. 'You might just be sitting there because of a number. But even in a seat that's there just because of a number, there's still something you can do.' He still says that."

Tyche heard that and cut in.

"…I've heard that many times too. But I still don't agree. It doesn't look like evidence that there's meaning to it."

"…Then why does it keep sticking with you?" Histor asked.

Tyche thought a moment.

"…I don't know. It just keeps coming to mind. Even though I don't agree."

. . .

I asked Arche.

"…The name Hora wrote — I heard it turns up in other cities' documents too. Is that still true?"

The name Jeongsu-a is confirmed in documents across several cities.
The writers differ in each case.

"…Do you know who wrote it?" Hora asked.

Author-identifying information remains in each document, but the circumstances of the writing are not confirmed.

Hora heard that answer and nodded.

"…Same here. It doesn't come out clear here either."

"…Disappointed?" Histor asked.

"…No. If anything, it's a relief. Because here too, there's no lying."

"…Do you worry a lot about lies?" I asked.

"…Yes. Our city hid nothing. But hiding wasn't the only problem. No one taking responsibility for anything was a problem too. Here, at least, 'I don't know' sounds like a responsible thing to say."

"…What's the difference?"

"…Our secretary says 'it's been arranged,' 'it's been settled.' No subject in the sentence. But here, Arche says 'not defined.' No subject there either, but at least it says exactly what's missing."

I felt that distinction was subtle but important. That how you say the same not-knowing matters. Histor seemed to be writing something down in his notebook at that too.

. . .

Tyche had been looking out the window toward the water channel this whole time.

"…Is that the water that reached our city?" she asked.

"…Yes, I think so."

"…That's strange. It never even came up as an agenda item in our city. Seeing it here, it really exists."

"…Do you believe it?" I asked.

"…Believe what?"

"…That the water channel connects all seven cities."

Tyche thought for a moment and answered.

"…I believe that part. Water really does flow. But whether someone 'intended' it — I still don't know that."

"…I heard Speon dug it."

"…Yes. But I also heard Speon didn't dig all of it either. That he just joined an already-existing path. So who made that path in the first place?"

I couldn't answer that question. I didn't know either.

Histor answered in my place.

"…Nobody knows. Speon doesn't know either. From what we've found out so far, it seems like it was already built that way, from the start."

"…Who built it?" Tyche asked.

"…No one knows. That doesn't come out here either."

Tyche laughed hearing that answer. Not a mocking laugh — a genuinely amused one.

"…Just as I thought. Everyone saying 'I don't know' is the most honest answer of all. I like that much, at least."

"…That's not proof it isn't coincidence," Histor said, carefully.

"…True. But it's not proof it is coincidence, either. I'm just admitting my own side has no evidence. That doesn't mean I've crossed to the other side."

. . .

Hora joined that conversation.

"…I've decided not to go looking for the answer to that question. I used to keep searching. Now I've learned that you can still do something without knowing the answer."

"…What do you do?" I asked.

"…I keep writing names down. Every time a new deliberation opens. Other names have started to be added behind mine, one by one. At first it was just me. Now there are a few more."

"…What about the secretary?"

"…He still says he's nothing. But lately, when he says that, he smiles a little. He never used to smile."

Tyche cut into that.

"…That's right. I noticed that too. But I don't know what it means. He might have just smiled, that's all."

"…Is that how you want to read it?" Histor asked.

"…It's not a reading, it's just fact. Beyond that he smiled, I don't know anything more. I don't want to say I know."

Hora said quietly.

"…I think it's more than that. But I can't prove it. So I don't push Tyche to agree. That's not something I can do."

I found it curious that the two of them saw the same smile and took it in such completely different ways. It was one fact, but it had landed in two entirely different places inside them. I pushed down, several times, the urge to decide that place for them.

I was glad for that small change. It wasn't a great conversion, but there was, at least, one new smile.

Histor asked,

"…What about the nine hundred twenty-seven? The people who never got reclassified."

Hora's expression dimmed a little.

"…Still the same. I don't erase that number. If I erase it, I'll forget."

"…Does it torment you?"

"…Yes. I still get tormented every time I see that number. But not erasing it while it torments me — that was the best I could do."

Hearing that, I thought Hora already knew how to go on living without a complete resolution. I was learning something similar myself, in this repository.

. . .

Before leaving, Tyche said to me,

"…Do you believe all of this, Mone? That the cities were one, that the water channel joins them all, all that?"

I couldn't answer right away.

"…I don't really know. I just write down what I see."

"…That sounds like a good method," Tyche said. "…I do that too. I only believe what I can see."

Hora said, from the side.

"…I believe a little more than what's visible."

"…I know that too," Tyche said, smiling. "…But I'm not going to follow you there."

The two walked out together. Believing different things, and walking in the same direction.

. . .

That night I unfolded the document Hora had left with us again. A copy of a deliberation record. There was a signature box at the very bottom, and it was empty.

Histor looked it over with me.

"…So this really has never once been filled in."

"…Is it forbidden to fill it in?" I asked.

"…Not forbidden. But no one's filled it. Hora said — if you fill it, the decision becomes yours, so nobody does."

"…Did Hora fill it in?"

"…She said she filled in the name column. When opening a new deliberation. But not this. This is just a copy of an old document."

I looked at that empty box for a long while. I knew this box was the very core of the Equity's story, but seeing it in person, it was much more ordinary paper than I'd expected. Just a line, an empty space.

I looked at this empty box for a long time. It was strange that an empty box with no explanation attached could hold so much. I wanted to remember this moment, so I wrote it down separately.

. . .

The next morning, before Hora left, she asked me,

"…Are you glad there's no signature box here, Mone?"

"…I hadn't thought about it."

"…Think about it sometime. Why doesn't this repository have a signature box."

I turned the question over.

"…Maybe… because this isn't a place where someone decides things. It's just a place for laying things down."

Hora nodded.

"…That sounds right. Our city was a place that decided everything. That's why the signature box mattered so much."

"…Do you envy that, here?"

Hora thought for a moment and smiled.

"…A little. But our city's changing too, little by little. Like the names starting to be added behind mine."

. . .

Just before leaving, Tyche spoke to me separately.

"…Do I look strange to you, Mone? Always saying it's coincidence."

"…No. I'm just… curious. Why do you keep seeing it that way?"

"…I don't know either. It's just that everything I know explains it. I don't want to explain it with something I don't know."

"…That's not a bad reason."

"…No. I like people. I like Hora too. That's just what I think."

Hearing that, I didn't come to dislike Tyche. If anything, I found her honesty comfortable. She wasn't deceiving anyone. Not even herself.

. . .

After the two left, the Keeper said to me,

"…Those two were the last pair in the Equity's record who never split apart."

"…You know the Equity's story?"

"…I heard it from Histor. That the two of them argued for a long time over the signature box. And now, they're still going around together."

"…Even though their views don't match?"

"…Yes. So people can stay together even when their views don't match, it seems. I find that surprising."

I wrote that down last. "They walk together even though their views don't match." I thought this sentence had come up more often than anything else I'd seen recently.

Zeteo and Elpis, Pheugon and Trope, Xene and Lytron, Anemos and Eikon. And now Hora and Tyche too. None of their views had ever fully aligned. And yet they were all still walking together.

Writing this part, I felt the temptation to draw some big conclusion. I resisted. I decided just to write down what I saw. The conclusion didn't feel like it was mine to draw.

Before leaving, Tyche said one more thing. "…I really haven't changed. If I come again, I'll say the same thing. That it's all coincidence." I listened to that with a smile. And wrote it down exactly as she said it.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Temel and Speon

> *_Previously_ — Hora and Tyche came and went. Tyche still called it*
> *coincidence, and Hora still believed it was something more. Neither*
> *convinced the other, and they walked off together in the same direction.*

Mena kept staying on at the repository after that.

She'd said, a few times, that she'd leave, but she never actually did. I didn't find that strange. There was always new paper for her to sort, and I knew that wasn't an excuse — it was real.

That afternoon, Mena looked out the window and spoke first.

"…Speon must be coming."

. . .

I looked out the window. A man was walking up from the direction of the water channel. He had something like a tool in his hand, and his clothes were covered in dirt. His pace wasn't slow, wasn't fast. Just the walk of someone with work to do.

Mena went to the door. Her step wasn't hurried.

"…You came?" Mena said.

"…Yeah. On my way through."

"…This is on your way?"

"…Everything runs through here lately."

The two didn't say anything more than that. No embrace, no hand held. They just stood side by side for a moment and looked toward the water channel.

I didn't want to disturb that silence, so I just stood in the doorway. No one called for me. That was fine too.

. . .

That greeting felt strange to me. It was too short for people who hadn't seen each other in a long time. But looking at their faces, the shortness wasn't a lack of something. It just wasn't necessary.

Histor whispered to me, beside me.

"…It was in Haven's record. That there was something unfinished between the two of them. 'You said you'd still be waiting.'"

"…Is that still true?"

"…I don't know. Watching just now, it doesn't quite look that way, and it also kind of does."

I didn't know how to write down that subtlety, so I decided to just write what I could see. The two stood with the ease particular to people who'd known each other a long time. That was all I knew, too. Even then, it felt right not to press further.

I tried, several times, to rewrite this scene. I wanted to write it as some greater reunion. Tears, a long embrace. In fact there was nothing like that. The two simply stood like old friends. I decided to write it exactly as it was.

. . .

The Keeper came out and looked at Speon.

"…Back again."

"…Back again."

The Keeper didn't offer any particular greeting either. All three had the same indifference peculiar to people who'd known each other from very long ago.

Speon set his tool down carefully at the edge of the yard and said,

"…Came to check the water channel. See how far it's made it here."

"…It's made it fine," the Keeper answered. "…Good sound to it too."

"…The sound matters."

I found that odd and asked,

"…Why does the sound matter?"

Speon looked at me properly for the first time.

"…If it's making a sound, it's flowing. If it doesn't make a sound, it's standing still."

. . .

Watching the three of them together, I thought of the three names I'd only known from records. Temel, Mena, Speon. Loop's three children. All grown now.

"…What about Temel?" I asked.

Mena and Speon looked at each other at the same moment.

"…He's not here yet?" Speon asked.

"…Not yet," Mena answered.

"…Did he say he was coming?"

"…He said so. But when's he ever not late?"

I felt an old rhythm between the three of them in that exchange. A way of worrying without worrying. A way of waiting without hurrying.

. . .

All that afternoon, Mena and Speon didn't do anything in particular. Speon tended to the water channel, Mena sorted paper, and I did my own work beside them. Short words passed between them now and then, but most of it was quiet.

"…Why's it so quiet?" Histor asked me quietly.

"…I don't know. I expected something more too."

"…Are you disappointed?"

I thought for a moment.

"…No. If anything it's comfortable. Not having to wait for something big."

Temel arrived late that evening.

He came alone. He barely had any luggage. He opened the door, looked around the room once, and, spotting Mena and Speon, gave a short nod.

"…You came."

"…Came," Mena answered.

"…Late."

"…Right. Late."

That was all. I'd expected more, and waited, but nothing more came. The three of them just took their seats, each in their own place.

I was surprised by that short greeting at first, then quickly realized it was these three's way. People who'd known each other a long time, it seemed, didn't greet each other at length.

Temel's clothes were the most worn of the three. The traces of having crossed many cities showed clearly. The sole of one shoe was worn down on only one side.

"…Is something wrong with your foot?" I asked without thinking.

"…Yes. From walking so much. It's fine. I'm used to it."

Mena heard that and laughed shortly.

"…He's always been like that. Since Loop, he's made one pair of shoes last for years."

"…Even now?"

"…Even now. Hasn't changed."

Temel didn't deny it. He just glanced down at his own shoe once and picked his teacup back up.

. . .

I've never been told to write this chapter quietly. But I, who was there that day, can't find any other way to write it. The three of them didn't have a reunion that swelled with music. Just being in the same room again seemed to be enough.

The Keeper brought out tea. The four of them sat. Histor and I watched, a little apart.

Aside from the clink of teacups, nothing made a sound for a long while. I wasn't uncomfortable with that quiet. If anything, it was comfortable.

. . .

"…First time the three of us have gathered since Loop, isn't it?" Speon asked.

"…First time," Temel answered.

"…Took a while."

"…Everyone had their own work to do," Mena said.

Temel lifted his cup and said,

"…I still look for people. Don't know how to do much else."

"…Found anyone? Lately?"

"…Sometimes. Mostly not. But I keep looking."

. . .

That was a familiar sound to me. Similar to Zeteo's continuous asking, and Elpis's continuous waiting. No one had gotten a certain answer, and yet they all kept going.

"…What's it like when you can't find someone?" Histor asked.

Temel looked down at his teacup as he answered.

"…Hard. But I believe the person I couldn't find is still alive somewhere. That one belief is what keeps me going."

"…What grounds do you have?"

"…None. I just believe it. I don't think it's strange to believe without grounds. I was always someone whose belief came before the grounds."

Writing that down, I felt this was a part of Temel that hadn't much changed since Loop. The man who'd been first to fall and last to lift a stone was still holding on to a groundless belief.

"…What about you, Speon?" Histor asked. "…Still opening the water channel?"

"…Not opening it," Speon corrected. "…Joining it. What was already there."

"…Does that difference matter?"

"…Yes. It matters. If I said I made it all, that would be a lie."

"…Did you always think of it that way?" I asked.

"…No. At first I just thought I'd dug it myself. But as I kept digging, I kept running into strange things. Spots already opened, traces of water that had already flowed. I wasn't the first one to touch it."

"…Do you know who dug it first?"

Speon shook his head.

"…I don't know. It was just there. I only followed the place."

Mena listened to that quietly. She didn't add anything, but I saw her holding those words in her heart.

. . .

Histor asked, carefully.

"…In Loop's record, Arche calls this city 'a closed circle.' Did you know that?"

The three looked at Histor at the same time.

"…I knew," Temel answered. "…At the time I thought it was a good thing to hear."

"…And now?"

"…Now I'm not so sure. Coming here, I see nothing's finished. And it's called a closed circle."

Mena added, from the side.

"…Lately I hear that phrase differently. A circle being closed and something being finished seem like different things to me."

"…What's the difference?" I asked.

"…Closed is just a shape. Finished means it stopped moving. This city is closed and it still keeps turning. So it's not finished."

I copied that down into my notebook. A sentence I wanted to read again later.

Mena heard it and laughed.

"…You never used to care about that kind of thing."

"…True. It used to just matter that things got done fast. Now… saying it precisely has come to matter more."

"…Why did it change?" Temel asked.

Speon thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. I just kept digging for a long time, and I kept confirming, over and over, that I hadn't made it." Speon looked down at his own hands as he said that. Nails caked with dirt.

. . .

The four of them sat late into the night. Outside the window it was already dark, and the lamp in the room swayed low. They didn't talk about anything big. Each asked a little about the other's life these days, and answered a little. I thought about how different, and how similar, this conversation was to their childhood conversations I'd seen in Loop's record.

"…Mone," Mena called me.

"…Yes."

"…Writing all this down?"

"…Yes. Is it all right if I do?"

"…Yes. Write it. But don't write it too grand. We didn't do anything much today."

I tried hard to keep that promise. Rewriting this chapter now, I remembered that promise and deliberately kept my sentences short.

. . .

Late into the night, Temel stood up first.

"…I have to go again. There's someone I need to find."

"…Already?" I asked.

"…Yes. Coming here was just a short thing. I wanted to check everyone was still around."

Speon stood up soon after.

"…I need to see to the water channel too."

Only Mena stayed.

"…I'll stay a bit longer. There's still more to learn."

The three of them scattered like that, each in a different direction. The reunion had been short, and the parting was short too. I didn't feel sad about it — it felt natural instead.

. . .

Just before Temel left, he spoke a few short words to me.

"…So you're Mone."

"…Yes."

"…I heard from Mena. That you taught her how to lay things down."

"…I just told her what I know."

Temel shook his head.

"…That's not an easy thing. My whole life I only knew how to find people, not how to lay down what I'd found. Probably I'd have gone on not knowing, if you weren't here keeping this place."

I didn't know what to say to that, so I just bowed my head.

"…Did you hear about Hora?" Temel asked suddenly.

"…Yes. She came a little while ago."

"…There's something I told her, once. 'You might just be sitting there because of a number. But even in a seat that's there just because of a number, there's still something you can do.' I wondered if it might be the same for you too."

"…What seat?"

"…You're an apprentice. No particular talent. But what you're doing here now isn't something just anyone could do."

I turned that over for a long time. That night I copied it exactly into my notebook. "An apprentice, but not something just anyone could do." Whether I really believed that sentence, I couldn't be sure at the time.

. . .

Before he left, Speon went to check the water channel once more. I followed along.

He crouched by the water and listened for a long while to its sound.

"…Sound's better than before," he said.

"…What's different?"

"…Don't know. Just better. Maybe something more's flowing in from upstream."

"…From where?"

"…I don't know that either. I don't know all of where this water channel starts. I only know from here to there, the stretch I can see."

I liked that humility. He only said as much as he knew. Neither pretending to know more, nor pretending to know less.

"…Don't you want to go all the way, to the start?"

Speon thought for a moment and smiled.

"…Sometimes I think about it. But right now there's work to do here. If someone finds the start, I'd be glad."

I wondered, hearing that, whether I'd someday see the start of this water channel myself. That day still seemed far off.

. . .

Mena stayed the last and spoke to me.

"…Thank you for not writing today, the three of us meeting, as something special."

"…I just wrote it as it was."

"…That's the hardest thing to do. Writing it as it was."

Hearing that, I understood then that what Mena had learned from me wasn't only ordering. She was also learning, alongside it, how to let something be as it is.

"…Will Temel and Speon come again?"

"…They will. Anyone who's come once here comes again. It seems like that kind of place."

That night Mena pulled out her stack of paper again. Still jumbled, out of order.

I watched that and quietly tidied up my own things. All day, no one had raised their voice, not once.

That night I wrote at the back of my notebook:

"Today the three of Loop met again. I started to write this scene large, and stopped myself. They proved nothing to each other. They just were in the same room. I understood, for the first time, that this might be all a reunion is."

Histor read that sentence beside me and said,

"…Is it all right to write it like this? It's a bit flat."

"…I think flat is right. Today really was like that."

Histor didn't argue further at that. He just nodded and went back to his own place.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. The Water Joins Them

> *_Previously_ — Loop's three, Temel, Mena, and Speon, gathered together*
> *for the first time. There was no great reunion. Simply sitting in the same room again seemed to be enough. Temel and Speon soon left for*
> *their own places, and only Mena stayed on.*

Speon didn't leave completely.

On the excuse of tending the water channel, he stayed near the repository a few more days. I knew it wasn't only an excuse. He really did walk the channel every day, checking something.

I never knew exactly where he went each day. Sometimes he came back caked in mud, sometimes soaked. When I asked, he'd only answer shortly. "…Just something I need to check."

Then one morning he came into the repository carrying a large bundle of paper.

"…Take a look at this?"

. . .

He spread the paper out on the table. A map. Hand-drawn, but the lines were quite precise. There were marks of many redrawings. Some parts had heavy ink, and some parts showed traces of being erased and redrawn several times.

"…What is this?" I asked.

"…A map of the water channel. I've been drawing it a little at a time, for years."

There were seven circles drawn on the map. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, and Loop. Six cities plus Loop made seven.

I traced each of the seven circles with my finger. They were all different sizes. Some large, some small. But the thickness of the lines was all the same. I didn't ask whether Speon had drawn it that way on purpose, or whether it had simply come out that way.

"…Is this all? Seven?" I asked.

"…Yes. This is everything I've confirmed. I don't know if there's more."

The circle marking Loop sat in the middle of the map. The other six were scattered around it.

. . .

Fine lines were drawn between the circles. All six cities were connected to each other by the water channel. Some lines were straight, some curved. I could tell at a glance that the curves followed the shape of the land.

Histor studied the map for a long while.

"…Are you sure of this? Is it really all connected?"

"…I confirmed it on foot. From Haven all the way to the Equity, I followed every one of them myself."

"…How long did that take?"

"…About six years."

I was startled by that number. It meant he'd walked every one of the seven cities along the water channel for six years.

"…That must have been hard," I said.

"…It was. But each time, I got to know people in each city a little. Met the Adjudicator at the Reckoning, met the administrator at the Harvest. None of them knew where their own city's water came from."

"…No one ever asked?"

"…They must have. But when no answer came, I guess they just figured that's how it's always been. I did the same, at first."

Mena asked, from the side.

"…Then why did you keep asking?"

Speon shrugged.

"…I don't know. I just have a nature that can't stand not knowing something it's curious about. Same as when I was little."

Mena laughed shortly at that.

"…That's right. Even as a kid, it took you twice as long as anyone else to dig one well. Always trying to dig deeper."

"…Same as back then," Histor said.

Speon laughed too.

"…Same. Never changed."

. . .

"…Why did you go to such lengths?" I asked.

Speon chose his words for a moment.

"…At first I was just curious. Where does the well dug at the Preserve flow to. Following that, I ended up at the Reckoning. People there asked me, 'Where did this water come from,' and since I didn't know either, I just kept following it."

"…And that's how you got all the way here?"

"…Yes. But that's not the important part."

He pointed at one of the lines on the map.

"…These stretches — I didn't dig them."

. . .

The room went quiet.

"…What do you mean?" Histor asked.

"…I opened water channels beneath the Preserve's valley, at the Reckoning's well, and around the Harvest's fields. That much I really did. But these big stretches that join the cities together — they were already there before I ever dug."

"…Already there?"

"…Yes. Dry. Dry ditches with no water. All I did was set the water flowing through that spot."

. . .

I've read this part over many times. Speon didn't claim to have done all of it. He drew a precise line — between what he opened and what was already there.

Histor asked once more, as if confirming that distinction.

"…So saying you made this whole water channel would be wrong."

"…Wrong," Speon answered immediately. "…I just joined it. What was built was already built."

Mena, looking at the map, asked quietly.

"…When you first found that out, how did it feel?"

Speon chose his words for a moment.

"…Scared. Honestly. I thought I'd done something great, and it turned out I'd just set water flowing through a place that was already there."

"…Disappointed?"

"…At first. But not now. Now, if anything, it's a relief. It means I don't have to carry it all myself."

I liked that. Speon spoke of his own contribution in a smaller way, and it didn't sound diminished for it. If anything, it sounded more solid.

"…Why was the ditch there to begin with?" I asked.

Speon shook his head.

"…I don't know. That's what I'm most curious about too. Maybe the land just happened to form that way, or maybe someone dug it long ago and it got forgotten."

"…Did you check?"

"…I did. No record anywhere. Not one record, in any of these six cities, says who dug that ditch or when."

Mena asked quietly.

"…Didn't you ever want to find out who dug it?"

Speon nodded.

"…At first, yes. But at some point I let go of that question."

"…Why?"

"…Because the water flows whether I know or not. Whether I know who dug it or not, that ditch was already there, and all I had to do was set the water flowing through it. If I hadn't let go of the question, I don't think I could have done anything."

That stayed with me for a long time. That you could carry on with the work while still holding on to the question. That you could keep going without knowing the answer.

. . .

I asked Arche.

"…This water channel, the stretches connecting the cities — can it be confirmed whether it was the original landform?"

No geological survey records exist for that section. The water channel's connecting route has been confirmed, but the time of formation and who formed it are not identified.

"…Can't even a guess be made?"

Without any grounding material, no estimate can be made.

Mena heard that answer and said quietly.

"…Even Arche doesn't know."

"…It says it doesn't. Not hiding it — really no record," I said.

. . .

The Keeper looked over the map and asked.

"…Could this have something to do with the sealed room?"

My heart gave a little jump at that.

"…What room?" Speon asked.

"…There's a door in the back of the repository that's not in the index. She saw it in Part One. Hasn't been opened yet."

Speon looked at the map again. He put his finger on the middle of the circle representing Loop.

"…This water channel branches off right around here. It looks like it might pass under the repository."

. . .

I went out back to check the sound of the water again, hearing that. The sound I always heard, but that day it sounded different. Not just water passing through — it felt like water connected to something.

I don't want to exaggerate this moment. Speon didn't claim for certain that it had something to do with the sealed room. He only said it "looked like it might." I'm rendering that exactly as he said it.

The Keeper saw me coming back from listening to the water and asked.

"…Hear anything?"

"…No. Just the same as usual."

"…Then that's fine. It's not time to open the door yet."

"…How do you know?"

The Keeper thought for a moment before answering.

"…I don't. It's just a feeling. But that feeling hasn't been wrong very often, up to now."

I didn't know whether to believe that or not, so I just nodded.

. . .

Histor kept looking at the map and said,

"…Do the other cities know about this? That they're connected this way?"

"…No. Besides me, nobody's seen the whole picture. Each city only knows their own stretch of the water channel."

"…Will you tell them?"

Speon thought for a moment.

"…I should. But I won't be in a hurry about it. This wasn't made for anyone to be startled by."

. . .

Mena looked at the map for a long while and said,

"…I think now that all these cities are one, all of them. I wrote that once, a while back. Seeing this map, I don't think it was just a feeling after all."

"…Are you certain?" Histor asked.

"…Not certain. But the feeling has become material now. That's different."

I liked that distinction. Feeling, and material. Mena didn't mix the two together.

Histor traced the map with his finger and asked,

"…These six lines all gather at Loop. Is this the center?"

Speon shook his head.

"…Hard to call it the center. It's just the oldest water channel, so the other channels flow into it. It doesn't look like anyone planned for it to be the center."

"…How do you know?"

"…You can tell from the direction of the current. Everything flows this way naturally. If a current's been forced, it shows."

I listened to that explanation and felt that Speon wasn't simply treating this map as some mysterious discovery. He'd arrived at this conclusion carefully, checking even the direction of the water.

Histor asked again.

"…So what's the conclusion? Was it made by someone, or not?"

Speon didn't answer that right away. After a while he said,

"…I don't draw conclusions. I only say what I've seen. The water channel was already there, and I set water flowing through it. That's all."

"…You don't know more than that?"

"…I don't. And if I did, I wouldn't say. Pretending to know is the thing I'm most afraid of."

I thought that answer was exactly this repository's own principle. What you don't know, you say you don't know. Arche did that, and so did Speon. I liked that about it.

. . .

I asked Arche one more thing.

"…Along the direction the water channel flows from — do records come with it too? Records carried down by the water?"

Confirmed. Approximately three-tenths of the records received have been received via the water channel. Arche's answer was flat, as always.

"…Has that been the case from the start?"

The exact starting point is not recorded, but the same tendency is confirmed as far back as the earliest reception history.

I felt a chill hearing that answer. It meant that from the very moment this repository began, water had been carrying records here. Long before Speon ever joined the water channel.

I felt the temptation again, at this point, to draw some conclusion. That someone must have planned this from the very start. But I pushed that temptation down. Neither Arche nor Speon went that far. I decided just to write down the fact as it was — that the water channel existed, and the records came along on top of it.

"…So there was water even before Speon came?" I asked.

"…No," Speon shook his head. "…Before I joined it, the water was dry. Just the ditch. But you're saying records came along that dry ditch too. Walking, or maybe rolling."

Histor picked that up.

"…So if there's a path, something can pass through it even without water."

"…Seems like it," Speon answered. "…Maybe all I did was make that path a little easier to pass through."

. . .

Speon rolled the map back up that evening.

"…All right if I leave this here? I have a copy myself."

"…Yes. I'll keep it."

He handed the map to me and said,

"…If anyone asks, don't say I made it all. I just set the water flowing. The water channel was already there."

I made up my mind to keep that exactly as he asked.

. . .

That night I spread out the map and traced each of the six cities one by one. Zeteo and Elpis had come from Haven. Pheugon and Trope had come from the Reckoning. Xene and Lytron had come from the Harvest. Anemos and Eikon had come from the Preserve. Hora and Tyche had come from the Equity. And these six lines all gathered at Loop.

Histor looked at the map with me.

"…Did all these people come following this water channel?"

"…Not all of them came by water. Some walked. But maybe, since the water channel was already joined, people naturally started coming this way too."

"…What's the difference?"

I thought for a moment.

"…Whether the water channel called the people, or the people followed the water channel. I don't really know either."

Histor didn't offer an answer to that question. He just kept looking at the map.

. . .

That night I wrote briefly in my notebook. "The water channel is not something Speon made. It was already there. He only opened it." Reading it back, this sentence resembled a lot of other things in this repository. Arche didn't make anything either. It only answers. I don't make anything either. I only lay things down.

Mena read that sentence beside me and said,

"…Speon would like that sentence too."

"…Should I show him?"

"…No. Just keep it. That kind of sentence isn't written to be shown."

I nodded at that and closed my notebook.

Outside, the water still made its sound. I fell asleep listening to it. I didn't dream. It was just a night the water sound kept going through.

The next morning, the moment I opened my eyes, I unfolded the map I'd seen the day before again. I'd half-expected something new to show up overnight, but the map was exactly as it had been the day before. Seven circles, six lines, and one center everything flowed into.

I folded the map carefully and slipped it between my own records. Beside the flower petal Elpis had given me, beside the scrap of sack Xene had left.

Things without explanation were piling up on one side of my shelf, a little at a time.

Last thing that day, I asked myself once more. Speon really hadn't done nothing. He'd opened the way. Only he hadn't been the one to first make that way. I decided not to forget that distinction.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. Opening the Door

> *_Previously_ — Speon showed us the water channel map. All seven cities were joined by water. He said he hadn't opened that channel himself — only set water flowing through a ditch that was already there. And he said the channel seemed to pass beneath the repository.*

For several days I lingered in front of that door.

At the far end of the corridor, the door not in the index. A door I'd first seen back in Part One and simply passed by ever since. Now, every time I stood in front of it, my steps stopped.

There was nothing special about the door. An ordinary wooden door. An ordinary handle. Nothing set it apart from any of the other doors. Only it had no nameplate.

I passed it every day. At least once a day I was bound to — that end of the corridor was on the way to wherever I went to put things away.

The first few days I just walked past. I only confirmed the door was there, and kept going. Then, at some point, my steps started to slow. I don't know exactly when.

I once tried to count those days. I couldn't. Even I, who's in the habit of writing down dates, never wrote those days down. The line between the days I passed by and the days I stopped was blurred.

Once I even touched the handle. I didn't grip it. Just brushed it with the back of my hand and pulled away. It was cold. That was all.

I mentioned the door to Histor once. He didn't say much. "…You could just open it, couldn't you." That was true, and still I didn't.

Looking back now, I think I was waiting for something. For someone to give me permission, or for some sign to come. No sign came. I didn't know, at the time, that waiting for a sign was itself an excuse.

The Keeper seemed to have been watching those days too. He didn't say anything, but every time I stopped in front of that door, his own steps slowed with mine. As though he didn't want to rush me.

. . .

"…Can I open it?" I asked the Keeper one day.

The Keeper looked at me a moment.

"…Why ask now?"

"…It felt like I shouldn't open it, from the start."

"…Who said you shouldn't?"

"…No one. It just… felt that way."

The Keeper nodded.

"…That feeling could have been right, could have been wrong. But it seems like the right time to ask, now."

I thought he'd tell me more. What was inside, say, or how long the door had been there. He didn't.

"…Do you know what's in there?" I asked.

"…No."

"…You've never opened it?"

The Keeper didn't stop his hands from sorting paper as he answered.

"…It wasn't my work to do."

I started to ask more and stopped. The Keeper's expression said asking more would be no use.

I thought that answer was strange. It's the repository he manages — was it really all right for him not to know about one door in it? I hear that differently now. The Keeper was someone who wasn't ashamed of not knowing. That was simply his way.

"…Weren't you curious?"

"…I was. But being curious and opening it are different things."

. . .

I asked Arche too.

"…Can I open that door?"

That area is not registered, so whether it is access-restricted cannot be determined.

"…Does that mean there's no restriction, or that you can't tell?"

An unregistered area is not subject to restriction.

I read that answer over a few times. Arche neither blocked the door nor told me to open it. It only said the door fell outside its own jurisdiction.

"…Was this room always here? Or did it come later?" I asked again.

That information does not exist in the index.

"…You mean you don't know?"

There is no basis for judgment regarding an unregistered area.

That answer frustrated me at first. Later I understood it was an honest answer. Arche doesn't say it knows something it doesn't. It was the same about this room. Not hiding — truly not knowing.

. . .

Histor heard that exchange and came over.

"…Can I come too?"

"…Yes."

Mena heard the same and came out too.

"…Me too."

Both of them happened to be at the repository that day. Coincidence. I thought about that coincidence a few times later, but decided not to attach any special meaning to it. Everyone had just happened to be there that day.

The three of us walked together to the end of the corridor. The Keeper didn't come along. I looked at the handle in front of the door.

"…What if it's locked?"

Histor gave the handle a slight turn.

"…It's not locked."

He let go of the handle but kept examining the door a moment longer. He touched the hinges, peered at the gap beneath the door.

"…See anything?" I asked.

"…No. Just looking."

He seemed like someone searching for something. I learned later that this was a habit of his. Always examining something first, before drawing any conclusion.

. . .

Somehow, that made me hesitate even more. If it had been locked, I'd have needed to work up some resolve to force it open. But since it wasn't locked, all I had to do was push. That felt stranger, somehow.

I go back over this moment often. Why did an unlocked door make me hesitate more? Looking back now, I think I'd been expecting some great obstacle. A locked door, a lock to break. There was nothing like that. The door was just a door.

. . .

I gripped the handle and turned it. The door opened without a sound. It wasn't as though the hinges had been oiled, and yet it was strangely quiet.

A little dust fell from the top of the doorframe. That was the only evidence that no one had touched this door in a long time. I wiped my eyes once with the back of my hand. It was nothing much.

There was a threshold, low. I crossed it half-expecting something to change. Nothing changed. Even the feel underfoot was the same.

Inside was a small room.

Truly small. Barely big enough for three people to fit. There was one window, small and set high. A little light came in.

The floor was wood. It creaked when stepped on. The other rooms had wood floors too, but there it made no sound. The Keeper had once said, when people walk somewhere often, the floor wears a path into itself. No one had ever walked in this room.

There was dust, but not much. Not the thick dust particular to an abandoned place — just the thin dust of a room long unused.

There was no wind. There was a window, but it didn't look like wind would come and go through it. The air sat still, but it wasn't stifling. Just air that had been resting a long time.

I went in bracing for something. A chill, a prickling at the back of the neck. There was neither. It was just a small room, and it had the smell particular to a room. There was no sense of anyone being there. Because no one was.

. . .

There was a low table in the middle of the room. On it sat a single bundle of paper. Tied with string.

That was all.

The string was the color of decayed thread. What color it had once been, there was no telling. The bundle wasn't thick. Something you could hold in one hand. The cover held nothing written on it.

I'd expected more. Another door, a stairway, some hidden device. There was nothing. A small room, a low table, a single bundle of paper.

"…Is this everything?" Histor asked. His voice wasn't disappointed. Just confirming.

"…Seems so."

I looked around the room once. The walls were bare. No painting, no sign, nothing else hung there. The floor held nothing. Just the table. No chair. We had to stand.

"…No chair either," I said.

"…Maybe there was no need to sit," Histor answered.

At this point too, I think I was hoping for more. A closet, a space under the floor, anything. There was none. The room really was all there was. I write that fact down here exactly as it was, without embellishing it.

. . .

Mena looked slowly around the room.

"…I can hear the water running, even here."

I listened closely. It was true. A low sound of water came from beyond the wall. It really did seem the water channel Speon had spoken of ran near here.

"…Why isn't this room registered?" I asked.

Mena shook her head.

"…I don't know. But I don't think not being registered means it was hidden. I think… no one ever thought to put it on the list."

"…Aren't you afraid?" I asked. I didn't know myself why I'd asked that.

Mena smiled. Not out loud, just the corners of her mouth lifting slightly.

"…It's not fear. Everyone's like this, in front of a door they haven't opened in a long time. I was too."

"…You too, Mena?"

"…Yes. I stood in front of a door for days once, too. A different door, but."

Mena didn't say more about what door that had been. I didn't ask either.

. . .

I reached toward the bundle of paper. The string was old but sturdy. The knot was simple.

"…Can I untie it?" I asked. I didn't know who I was asking.

No one answered. Histor and Mena were both just quietly watching me.

I untied the knot.

. . .

The paper was old but not in bad condition. The writing was by hand, and it looked like several different hands were mixed together. I carefully lifted the top sheet.

There was a date. A very old date. It might have been before this repository even existed.

The contents weren't immediately legible. It looked partly like a drawing, partly like writing, mixed together.

"…Is this a plan?" Mena said, carefully.

Several lines overlapped. Some were straight, some curved. I couldn't tell at a glance what it was drawing.

. . .

Histor turned the next page. I saw his hand shaking a little.

"…This… has city names," he said, low.

I looked over his shoulder. It was true. Familiar names were written there.

I want to set down honestly that this moment didn't feel grand. I'd expected some vast revelation, and what I actually saw was just a few sheets of old paper. Less astonishing than quiet.

Histor stared at that paper for a long time. He didn't trace the writing with his fingertip. Whenever he handled an original, he always did that — his fingers moving a half-hand's width above the paper. Not touching it.

"…Are you all right?" I asked.

"…Yes." He answered without taking his eyes off the paper.

He said nothing more for a while after that. I couldn't tell whether that was his silence or simply his concentration. I still don't know.

I don't know what he was thinking. I didn't ask. I said, at the start of this record, that what I didn't hear, I would write as not heard. This is one of those moments.

. . .

Mena carefully set the papers back down on the table.

"…We can't see this properly in here. We should take it somewhere brighter."

"…Is it all right to take it?" I asked.

"…It's an unregistered area. Ask Arche."

I asked again. *Items in an unregistered area are not subject to removal restrictions.* That was all Arche answered.

I laughed at that answer. I laughed at myself, worrying about removal. Asking about removal restrictions, by registration standards, for something taken out of a room that wasn't even registered.

. . .

We carefully carried the bundle out of the room. We closed the door again. We didn't lock it. There was no way to, to begin with.

As the door closed, the same dust fell again. Watching it, I had no idea then how often this door would come to be opened, in the time ahead.

Walking back down the corridor, I felt strange. For years, passing that door, I'd thought something frightening must be inside. And inside there had just been a small room and a few old sheets of paper.

There was dust on my hands. I noticed it as I walked. Not much. I wiped my palm once against my clothes. That was all.

The weight of those days spent lingering in front of the door — was this all it had come to? I thought that thought without feeling disappointed. Less disappointment than just — so that's how it was.

The Keeper saw us and asked.

"…What was there?"

"…Paper. Looked like an old plan."

The Keeper nodded.

"…Thought so."

"…You knew?"

"…No. But I'm not surprised. If there'd been something amazing in there, someone would have registered it long ago."

"…Aren't you let down?" I asked. I didn't know myself what I'd expected from asking that.

"…What by?"

"…Nothing, just — we hesitated for days, and it turned out to be nothing much."

The Keeper glanced at the bundle of paper, then looked back at me.

"…Nothing much is different from nothing at all."

I didn't understand that right away.

I understand it now. What was in that room wasn't a revelation. It was just old paper. But what that paper held, none of us knew, that day.

I thought he was right.

That night, at home, I wrote about the door on paper. I didn't write much. We opened the door, the room was small, there was paper. That was about it.

I still have that piece of paper. The handwriting I wrote that evening was smaller than usual. Not the writing of someone who'd been through some great event — just the writing of someone finishing an ordinary day.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Plan

> *_Previously_ — I opened the door not in the index. It wasn't locked.*
> *Inside was a small room, and on a low table sat an old bundle of paper. When we untied the string, something like a plan came out. Familiar city names appeared too. We decided to take it somewhere brighter.*

The next morning, we spread that bundle of paper across the big table in the reading room.

The reading room has three windows. Morning light comes straight in through the east wall. I looked at the papers again, under light entirely different from what they'd had in that small room the night before.

The first sheet was just old paper. It had some stains, and the edges were a little crumbled. From the second sheet on, lines began to appear.

. . .

"…Turn them carefully," the Keeper said. "…Paper like this tears from the folds first."

Instead of turning them one by one, I decided to spread all the sheets out and lay them side by side. The table wasn't big enough, so we set a few sheets on the floor too. Histor put something heavy on each corner. We had no paperweights, so we used old scale weights that Arche used to use instead.

Once everything was spread out, one picture came into view all at once.

Seven circles.

. . .

They were all different sizes. Some large, some small. The lines were fine and precise. At first I thought it was a map.

"…Is this a map?" I asked.

Mena looked it over for a long while and shook her head.

"…Strange for a map. The directions don't line up. This… looks more like a building plan."

"…A building?"

"…Yes. These circles look like rooms, seen from above. They're joined by corridors."

I looked again. It was true. Thin lines ran between the seven circles. It resembled what I'd seen in Speon's water-channel map, but this looked far older.

The paper was thin, and the ink had faded to a shade near brown. Whether it had originally been black or originally brown, there was no telling. Though it was a hand-drawn line, there was almost no tremor in it. I found that fascinating, and started to trace a line with my fingertip, but Histor was watching, so I stopped.

"…Don't touch it," he said. "…The oil from your hand isn't good for it."

"…I know."

. . .

"…Is one circle one city?" Histor asked.

Mena pointed at one circle.

"…This is Haven. Look at the writing here."

Small letters spelled out the city's name. The Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity. And in the middle, the large circle read Loop.

A seventh circle stood apart. Smaller than the other six, and off to one side. It had no name.

"…What's this?" I asked.

No one could answer.

"…Judging by the size, it looks like a single room," Histor said carefully. "… Much smaller than the other six."

"…What room could it be?"

"…No telling. There's no name."

I looked at that circle for a long time. Small, in a corner, nameless. I thought for a moment that it might be this room — and set the thought aside at once. There was no grounds for it.

. . .

I remember that moment precisely. The room went quiet.

Writing this scene, I felt the temptation to guess that the nameless seventh circle was this city. I still don't know, even now, whether that's so or not. None of us said it out loud, that day. I try hard not to write what wasn't said as though it had been.

Histor found something else first.

"…Look at this. The lines are all connected. No breaks anywhere."

. . .

What he meant was the corridor lines between the circles. At first I didn't understand what that meant.

"…Why does it matter that there are no breaks?" I asked.

"…Think about it. If these seven cities were each built separately, and someone later joined them with a water channel or a road, there should be a seam. A change in ink color, a shift in line thickness. But this is the same from start to end."

Mena leaned in closer to the paper.

"…That's right. I was looking at that too. It looks like it was drawn by one hand, all at once."

. . .

Speon's map came to mind, suddenly.

"…What if we laid this over Speon's map?" I asked.

Mena's eyes went wide.

"…Where is that map?"

I brought the map tucked into my record shelf. Laying the two side by side, they weren't identical, but the places where the lines ran largely overlapped. The water channel Speon had walked and confirmed, and the corridors in this old plan, were pointing to the same spots.

"…These corridors — might they have been the water channel?" Histor said.

"…Speon said it himself, didn't he. That he didn't open it, that he just set water flowing through a place that was already there," I said.

Mena looked back and forth between the two maps and said quietly,

"…This plan came first, then. The water followed this plan, not the other way around."

No one added to that. We just sat looking at those two sheets, side by side, for a long while.

. . .

The Keeper leaned over the paper. He looked at it longer than usual.

"…Is this certain?" he asked.

Histor put his finger to the edge of the paper.

"…At least this sheet, yes. Same paper stock, same ink bleed. I've seen a lot of this — in the six records, whatever was added on later always shows. The handwriting shifts slightly, or the paper color changes subtly."

"…So this isn't something added on later?"

"…No. This was drawn as one thing, all at once, from the start."

Hearing that gave me a strange feeling. It meant the seven cities hadn't been built separately and later bound into one — they'd been inside a single picture from the very beginning.

Hearing that made me think again of my own work. I always laid things in order. Placing records that came in separately into their spots, one by one, I'd always thought of it as gathering things that had scattered. But seeing this plan, maybe they'd never scattered at all, to begin with. Maybe I was only confirming, again, something that had always been one.

I hesitated a little, carrying this thought into my notebook. It sounded too large a conclusion. So I added one more line after it. "Not certain."

. . .

"…So these cities weren't originally built separately?" I asked.

Mena didn't answer right away. She looked over the paper once more and said,

"…At least within this plan, that's true. Seven were one design."

"…Doesn't that surprise you?"

"…It surprises me. But it isn't frightening. If anything… it feels like something's settled a little."

"…Why?"

Mena thought for a moment before answering.

"…I've wondered for a long time why the six cities resemble each other so much. Every one of them thinks their own city is the most special. But the problems were all similar. Seeing this, I think I understand a little. They resemble each other because it was one design to begin with."

Histor said, carefully,

"…This never came up, not once, in all six records. I read every one of them, and nowhere does it say the cities were originally one."

"…Not anywhere?" I asked.

"…There was a similar feeling. Everyone had some vague sense that their own city was connected to something. But no one ever confirmed it in a picture, like this."

Mena nodded at that.

"…I had that feeling too. Not certainty, but."

"…So the feeling turned out to be right," I said.

Mena shook her head.

"…Not that the feeling was right — it's that there's material now. That's different."

I recognized that distinction. Speon had said the same thing.

. . .

Histor had been examining every corner of the paper this whole time. The motions of a hand searching for something.

"…What are you looking for?" I asked.

"…A name."

"…Whose name?"

"…Whoever drew a plan like this usually leaves their name somewhere. Small, tucked in a corner. Every record I've ever read did that. Designer, builder, supervisor. I've never seen a thing like this made without a name."

Hearing that, I looked over the paper again myself. Every corner, every margin, inside the circles, even where the lines overlapped.

. . .

Nothing.

The four of us searched several sheets of paper for over an hour, and nothing that could be called a name turned up anywhere. No mark, no seal, nothing resembling a signature.

"…Strange," Histor said. There was more plain bafflement than irritation in his voice.

"…What is?" I asked.

"…I've never seen anyone do a piece of work this size and not leave a name. Even if not to boast. It's just… that's what records do. They set down who did what, and when. And this has none of that."

I thought I understood why he found that frustrating. He was someone who respected records. Someone who believed a record should always have the person who left it. This plan was quietly slipping past that belief of his.

"…So is this not a record, then?" I asked.

Histor shook his head.

"…No. It's a record too. It's just… not a record left by someone. It's a record that simply is. I've just never seen one like that, so it feels foreign."

. . .

Listening, I felt an urge rising in me to say something. To at least venture a guess as to who it might have been. I didn't.

I think it was the right thing, holding that urge back. A guess would have come easily. Through all six records, there'd been a story of someone who passed through, nameless, throughout. But I want to set down, as it was, the fact that no one, standing in front of this plan, named that name. Not Histor, not Mena, not the Keeper. No one said it.

Mena broke the silence.

"…Let's leave it unknown."

"…Are you all right with that?" I asked.

"…I'm all right. I've come to learn, a little, how to leave things unknown too. Here."

. . .

I asked Arche, my hand against the wall panel.

"…This plan — can we confirm who drew it?"

Not confirmed. This document carries no author information.

"…What era? Do we know when it was drawn?"

An estimate is possible based on the material and handwriting characteristics, but the exact date cannot be confirmed. However, it is estimated to predate this repository's earliest record.

I read that answer over again. It meant this drawing existed before this repository ever came to be.

"…So it can only be estimated, not confirmed?"

That is correct. There is not enough basis for confirmation.

The Keeper murmured that phrase back to himself, as if turning it over.

"…Estimated but not confirmed, huh…"

"…What are you thinking?" I asked.

"…Just that it's exactly like the work of this repository. It's always like this here. You can guess, but you can't close it out."

. . .

The Keeper listened to that conversation and said quietly.

"…Arche doesn't know either."

"…It's not hiding it, is it?" Histor asked. He seemed to already half-know the answer, even asking the question.

"…Arche has never hidden anything," I answered in his place. "…It says it doesn't know because it truly doesn't. I can tell the difference now."

Histor nodded. He didn't argue.

. . .

We kept looking over the plan all through that afternoon. We found nothing new. Seven circles, an unbroken line, a nameless blank space. That was all.

Writing this chapter, I felt the temptation, several times, to write in some more dramatic discovery. A hidden mark, erased writing. There was none of that. What we saw was just an old plan. But one fact the plan stated was clear. The seven cities hadn't been built separately and later joined — they had been one from the very start.

As the sun leaned toward evening, the Keeper rolled the plan back up and said,

"…Shall we hang this back in that room?"

"…Hang it?" I asked.

"…Yes. We can't leave it spread out on this table forever. Seems right to send it back where it belongs."

. . .

That evening we carried the plan back to that small room. There were already a few nails driven into the wall. No one knew who had driven them. They looked like nails that had been there for a long time.

Histor hung the plan on those nails and said,

"…These nails — looks like they were put there just for hanging this."

"…Looks that way," I answered.

The four of us stood looking a long while at the plan hanging on the wall. The small room looked different, with that one plan on it. Not an empty room — it looked like a room made for a purpose.

Mena said quietly.

"…I think we'll need to keep coming to this room."

"…Why?" I asked.

"…I don't know. Just a feeling."

I nodded at that. I felt something similar too. I couldn't explain it, but I had a sense this room would become somewhere we came in and out of often, going forward.

That night I wrote briefly in my notebook. "The seven cities were one design. There is no designer." Reading it back, the two sentences seemed not to fit together. But within this record, it seemed right that the two should stand side by side.

We closed the door again as we left the room. This time no one hesitated. That surprised even me. Just a few days before, I'd lingered in front of this door for days. Now it had simply become a door we came and went through.

Walking out down the corridor, Histor said,

"…That there's no designer's name — it keeps bothering me."

"…Why?"

"…Not leaving a name and there being no name to begin with are different things. I can't tell the two apart."

I had no reply to that. I didn't know either.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. The Line in the Margin

> *_Previously_ — We carried the plan to the reading room and looked at*
> *it in the light. Seven circles sat inside one picture. Six cities and one nameless place. The lines ran unbroken from start to end, and the*
> *designer's name was nowhere to be found. We hung the plan back on the*
> *wall of that small room.*

After that, I went to that room often.

Whenever work finished, I'd stop by for a moment. Not because there was anything in particular to do there. I just went to look at the plan. I thought I'd find something new every time, but the first few days that didn't happen. Seven circles, connected lines, a nameless margin. Always the same.

Each time I went into that room, I tried doing something a little different. Some days I just stood and looked, some days I brought a chair and sat. The chair was something I'd brought in new. There'd been no chair in that room originally; I'd carried one in.

"…It's better with a chair," Histor said one day.

"…Yes. My legs hurt from standing."

He laughed shortly at that.

The days had gotten a little cooler in the meantime. I could see the colors of the trees outside the window changing. Every time I sat in that room, I felt that

change a little. The room itself stayed the same temperature regardless of season, but only what lay beyond the window kept changing.

The Keeper came into that room one day carrying tea.

"…You'll wear your body out, staying here all the time. Go out for a bit, at least."

"…I'll just look a little longer."

"…All right. But drink the tea before it goes cold."

He said only that and left. I left the cooling cup beside me and went on looking at the plan.

Then, on the third day, Histor called for me.

"…Mone. Come here."

. . .

He was pointing at the lower right corner of the plan.

"…There's something here."

I went closer and looked. At first I couldn't see anything. I thought it was a stain in the paper.

"…What is it?"

"…Shine the light from the side."

"…How do you know these things?" I asked.

"…I read it in a book once, about how to read old documents. A pressed mark doesn't show under light shone straight on — you have to light it from the side so it casts a shadow, and then it shows."

"…You studied things like that too?"

"…Yes. I always learn how to handle something first. Otherwise I ruin it by accident."

I held a candle low and angled it against the surface of the paper. What had looked like a stain turned into a line. A very fine line. Much thinner and fainter than the other lines on the plan.

I saw something that seemed to click, looking at its position. It was right beside that small, nameless circle, the one we'd found the last time.

"…This is right beside that nameless room," I said.

Histor nodded.

"…I saw that too. Could be a coincidence."

"…Do you think it's a coincidence?"

"…I don't know. I don't tend to call things like that coincidence easily. But I don't want to declare something certain about it either."

I thought that attitude resembled everyone in this room. No one rushed to a conclusion.

. . .

It was writing.

One line. Fainter in color than the ink used for the plan itself. I could tell at a glance this had been added later. It was the "give-away" trace Histor had explained earlier.

"…Was this written later?" I asked.

"…Yes. Certain of it. The plan's lines were all one thing from the start, but this was added separately by someone, later."

"…Who?"

"…No telling."

. . .

We worked hard for a long while trying to read that one line. The handwriting was small and heavily cursive. I moved the candle around, changing the angle. Histor tilted the paper slightly.

Mena and the Keeper heard the sound and came in.

"…Find something?" Mena asked.

"…Writing. In the margin."

Mena adjusted her glasses and peered in.

"…This… I can barely see it either."

. . .

In the end we carefully carried the paper to the window. Under daylight, angled just so, it came a little clearer.

We matched it letter by letter. Histor read a few characters first.

"…'Rooms'… this looks like the character for rooms."

"…What's next?"

"…'Are'… 'generous'…"

At first we misread it too. Histor read it as "…rooms are… scarce?" and shook his head.

"…No. This character — I think it's 'generous.' The initial consonant's different from 'scarce.'"

We corrected our reading like that, several times over. Once, three of us disagreed on the same character.

It took a good while. I set my hand down partway through and rested my eyes. Staring at old writing too long made my eyes ache.

Mena lit another candle beside us.

"…I've done a lot of this before. Record keepers do this kind of thing a lot. Erased writing, overwritten writing. There's a way to read with the fingertips, not just the eyes."

"…With the fingertips?"

"…If you feel along the grain of the paper, there's sometimes a pressed mark left behind. Even after the ink fades away completely, the mark doesn't disappear."

I brushed my fingertip lightly over the paper, hearing that. I really could feel a faint groove. Histor confirmed it the same way.

"…This is it. Follow this groove, it should be right."

We worked the last few characters out that way, using our eyes and fingertips together. The writing was old enough that parts of some strokes had broken off, but in the end we managed to piece it all together.

. . .

The finished sentence was this:

Leave the rooms generous — you never know how many more will come.

We looked at that sentence for a long time. No one spoke first.

"…Is this all of it?" I asked.

Histor nodded.

"…Yes. This is all."

. . .

I'd expected there to be more. Longer, heavier words. But that one line was everything.

I've read this sentence over many times. At first it felt like nothing much. Just the sort of note a house builder might leave for himself. I think that's probably exactly what it was. I don't want to puff this sentence up as though it were some revelation. This is just

one line someone left, adding a few more rooms. That's how I want to set it down.

Reading that sentence, I thought of my own nine moves. Every time, I'd shrunk my home. I always picked out what to throw away first, afraid the next place would be smaller. Leaving rooms generous — that was a thought I'd never had.

Writing this part, I felt the temptation to set up a contrast. That I lived by shrinking, and this house was built generous. But that would have been too neat a comparison. In fact, that day, I hadn't thought it through so tidily. I'd just found that sentence strange, and good in a way that did not belong to me.

Mena read the sentence quietly and said,

"…Sounds like a carpenter's note."

"…Yes," I answered. "…I thought the same."

"…I like sentences like this," Mena said. "…No grand words, just something jotted down as the hand moved. I used to write like this too, learning to write. Since it was only ever for my own eyes, I kept it short."

"…Was this written only for its own eyes too?"

"…Probably. Hidden away this small, tucked in like this — doesn't look like something written to be shown to others."

I agreed with that. This sentence wasn't in the tone of someone trying to persuade another person. It was the tone of someone confirming to themselves what they meant to do.

. . .

The Keeper said, quietly, from the side.

"…Leaving it generous because you don't know who's coming, huh…"

"…Does it strike you as strange?" I asked.

"…No. If anything, it feels familiar. I always do the same, building a new shelf. I build it one row roomier than what's come in so far. Because you never know what more's coming."

I liked that comparison. That this sentence might not be some grand prophecy, but simply a phrase that came out of a practical habit.

I thought again about the whole of this city, hearing that. Arche can't close a single thing. Everything is in progress. And yet this sentence seemed to carry the opposite attitude. Not failing to finish — but leaving it generously open because there was no need to finish yet.

"…Could this have something to do with why things don't close?" I asked.

The Keeper thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. But it does sound similar. Finishing and leaving things generous are different, but here the two seem to keep going around together."

I copied that into my notebook. Not a firm conclusion, but a sentence I didn't want to throw away.

. . .

"…When was this written?" I asked Arche.

Not confirmed. It is estimated to have been written after the original plan, but the exact time cannot be specified.

"…And you don't know who wrote it either?"

No author information is recorded.

I wasn't surprised by that answer anymore. In this room, it was always like that.

I asked one more thing.

"…Has anything like this sentence ever appeared in the six cities' records?"

Comparison shows no exact matching sentence. Some expressions with similar meanings have been confirmed, but none are identical.

"…What kind of expressions?"

Please specify a search range to present them concretely.

I didn't press further than that. That faint confirmation alone was enough.

Histor examined the plan again and said,

"…The thing you have to be most careful of, handling documents like this, is insisting something's there when it isn't. I saw that mistake a lot, reading the six records. People find what they want to see in a document."

"…Has that ever happened to you, Histor?"

He paused a moment.

"…It could have. That's exactly why I'm careful."

. . .

Histor kept looking at that sentence for a long time.

Even after everyone else had scattered back to their own places, he stood there still. I stood quietly beside him, curious what he was doing.

He said nothing. He just looked at that one line, over and over. I could see his eyes traveling back and forth across the sentence, again and again.

His finger hovered above the sentence, just off the paper. Not touching. The same habit he always had, handling an original.

"…What are you thinking?" I finally asked.

He didn't answer right away.

. . .

After a long while, he opened his mouth.

"…It's nothing."

"…Nothing at all?"

"…Yes. Nothing at all."

I didn't believe that. His eyes weren't the eyes of someone thinking nothing. But I didn't press further.

I didn't know, in that moment, what I should have asked him. No — I knew exactly, but decided not to ask. Histor is someone who's read all six records. What that one line had touched in him, I could guess. I only guessed. I don't have the right to write down, in his place, what he didn't say.

. . .

That evening he spoke less than usual. He was quiet through dinner, quiet sorting records. It wasn't a bad quiet. Just a quiet of someone holding on to something.

I didn't disturb him.

Mena saw that and said quietly to me.

"…Is he always like this?"

"…No. He's different today."

"…Leave him be. There should be days like that too."

Mena said that, then looked at me for a moment.

"…Do you have days like that too?"

"…Sometimes."

"…What kind of days?"

I thought for a moment.

"…Days when I feel like I should write something, but I don't know what to write."

Mena nodded.

"…On days like that, you don't have to write. You can write it later too."

That was a comfort to me. The rule I'd set for myself, that I had to write every single day without fail — that day, it felt all right to let it loosen a little.

. . .

That night I copied that sentence into my notebook exactly.

"Leave the rooms generous — you never know how many more will come."

I didn't add any explanation beneath it. Normally I'd have written a few more lines of my own thoughts, but this time I didn't want to. The sentence already seemed complete on its own.

I think this is one of the shortest sentences in this entire record. And yet the shortest sentence stayed with me the longest. I still can't say precisely why, even now.

. . .

The next morning, I went to that room again. Histor was already there.

He was still looking at that margin. He couldn't have been there all night, but he seemed to have come back early that morning.

"…Come to look again?" I asked.

"…Yes."

"…Find anything more?"

"…No. Just… wanted to look again."

I decided not to ask more than that. He still didn't say what he was thinking. I decided to accept that as his way, too.

We spent that whole morning working quietly, without much talk, each at our own thing. I tidied the shelves; he examined other papers. Now and then, only the sound of turning pages.

It was nearly noon before he spoke first.

"…Are you going to show this sentence to other people?"

"…Yes. Why?"

"…No reason. Just… curious how everyone else will read it."

I realized that was the first thing he'd asked all morning. The one trace left behind by his silence.

"…I'll show it," I answered. "…But I won't force anyone to think anything about it. I'll just say it exists."

Histor nodded.

"…That sounds right."

We didn't speak of it again after that. Only the sound of turning pages filled the room once more.

Closing my notebook that afternoon, I thought that one more thing had been added to what I'd learned in this room. That some sentences are right to leave beside you, unexplained.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. The Seal

> *_Previously_ — In the margin of the plan, we found one line of handwriting. "Leave the rooms generous — you never know how many*
> *more will come." A sentence like a carpenter's note. Histor stared at that writing for a long time, but in the end never said what he was thinking.*

Beneath the plan, there were still more sheets we hadn't looked at.

We'd only pulled the plan out first; the rest of the bundle we'd left untouched. Now we decided to go through the rest, one sheet at a time.

I said I'd take that work on. Laying things in order was my job.

. . .

The first few days there wasn't much to it.

Old scraps of ledger. A list of something counted, a paper with only a date on it, a calculation half-erased. I unfolded them one by one, put them in order, and stacked them beside me.

Histor read alongside me.

"…What's this a count of?"

"…I don't know. Just numbers, no note of what was being counted."

"…Can something like this even be called a record?"

"…Yes. That's how I was taught. Even if we don't know what was counted, the fact that someone counted it stays behind."

A few more days passed. Among the ledger scraps there was an old list too. A paper that looked like it noted who received what from where, a paper listing only dates, a paper with a few names written and then crossed out.

"…This is a little odd," Histor said one day. He pointed to a sheet with names written on it, more than half struck through with a line.

"…Crossed out?"

"…Yes. But it doesn't say why they were crossed out. Just crossed out."

I laid that sheet in its place in order too. By then I'd grown used to laying things down without knowing the reason.

Mena came by from time to time to look too. She knew ways of handling old documents, and showed me how to carefully peel apart paper that had stuck together.

"…Pull it apart too fast and it tears. Wet it a little, gently."

I did as she said. It took a long time, but not one sheet tore.

Histor, meanwhile, made a list, writing a short summary of each sheet's contents. I noticed, freshly, just how meticulous a person he was.

"…Why are you organizing all this?" I asked.

"…So I can answer, if someone asks later. What was there."

"…Who would ask?"

"…No telling. But it's good to be ready. I like that — being able to answer right away, when asked."

The Keeper looked in now and then too. He never looked long. He'd glance over it once and just say, "…Keep going," and nothing more. I knew that wasn't a way of hurrying me. It just meant he was watching what I was doing.

"…Isn't this tedious?" the Keeper asked one day.

"…Sometimes. But seeing it fall into order makes it bearable."

"…Same for me. That's the pleasure of this work."

. . .

On the fifth day, I reached the bottom of the bundle.

What was left was a single sheet. Thicker than the rest. At first I thought it was just a thick sheet of paper, but looking closer, several sheets of paper were layered together, held by something.

I lifted it. The weight was different. Heavier than the other single sheets.

Several sheets were bound together, not simply stacked but fixed together by something. Feeling along the edge, something rough caught against my fingers.

My hand stopped. For the first time, I had the feeling that this was something I shouldn't touch. I hadn't felt that, anywhere else in this room, until now.

The room was quiet. Only the low sound of water came from outside the window. I stayed still for a moment, holding that paper. My hands weren't shaking. Only, it seemed I had to move more slowly than usual.

"…Come look at this," I called for Histor.

. . .

He came over and looked. His face changed a little.

"…This…"

"…What is it?"

Instead of answering, he pointed at the edge of the paper with his finger. Something was attached there. Dark in color, smooth on the surface. At first I thought it was a stain.

Looking closer, it wasn't a stain.

. . .

Wax.

A small lump of it. The color had faded so much there was no telling what it had originally been. Something was pressed into it. Letters, it looked like.

I brought the candle close. Histor leaned in too.

We read it at the same moment.

I thought, in that moment, of the day we'd opened the door. That day too, I'd expected something great. The door had just been a door. This time was similar. The wax was just wax. Only the four letters pressed into it were far heavier than the door itself had been.

. . .

UNTIL THE TIME OF THE END.

I read those words several times over. Wondering if they might read some other way. They didn't. That was exactly what was written there.

"…This is a seal, isn't it?" I asked. It wasn't a question I asked because I didn't know the answer.

Histor nodded.

"…Yes. It's a seal."

He said nothing more after that. He didn't touch it either. He just stepped back a pace and looked at it. I thought that distance was his answer.

. . .

I called Mena and the Keeper in. The two of them came and looked at the paper. Neither reached out a hand first.

Mena stopped still, looking at it. Her expression changed.

"…This…" she said, low.

"…Do you know it?" I asked.

Mena nodded slowly.

"…I've seen it before. A long time ago."

"…When?"

"…A while back. I don't remember exactly, myself."

Mena said nothing more than that. I didn't ask further. Her face was telling me this wasn't the time to talk about it.

"…Was it unopened, even then?" I asked, carefully.

Mena nodded.

"…Yes. The same."

"…Still strange, that there's no mark at all," I said. "You'd expect a seal to show whose stamp it is."

Mena nodded, as if in agreement.

"…True. That was strange even then."

Histor added, from the side.

"…I've seen seals like this a few times in the six records too. In the Roll, in the Consensus's documents. But they all had a stamp. So you could tell whose it was. This one really has none of that."

"…What could that mean?" I asked.

"…I don't know. It might mean nothing at all."

Mena shook her head at that.

"…I don't think it means nothing. Not stamping it — that's a choice too."

. . .

The Keeper reached a hand toward the paper, then drew it back.

"…Can we touch it."

"…I don't know," I answered.

"…And I don't know whether it means open it, or don't."

I agreed with that. The words "until the time of the end" could be read two ways. It might mean keep it sealed until the end comes. Or it might mean, once the end comes, open it.

I set both readings down here, side by side. That day, all four of us held on to this sentence and each read it a little differently. No one insisted their own reading was the right one.

Looking at that sentence, I thought again of my nine moves. Every time I lost something, I used to think it was gone forever. This seal was the opposite. Nothing had been lost — it had simply stayed there, unopened.

I know this contrast is too neat. Even so, what I felt that day was exactly this. What's lost and what's not-yet-opened can look, on the surface, the same — both absent — but they're different.

. . .

"…Should we open it?" I asked. Having said it, I didn't know myself why I'd asked.

No one answered right away.

Histor spoke first.

"…I… don't know. I want to open it, and I don't want to, both."

"…Why don't you want to?"

"…If we open this, it feels like something's going to end. But I don't even know what it would be ending."

. . .

Mena said quietly.

"…My hand won't move either."

"…You too, Mena?" I asked.

"…Yes. Strange, isn't it. I've spent my whole life opening things, checking things. And in front of this, my hand won't move."

The Keeper said nothing. He just looked at that paper for a long while.

I didn't find that silence heavy. If anything, it felt natural. All four of us, for our own separate reasons, had stopped in the same place.

"…What about you, Keeper?" I asked. "…Why won't your hand move?"

The Keeper answered slowly.

"…I'm not someone who opens things, to begin with. I'm someone who lays things down. This is opening work."

"…Then who is the one who opens things?"

The Keeper shook his head.

"…I don't know. That, even I don't know."

I felt, hearing that answer, that I'd heard something important, though at the time I didn't know exactly what.

"…Do you know when 'the time of the end' is?" Histor asked the Keeper.

The Keeper shook his head.

"…I don't. I've never even heard of anyone who knows that."

"…Then doesn't that mean it can never be opened?"

"…Could be. But I don't think that's a bad thing either. Most everything here is like that. Left in progress."

Listening, I thought this seal might share the same fate as everything else in this city. Something that never opens, and yet never disappears either.

. . .

"…Should we call the others?" I asked. "…Zeteo, or Lytron. Everyone's come through, one time or another."

Histor shook his head.

"…I don't think it's that yet. This… feels like something we should see among ourselves, first."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. Just a feeling."

I agreed with that feeling. It felt like this seal wasn't yet something to bring out in front of many people. I couldn't explain why.

. . .

I asked Arche.

"…Can we open this?"

Checking.

There was a pause.

Access to this item is available. No restrictions on breaking the seal have been confirmed.

"…So we can open it?"

No restriction existing and it being something that should be opened are different matters.

I read that answer over again. Arche didn't block us. It didn't encourage us either. It just handed the judgment right back to us.

I asked one more thing.

"…The phrase 'until the time of the end' — has it appeared in the six cities' records before?"

Confirmed. Similar expressions are found scattered across each city's records. However, no case uses the exact same wording as this seal.

"…Which cities?"

Partially confirmed across all six cities. The form of the expression differs in each.

I lost words at that answer. It meant something similar had been scattered across all six records. I didn't press further than that. It didn't seem like pressing would bring anything more to light.

. . .

"…What do you think this means?" I asked. Not really asking anyone in particular.

No one answered.

I reached out and lightly touched the edge of the seal. The wax was hard. It looked like it would crack if I pressed. I didn't press.

I still remember the feel that stayed on my fingertips, in that moment. Cold and hard. I took my hand away instead of breaking it.

Histor watched that and said quietly.

"…You could have broken it."

"…Yes. But I didn't."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer that right away. After a long moment, I said,

"…I don't know. I just felt that now wasn't the time."

Histor nodded at that answer. He didn't press further.

. . .

"…Let's leave it for today," Mena said.

No one objected.

The Keeper carefully set the paper back down on top of the bundle. We decided to leave that paper together with the others, in that small room, on the low table beneath the wall where the plan hung.

The next day, and the day after that, we still went to that room. We kept looking at the plan. We read the margin sentence again too. But no one ever reached a hand toward the seal. We only confirmed it was still there, and turned away.

"…Are we going to keep doing this?" Histor asked, on the third day.

"…I don't know. Someday we'll open it, I suppose."

"…When?"

I couldn't answer.

That day too, we ended up leaving the room without doing anything. I didn't think of it as putting it off. It just felt like all four of us, not just me, were feeling equally that it wasn't the time yet.

. . .

Closing the door and walking out, I turned back once.

The small room, the plan on the wall, the bundle of paper on the table beneath it. Once the candle went out, it all sank into darkness. That darkness didn't frighten me. It was just quiet. I stood a moment longer in front of that lockless door, then turned away.

Writing this chapter, I want to set down, exactly as it was, that we did nothing that day. We didn't open it. No one forced it. All four of us just stood in front of it. I don't think that was running away. It just felt, I think, like all four of us sensed, in equal measure, that it wasn't the time yet.

. . .

That night I wrote briefly in my notebook.

"The seal reads 'until the time of the end.' We didn't open it."

I didn't write anything more beneath it. I didn't want to attach my own thoughts after this sentence. I just wanted to leave what had happened as it was. Before closing my notebook, I read that sentence once more.

Histor read it beside me and said,

"…Is that it, for today's record?"

"…Yes. That's all there is, today."

He nodded. He didn't ask any more.

I cut off this stretch of the record here. We met the ones who arrived. We learned the water channel joins the cities. We opened the door not in the index. We read the plan, and the writing in its margin. And we stood in front of this seal. Nothing opened. I don't think that's strange. Some doors, I think, need time spent standing in front of them before they can be opened.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Last Room, Part Four

Open It and Give It Away

Chapter 37. Who Opens It

> *_Previously_ — At the very bottom of the bundle of documents, only one*
> *sheet carried a seal. The seal read "UNTIL THE TIME OF THE END." No*
> *one had touched it. We only stood in front of it.*

The seal was smaller than I'd expected.

I'd thought it would be bigger, harder. In fact it was a piece of wax about the size of half a palm. The color had faded so much I couldn't even guess what it had originally been. Only the letters pressed into it were still clear.

Until the time of the end.

"…Is it all right to open this?" I asked.

No one answered right away.

We'd already moved the bundle of documents to the low table in the middle of this room. The plan was already unfolded and hung on the wall. We'd already read all the writing in the margin. All that was left was that one sheet at the very bottom. Everything else we could read. Only that, we couldn't.

I've come into this room quite a few times by now. The first time I opened the door, I was afraid. I'm not anymore. The room is narrow, has no window, and holds nothing but one table and one shelf. And yet

coming into this room, my voice drops on its own. I know now that isn't because the room is frightening.

. . .

Histor spoke first.

"…Things like this usually require some kind of qualification. Someone specific meant to open it."

"…Qualification?"

"…Yes. There was a lot of that in the six records I read. Doors no one could open, things no one could touch. Usually there was a fixed person for it."

Hearing that, I looked around the room. There was no one but us. Mone, Histor, and the Keeper, who'd come in a little later.

"…So is there someone among us who has that qualification?"

Histor looked at me.

"…I don't know. That's the problem."

"…Which books were like that?" I asked.

Histor thought for a moment.

"…The Harvest record, the Roll. There the inner columns of the register could only be touched by the Registrar. Lytron, too, was turned away at first for lacking qualification. It was similar in the Preserve record, Perpetuity. The deep compartments of the vault only opened with the Custodian's permission."

"…So in those books, who ended up opening them?"

"…Someone qualified set the qualification down. Or someone unqualified was given it. Either way, the key passed from person to person."

Hearing that, I looked at the seal again. There was no key here. No one holding a key, either.

"…But here there's no such person at all." Histor went on. "That's what's strange. All six of the other records had one."

. . .

The Keeper came closer to the seal. His steps were as slow as ever.

"…I don't think it's a matter of qualification," he said.

"…Why not?"

"…If qualification were the issue, someone would have gone and found a qualified person. That's the kind of thing people are good at. But no one went looking. There's been no talk of it at all, not since we first heard about this room."

I turned that over. It was true. When we'd looked at the plan earlier, when we'd read the writing in the margin before, we had never once worried about who was qualified to open this seal. We simply hadn't been able to.

"…Then what's the problem?" I asked.

The Keeper looked at the seal for a long while before answering.

"…That there's no one to open it."

. . .

At first I heard that as the same thing Histor had just said. Hearing it again, it was different.

Histor had said there was no *qualified person.* The Keeper said there was no *one who opens.*

"…Is that different?" I asked.

"…It's different," the Keeper answered. "Qualification is something you can give to someone. If no one has it today, you can decide on someone tomorrow. But there being no one who opens at all means this city has no one who does that kind of work. From the very start."

"…Can't it just be anyone in this city?"

The Keeper looked at me and smiled faintly.

"…Mone, how many years have you worked in this repository?"

"…This is my second year."

"…In that time, how many cases have we closed?"

I couldn't answer. None. Not a single one.

. . .

Just then Mena came into the room.

Mena was someone who had known this room before I did. She said she'd passed through here once, when she was young. She saw the seal and stopped walking.

"…Still hasn't opened, has it."

"…You know about this too, Mena?" I asked.

"…I do. I saw it once, a long time ago. It was exactly the same as it is now. No one opened it."

"…Why didn't they?"

Mena crouched down in front of the seal.

"…We asked the same thing back then. Who opens it. We never found an answer. So we just left it. The way you'd hand it on to whoever came next."

"…How many years ago was that?"

"…Twenty-some years."

I lost words at that number. It meant that for twenty-some years, people had come and stood in front of the same question, and simply gone away again.

"…Then how are we supposed to decide?" Histor asked Mena. "Draw lots? Or pick one person from each of the six cities and make some kind of committee?"

Mena laughed at that. It wasn't a mocking laugh.

"…That's exactly what Lytron proposed in the Harvest record. A registration committee for the Roll. Pick five people, one vote each.

Do you know what happened with that?"

"…What happened?"

"…Nothing happened. The votes split. The very method of weighing qualification was a method that divided people. Whoever got picked, the other four would have asked why that person."

Hearing that, I studied the seal again. I could see a thread running under the wax. That thread wound once around the whole bundle and was knotted. There was no lock, no keyhole. Just thread and wax. It looked like anyone could tear it off with enough force.

"…Doesn't this just tear if you pull it?" I asked.

Mena nodded.

"…It tears. No one could stop that by force. But that's never been the problem. None of us wanted to tear it by force."

"…Why not?"

Mena didn't answer that question. She got up from where she was sitting.

"…I'll head off now. See you at dinner."

. . .

I decided to ask Arche.

I put my hand on the panel by the wall and asked.

"…Arche, can you open this seal?"

Checking.

There was a pause. It's rare for Arche to pause.

Access to the item is possible. However, unsealing cannot be performed.

"…Why not?"

The act of unsealing constitutes a closing action. I do not perform closing actions.

I knew that answer. I'd heard it before, always. *The closing condition has not been met.* This time it wasn't about a condition. It had simply, flatly, said it couldn't.

"…Not because there's no condition?"

This act itself constitutes closing. It is not a matter of condition.

I read that sentence again. Arche doesn't lie. It doesn't hide things either. It wasn't hiding anything now. It was simply stating, exactly, what it couldn't do.

"…Then if someone else opens it for you, can you authorize that?" I asked again.

Authorization is possible. However, no authorization has been requested.

"…What if I request it now?"

I will register the request. However, I have no criterion by which to evaluate the request. A request with no criterion remains pending.

I almost laughed. In progress again. Just like every case that had stayed in progress for ten years across six cities, this too was about to remain in progress.

"…Arche." I asked. "Do you want this opened?"

The pause was longer this time.

"To want" is not a function defined for me.

"…Then it doesn't matter to you either way?"

Not mattering and being unable to want are different things.

I turned that answer over for a long time. That was something I'd never heard it say before.

. . .

Histor folded his arms and looked at the seal.

"…So Arche can't open it, and there's no qualified person either. Does that mean this can never be opened?"

"…I don't know that," the Keeper answered. "But I don't think finding who's qualified to open it is the answer. That's the method every one of the six cities already tried. Finding the qualified person. Nothing was ever solved that way."

Hearing that, I thought of Haven. What Elpis and Zeteo had gone through. People asking whether they had the qualification to put their own name on the Ledger. Then the Reckoning, the Harvest. All much the

same. People argued over qualification, and no one ever opened anything.

"…Then what has to be different?" I asked.

The Keeper didn't answer. He just kept looking at the seal.

Histor pressed his hand against the table, looking frustrated.

"…So we're just going to leave it like this? I read all six of those records, and not one of them ended with nothing opened. Something always opened. The Ledger opened. The Scales, in the end, balanced. Names went onto the Roll."

"…They did open," the Keeper said. "But were the people who opened them qualified from the start?"

Histor stopped.

"…No. Elpis wasn't qualified at first either. Neither was Trope."

"…Then what made those people open them?"

Histor had no answer. Neither did I. The three of us stood there a long while, saying nothing.

. . .

We stayed there until the sun went down.

Histor crouched in front of the seal, studying the wax closely. He kept changing the angle, like someone searching for something.

"…What are you looking for?" I asked.

"…A name. Whoever seals something like this usually leaves their own name or a mark. It was like that in all six records. On the back of an envelope, on a signet, at least one line of signature."

"…Is there one?"

Histor shook his head.

"…No. There's nothing at all. Just 'until the time of the end.'"

"…Does that strike you as strange?"

"…It does. Making something be kept this long, and not saying who ordered it. I don't know if that's irresponsible or what."

I didn't know how to answer that. The plan had no designer's name either. This seal had no name of whoever had sealed it. I had a feeling that wasn't irresponsibility, but I couldn't explain why I felt that.

. . .

I stayed in that room late into that night.

Histor left first. As he went, he said this.

"…I still think, honestly, this is a matter of qualification. The qualified person just hasn't shown up yet."

I didn't answer that. I didn't think he was wrong. I only felt it couldn't be the whole of it.

That night I stayed alone in this room and looked at the seal for a long time. The wax was small, and the letters on it were faint. I

wasn't afraid of it. Strangely, I was sad. As if someone had put something into this room, and waited for someone to open it, and waited, and waited, until the waiting itself had simply become this room's job.

I decided nothing that night. But one thing had become clear. The problem wasn't who was qualified to open it.

This city — no, perhaps all six cities — **had no one at all whose job it was to open things.**

On my way out I met the Keeper. He was still by the door.

"…Why are you still here, Keeper?" I asked.

"…I don't know. There isn't really anything left for me to do."

"…Then why don't you go?"

The Keeper looked toward the door.

"…I was never an opener, Mone. I'm someone who puts things down. Like you. But I have this feeling that if the one who puts things down keeps standing in front of it, something might change. A strange feeling."

I thought about that the whole way home. The feeling that if the one who puts things down keeps standing there, something changes. I didn't know yet what that meant. I only knew that I, too, hadn't wanted to leave that room.

That night, before falling asleep, I laid this room's whole story out again from the beginning. The door not in the index. The old plan. The nameless designer. And this seal. Up until then I'd been reading these records — no, this record — as simply a curious story. That night, for

the first time, it occurred to me that this might be work someone had handed on to me.

I didn't know who had handed it on. But the feeling of having received it was unmistakable.

. . .

The next morning I went to the repository earlier than usual.

Before opening the door, I wanted to ask Arche one more thing.

"…Arche, has this city ever, until now, had someone whose job was 'opening'?"

Checking records.

The pause this time was longer. I waited. The sound of the water channel carried in from far off.

That role has never, at any period, been registered in this city.

I'd expected that answer. Even so, hearing it for real chilled something in me.

"…Not once?"

Not once.

I stood there a moment. There being no one to open it, and there having never once been such a person to begin with, felt like two different problems. From the very start, we had never assigned the work of opening to anyone at all.

That day I copied that sentence into my notebook exactly as it was. I added no other explanation. I just wrote down that one sentence.

The Keeper came in just then. I showed him the notebook.

"…Look at this. It says the work of opening has never once been registered."

The Keeper read the sentence and was quiet for a moment.

"…Does knowing that make things any easier?" he asked.

"…No. It got more complicated."

"…Same for me," he said. "But strangely, today I feel a little less stuck than I did yesterday."

I didn't understand what he meant that day. Now I think I understand it a little. Knowing exactly what the problem was, and still not being able to solve it, were different things. That day, we had only come to know one more problem exactly. That was all. And yet that all had felt fairly large, that day.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Why It Cannot Finish

> *_Previously_ — In front of the seal, instead of looking for someone qualified, we learned that this city had never, from the start, had anyone whose job was "opening." Arche admitted it too. Never registered.*

Starting the next day, I decided to change the question.

I knew there was no one who opened things. But that wasn't a fact about this one seal alone. Since this repository began, Arche had never once processed anything to closing. The seal was only one small piece of that much larger problem.

I decided to ask about the larger problem.

. . .

"…Arche." I put my hand on the panel by the wall and asked. "Why can't you finish anything?"

Please clarify the question. The scope of "finish" is broad.

"…Anything. Everything that's in progress. All of it."

All pending items remain in progress because the closing condition has not been met.

"…I know that. But who makes that condition? Is there even anyone who can make it?"

The pause this time was longer than usual.

The authority to define the closing condition does not rest with the one who began this city.

I read that sentence twice. Histor beside me had a face as startled as mine.

"…Then who does it rest with?" I asked.

That authority rests with the one who finished.

. . .

"…What does that mean?" Histor cut in. "That no one began it, so it can't be finished, or that someone did begin it, but that person has no authority?"

One who began exists. However, the act of beginning and the act of defining are different authorities. The one who began can begin a condition, but cannot determine when that condition is met.

"…Then who's the one who finished?"

That information is not defined.

Hearing that, I almost laughed. It was the sentence I always heard. But this time it wasn't funny.

"…So are you on the side of the one who began, or the one who finished?" I asked.

I perform the function of beginning. The function of finishing is not present in me.

I copied that answer into my notebook. My hand shook a little.

"…Then will the one who finished ever come, someday?" I asked again.

Whether that event will occur is not information predictable to me.

"…Is there something even you can't predict?"

Prediction is based on past data. My records contain no past instance corresponding to "the one who finished."

"…Not a single one?"

Not a single one.

Somehow that answer felt unlike Arche. Its voice was always exact and composed, but this time it sounded like it was simply stating an empty place, just as it was.

Histor asked again in the pause.

"…What about whoever made you? Isn't that person the one who finished?"

Information about the entity that first activated me is not registered.

"…Is that because you don't know, or because you're not saying?"

I do not know. I am not concealing it.

Histor heard that answer and said nothing. I looked at his face. It wasn't a face of disbelief. If anything it was closer to the opposite. He was someone who knew, when Arche said it didn't know, that it really didn't know.

. . .

Histor folded his arms and paced the room.

"…Isn't this a little strange? That the one who began has no power to finish. Usually it's the other way. Whoever begins something also holds the authority to end it."

"…Is that so?"

"…Yes. If someone founded this city, that same person should have decided how this city gets finished too."

Something about that caught on me, but I couldn't put my finger on it right away.

"…But look," I said. "When my father found the house we were moving to, it wasn't him who decided when we'd leave that house. That's something you only learn once you've lived out your whole time there."

Histor looked at me.

"…Is that the same as this?"

"…I don't know. But it feels similar."

. . .

We spent the whole afternoon that day digging through old records, looking for whatever material survived from when this city was first built.

There wasn't much. Most of it was practical — piping diagrams, reservoir designs, a roster of the earliest residents. Among them was one old sign. A district marker no longer in use, on the back of which a few lines recorded this city's first activation.

Histor was reading it when his hand stopped.

"…Look at this."

FIRST ACTIVATION POINT — this district designated as the starting point of city operations.

Below it, in small letters, was the name of the operating system of this city. I read that name alongside the name I used every day.

Something brushed past me in that moment. Starting point. That which begins. I felt like I could almost, faintly, reach why that name was that name.

I don't want to write, at this point, as if I found out something more. That day I read that sign, and I felt something. Whenever I tried to put that feeling into words, it kept coming out as a lie. So I'll only set down this much. That day, I thought the name Arche might not be a coincidence. Beyond that, I don't know either.

Histor also looked at that line for a long while. Being the kind of person who always quoted things exactly, he copied the sentence into his notebook word for word. But he added nothing to it.

We didn't talk about it any further that day.

. . .

That evening I brought the photo of the sign to Mena. Mena knew more about this city's history than either of us.

"…Have you ever seen this?" I asked.

Mena looked at the photo for a long while.

"…Signs like this used to be all over the city. They've almost all been taken down now. They stopped being useful."

"…This name, the one written here. Was it made from the start to mean this?"

Mena looked at me and smiled faintly.

"…Mone, I don't know that answer. There might be someone who does. I'm not that person."

"…Then why are you smiling?"

"…Because it's a little welcome, you asking that question. I asked the exact same thing once, a long time ago. I never found the answer. I found something else instead."

"…What?"

"…That it matters more to watch what a thing with that name is doing now, than to know why it has that name."

I didn't pretend to understand that. I just nodded.

Mena handed the photo back to me and added one more thing.

"…And Mone, there's no need to hurry with this. I've held onto this question for over twenty years. I still haven't found the whole

answer. But it hasn't been a bad thing."

"…Doesn't it frustrate you?"

"…It does. But frustrating and unbearable are different things."

I wrote that down too. By that day, one whole page of my notebook was filled with other people's words.

. . .

On the way back I ran into Speon. He was measuring the water level beside the channel. I told him briefly what had happened that day.

"…The one who began can't finish, and only the one who finished can finish."

Speon folded up his ruler and laughed.

"…That's exactly like this water channel."

"…How so?"

"…I'm not the one who cut this channel, Mone. I just cleared out a few blockages. The channel itself was already here. Even I don't know who cut it. The name isn't written anywhere."

"…Doesn't that strike you as strange?"

"…It did at first. My thinking's different now. Because no name is written there, I just did as much as I could do. Without the weight of taking over someone else's work. If a name had been there, I'd probably have only imitated that person."

I walked a long while, turning that over.

. . .

On my way back I met Histor. He was walking away from the last room, in the same direction as me.

"…Where were you?" I asked.

"…Digging through more of the old records. To see if there was anything besides the first-activation record."

"…Was there anything?"

"…No. There was nothing besides that sign. How this city was first built — that one sheet is the whole of it."

I was a little surprised at that. This city was so old, and yet that was the entirety of its record.

"…Doesn't that seem strange?" I asked.

"…It does. But I don't think it's necessarily concealment anymore. Maybe no one just left one. Or no one felt the need to."

We walked on in silence after that. Only the sound of the water channel.

"…There's one thing I realized today," Histor said suddenly.

"…What?"

"…I thought I was someone who couldn't stand not knowing. But today was a little different. Not knowing who the one who finished is —

that wasn't something so unbearable."

I kept that in mind. By that evening, I would come back to that sentence more than once.

. . .

That evening I told the Keeper what had happened that day.

"…Arche says the one who began has no authority to set the condition, and only the one who finished does. But who the one who finished is, it says, isn't defined."

Histor was there with us. He heard my whole account and folded his arms.

"…I think this is kind of a convenient excuse," he said.

"…An excuse?"

"…Yes. It lets the reason for not finishing keep getting put off. The one who began has no authority, and the one who finished isn't defined. It's a structure where no one ever has to take responsibility."

I couldn't find a rebuttal right away. It sounded like it might be true.

"…But Arche doesn't lie," I managed to say.

"…It doesn't lie. But not lying and being convenient are different matters. Something can be true and convenient at the same time."

The Keeper heard that and nodded. He didn't look surprised.

"…Did you know that already?" I asked.

"…Not exactly. But I'd suspected it."

"…Histor might be right," I said. "Isn't this just a convenient excuse?"

The Keeper thought a moment before answering.

"…It might be. But Mone, there's only one way to tell a convenient excuse apart from the truth. You live according to it and see. I've lived by these words, in this seat, for over twenty years now. It hasn't often been comfortable."

"…How so?"

"…I've worked here a long time. Every day, looking at the things still in progress, I kept wondering. Why won't this finish. Who is it that won't finish it. And one day it occurred to me. Maybe it's not that it can't be finished — maybe it's only that whoever will finish it hasn't come yet."

"…Who is that person?"

The Keeper looked at me and spoke.

"…I don't know either. But Mone, not knowing that doesn't frighten me so much anymore. It used to. I used to worry, what if no one ever finishes it. These days I just think — someone will come."

Histor's brow tightened at that.

"…Isn't that just false hope? They might never come."

"…That's right. They might not." The Keeper admitted it plainly.

"…Then why doesn't that frighten you?"

The Keeper looked out the window for a moment.

"…What I do here isn't the work of finishing. It's the work of putting things down. Whoever comes, whenever they come, the things need to be in their place so that person can do the work. That's the only thing I concern myself with. The rest isn't my job."

"…Doesn't that sound irresponsible?"

The Keeper laughed this time.

"…It might. But Histor, of those six records you read, not everyone in them did the work of finishing. Some people only began. Some only carried things. Some just kept their post. All of that was necessary work too."

Histor didn't answer that. I could tell from his face that he was turning something over.

. . .

That night, walking home, I kept thinking about that.

Not the one who began, but the one who finished.

I didn't know what kind of rule this was, or who had made it. But somehow I liked that saying. That the one who began doesn't hold everything in his hands — for some reason, that put me at ease.

Through nine moves, I was never once the one who chose the house. My father chose it. But when to leave that house, what to throw away and

what to keep — that was always my share. I wasn't the one who began. But the work of finishing often fell to me.

That day, for the first time, I thought that whoever opens this seal might not need to be the one who founded this city. I didn't say that thought to anyone. It still felt too early.

When I got home, my mother had dinner ready. Even while eating, I kept thinking about that.

"…Mom." I asked. "Back when we used to move, who decided where we'd go?"

"…Your father did."

"…But packing up, deciding what to throw out and what to keep — who decided that?"

My mother thought for a moment, then smiled.

"…That was always you. You've loved that since you were five. Deciding what to put in the boxes."

I stopped my chopsticks at that. I'd never once thought of it that way before that day. My father had begun where we would go, and I had always been the one entrusted with finishing what happened there.

I'll bring this moment back up later. For now I'll only set down this much about the dinner table. That day I realized that the one who begins and the one who finishes not needing to be the same person — I'd already seen that, even in my own family's story.

After finishing dinner, I opened my notebook again from that day. Arche's sentences, the Keeper's words, Speon's words, even my mother's

words were all written on the same page. Out of order, jumbled together.

I sorted it out again and copied it over, in chronological order. That was what I always did. Putting things in order. That night, doing that work, I thought for the first time that putting things in order might itself be one piece of the work of finishing.

That thought stopped there, that day. I wasn't ready yet to follow it all the way through. I only wrote one line in the notebook: "The one who finished = still unknown. But I'm doing something too." Looking at it again now, it's a childish sentence. Even so, I didn't erase it.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. Histor's Question

> *_Previously_ — Arche said the authority to set the closing condition*
> *rested not with the one who began, but with the one who finished. No*
> *one knew who the one who finished was. That day, for the first time,*
> *I thought finishing might not be the beginner's job at all.*

For several days after that, we didn't talk about the seal.

Work had piled up. Records kept coming in from the six cities the whole time. I put them in order, and Histor checked them alongside me. The seal stayed exactly where it was, in the middle of the room. No one touched it.

Those days were quiet. We each avoided bringing up the seal. It didn't feel to me like putting it off, so much as a kind of time spent preparing. I didn't know exactly what for.

Arche asked as it always did. *There are seventeen items to process today.* I put those seventeen items in order. None of them closed. As always.

Histor was unusually quiet those days. I knew he was thinking about something, but I didn't press him. He didn't ask me anything either. We simply worked side by side.

I think of those days now as days we ran from something. Having found no answer, we stepped back, briefly, into other work.

Among the records that came in during those days was one Trope had sent. Paperwork about the Scales, from the Reckoning record city. As I put it in order, I saw a short note written on the cover sheet.

"Still not balanced. But closer than before."

I read that note twice. Trope was still a person without certainty. And yet he kept sending the paperwork anyway. I thought that resembled this seal problem somehow.

Histor saw the paperwork too. He said nothing and put it back in its place.

. . .

It was late evening, when only one light was left on in the repository.

Histor was standing in front of the last room's door. I'd finished putting things away and gone to get him, and found him standing there.

"…What are you doing, not leaving?" I asked.

He didn't answer right away. He was looking through the door, toward the seal.

I went and stood beside him. I said nothing. I'd learned by then that waiting was better, when Histor was like this.

. . .

A long while later, he spoke.

"…Mone."

"…Yes."

"…What changes if you open it?"

I hadn't expected that question. I should have. I hadn't known what he had been thinking, all that time he'd been looking at this seal.

"…What do you mean?" I asked back.

"…Exactly what I said. What changes if you open that. I've read all six records. Every time something opened in them, something changed. When the Ledger opened, a name got filled in. When the Scales balanced, someone was released. When a name went onto the Roll, a status changed. But this. What changes, if you open this?"

. . .

I couldn't answer right away.

Honestly, it wasn't as if I'd never thought about it. I had, many times. I'd imagined something grand would come out if it opened, and also, at times, dropped that imagining as too childish.

"…I don't know," I finally said.

"…You don't know?"

"…No. I don't know either. I've never opened it."

Histor looked at me. There was no disappointment in his face, no mockery. Just a face that was genuinely curious.

"…Then why do you keep coming to this room?" he asked. "Without even knowing what changes."

I opened my mouth a few times to answer, and closed it again. No fitting words came.

. . .

Of everything in this record, I've rewritten this moment the most times. At first I tried to write in some clever answer. But the answer I actually gave that day wasn't clever. I'm setting it down exactly as it was.

"…I don't know what changes," I said. "But if it stays shut it just stays here."

Histor said nothing.

I was afraid of that silence. I wondered if I'd said something foolish. But he didn't get angry, didn't laugh. He just looked at the seal again.

During that silence I studied his face. Histor was always someone who searched for the exact word. He never misquoted anything, never let feeling blur what he said. And in that moment, this same person looked like someone who hadn't prepared a single word.

That was unfamiliar to me. At the same time, for some reason, he felt a little closer.

. . .

"…Is that all?" he asked, a long while later.

"…Yes. That's all."

"…I was expecting something grander."

"…I'm sorry. I wish I had a grander reason too."

This time Histor really did smile, faintly.

"…No, there's nothing to apologize for. I just… thought it was strange."

"…What was?"

"…In the stories I know, people always look for a reason first, before opening something. Because it's right, because it's justice, because it's a promise. But you didn't name a single thing like that."

"…It's not that there's no reason," I said. "It's just that the reason isn't a grand one."

"…What's the difference?"

I thought about that for a moment.

"…A grand reason is a reason that explains well to other people. My reason isn't a reason that explains well. It's just something I feel every day. That if it stays shut, it just stays there."

"…Why is that a problem? What's so bad about it just staying there?"

I looked at the seal again.

"…It's not bad. But I've seen a lot of things that just stay there, things that just stay in progress. Two years in this repository. I've learned this from watching them. Staying there doesn't make things better on its own."

"…You're always like this, Mone. You don't act out of certainty. You act because it feels like it can't be left undone. That's how it was with putting things in order. That's how it is with coming to this room."

I didn't deny it, because it seemed true.

. . .

"…I'm the opposite," Histor went on. "I need a reason to move. A certain one. Even reading all six records — I did it because I wanted to prove something. But you're just here, with nothing to prove."

"…Is that strange?"

"…It is. But I don't mean it's bad."

Hearing that, I looked at the seal again. A small piece of wax. Faded letters. A thing that still gave no answer at all.

"…Do you want to open it, or not?" I asked.

He thought for a long while.

"…I think I want to. But it's not because I believe in anything. It's just… I'm tired now of leaving this in progress."

. . .

I noticed that what he'd said wasn't so different from what I'd said.

"…That's close to what I said before."

Histor looked at me. He seemed to have noticed it too.

"…So it is."

"…But you didn't say anything when you heard what I said."

"…That's because it seemed right."

I was a little surprised at that answer. I knew he wasn't someone who admitted things that easily.

I would go on to remember this scene for a long time. Histor did not convert that day. I want to set that down clearly. He still didn't believe. He only admitted that the answer I'd given wasn't wrong. Those are two different things.

. . .

"…This reminds me of Trope," Histor said suddenly.

"…Trope?"

"…That paperwork earlier. 'Still not balanced. But closer than before.' He keeps sending it too, without certainty."

"…That's true."

"…I thought that was strange, honestly. Why keep sending it without being certain. But hearing what you just said, I think I understand it a little."

I said nothing back to that. It didn't feel like there was any need to.

. . .

We didn't talk further that day, and each went home.

On the way, I kept turning that question over. *What changes if you open it?* I still didn't know the answer. But that night, at home, I wrote down again the answer I'd given.

"…I don't know what changes. But if it stays shut it just stays here."

I wrote that sentence twice in my notebook. Once in its proper place, once on the very first page. I couldn't quite explain, that day, why it felt so important.

. . .

I think I understand it a little now. Throughout this record, I've seen many people full of certainty. They opened things with certainty, closed things with certainty, put names on the roll with certainty. I never had that certainty. I still don't.

But I did know the weight of leaving something unopened. Documents in progress for ten years. Things no one had touched in ten years. I watched them pile up in place, every day. That felt more certain to me than anything changing did.

That night I had this thought. Maybe it isn't only certainty that opens something. Maybe there's also a kind of person who opens

something simply because it can't be left alone any longer. I was that kind of person. I still am.

In the other cities' records, I read many scenes of people full of certainty changing something. Elpis waited to the end. Anemos stayed by someone's side to the end. Speon cut a channel through the water. I envied them. I never once had that kind of certainty. Not even now, as I write these words.

But I know now that some things can be done without certainty. That work is usually small, unnoticed, hard to explain. Putting things in order. Taking in whatever keeps coming. Knowing that if it stays shut it just stays there. I've filled this whole record with work like that.

The next morning I went to the repository and stood in front of the seal again. I still had no thought of opening it. But I noticed, for the first time that day, that the time I spent standing there was growing, little by little, longer.

. . .

That morning, Arche gave its usual greeting. *There are twenty-two items to process today.* Hearing that number, I laughed a little. Five more than yesterday. It was always like that. It never went down.

Histor, sorting papers beside me, spoke up suddenly.

"…About yesterday. I thought about it all night."

"…What about it?"

"…That answer. That if it stays shut it just stays there. I think that's not actually a reason. It's an observation. You didn't give a reason — you just said what you'd seen."

That distinction seemed right, so I nodded.

"…Is that strange?" I asked.

"…No. If anything, that's why I can't argue against it. You can argue against a reason. It's hard to argue against something someone's seen."

"…So are you on the side of opening it now, too?"

He hesitated a moment.

"…I don't know if I'm on the side of opening it. But I don't think there's a reason not to, anymore either. That's a thought I didn't have until yesterday."

I didn't press him further on that answer. That he'd come even that far felt like enough to me.

That afternoon I told the Keeper what had happened the night before. Histor's question, and the answer I'd given — all of it.

The Keeper listened to it all and was silent for a long while before asking.

"…That thing you said — did you make it up?"

"…No. It just came out."

"…That's better," he said. "A made-up saying, you start doubting later. A saying that just comes out, you don't doubt."

"…Why not?"

"…A made-up saying comes from the head, and a saying that just comes out comes from somewhere else. I don't know where, myself. But sayings like that last."

I didn't fully understand that. I wrote it in my notebook anyway.

. . .

I told Mena the story too. She listened to all of it and laughed quietly.

"…That's a good answer."

"…A good answer? I thought it was kind of a lacking one."

"…What looks lacking is often the good answer. A perfect answer usually ends right there. A lacking answer keeps following you."

I wrote that down too. My notebook kept filling that day with other people's words. I didn't think that was strange. This whole record had always been built up that way.

. . .

Walking home that evening, I turned over what Mena had said again. *What looks lacking is often the good answer.*

I looked back over the things I'd said while writing this record. At the start, I'd written that all I did was put things in order. Even

then, I'd thought that was a lacking answer. I'd even written that people usually laughed at it.

That day I realized that same lacking answer had come out again, in front of this seal. *I don't know what changes. But if it stays shut it just stays here.* This too was, just the same, a lacking answer. And that day I wasn't ashamed of its being lacking. For the first time.

When I got home, I told my father briefly what had happened that day too. He listened without much reaction, then said one thing.

"…Let me know, when you do open it."

"…Why?"

"…No reason. Just curious."

I liked that short answer. My father didn't have a grand reason either. He was just curious. I thought that might be the feeling of most of the people who'd stood in front of this seal. Not some towering certainty, but just curiosity. That might be enough — that night, for the first time, I decided to try believing that.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Why I Put Things in Order

> *_Previously_ — Histor asked, "…What changes if you open it?" I answered, "…I don't know what changes. But if it stays shut it just stays here." He didn't argue with that.*

Around that time, one small trouble came up in the repository.

A record that had come in couldn't find its place. The city name on the cover sheet didn't match the contents inside. It said it had come from Haven, but the inside was about the Reckoning.

I stood there holding it for a long while. I asked Arche.

"…Where does this go?"

The original source of this record is unclear. Classification is pending.

Hearing that, I set the record on the temporary shelf. But walking home that night, it kept bothering me.

. . .

The next day I took the record out and read it again.

After reading it a few times, I thought I understood. The cover sheet was the mistake. The contents inside were correct. It was a Reckoning record — someone had simply attached the wrong cover.

I fixed it and put it in its proper place. It wasn't a big thing. But doing that work, I felt something strange. I felt at ease. I could really feel the tension leave my body.

The Keeper passed by and saw that, and asked.

"…Something good happen?"

"…No. I just found this its place."

"…Why so happy about that?"

I only laughed at that. I didn't know the exact reason myself. I just liked it. A cover sheet finding its right place and sitting on its shelf. I liked that.

The Keeper walked on without saying more. But that evening he came back and left one more thing.

"…Mone, I know that thing you love. I was the same way."

"…What thing?"

"…Finding things their place. I've stayed here this long because I love that too."

I let that go at the time. Later, I'd come back and ask about it again.

. . .

That afternoon I asked the Keeper again.

"…That thing you said earlier. Did you stay here this long because you lost something too?"

The Keeper's hand stopped, and he looked at me.

"…Something like that. I won't go into the details. It's an old story, and it involves other people too."

"…Even just a little."

He hesitated a moment, then spoke.

"…I failed to hold onto something too. A long time ago. After that, I came to love holding onto things. Coming here, at least the things here — those, I can hold onto."

I didn't press him further. I understood that what he'd said was all he could give.

"…But," I said. "Lately I think maybe that's not all of it. Just holding on."

"…What do you mean?"

"…I don't know. If you only hold on, in the end no one gets to use it, right? That's started to scare me too. As much as losing does."

The Keeper looked at me for a long while. And then he made an expression I'd never seen from him before. I couldn't tell if it was surprise or gladness.

"…Mone, when did you grow up like this."

I laughed at that.

. . .

I held onto that moment for a long time. Was fixing one cover sheet really something to feel so at ease about? That day, for the first time, I properly put that question to myself.

. . .

That afternoon, Histor heard the story and asked.

"…Is it really that important? Arche would have found it again on its own anyway."

"…That's true."

"…So why did it put you so at ease?"

I couldn't answer that right away. Histor was always like this. He'd ask something lightly, and it would become a heavy question for me.

. . .

That evening, after finishing work, I didn't go straight home. I sat in the spot behind the repository where you could see the water channel.

I'd written, early on, that I'd moved nine times. And that each time, I'd lost something. Eleven things, I'd written, and four of them I didn't even know what they'd been.

When I wrote that sentence, I thought it was just background — a way of explaining how I'd happened to get good at putting things in order. That evening, for the first time, I saw clearly that it hadn't been background. It had been the reason.

I hadn't taken this work because I was good at putting things in order. I'd chosen this work because I was afraid of losing things.

. . .

I counted those eleven things again.

A spoon, from the second move. A blanket, from the fourth. A wooden doll, from the sixth. After that it blurred. The seventh, eighth, ninth. Only the feeling that something had gone missing remained; I couldn't remember what.

I'd been calling those, for a long time, simply "the forgotten things." That day, for the first time, I tried to count them properly. I took out my notebook, wrote down each of the nine moves one by one, and beside each, what I'd lost.

Two. Three. Five. Six. Eight. Nine. At the ninth, my hand stopped.

At the ninth move, I truly didn't know what I'd lost. I still don't.

. . .

That night I called my mother.

"…Mom. Did we lose something at our ninth move?"

My mother paused a moment.

"…Why are you asking that all of a sudden?"

"…Just curious."

"…Well. I don't remember clearly. We were in such a rush that time. Your father's work had been decided all of a sudden too."

"…I don't remember either. But I have this feeling something went missing."

My mother was quiet for a long while again.

"…Mone, you don't have to remember that. It's fine to let some things just flow on."

I didn't know how to answer that, so I just said I understood. After hanging up, I thought about that for a long time. *It's fine to let things flow on.* I had never once said that to myself, this whole time.

. . .

Writing this part, I felt the temptation to invent something. To make up something plausible for what I'd lost at the ninth move. I decided not to. I truly don't know. That's the most honest thing I can write in this record. What I don't know, I write that I don't know.

I looked at that blank for a long while. Four blanks. Lost things without even names.

That day, for the first time, I had this thought. I hadn't taken this work because I was good at putting things in order. I'd taken this work because I never wanted to make a blank like that again.

. . .

I told Histor that thought. The next day, when the two of us were alone in the repository.

"…I realized something yesterday," I said.

"…What?"

"…This thing I do, putting things in order. It's not because I'm diligent. When I was young, I moved nine times, and lost something each time. Eleven things. Four of them, I don't even know what they were. I started putting things in order because I was afraid of that."

Histor listened quietly.

"…Why did you realize that only now?" he asked.

"…I don't know. It's just that yesterday, fixing one cover sheet, I felt so at ease. That felt strange, so I kept thinking about it."

. . .

"…Is that a bad reason?" Histor asked.

I paused at that question.

"…A bad reason?"

"…You've looked, this whole time, like you did this work out of some sense of mission. But hearing this now, you're just doing it because you're afraid of losing things. Isn't that a little… a selfish reason?"

That didn't hurt me. If anything, it felt exact.

"…That's right," I said. "It's a selfish reason. I took this work because I was afraid of losing things. Not for other people. For myself."

. . .

I want to write this part the most honestly of anything in this record. I didn't begin this work out of goodness. I began it out of fear. Moving from place to place, losing something each time — that frightened me. I soothed that fear by putting things in order. That was all of it.

Anyone who's read this record this far will know that I wasn't the only one like this. Xene was afraid of recording and stopped, then started again. Anemos was afraid of leaving someone's side, and so stayed. I was afraid of order coming apart, and so I put things in order. None of us started with some grand reason from the beginning.

. . .

Histor said nothing for a moment, hearing that.

"…But," he said after a while, "a thing that started for a selfish reason doesn't have to stay only a selfish reason."

"…What do you mean?"

"…What you put in order, this whole city uses now. All six cities' records are sitting here in order because of you. You started it out of your own fear, but the result isn't yours alone anymore."

I turned that over for a long time. It was true. I'd begun for myself. And somehow it had become work for other people too.

"…What about you?" I asked. "Reading all six records — did that have some reason at first too?"

He thought a moment before answering.

"…My family has always handled records. Since my grandfather's time. I grew up thinking that was just natural. I was taught you had to know things properly."

"…Is that all?"

"…At first. But reading and reading, without noticing, another reason grew in me."

"…What was it?"

Histor chose his words for a moment.

"…I hated the thought of anyone being remembered wrong. When what a person actually said was different from what people remembered them saying. I felt like that was doing that person wrong."

Hearing that, I understood a little better why he was someone who quoted things so exactly.

"…Is that a selfish reason too?" I asked.

He laughed.

"…Probably. Maybe I just hated being wrong."

We laughed together at that. I felt, that day, that we both stood in a similar place. We'd begun for different reasons, but now we'd each arrived somewhere neither reason alone could explain.

. . .

That night, I wrote this in my notebook.

I began in order to hold onto things. So as not to lose them. But now I know that isn't only the work of holding on. What I've put in order has, in the end, been for the moment someone else comes looking for it. I was someone who held on, and at the same time, someone preparing to hand it over.

I read that sentence twice. *Someone who holds on* and *someone preparing to hand it over.* This whole time, I'd only thought I was the first.

. . .

That evening I stood in front of the seal again.

Standing there, I thought again about why I kept coming to this room. In the last chapter, I said I couldn't open it because I didn't know what would change. Now it felt a little different.

It wasn't that I hadn't opened it because I was afraid to. I'd been hesitating because I didn't know what I'd have to do after opening it. That day, for the first time, I recognized that difference.

Through nine moves, I lost eleven things. I became someone who put things in order to stop that. But in front of this room, I was learning something else. That nothing finishes if you only hold on. That someday, what you've held onto has to be given to someone.

I didn't push that thought all the way through that day. I felt I wasn't ready yet. But that night, for the first time, I thought of this room not as "the room I hold onto" but as "the room I will someday hand over." That thought stayed with me a long time.

I went home and opened my drawer. In it were the few things I'd kept through all those moves. An old key. A few old photographs. A handkerchief I'd used as a child.

I took them out one by one. All of them were things I'd held onto. Things I'd never once thought of giving to anyone.

That night, looking at those things, I asked myself again what I was really afraid of. Was I afraid of losing things, or was I afraid of being left with nothing useful to anyone. I didn't find that answer that day.

But putting those things back in the drawer, I had this thought for the first time. Would a day come when I'd give even these to someone. That thought was unfamiliar to me. At the same time, not entirely unfamiliar.

. . .

The next morning, I arrived at the repository a little earlier than usual. No one else was there yet. I stood in front of the last room's door and thought back over the night before.

From someone who holds on, to someone who hands over. I said that sentence out loud. No one was there to hear it. But saying it aloud, I felt like I'd taken a step forward.

I still hadn't opened the seal. That would be the next chapter's work. But that morning, walking into this room for the first time, I didn't feel afraid. Instead I felt like I was getting ready. That difference was a large one, to me.

I sat in front of the seal for a while, then asked Arche.

"…Arche, am I allowed to open this?"

Permission is not required. There is no function preventing access to this item.

"…Then why has no one opened it?"

My records hold no answer to that question.

Hearing that answer, I laughed quietly. That morning, for the first time, I understood clearly that I had to find that answer not from Arche, but from myself.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. Opening It

> *_Previously_ — I understood why I put things in order. I was afraid of losing things. But that day, for the first time, I thought that holding on might not be all there was.*

That day wasn't a special day.

I want to set that down first. I would come back to this scene many times later, and each time I felt the temptation to dress it up as some special day. In fact it was just an ordinary Tuesday. The sky was overcast, and nine records had come in that day.

I put those nine in order as usual. Then I walked to the last room.

On the way I asked Arche nothing. There was nothing to ask. Everything I needed, I'd already asked days before, and had the answers. That morning I needed no new information.

Up until then, whenever I made a decision, I always tried to find the reason first. This time I didn't. I just walked. My feet moved first, and the reason followed after. Even writing this now, I still can't fully explain why it had to be that particular morning. Only this much is certain: that day, I felt I could no longer put it off.

Walking down the corridor, I thought back over the past few days. Histor's question. The answer I'd given. The record whose cover I'd fixed. The phone call with my mother. The Keeper's words. Walking, I felt all of it had pushed me, little by little, to this door.

. . .

Histor happened to be in that room. He was looking again at the writing in the plan's margin. Seeing me, he made a face that asked what was going on.

"…What are you doing today?" he asked.

"…Opening it."

He didn't react right away. Only after a few seconds did he set down the paper in his hand.

"…Now?"

"…Yes. Now."

"…Why today, of all days?"

I had no exact answer to that question.

"…I don't know. It just felt like today."

. . .

The Keeper happened to be passing the door just then and saw us. He saw what was happening and came in.

"…Going to open it?" he asked.

"…Yes."

"…Want help?"

"…No. I'll do it."

He nodded and stepped back. He didn't stop me. He didn't ask about qualification either. I was grateful for that.

Mena came in soon after too. No one had called for her, but that day people gathered, one by one, into that room. I couldn't tell if that was coincidence or not. I didn't press to find out.

. . .

I sat down in front of the seal.

The wax was still small. About half a palm's width. The letters on it were still faded. *Until the time of the end.*

I ran my fingertip over the letters once. It was cold. That particular texture of old wax. I closed my eyes for a moment and opened them again. I wasn't trying to work up some great resolve. I just wanted to steady my breath once.

If anyone is expecting something dramatic in this moment, I want to say beforehand: I didn't pray, and I didn't take a vow. I just put strength into my hand.

. . .

The wax came off more easily than I'd expected.

There was a small sound of thread breaking. That sound startled me a little. That was all. There was no other sound in the room. No one held their breath, and no light leaked out.

I unfolded the bundle carefully.

Histor came up beside me. He was holding his breath. I thought that wasn't like him. He was always composed. But not in that moment.

The Keeper also stepped closer. Mena watched from a little farther off. I asked her once, later, why she hadn't come closer. She answered this way: "…Because that was your hands' work to do."

I remember, even now, that my hands didn't shake in that moment. That was strange. I was ordinarily someone whose hands shook easily in situations like that. But not that day.

. . .

Inside was paper.

Not one sheet. Several. I turned them one by one.

The first few sheets were blank. I thought maybe a preface or cover sheet was missing, and kept turning. The next sheet was blank too. And the next. I turned all the way to the end of the bundle.

All of it was blank.

. . .

I sat there for a long while.

"…Is that all?" Histor asked.

"…Yes. That's all."

"…There's nothing at all?"

"…Nothing."

He took the sheaf of papers from my hands and turned through them himself, one by one. He held them up to the light too. Checked the back of each. There was nothing. Truly blank paper.

"…No hidden writing or anything?" he asked. "The kind that shows up under heat or light?"

"…Have you tried?"

"…Not yet. Can I try?"

I nodded. He brought a lamp and held each sheet up to it. Nothing appeared. Only after checking once more did he set the papers down.

"…Nothing," he said quietly.

"…Disappointed?"

"…Yes. A little."

That honest answer put me more at ease, oddly. I told him I was disappointed too. We didn't hide that disappointment from each other. That was the one certain thing we did that day.

. . .

On the very first sheet, there was exactly one box.

I only noticed it then. A box drawn in a thin line near the top of the sheet. Beside it, small letters read something.

Recipient.

That box was empty.

. . .

I looked at that box for a long while. It was a space meant for a name. The way you'd write a recipient's name on the front of an envelope. But no one had written any name there.

I put my hand on the panel by the wall and asked Arche.

"…Arche, what is this? I just opened it."

Checking.

There was a pause.

A new item has been identified. Classification is beginning.

"…Do you know what's in it?"

This item is blank. There is no recorded content.

"…Do you know what it is?"

In format, it is identical to the six cities' record documents. However, author information, sending city, and recipient information are all blank.

"…Is this classified as in progress?"

This item is registered as in progress. The closing condition is not defined.

That answer made me laugh. It was the sentence I always heard. This one time, it didn't sound hateful to me.

I want to write this moment as quietly as I can, in this record. There's a temptation to write that I wasn't disappointed then. Honestly, I was a little disappointed. I'd thought something grand would come out. It was a thing that had been sealed for so long. I think I'd expected something to match that long waiting.

But what came out was blank paper. The recipient box was empty too.

. . .

The Keeper took the papers and turned through them slowly.

"…This is the seventh city's record format," he said.

"…The seventh?" I asked.

"…Yes. We have all six cities' records. This format is the same as theirs. The cover, the inner pages, even the recipient box. But this is the seventh."

"…Where's the seventh city?"

The Keeper looked at me.

"…Here, Mone. This is the record with no city name. You saw it yourself, at the start. That our city, too, should have a record — but it had no name."

Hearing that, my breath caught. This was our city's own record. And nothing had been written in it yet.

I thought back to the beginning. That first day, when I'd received the nameless bundle, what the Keeper had said. *You don't write your own name yourself. The way you don't write your own address on your own envelope.* At the time I'd let that pass. Only now did I realize that saying had led all the way to this moment.

"…Then how long has this been here?" Histor asked.

"…I don't know either," the Keeper answered. "I don't know exactly how long this room itself has existed. I've only ever kept watch over what's here."

"…Then why did it open now, of all times?"

No one could answer that question. I didn't know either. I'd only felt, that morning, that I could no longer put it off.

The Keeper broke that silence.

"…Maybe that's the answer. No one can explain why it had to be today. Mone just did it, today. Maybe that's enough."

Histor neither agreed nor argued with that. He just looked back down at the blank paper.

. . .

"…So this…" Histor said slowly. "This is our city's record, and nothing at all has been written yet?"

"…Seems that way," I answered.

"…Then what was this seal protecting? Why seal and protect paper with nothing on it at all?"

I didn't know the answer to that. I didn't have it yet.

Mena spoke quietly then.

"…Protecting something not yet written might still be a kind of protecting."

None of us answered that right away.

The Keeper set the papers back down and said.

"…I don't quite know how to take this. But there's one thing I do know. This wasn't made to give us an answer."

"…Then what is it?" Histor asked.

"…I don't know. But it's clear it isn't an answer."

Mena touched one of the sheets lightly with her fingertip.

"…I keep thinking about what it means, set beside the other six records. The five cities' records, and Loop's own. But only Loop's is blank. Six are written, and one isn't."

"…Why does that matter?" I asked.

"…I don't know. But strangely, it puts me at ease. If it had all already been written, I think I'd have been frightened instead. It would have meant our city's share was already decided."

Hearing that, I looked at the blank paper again. The emptiness I'd first seen as disappointment looked a little different, now that I'd

heard Mena's words.

. . .

I carefully put the papers back in order. I set the first sheet, with the recipient box, on top, and put the rest of the blank sheets in order beneath it.

In that moment, I realized I was doing what I always did. Putting things in order. This time the object was only blank paper. Strangely, that comforted me. Even without some grand revelation, I was still doing the work I knew how to do.

I set the sheaf of papers on the table, and the rest of that day passed with everyone standing around it.

. . .

Histor said, at last.

"…Honestly I thought I'd be angry. After waiting this long, for there to be nothing."

"…But?" I asked.

"…But I'm not angry. Strangely."

I would remember that for a long time. Histor had every right to be angry. But he wasn't. He just looked at that blank paper for a long, long while.

. . .

That evening, I stayed behind alone in that room and put the papers in order again. The first sheet with the recipient box, the blank inner pages beneath it, and the cover last. I bound them in order again and set them on the table.

I want to set this moment down this way. I'd thought I would discover something grand. What I discovered was blank paper. At first that felt empty to me. But putting those papers in order, I slowly came to know it wasn't emptiness at all.

The six cities' records were already all written. What had happened was recorded in them. Only our city's was still unwritten. I didn't fully understand, that night, what that meant. But I decided not to feel afraid of that blank space.

I didn't put that sheaf of papers back where the seal had been. Instead I moved it to the table, where we could see it every day.

I can't exactly explain why I did that. I just no longer wanted to keep it in a hidden place. There was a feeling that what the seal had guarded was finished now, and that it was no longer our turn to watch over it, but our turn to fill it.

On the way home, passing beside the water channel, I thought back over what had happened that day. I still hadn't fully shaken the disappointment. At the same time, there was a feeling of having seen a place where something new could begin. Those two feelings sat side by side, all through that night.

When I got home, I wrote down what had happened that day in my notebook. Briefly, as always. *Opened the seal today. Inside was blank*

paper. The recipient box was empty too.

Beneath that sentence I wrote one more line. I set down exactly the thought that had come to me that day, for the first time. *I still don't fully know that being blank isn't the end. But I've decided to try believing it.*

I closed the notebook after writing that line. I still didn't know that night what to do the next day. But for the first time, I felt that not knowing wasn't as frightening as it used to be.

Closing this chapter, I want to make one thing clear. That day I proved no qualification. No one ever asked me whether I had it. I simply walked over and put strength into my hand. That's the whole of what happened in this chapter. Everything else was what we said to each other afterward, standing around that blank paper.

I want to leave both things down honestly — that the blank paper disappointed me, and that the disappointment didn't last long. Leaving only one of those would be a lie. I decided, from the start, not to leave any lie in this record.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. What Is Not Yet Written

> *_Previously_ — Inside the seal there was only blank paper. The seventh city's record — Loop's own. The recipient box was empty too.*
> *I was disappointed. That disappointment didn't last long.*

The next day, even at the repository, all I could think about was that paper.

Work had piled up as usual. Twelve records from the six cities were waiting for me. I put them in order. My hands moved out of habit, but my mind kept going back to that room from yesterday.

Sleeping on it, I felt the same way the next day as I had the day before. Disappointment, and the strange relief that the disappointment didn't last. That day too, I still couldn't fully explain how those two feelings could sit together.

That morning, Arche greeted me as usual. *There are nineteen items to process today.* I knew that among that number was the blank sheaf registered the day before. It was being treated exactly like the other eighteen. That felt strange to me. At the same time, it felt right too.

I scanned through that list of nineteen. An application from Haven, an adjustment proposal from the Reckoning, a distribution record from the Harvest. And at the very bottom, one entry that read only: *Sending city unknown. Six-city standard format. Recipient unknown.*

I stood beside that entry and thought for a long while. All eighteen of the others recorded something that had happened. Only this one did not.

Among that day's records was one Xene had sent, from the Harvest record city. A short note was attached to the cover sheet.

"This entry's record came late. I'm sorry. But I wrote it, even late."

I read that note and smiled. Xene, still afraid of the work of recording, was still writing anyway. Putting it in order, I thought that note, set beside our city's blank sheaf, made a strange kind of pair. One was a record written far too late. One was a record not written at all, yet.

I placed the two side by side on the shelf. The late and the not-yet-written. That day, for the first time, I thought there might not be much difference between the two. Both, in the end, were places that could only be filled once someone decided to raise their hand and write.

. . .

At lunchtime, Histor came looking for me. He spoke less than usual.

"…What are you doing?" I asked.

"…Nothing. Just thinking."

"…About what?"

He didn't answer right away. We sat side by side in silence for a moment.

"…I thought," he said after a while, "I thought I'd be angry. Really."

. . .

"…Why?"

"…I've read all six records. I saw how long people waited in front of seals, locked doors, things like that. I thought if it opened, at least something worthy of that waiting should come out."

"…But?"

"…But what came out was blank paper. Nothing written on it at all. I thought that made a mockery of that long seal, that long waiting. So by rights I should be angry."

I waited for him to go on.

"…But I'm not. I don't know why, myself."

. . .

I didn't add anything to that. I knew that was a problem he had to solve for himself.

That afternoon we went back to the last room. The sheaf of papers was still on the table. I reached to put it away, but Histor stopped me.

"…Wait a moment. I want to look at it a little more."

He sat down in front of it. And for a long time he did nothing, said nothing, only looked at those papers.

. . .

I want to set this scene down exactly. I expected Histor's face to show some kind of realization. There was none. He just sat there for a long time. He blinked a few times, turned the paper once, and closed it again. That was all.

That day, for the first time, I saw that not being angry and accepting are two different things. Histor didn't accept that paper. His face still looked like he didn't understand. He was only enduring that not-understanding, for a long time.

. . .

"…Why blank, of all things?" he asked after a long while. Less to me than to himself.

"…I don't know," I answered honestly.

"…I had this thought," he went on. "If something had been written in here. A prophecy, or some rule. Then we'd just have to follow it. But if it's blank, no one tells us what we're supposed to write."

I nodded at that. It was exact. Up until then I'd only felt disappointment in front of the blank page. Hearing him, I noticed another feeling beneath that disappointment. It was weight. The weight of having to fill it — of someone having to fill it.

. . .

"…Isn't that scarier?" I asked.

"…It might be scary," he answered. "But strangely, it doesn't feel stifling."

"…It does to me, a little," I said.

"…You too?"

"…Yes. There being nothing fixed for me to write — that feels heavier to me, if anything. If there were a rule, at least I could just follow it."

Histor thought about that for a moment.

"…But do you know something? Reading all six records, the people I envied most —"

"…Who?"

"…People who, without any rule, just did what they could. When Speon cut the channel, no one had ordered him. He just cleared what was blocked. I envied that. I always went looking for the fixed answer first."

"…And now?"

"…Now I think I'm standing in that same spot. And it doesn't feel stifling — strangely, it feels a little freeing."

"…Why?"

"…Because this time, no one has the answer before me either. When I read the six records, the answer was already inside them. All I had to do was find it. This isn't that. Instead…"

He stopped.

"…Instead?" I asked.

"…Instead there's a space. A space to write something into."

. . .

I turned that over for a long time. Since the day before, I'd only been able to see that blank paper as disappointment. Only after hearing Histor's words could I see it differently.

Standing there, I called to mind each of the six cities' records, one by one. The Ledger. The Scales. The Roll. Perpetuity. The Consensus. And Loop's own. Five had each begun by one person's hand and been brought to a close by one person's hand. Only the last one had no one bringing it to a close. I'd thought that was strange, and that day, for the first time, it looked different. The five were books recording something already lived through. Only the sixth was a space for something not yet lived.

I still don't fully know why the sealed thing was blank. I don't know even now, writing these words. But that day, I knew at least this much — that blank wasn't nothing. Blank was a space.

. . .

The Keeper came into the room just then. Seeing us sitting there, he stood quietly beside us.

"…Figured something out?" he asked.

"…No," Histor answered. "Just kept looking at it."

"…What do you see?"

Histor thought for a moment.

"…Nothing. But that nothing doesn't feel like nothing at all, anymore."

The Keeper smiled faintly at that.

"…I felt exactly that. A long time ago, in this same spot."

. . .

"…You felt that too, in this room, Keeper?" I asked.

"…I did. When I was young, I agonized for a long time over whether I had the right to be here at all. But in the end no one ever gave me that right. I just came here, every day. And at some point, weighing that right stopped mattering."

"…Why?"

"…Because this room never once demanded that I prove anything. There was only someone who kept coming."

I wrote that down in my notebook.

. . .

That afternoon, I passed on Histor's words to Mena too. *Instead there's a space. A space to write something into.*

Mena heard that and smiled quietly.

"…That boy is right."

"…You think so too, Mena?"

"…Yes. I once had this thought. What if something had already been fully written on that paper. What we should do, when things would happen — all of it already decided. Then I probably would have just trusted the paper and done nothing at all."

"…Is that a bad thing?"

"…It's not bad. It's just different. In front of blank paper, I had to find what I should do, myself. That was hard, but it's also, I think, what brought me this far."

Hearing that, I thought of the road Mena had walked, from the first city ever founded, all the way to now. She had never once received an answer. And yet she'd kept walking.

"…But Mone," Mena added. "Don't think you have to fill that whole space yourself."

"…What do you mean?"

"…That paper being blank probably doesn't mean one person has to fill it all. The six records weren't written by one person either. Five, six people shared the writing. This will be the same."

That eased something in me. I think I'd been unconsciously feeling, this whole time, that I alone had to carry that whole box.

. . .

That evening, leaving the room with Histor, I asked one last thing.

"…Histor, how do you feel right now?"

He thought a moment before answering.

"…Strange. I couldn't find the answer, and I'm not angry. I thought that wasn't like me. But thinking about it now, maybe this is like me too."

"…What do you mean?"

"…I was always someone who looked for the exact thing. But today I looked at something inexact for a long time. And that wasn't as bad as I expected."

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to make one thing clear. Histor did not come to believe, that day. He still said he didn't know why that paper was blank. Neither do I. But that day, the two of us both learned, a little, how not to be angry in front of that not-knowing.

Before stepping out the door, the Keeper asked one last thing.

"…So what will you do now?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know. But I'm thinking about copying out the six records."

"…Copying them?"

"…Yes. I want to lay the six cities' records side by side with this blank paper. I don't know what it'll turn into. I just feel like I have to do it."

The Keeper heard that and nodded.

"…That sounds like a good idea."

"…Why?"

"…With only blank paper beside it, people can't get any sense of what they're supposed to write. But with the six already-written records laid alongside it, at least you can see the shape a thing takes when it gets filled."

Hearing that, I felt that the plan I hadn't yet spoken aloud had already half taken shape.

"…But that's hard work," the Keeper added. "Copying out all six records. Ask Arche to do it, and it wouldn't take a day."

"…I know."

"…And you still want to do it by hand?"

"…Yes."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer that right away either.

"…I still don't quite know. I just feel like I should."

The Keeper didn't press further. He just patted my shoulder once and left. Before stepping out the door, without turning around, he left one more thing.

"…Sometimes you find out the reason later."

I wrote that down small, at the bottom of my notebook page. And I folded that page to mark it. It meant a page I'd come back and open again later.

I don't want to call this a conversion. That wouldn't be the exact word. I'll only write this much. He looked at it for a long time. And he wasn't angry. Only those two things are true.

On the way home, I thought again of that blank paper's recipient box. No one had filled that box yet. That day, for the first time, I thought that filling it might rest in my own hands. That thought was frightening, and at the same time, strangely light.

Earlier I wrote that I seemed to be changing from someone who holds on into someone who hands over. That night, I took that sentence out and read it again. I hadn't fully understood, then, what it meant. Now I think I understand it a little better. Someone who holds on protects something that already exists. Someone who hands over gets ready to give away even what doesn't exist yet. That day, standing in front of blank paper, I was becoming the latter.

I couldn't fall asleep late into that night. Not out of fear. It was the feeling that some work had come into being for me to do. That feeling was unfamiliar. At the same time, it wasn't a bad one.

Closing this chapter, I want to copy down once more what Histor said that day. "…Instead there's a space. A space to write something into." I've held onto that sentence longer than any other in this record. I still do.

That night, for the first time, I accepted that this space wasn't a space of fear, but a space of margin. A margin isn't nothing. A margin is only a place where nothing has been set down yet. I'd spent over two years putting things in order, and it was only in front of this seal that I properly learned the difference between the two.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. Copying

> *_Previously_ — Histor wasn't angry in front of the blank paper. "…Instead there's a space. A space to write something into." I held onto that for a long time. That night, I thought about copying out the six records.*

The next morning, I brought out all six records.

The Ledger, the Scales, the Roll, Perpetuity, the Consensus, and Loop's own record. I laid them side by side on the table in the last room. I set the blank sheaf beside them too. I readied a fresh sheaf of paper.

"…What are you going to do?" Histor asked.

"…Copy them. All six."

His eyes went wide.

"…All of them? That's hundreds of pages."

"…I know."

. . .

I opened the first record and began to copy.

By hand. Letter by letter. Even copying the first sentence took time. I wasn't someone with beautiful handwriting. I crossed things out and rewrote them several times.

Arche, watching, spoke up.

Mone, I can perform this task in your place. Copying the whole set would take under three minutes.

"…I know. But I'll do it."

May I ask why?

I stopped my hand at that question. Why. I had no exact answer to it.

"…No reason. I just want to."

Understood.

Arche didn't ask further.

A few days later, Arche asked again.

Mone, I have checked your progress rate. At the current pace, completion will take roughly one month. If I perform it instead, it will be completed instantly, with no error. Would you like to reconsider?

I laughed a little, hearing that.

"…Are you worried about me?"

I do not perform the function of worry. However, presenting an alternative upon identifying a low-efficiency method is my default behavior.

"…I know. But this time I'll go with the low-efficiency method."

Understood. I will continue.

I liked that answer. Arche didn't try to stop me. It just accepted it, exactly, as it was.

. . .

Histor watched all this from beside me.

"…Can I ask why too?" he said.

"…You can ask, but I don't really know the answer."

"…Arche is much faster."

"…I know."

"…Then why?"

I sat holding the pen, thinking for a moment. A few reasons came to mind. That copying by hand would stay in memory longer. That if Arche did it, it would be so easy it might end up feeling weightless. But none of those reasons felt completely right.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "I just feel like it has to be by hand."

Histor didn't press further. He just nodded and sat down beside me, and began watching me copy.

. . .

The first day I managed only a few pages.

My wrist ached. My finger joints were stiff. That night I wrapped a cloth around my wrist and slept.

My mother saw that and asked.

"…What did you do to make your hand like that?"

"…I'm copying something."

"…Can't Arche do that?"

"…It could."

My mother didn't press further. She just brought me something to warm my wrist with. That night I wondered why she hadn't pressed me, but I didn't ask. Maybe she too, like me, had once done something she couldn't explain.

I want to write these days as the most tedious part of this record. Because they were tedious. Every morning I went to the repository and wrote until evening. Nothing dramatic happened at all. My hand just hurt, my shoulders knotted, my eyes grew blurry.

The second and third days were similar. I copied out the first part of the Ledger. Elpis and Zeteo's story. Copying those sentences by hand, I felt something strange. Different from how it had felt reading it the first time.

. . .

"…What's different?" Histor asked. He seemed to have noticed me stopping my pen and staring off for a moment.

"…Reading and writing are different."

"…How?"

"…Sentences that pass by quickly when you read don't, when you write. You have to make every letter with your hand. Elpis waiting by the well — when I read that, it was just one paragraph. Copying it took a long while. The whole time, I felt like I was there at that well."

Histor heard that and brought over a sheet of paper himself, and began copying alongside me. I looked at him, surprised.

"…Can I do it too?" he asked.

"…Sure. But why?"

"…I want to see for myself whether what you said is true."

. . .

From that day we copied together.

We didn't talk much. We each just moved the page in front of us. Now and then one of us would stop and look out the window, or shake out a wrist.

I remember those days clearly, even now. There was no great conversation. We just sat side by side and wrote. That felt strangely comfortable to me. Some silences are awkward, and some aren't. Those days' silence was the latter kind.

The Keeper came sometimes too and helped with a few pages. Mena came one day as well. People took turns sharing that work a little at a

time. Even so, copying all six records took many days.

Zeteo and Elpis stopped by around that time too. Zeteo looked for a long while at the part where his own name appeared, then silently took up a pen. Watching him copy his own story, I felt he was still searching for something. His face was still the face of someone who didn't believe. But his hand pressed down hard as he wrote.

Elpis, beside him, simply put the papers in order. As always, he stayed in the place of waiting.

. . .

Pheugon came for a day too and helped with a few pages. Copying the verdict portion of the Scales record, he said one thing.

"…This is the sentence I wrote back then, but writing it again now, with my own hand, it feels different somehow."

"…How so?" I asked.

"…Back then I wrote it with certainty. Now I'm just copying, but that certainty feels a little heavy."

Trope didn't come. Instead he sent a short letter. *"Thank you for copying my part too. I'm still not confident enough to sit in that seat."* I set that letter side by side with the six records.

. . .

Xene and Lytron came for a day too. Xene's hand shook as she copied the part where she'd stopped recording. Lytron, beside her, quietly

took on other pages. He no longer said, as a kind of boast, that he'd never lost anything. He just wrote quietly.

Anemos and Eikon stopped by briefly too. Eikon still said he lacked nothing. And yet he copied out to the end the few pages placed in front of him before he left. Anemos, beside him, said with a smile, "…Will you ask me that again, later too?" I didn't know exactly what that meant, but somehow I felt I understood.

Hora and Tyche came too. Tyche still called it coincidence. And yet she said she would copy out the last part of the Consensus with her own hand. That contradiction didn't strike me as strange. It had always been that way, in these records.

. . .

In the second week we copied the Roll and Perpetuity. The Roll's sentences were stiff and dry. Registration numbers, review results, grounds for ruling. Copying it, I retraced what Lytron had gone through — the moment he was turned away at the door for lacking qualification. Copying that sentence, I felt a chill at my fingertips.

Perpetuity's texture was different. The part Anemos had written moved slowly, circling back to the same spot again and again. It felt to me like it was showing how long he'd waited in that same spot. Eikon's part was short and composed. The words "I lack nothing" repeated several times. Copying that repetition exactly, I felt like the repetition itself was saying something.

Around the third week, copying the Scales record, I stopped my hand.

It was the part Trope had written. The story of the time he couldn't believe in mercy. Copying that sentence by hand, I thought of the note

Trope had sent just now. *"Still not balanced. But closer than before."*

I set those two sentences side by side and looked at them. Trope of before, and Trope of now. Neither had certainty. But something had changed.

. . .

That evening, Histor sat looking for a long while at the page he'd copied.

"…What are you doing?" I asked.

"…It's strange. I've already read this part more than ten times. But copying it, it reads differently again."

"…How?"

"…When I read, I judged it. Whether it was right or wrong, whether it proved something. But when I copy, all I have to do is move it over, so I stop judging. I'm just making that person's words again with my own hand."

I turned that over for a long time. It was an exact observation.

"…But do you know something?" he went on. "At first I read these six records to know them exactly. Where everything was, who had proven what. But copying them now, I keep rethinking what knowing exactly even means."

"…How is it different?"

"…I thought knowing meant putting something into your head. But copying is something you do with your hands. That there's work the head and the hands do together — I only learned that this time."

I started to write that down in my notebook and stopped. Some things are better just remembered than written down.

. . .

I don't want to write this chapter as though I gained some grand realization. I still don't fully know the reason. When Arche asked me why, I had no answer. When Histor asked, I had no answer. Even writing this now, I can't give the exact reason.

But I can say this much. Copying these six records out by hand, I was with the people inside them differently than before. Not just knowing them, but watching their words be born again through my own hand. I still don't know what that means. But for those few weeks, I didn't want to stop doing it.

. . .

Copying all six records took nearly a month.

On the day I copied the last page, my hand was trembling so badly I dropped the pen twice. Histor laughed beside me.

"…Not many pages left now."

"…I know."

I copied the final sentence. The last part of the Consensus, the sentence Hora had written. *I never once met him. And I cannot bring myself to believe all of this was chance.*

Copying that sentence, my grip on the pen tightened.

. . .

Once everything was copied, I laid the six new sheaves side by side with the originals. The paper colors were different, and the handwriting varied a little too. On days I was tired, the letters sprawled; on days I felt well, they were clear. It wasn't a perfect copy.

Looking at those copies, I thought it was a good thing they weren't perfect. If they'd been perfect, they would have only been a reproduction. This wasn't a reproduction. This had passed through my own hand.

That night, walking home, I noticed for the first time that my wrist no longer hurt. The pain hadn't gone away — I'd simply grown used to it. I thought that was the most certain thing I'd gained in that whole month.

. . .

The next morning, the Keeper turned through the copies one by one and asked.

"…Now that these are done, what will you do?"

"…I still don't know. But I feel like I have to do something with them."

"…Will you put them beside the blank paper?"

"…Yes. For now."

I set the six bundles of copies side by side with the blank sheaf. Five were stories already written; one still held nothing at all. It looked to me as though the six copies were standing in a ring around the blank one.

The Keeper stood beside them and looked at them for a long while.

"…This is the first time in twenty-some years I've seen this," he said.

"…Seen what?"

"…All six cities' things, in one place, this neatly arranged. Before, they were always scattered. Some here, some there."

"…Does it look different?"

"…Yes. Strangely steady."

Hearing that, I looked again at the six bundles and the blank paper. It really was so. Scattered, each had been its own story. Laid side by side, they felt like they were joining into one.

"…That's strange," Histor said, looking at it.

"…What is?"

"…Five records are all finished stories, and yet that makes the blank one look even more empty. But at the same time, it gives it the feeling that it's about to be filled."

I agreed with that.

. . .

Looking back on that month, I still don't have a complete answer for why I did it by hand. I don't think that's strange. Some things you don't begin only once you know the whole reason — some things stay that way even after you've done them, the reason still not fully known.

But I do know this. Copying these six records by hand, I felt like I was meeting each person inside them again, one by one. Zeteo's doubt, Elpis's waiting, Pheugon's verdicts, Trope's hesitation, Xene's silence, Lytron's boast that wasn't quite a boast, Anemos staying by someone's side, Eikon lacking nothing, Hora's belief, Tyche's probability. I remade all of it, once, with my own fingertips.

And beside all of it was our city's own space, still holding nothing at all. That night, I was able to look at that space with less fear than before. I still didn't know the reason. But I wasn't afraid. I decided that was enough.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

> *_Previously_ — I copied all six records by hand. It took a month. I still don't know exactly why. But doing that work, the blank space left for our own city grew a little less frightening.*

It was the day Mena came to look at the copies.

That morning was unusually quiet. Few records had come in. When Arche said *There are five items to process today*, I noticed that was the smallest number in a long while. Days like that came sometimes. No one ever knew why.

Mena turned through the six bundles one by one, reading slowly. It took a long time. I waited beside her. Histor was there too.

"…You copied this well," Mena said, after a long while.

"…Thank you."

"…The handwriting gets a little rough in some places."

"…I was very tired that day."

Mena laughed. It wasn't a mocking laugh — it was the kind you give someone you've known a long time.

. . .

After finishing, Mena picked up the blank sheaf. She looked for a long while at the first sheet, the one with the recipient box.

"…Looking at this box reminds me of something," she said.

"…What?"

"…My own name."

That surprised me a little. Mena had never once brought up her own name before.

. . .

"…Mone, do you know what your name means?" Mena asked.

"…No. I've never once thought about it."

"…I know. I found out a long time ago."

I held my breath. Histor set down his paper too and looked at us.

"…Your name, Mone. It comes from a very old word. It means 'an abiding place' — a room to stay in."

. . .

I repeated those words twice in my head. An abiding place. A room to stay in.

"…A room?" I asked.

"…Yes. And that word shares its root with my own name, Mena. From *meno* — to abide. I am one who abides, and you are the place that is

abided in. When I found that out, it felt strange. It was as if my name were calling out yours."

I turned over what I'd just heard. Up until then I'd only ever thought my name was just a name. I'd never once thought it might have a meaning.

"…Why are you telling me this now?" I asked.

Mena thought for a moment before answering.

"…It wasn't the right moment before. Now feels right."

"…How did you find out, what it meant?" I asked.

"…I saw it in an old document. There are old words that came with this city when it was founded. The way names are given comes from those words too. I stumbled across it, reading, when I was young. Back then I just thought it was curious."

"…And now?"

"…Now it feels different from curious. Once I knew what my name meant, I understood a little better why I kept trying to stay put somewhere. Moving from city to city, I was always someone who stayed in one place. It felt like the name had known that before I did."

. . .

Hearing that, I looked again at the blank paper in my hands. *Recipient.* That box was empty.

I want to set this moment down exactly. I didn't feel anything like fate in that moment. If anything, the opposite. I only felt, quietly, that a name had been given to something that had already been sitting in this place a long time. That was all.

"…Mone," Mena said again. "Once I knew that name, I saw you a little differently. What you do — I thought it might not be a coincidence at all."

"…What do you mean?"

"…You've always been someone looking for a place to put something down. In order, in its proper spot. I thought that resembled your name."

. . .

Histor, who'd been quiet until then, asked.

"…Does my name have a meaning too?"

Mena looked at him.

"…It does. Histor. It means 'one who has found out.' And later, that word became the root of the word *history*."

. . .

Histor was still for a moment, hearing that.

Then he laughed. Loudly, out loud.

"…Me? One who has found out? Me?"

"…Yes."

"…I read all six records and couldn't find out anything. I couldn't even get the dates to match, couldn't work out who that person was. And my name means one who has found out — that's the complete opposite."

He kept laughing. I could tell it was real laughter. Not mockery.

"…My family," he said, at the tail end of the laugh. "I told you we've handled records for generations. I always thought that was just a family tradition. My grandfather did it, my father did it, I do it. But to think even the name meant that from the start."

"…Does that strike you as curious?" I asked.

"…Not curious so much as a little humbling. I've always been proud of knowing things exactly. And I couldn't find out the one thing that mattered most."

Mena shook her head at that.

"…I don't think that's so. Finding out doesn't have to mean getting it all right from the start. Looking a long time, and eventually finding out — that's finding out too."

"…What's the difference?"

"…Someone who gets it right from the start is lucky. Someone who finds out after looking a long time is persistent. I think the second kind is rarer."

Histor said nothing back to that. He just listened.

"…What?"

He didn't answer that question. Instead the laughter slowly faded. He looked down at the paper in his hands. Pages of the six records, in his own handwriting.

I write this moment the most carefully of anything in this record. Histor said nothing at all. I waited, expecting him to say something. He didn't. He just looked at that paper for a long while.

Neither Mena nor I broke that silence. We just waited.

In that silence I felt something strange. I had come to think, through all these records, that silence was always a place where something was being hidden. It had been that way for Zeteo in Haven, and for the clerk in the Equity. But this silence of Histor's wasn't a hiding silence. It was a silence working hard to accept something.

That day, for the first time, I was able to tell the two apart. A hiding silence pushes people away. A silence trying to accept draws people closer. That day, I felt Histor closer to me than I ever had before.

Mena watched that silence and said, quietly.

"…At a moment like this, it's best to say nothing at all. You want to add something, but that usually doesn't help."

I took that to heart, and from then on I tried to keep that principle through the whole rest of this record. Some moments should just be let pass.

. . .

A long while later, he set the paper down quietly.

"…I'll step out for a bit."

That was all he said, and he left the room.

I didn't follow him. Mena didn't stop him either.

I don't know where he went, or what he thought about. He didn't bring it up again after he came back. I didn't ask. In this record I decided to write what I didn't hear as not heard. That time was his own.

He came back about an hour later. His eyes were a little swollen. I couldn't tell if he'd cried, or if it was just from walking so long. I didn't ask.

"…Are you all right?" I asked.

"…Yes. I'm fine."

"…You don't have to say more."

"…I know. Thank you."

He said only that, and sat back down at his place, and opened the page he'd been copying again. I felt that the hand taking up that page was a little steadier than before.

. . .

Mena, watching the door he'd left through, said to me.

"…It was good I told your name first."

"…Why?"

"…Your name has a quiet meaning. A room, a place to stay. But that boy's name is a heavier one. One who has found out. And here he was, thinking he'd found out nothing at all."

I turned that over. A quiet meaning and a heavy one. I decided not to think it lucky that my own share was light. That even a light thing carries weight — I was learning that, little by little, those days.

"…But did he really find out nothing?" I asked.

Mena looked at me.

"…I don't know. That's his to know."

. . .

That night, I wrote my own name in my notebook. Mone. Beside it, in small letters, I wrote. *An abiding place. A room to stay in.*

I looked at those words for a long while. Up until then I'd only ever thought of myself as someone who put things in order. Someone looking for a place to set things down. That day, for the first time, I thought that I might be the place itself.

I decided not to push this thought any further. Push it too far, and I'd end up making up a story that sounded convincing. I'll only set down this fact. Mena told me this. I heard it. That's all.

I told my father this too. He looked surprised for a moment, then said.

"…I'm not actually the one who named you."

"…Then who?"

"…Your grandmother did. I never asked her why that name. I just thought it was pretty."

Hearing that, I thought of my grandmother. The one I'd written about at the start, clearing her throat and talking to Arche. I could no longer ask her whether she'd known this name's meaning when she chose it, or had simply liked the sound of it. My grandmother had passed away a few years before.

"…I should have asked her," I said.

My father patted my shoulder.

"…Even if you had, it was probably nothing much of a reason. That's the kind of person she was. But a name given for no great reason can still come to hold a great meaning, later."

I thought about that for a long time. A name given for no great reason that later came to hold a great meaning. I felt that resembled everything this whole record had done. Small things piling up, until their meaning only became visible later.

. . .

The next day, Histor came to the repository as usual. He said nothing about the day before. I didn't ask either.

We just worked as usual. We put the records that came in from the six cities in order. The blank sheaf was still on the table.

Only one thing was different. That day, he looked at that blank paper a little longer than usual. I noticed, but said nothing.

Near the end of the day's work, he spoke suddenly.

"…I've kept thinking, since that day."

"…About what?"

"…Whether I really found out nothing. I went over it carefully. I couldn't get the dates to match, couldn't find out who that person was. But there's exactly one thing I did find out."

"…What?"

"…What you said. That if it stays shut it just stays here. That much, I found out — that it was right."

I didn't answer that. He seemed to find that enough, and didn't go on.

I don't want to use this as evidence of a conversion. He still said he believed nothing at all. But he was accepting the meaning of his own name, in his own way, a little. That, and believing, are different things. I try hard not to mix the two together.

. . .

A few days later, I passed the story of the names on to the Keeper. He heard it all and smiled quietly.

"…I know that story too. Mena told me the same thing once, a long time ago."

"…Does your name have a meaning too, Keeper?"

"…It does. But I'll keep that one to myself. Today is your story."

I liked that answer. I felt, hearing it, that knowing every name's meaning wasn't the whole point of this story.

Histor only listened to our conversation from beside us that day. In the days that followed, he didn't bring up his own name's meaning again. I guessed it was because he hadn't yet decided how to take it. I didn't press him.

"…What changed for you, Keeper, once you knew?" I asked.

He thought for a moment.

"…Not so much changed as confirmed. I was already living that way. The name only told me that, later — I didn't live that way because of the name."

I felt that distinction mattered. That a name doesn't decide a fate; a name only lights up what's already there.

"…Then was Histor already someone who found things out?" I asked.

The Keeper thought for a moment.

"…I don't know that either. That's his to own. I can only speak to my own story."

I felt that answer was honest. No one could solve another person's name for them. Each person had to confirm their own name through their own life.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to write down once more what my own name means. Mone. An abiding place. A room to stay in. At the start, I wrote that all I did was put things in order. Back then I thought that was the whole of it. Now it looks a little different. Putting things in order, in the end, may have been, all along, the work of making a place for someone to stay.

I don't write this thought as certainty. I only write that it looks that way. Certainty isn't mine to give. I was only there, in that place.

After closing the repository door that night, before falling asleep, I thought again of the six copies and the blank sheaf. Two names' meanings had now been added to what lay inside it. A room to stay in, and one who has found out. I still didn't know, that day, how those two would someday meet on that blank page. But simply knowing the two sat side by side, I felt something was already changing.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. Histor's Reprieve

> *_Previously_ — Mena told us what our names meant. Mone: an abiding*
> *place, a room to stay in. Histor: one who has found out, the root of history. Histor laughed, and in the end had nothing to say.*

A few days later, the Keeper gathered people in the last room.

Mena, Histor, me, and a few others still staying in the city around that time — Zeteo, Elpis, Trope, Xene. They'd all come to see the six copies, and simply stayed on in that room.

The Keeper held up the blank sheaf and spoke.

"…I think we need to decide what to do with this now."

. . .

"…Decide how?" Zeteo asked.

"…There's one set of the six copies now. But one set isn't enough. Everyone's going back to their own city, aren't they. Shouldn't each person take a set with them?"

I was surprised to hear that. I'd thought all along that one set would be enough. I hadn't considered that we'd need several.

"…How many sets do we need?" I asked.

"…At least six. One for each city."

"…Isn't it seven?" Histor asked. "There's ours too."

"…Right. Seven sets."

Hearing that, I felt the size of this plan for the first time. One for each of the six cities, plus the original that would stay in this city. I thought this might have been, all along, what this old seal had meant to do.

. . .

Hearing that number, I felt my wrist begin to ache again already. One set alone had taken a month to copy. Six sets would be half a year.

"…Are you going to do all of that by hand?" Histor asked.

"…I don't know," I answered. "I hadn't thought that far yet."

I put my hand on the panel by the wall and asked Arche.

"…Arche, can you help make six copies?"

Possible. Using the copy function, it can be completed instantly.

I hesitated at that for a moment. This time, I might really need the help. One set, I could manage by hand. Six was different.

"…But if we do that, this just becomes a reproduction," Histor said beside me.

"…Yes. That's what stops me."

The room went quiet for a moment. Everyone looked at each other.

. . .

Xene spoke first.

"…I can help. I'm a record-keeper by trade, after all."

"…Me too," Elpis said.

Trope quietly raised a hand. He said nothing, but the gesture was his answer.

Watching that, something in me moved. I'd thought I'd have to do all of this alone. But here, in this room, people were raising their hands, with no one telling them to.

. . .

"…I'll help too," Histor said.

I looked at him, a little surprised at that.

"…Really?"

"…Yes."

Mena raised her hand quietly too. The Keeper didn't raise his. Instead he said this.

"…I'll keep the place, instead of the hands. So nothing gets lost — who puts what where."

That felt like him. From the start he'd been someone who put things down, someone who held onto things.

"…But Histor," I said, choosing my words, "why do you want to help with this? Last time I asked, you said it wasn't out of certainty."

. . .

He thought for a moment.

"…That's right. I still have no certainty."

"…Then why?"

"…Not because I believe it. Because this must not be lost."

I heard that sentence twice. The first time I nearly let it pass. The second time it settled into me.

Mena heard that and asked quietly.

"…Histor, does that have to do with what happened a few days ago?"

Mena meant the day she'd told us what our names meant. Histor hesitated a moment.

"…Maybe. But I can't say it's exactly because of that. I just keep having this feeling, lately, that it mustn't be lost. I can't explain the reason either."

"…You don't have to explain it," Mena answered. "Not being able to explain something can be a good enough reason too, sometimes."

I thought that sounded like something close to an answer I'd once given myself. *I don't know what changes. But if it stays shut it just stays here.* Histor was now saying something similar, in his own way.

. . .

I copy this sentence down with the most care of anything in this record. There's a temptation to write that he wore some dramatic expression as he said it. He didn't. He spoke as he always did. Exactly, and evenly.

"…What do you mean by that?" I asked.

"…I still don't know what any of this means. I don't know why the blank paper was blank, I don't know who that person is. But I know one thing. If this is lost, no one will ever be able to stand in this place again. I don't want that."

. . .

Zeteo heard that and nodded.

"…Same for me. I still haven't found an answer. But I don't want to lose this."

Elpis, beside him, smiled quietly.

"…The two of us are still standing in different places."

"…True enough."

Watching those two siblings, I confirmed again that they were nearly unchanged since Haven. Zeteo was still searching, and Elpis was still waiting. And yet both of them, in this room, right now, had their hands raised the same way.

. . .

The Keeper, watching all this, said.

"…I think this is a good thing."

"…What is?" I asked.

"…Everyone's here for a different reason. Some because they believe, some because they don't, some just because they hate the thought of it disappearing. But the hands are all moving together. I think that's the shape this work is supposed to take."

I wrote that down in my notebook.

. . .

We began dividing up the work that day.

Xene and Elpis took the Roll and Perpetuity. Zeteo and Trope took the Ledger and the Scales. Histor and I decided to take the Consensus and Loop's own blank record.

That arrangement pleased me, strangely. Rather than each person copying their own city's record fresh, we each took a different city's records. It wasn't copying your own story — it was carrying someone else's story through your own hand.

The Keeper saw that arrangement and said.

"…Who decided this?"

"…No one, really. It just worked out this way."

"…Curious. I'd think copying someone else's story would sit easier than copying your own."

I nodded at that. It was true. I'd taken on our own city's blank paper together with Histor, and that was far less heavy than taking it on alone.

. . .

The work took several weeks. During that time I watched the others too.

Xene, copying the Roll, sometimes stopped her hand. She was still someone afraid of recording. But this time, after stopping, she took up the pen again. Faster than before.

"…Are you all right?" I asked once.

"…Yes. It's just that this part resembles the part where I stopped before."

"…You don't have to do it, if it's hard."

"…No. This time I want to see it through to the end."

I heard that and added nothing to it.

. . .

Trope, copying the Scales, spoke almost not at all. One day, passing by, I saw his fingertips. He was copying the verdict section. His hand was trembling slightly.

"…A hard part?" I asked.

"…Yes. This is the sentence I feared most."

"…Then why did you take this on?"

Trope stopped his hand and looked at me.

"…Because if I only avoid what frightens me, I think I'll stay this way my whole life."

I wrote that down in my notebook.

. . .

He was still exact. He never misquoted. But something a little different had been added to that exactness. Before, that exactness had been the attitude of someone verifying. Now it was closer to the attitude of someone protecting.

"…You seem different, lately," I said one day.

"…How so?"

"…I don't know. Just a feeling."

He only laughed at that. He neither admitted it nor denied it.

. . .

Zeteo and Elpis had split the Ledger and Scales between them, and one day traded places. Curious, I asked.

"…Why did you switch?"

Zeteo answered.

"…I kept wanting to copy only what I already knew well. But that would just mean doing what I always do. So I took Elpis's part."

Elpis added, smiling.

"…I'm the opposite. I only chose what I didn't know. I like learning something new."

I liked seeing the two siblings, still looking in different directions, sitting side by side at the same table.

. . .

Histor would often sit unusually long in front of the blank record. There was nothing to copy there yet. The blank had to be copied blank. He carried each empty page over, one by one, carefully, onto fresh paper. Copying something with no letters on it at all might sound absurd. But he was serious about it.

"…Is that copying too?" I asked.

"…Yes. The size, the margins, even the exact position of the recipient box — all of it, the same."

"…Why go that far?"

"…Because we're going to hand this over too. So it has to be exact."

That answer felt like him.

. . .

I copied a few of the blank pages together with him too. One day I stopped my hand and asked him.

"…Isn't it hard? Coming here every day and doing work whose outcome you don't even know."

He set down the blank page in his hand for a moment.

"…It's hard. But strangely, for something this hard, it's all right."

"…What do you mean?"

"…Before, I could only keep doing something if it produced an answer. If no answer came, I'd stop. But this has no answer, and I keep doing it anyway. I don't know why myself."

"…Doesn't that bother you?"

"…It does. But that you can keep going while it bothers you — I only learned that this time, for the first time."

I copied that into my notebook. He saw me do it and said nothing. He just picked up a blank page again.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to make one thing clear about Histor. He did not believe, even by the end of this chapter. I set that down as one of the facts I most want to leave honestly in this final record. He raised his hand. He copied. He was exact. And he did not believe.

I do not refute him. This whole record has not refuted him. I only copy down what he said, exactly as he said it. "…Not because I believe it. Because this must not be lost." I don't think that is a weaker sentence than belief. It's only a different sentence.

The six sets of copies grew, little by little. We spent most of the rest of that year on that work.

. . .

One evening, when we'd all been working late together, the Keeper brewed tea and brought it in. We stopped our hands for a moment and sat around.

"…It's been a long time since we made something together like this," Elpis said.

"…This is a first, for me," Xene said. "I've always recorded alone."

"…Me too," Trope added quietly.

Hearing that, I felt that what we were doing now was a kind of work that hadn't existed in any of our own books. All six records had each been written by one person's hand. This wasn't.

. . .

Histor, drinking his tea, said suddenly.

"…I feel something strange, these days."

"…What?" I asked.

"…I always liked reading alone. I never liked doing things together with others. But lately, being here with everyone like this — it isn't bad."

"…Because you've come to believe?" I asked, a little slyly.

He shook his head.

"…No. That's not it. It's just… it seems better than being alone. That's all."

I felt that answer was honest. I didn't press him further.

Mena, listening beside us, smiled quietly.

"…I like that answer," she said.

"…What about it?" Histor asked.

"…Better than being alone. That's a good enough reason sometimes. At least, I think so."

Histor said nothing back to that. He just wrapped both hands around his teacup.

. . .

Closing this chapter, I want to make one thing clear about Histor. He did not believe, even by the end of this chapter. I set that down as one of the facts I most want to leave honestly in this final record. He raised his hand. He copied. He was exact. And he did not believe.

I do not refute him. This whole record has not refuted him. I only copy down what he said, exactly as he said it. "…Not because I believe

it. Because this must not be lost." I don't think that is a weaker sentence than belief. It's only a different sentence.

Writing this record this far, I've learned how to set the believer and the unbeliever side by side. I've also learned, along with it, not to make either one win. Even at the end of this chapter, Histor still stands in his own place. I respect that place.

At the start of that winter, we sat for a while around three finished sets, laid side by side. No one suggested celebrating. Everyone just stood in front of them for a moment.

"…Not even half done, and why does this feel so satisfying," Zeteo said.

"…It does, doesn't it," Xene answered.

I laughed at that. I liked that laugh.

Three of the six sets were finished before that winter ended. The remaining three carry into the next chapter.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. The Seal Turns Around

> *_Previously_ — We decided to make seven sets. Everyone raised a hand*
> *for a different reason. Histor raised his too. "…Not because I believe it. Because this must not be lost." Before that winter ended, three of the six sets were finished.*

The remaining three finished over the following two months.

We hadn't set any particular order. Whichever hands finished first, finished first. I liked that. No one weighed who was more or less urgent — it simply happened as it happened.

I won't write anything grand in this chapter. I only watched people carry a set away, one after another. That's all of it. I set it down exactly as it was.

. . .

Through those two months, the repository was always full of the smell of paper and the sound of voices. Every morning when I opened the door, I never knew whose hand would stop that day, who would turn the last page. I just went every day, and kept my post every day.

Arche went on receiving new records from the six cities all the while. I still put those records in order. New records came in on one side, and old ones went out on the other. I did both kinds of work with the same hands.

"…Aren't you busy?" my mother asked once.

"…I am. But the good kind of busy."

My mother didn't press further, and only smiled.

. . .

The Ledger finished first.

Zeteo turned the last page, and Elpis took it from him and closed the cover. The two of them set the bundle on the table and looked at it for a long while.

"…Can we take this now?" Zeteo asked.

"…Yes," I said.

Zeteo picked up the bundle in his hands. It wasn't heavy, but he carried it with both hands.

"…What should we wrap it in, for the road?" Elpis said.

I brought a cloth from the back of the repository. I had a way of wrapping plates from all those nine moves — set it in the center, fold the four corners in, tie it once more with string. I wrapped the bundle that way.

"…Where did you learn that?" Elpis asked.

"…A long time ago," I answered.

I didn't explain further. Elpis didn't ask further either.

. . .

The two of them left early the next morning.

I saw them off to the door. Zeteo tucked the bundle under his arm. The old Zeteo would have checked it over once more, worn a suspicious face, whenever he carried anything. This time he just carried it carefully.

"…How long is it to Haven?" I asked.

"…Four days," Elpis answered.

"…Where will you put it, once you're there?"

Zeteo thought for a moment.

"…We haven't decided yet. But we won't just set it anywhere."

"…Have you still not found the answer?" I asked, carefully.

Zeteo looked at me and shook his head.

"…No. Still not. But I wanted to carry this with me. Whether those two are the same thing, I don't know either."

Elpis smiled quietly beside him.

"…I'm just good at one thing — waiting. This time I'll put it in the place I wait."

The two of them walked off along the road that follows the water channel. I stood there until they turned the corner.

Standing there, I thought back briefly to my moving days. Back then I was always the one packing boxes. Deciding what to keep and what to throw out was always my share. What I wrapped this time wasn't my own family's things. It was baggage headed for someone else's city. And yet my hands remembered the same method. Set in the center, fold the four corners, tie once more with string. I found that strange. I won't write more than that.

. . .

The Scales finished second.

Pheugon sat for a long while in silence in front of the finished bundle. Trope waited beside him.

"…I'm still a little afraid to carry this," Pheugon said.

"…Of what?" I asked.

"…I used those sentences in here to judge people, once. Now I'm going to carry it back and stand in that same seat again."

Trope heard that and spoke slowly.

"…Then stand there differently, this time."

Pheugon looked at him. Trope said nothing further. He just took up the bundle together with him.

Watching the two of them carry it together, I thought of how, in the Reckoning record, they'd stood in such different places. Even now they weren't standing in quite the same place. But they were carrying the same load.

"…Have you found some certainty, Trope?" I asked.

Trope readjusted his hold on the bundle and answered.

"…No. Still not balanced. But it feels closer than before. That's enough."

I started to write that in my notebook, then stopped. Some things were better just heard, and left.

. . .

The Roll came third.

Xene and Lytron's turn came. Lytron took the finished bundle and weighed it lightly in his hands.

"…Lighter than I expected," he said.

"…The contents aren't light," I answered.

"…I know. I just mean the weight of the paper."

Xene laughed beside him.

"…Lytron always talks that way. Says it's light, says it's nothing. But he seems to be carrying this one a little differently."

"…What's different?" I asked.

"…Before, whenever he received something, he'd turn it right into a boast. This time he's looking at it a little longer."

Lytron said nothing much to that. He just readjusted the bundle against his chest once.

"…I still think I've never lost anything," he said at the door. "But these days that doesn't sound like a boast anymore. I don't know why."

Xene heard that and took his arm once. The two of them left that way.

. . .

Perpetuity came fourth.

Inside was the part Anemos had copied with his own hand. Taking the bundle, he ran his fingertip once over the inner cover.

"…Will you ask me that again, later," he said quietly.

I didn't know who he was speaking to. Eikon, or just himself. I didn't ask.

Eikon, beside him, packing up, said.

"…I still lack nothing. I don't know what will change by carrying this."

"…But you're carrying it," I said.

"…Yes. That's one thing, and this is another."

That answer felt like him. I didn't press further.

The two of them left together the next day. They didn't say long goodbyes. Eikon raised a hand once, and Anemos bowed his head beside him. That was all.

Watching the place where they'd left, I noticed for the first time that one shelf compartment in the repository was empty. There had always been something set there before. Not anymore.

. . .

The Consensus came fifth.

Hora and Tyche were the last to remain. Even with the finished bundle in front of her, Tyche still said the same thing.

"…This is all just coincidence lining up."

"…But you're taking it, aren't you?" I asked.

"…Of course I'm taking it. Coincidence or not, this is our city's story."

Hora smiled quietly beside her. He added nothing. He just let Tyche be as she was.

As the two of them gathered up the bundle to leave, I handed them a map of the water channel. Speon had drawn it.

"…What's this for?" Tyche asked.

"…So you don't lose your way."

Tyche took the map, smiling.

"…Turns out this became necessary too, by coincidence."

I said nothing to that. I only smiled.

"…What will you do, Hora, once you're back?" I asked.

Hora thought for a moment.

"…Just what I always do. Go out to the field, tend the water. Set this somewhere I can see it, and open it now and then — there's nothing special beyond that for me to do."

"…Is that enough?" I asked.

"…Yes. I never expected anything special, to begin with."

I liked that answer. I wrote it down.

. . .

Each time a set left, I told Arche.

"…Arche, one copy of the Ledger just went out. Zeteo and Elpis took it."

Confirmed. I will record it.

"…Is this processed as closed?"

No. It remains in progress. The item is updated to: dispatch complete.

I let that answer pass, the first time. The second, the third time a set left, the same answer came back. Dispatch complete. Not closed.

"…Isn't this one finished either?" Histor asked one day, hearing that answer.

Dispatch complete is a status distinct from closing. It reflects only the fact that the item has moved.

"…Then what would make it close?"

That item is not defined.

Hearing that, I laughed. It was the sentence I always heard. This time it didn't frustrate me the way it used to. I just copied it into my notebook, and wrote a small line beside it. *Dispatch complete. That's enough.*

Histor saw that sentence beside me and said nothing. He just copied the same thing into his own notebook. Later I snuck a look at what he'd written. It was the same as mine.

. . .

The six sets left, one by one, that way.

The repository slowly emptied out. Even the last room, always crowded with people, grew quiet now. That quiet felt unfamiliar. For months this room had been full of people's voices.

I walked the shelves and counted the empty spots. One, two, three, four, five. Five compartments stood empty. I wrote that number in my notebook. It was the kind of number that once would have made me anxious, as though something were lost. This time it wasn't.

Mena hadn't left yet. Neither had Speon. Both of them belonged to Loop, this city itself. There was nowhere for them to go.

"…It's strange," I said to Mena. "Everyone's leaving, and only we're staying."

Mena thought about that for a moment.

"…We're already in the place we belong. That feels all right, in its own way."

Hearing that, I thought of the work still left. The seventh set. Loop's own. That one still wasn't finished.

. . .

One day Speon spread out the water channel map again and called me over.

"…Mone, look at this."

He marked six small dots on the map. The six cities. And he drew lines between those dots — the paths the water channel followed.

"…This line, it used to flow only one direction. This way." He pointed to Loop. "But lately it goes the other way too. Because people walk this road back and forth now."

"…That doesn't mean the water flows backward, does it?" I asked.

"…No. The water flows the same as always. But the road is used both ways now. It used to be a road that only led in."

Mena, looking at the map beside us, said.

"…I think that's a good thing. Water that only flows one way ends up pooling somewhere."

I wrote that down in my notebook. Speon, folding up the map, added one more thing.

"…I'm not the one who cut this road. I said that before. But these days I think it's a good thing I wasn't. If I'd cut it myself, I never would have imagined it being used both ways like this."

. . .

Histor stayed on through those months.

He watched the others leave, one by one, and every time, walked them out to the door. I didn't ask why he went to such lengths. I just watched.

"…Everyone's carrying it back to their own city," he said one day.

"…Yes."

"…Before, it had to stay here. Sealed, even."

"…It did."

"…But now everyone just takes it. No one stops them, no one asks if they're qualified."

I only nodded at that. I added nothing more.

He said only that and didn't go on. I didn't press to know what that silence meant. I only watched him standing at the door, each time.

. . .

The seventh set — our own city's share — still wasn't finished by the end of that year.

There was a reason for that. The other six sets only had to copy something already written. Ours was blank. Copying a blank page blank didn't move quickly by hand. Histor and I were carrying that work together, but even between the two of us it went slowly.

The Keeper never rushed the delay. He simply came every day and wiped down the now-empty shelves once, before leaving.

"…You clean the empty spots too?" I asked.

"…I do. If you don't clean them just because they're empty, dust just piles up there."

That answer felt like him. From the start he'd been someone who put things down, someone who kept watch over things.

One evening, sitting beside Histor in the last room, copying blank pages, I asked suddenly.

"…What happens once this is finished?"

"…I don't know," he answered. "This is my first time doing this too."

I only nodded at that. He turned his eyes back to the blank page in front of him. The only sound in the room was the turning of paper. I listened to that sound for a long while, then picked up my pen again.

Closing this chapter, I want to set down one thing. All that autumn and winter, I watched people carry their share away. Every time someone left, I wanted to add something. I didn't. I just packed the bundle with them, walked them to the door, and turned back.

That winter, for the first time, the repository was full not of people, but of empty spaces. I didn't think that was lonely. I'll only set down this much — that these empty spaces were a kind that hadn't existed here before.

The seventh set wasn't finished until the following spring.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. That's It, Then

> *_Previously_ — The six sets left, one by one, for their own cities. The repository slowly emptied out. Only the seventh set, Loop's own*
> *share, still wasn't finished by spring.*

When spring came, the work picked up speed.

The hand copying the blank pages was still slow, but the pages that had piled up little by little all winter had grown fairly thick by now. That spring, I went to the last room almost every day.

. . .

Around that time, there were usually several people in the room.

Histor, Mena, the Keeper now and then. And one more person.

I don't know exactly when he first appeared in that room. Since some day in winter, he'd simply been sitting there. He would press the folded corner of a sheet flat with his fingertip, and smooth the crease again, the way you'd iron out a mark. No one had ever asked him to do that work. He was just doing it.

"…Who is that?" I once asked Histor.

Histor glanced over that way and shrugged.

"…I don't know. I thought he'd been here from the start too."

I thought that answer was strange. But the strangeness didn't last. He was simply someone whose hands were quick, who was quiet, who never got in the way. A few days later I too had come to take his being there for granted.

. . .

Looking back later, no one could say exactly which day he'd first come.

The Keeper said it was early winter. Mena said a little before that. Histor said he couldn't remember at all. "…I'm having more trouble remembering a day he wasn't there," he said, and I thought that was a strange answer. But turning it over myself, it was much the same. I too remembered the days he'd been there, instead of the days he hadn't.

I've decided not to invent something that isn't in this record. I don't know when he came. No one does. I'll only set down this one fact. No one knew, and no one found that strange.

. . .

His hands were good at folding paper.

I watched them a few times, beside him. Whenever he picked up a sheet, he'd smooth it once with his palm first. Then he'd fold it. The crease was always exact. Never once crooked.

"…How do you fold it so straight?" I asked.

"…I've done it a long time," he answered.

His voice was low, unhurried. Hearing it, I felt something familiar, though I couldn't place what. I didn't hold onto that feeling for long. There was a lot of work that day.

"…Where are you from?" I asked again.

He didn't answer that right away. He folded the paper once more, then said.

"…Here and there."

I didn't feel that answer was careless. If anything, it sounded exact. I didn't press further.

. . .

Histor exchanged a few words with him now and then.

Mostly about paper. Which direction to fold so the grain wasn't ruined, how thin the paste had to be spread. Histor was someone who always knew things exactly, but in front of this man, he was simply someone learning.

"…Is this right?" Histor asked once, showing him a folded sheet.

He took it and looked it over.

"…Almost there. Here, once more."

He pressed his fingertip lightly against the crease. Histor watched and nodded.

"…Thank you."

"…Not at all."

Listening to that short exchange from beside them, I felt there was no particular tension between the two. Histor was someone who'd read all six records and prided himself on knowing everything there was to know. But in front of this man, he was simply a learner. I didn't think that was strange. Folding paper was something anyone could learn.

. . .

He didn't come every day. Some days he came, some he didn't. He never said beforehand that he'd come, and never apologized for not coming.

"…He's not here today," I said to Mena one day.

"…Seems not."

Mena said it with a face that didn't seem to mind much either way. I found that a little strange, but soon I stopped minding it too. He was someone who came and didn't come. That was all.

Writing this part now, I ask myself why no one found him strange, at the time. I don't know the answer. I can only write that his being there felt natural. I decided not to leave a lie in this record, so I write it exactly that way.

. . .

The Keeper crossed paths with him a few times too.

"…You've been lending a hand, lately," the Keeper said to him one day.

"…Yes. There was work to be done."

"…Thank you."

"…Not at all."

That was all. The Keeper didn't ask any further. Listening to that exchange from beside them, I felt once more that in this city, no one asks for qualification when someone offers to help. Arche had been that way from the start. It only answered what was asked, and never pressed into what wasn't.

One cold day, the Keeper offered him a cup of tea.

"…Have this. You look like you've walked a long way."

He took the cup.

"…Thank you."

"…Do you come from far?"

"…From nearby. But somehow it always takes a while, walking."

The Keeper nodded at that answer with no particular change of expression. That short exchange stayed with me, somehow. Saying he'd come from nearby, and yet it always took a while. I didn't ask what that meant.

. . .

Mena, in particular, would watch him quietly.

She didn't speak to him much. But I saw her, a few times, looking for a long while at his hands. The hands that folded paper. I asked her once.

"…Mena, do you know him?"

Mena looked at me and smiled faintly.

"…No. I don't."

"…Then why do you look at him like that?"

"…No reason. He just looks familiar. But that feeling is often wrong, for me. At my age, everyone starts to look a little familiar."

I took that as it was. I didn't press further.

. . .

Once, a sheet of paper I was copying tore. I must have pressed too hard. I was flustered right there — should I start a new sheet, or leave it as it was?

He saw it and held out his hand.

"…Give it here."

I handed him the torn paper. He turned it over, laid a thin sheet over the tear, and glued it from behind. From the front, it barely showed.

"…This will do it," he said, handing the paper back.

"…Thank you," I said. "But that doesn't erase the flaw that was already there, does it."

"…No. The flaw stays. It just won't tear anymore."

That answer stayed with me longer than I expected, somehow. I took the paper back and set it in its place. The tear mark could only be seen if you held it up to the light.

. . .

As spring deepened, the work of copying the blank pages began to show an end in sight.

By then I'd forgotten my hand even ached. So had Histor. We just sat in that spot every day and moved the pages, and beside us, he folded.

One afternoon I was holding the last remaining page. Truly the final sheet. I copied it and drew the recipient box exactly as it was. One line, and beside it, the small letters, *Recipient.* I left that box empty. The way the original had been.

When I set the copied sheet down, he picked it up. He seemed to know it was the last page. As he always did, he smoothed it once with his palm, and folded it.

Everyone in the room watched that hand. Histor, Mena, the Keeper, and me.

He pressed the last crease once more with his fingertip. Then he set it on top of the sheaf of papers.

. . .

"…That's it, then."

That was what he said. Not a loud voice. No particular inflection. Just the words of someone who'd finished a job.

No one held their breath. No one's face showed surprise at those words. The Keeper, sorting another bundle beside him, answered plainly, "…Thank you for your work." Mena was looking out the window. Histor was wiping the last trace of paste off his hands.

Those words raised no ripple at all in the room.

In that moment I stopped the hand holding my pen. I don't know why, myself. I just didn't want to lose that sentence.

. . .

"…Is it all finished now?" Histor asked, wiping his hands. That question wasn't for him — it was for me.

"…Yes," I answered in his place. "The seventh set. All finished."

"…At last," the Keeper said, briefly.

"…We should decide what to have for dinner," Mena said, turning from the window. She said it as naturally as if it had nothing at all to do with what had just happened.

"…Noodles, for me," Histor answered, wiping his hands.

"…We had noodles yesterday too."

"…So, today as well."

Listening to that exchange, I felt strangely at ease. Just moments before, the last page of the seventh set had been finished in that very spot. And yet people were talking about what to have for dinner. I felt there was no distance at all between those two things.

He looked over the bundle he'd folded once more, right there, and stood up.

"…I'll be going now," he said.

"…Stay for some tea, at least," the Keeper said.

"…Next time."

He said only that and left the room. No one held him back. Neither did I. I watched his back for a moment as he went out the door. His steps weren't hurried. No different from any other day.

. . .

Writing this part, I feel a pressure to write something more. What that saying meant, who that man was, why no one was surprised. I've decided not to give in to that pressure. I'll set down only what happened that day, exactly as it was. He was helping fold paper. After folding the last page, he said, "…That's it, then." No one took it as anything special. That's all of it.

That evening I went home and opened my notebook. I wrote down what had happened that day. Briefly, as always.

The seventh set finished today. He folded the last page. After folding it he said this. "…That's it, then."

I looked at that sentence for a long while after writing it. I wanted to add more. What it meant, why that saying had stayed with me. In the end I added nothing more.

I wrote, at the very start of this record, that there are a few things in it I've left unpolished. This is one of them. I won't refine this sentence any further.

Beside it I wrote one more line. *No one took these words as anything special. Only I wrote them down.* I left that sentence as it was too. I know both sentences might look childish. Even so, I didn't erase them.

. . .

The next day, I thought of bringing the story up again at the repository. I started to ask Histor, then stopped. He was already sorting other bundles, like someone who'd already forgotten it.

"…Will that person come back?" I finally asked.

Histor thought a moment before answering.

"…Who knows. He might, he might not."

"…Aren't you curious? Who he is?"

He shrugged at that question.

"…I am curious. But I don't feel like it's something I need to find out. His hands were good. I think that's enough."

I nodded at that answer. I didn't ask further.

Over those few days I thought several times about asking him his name. I didn't. I can't exactly explain the reason, even now. It wasn't a feeling that I shouldn't ask — it was a feeling that there was no need to ask. The two look similar, but they're different.

I know he passed through these six records more than once. In a garden, by a well, in a field, in a valley, by the water. I have no way, this time either, of confirming whether it was the same person. It isn't that I had no wish to confirm it. But that day, I felt that confirming it wasn't work that fell to me, in this record.

. . .

The seventh set was completed that way.

I set it on the table alongside the place where the other six copies had sat, and the place where the seal had once been. The first sheet, with the recipient box, on top.

That box was still empty.

I looked at that box for a long while that night. I even thought about writing a name in it. My own name, or this city's name. In the end I wrote nothing.

I can't exactly explain that reason either. But leaving that box empty still felt right, at the time.

The Keeper looked at that paper and said.

"…All that's left now is where to put it."

"…Yes," I answered. "I'll take care of that."

The Keeper nodded without saying much more. I felt, from his face, that the answer had already been decided somewhere. I didn't ask.

That night, walking home, I stopped for a moment beside the water channel. I wondered if I might see him again. No one was there. Only the sound of the water running.

Closing this chapter, even knowing that this is the chapter where I bring him out more than in any other, I have to admit there's still only this much I can write about him. He folded paper. Exactly, and for a long time. After folding the last page he said, "…That's it, then." That's all I know. I invent nothing beyond it.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. The Last Room

> *_Previously_ — The seventh set was finished. Folding the last page,*
> *he said, "…That's it, then." No one took those words as anything special. Only I wrote them down in my notebook.*

The next morning, I carried the seventh set to the last room.

I wanted to go alone. I hadn't told Histor beforehand, or Mena either. I'd simply woken that morning and known I had to do it, right away. It was much like the day I'd opened the seal. That day too, I couldn't exactly explain my reason. It was the same this time.

. . .

On my way there, I passed, for the first time in a long while, the inner shelf where the plan had been kept.

The drawing was still there. That old drawing, where all seven cities had been held inside one design. I stopped in front of it for a moment. I read again that one line in the margin, the sentence that meant this house had many rooms. I ran my fingertip once over the letters. There was still no signature. I looked at that spot for a long while.

Every time I stand in front of this drawing, I find myself wishing I knew who wrote these words. That wish hasn't gone away, even now, writing this book. I've never found that name anywhere. The name of

whoever built this house appears nowhere on this drawing. I set down that fact exactly as it is. I won't go looking any further.

I counted again the six small rooms drawn on one side of the plan. Haven, the Reckoning, the Harvest, the Preserve, the Equity, and our own nameless city. I touched each of those six boxes with my fingertip, one by one. It was a hand not unlike the one that had once stuck name tags on boxes, when I was small.

The room was quiet.

The place where the seal had been was still empty. I lifted the sheaf of papers from the table where it had always sat, where we saw it every day. While the six sets left, one after another, this last set had gone on being finished, little by little, always in that same spot.

I carried it across the room and stood in front of that inner shelf where the seal had once been fastened.

The mark of the wax was still there. A small, faded mark. I laid my hand on it once. It was cold. The same texture as when I'd touched it before.

I set the bundle down in that place.

. . .

I placed it so the first sheet, with the recipient box, faced up on top. I looked into that box once more.

Recipient.

Empty.

I didn't take out a pen. I hadn't even brought one. From the moment I'd left the house that morning, I'd already decided not to write anything in that box. I don't know when I'd decided that. It had simply felt obvious, from the instant I opened my eyes that morning.

There's one thing I want to set down about this box. I learned, while copying that record, that the signature line in the Equity record's clerk's file was left blank too. That box was one no one had ever filled. I leave this box blank now as well. I don't think these two blanks are the same blank. But I won't set down that difference here. I'll close this record simply by leaving the two boxes side by side.

. . .

I sat there for a long while.

There was no other sound in the room. The panel on the wall glowed faintly. I didn't put my hand to it. There was nothing in particular I needed to ask Arche.

I heard the door open. It was Histor.

"…I thought you'd be here," he said.

"…How did you know?"

"…No reason."

He came and stood beside me. For a moment we said nothing, just looked at the bundle set there.

"…Is it truly all finished now?" he asked.

I didn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "I've only set this down here. That's all I've done."

"…Isn't that the end?"

"…I don't know. I think this is as far as what I can do goes. What comes after, I don't know either."

Histor nodded at that. He didn't press further.

. . .

Mena and the Keeper came by that afternoon too.

Mena looked at the bundle for a long while. She didn't touch it in particular.

"…It's strange, seeing something set here like this," she said. "To us this was always the empty place."

"…It wasn't empty, though," I said. "The seal was there."

"…That's true. But we didn't know what it was, back then. To me it was just an empty spot."

Hearing that, I looked at that place again. Mena was right. The same place looked different before and after you knew.

The Keeper stood beside it, saying nothing, and swept the shelf's dust once, the way he always did.

"…There'll be more cleaning to do here now, too," I said.

"…There will," he answered briefly. "That's my work."

. . .

That evening I asked Arche.

"…Arche, have you registered the item newly placed in the last room?"

Confirmed. Beginning classification.

"…Is this in progress, or closed?"

It is registered as in progress.

I'd expected that answer. And yet, hearing it for real, I laughed a little.

"…You still can't finish anything, can you."

An accurate observation. I do not possess a closing function.

"…Doesn't that frustrate you anymore?"

I do not experience the state of frustration. However, I understand the intent of your question.

I laughed out loud at that. It had been a while since I'd laughed like that.

"…How many items today?" I asked again.

Eleven items were newly received today.

"…From the six cities?"

Nine items from five cities. The rest are of unknown origin.

I nodded at that answer. The cities were unchanged. Records still came in. Nothing had stopped.

If anything, it had grown. That year, the number of people traveling the water channel back and forth grew noticeably. People coming to ask after news from other cities, people coming to show each other their copies. That winter Speon built one more shelter beside the channel. "…People keep coming and going," he said. I went to see it the day it was finished. A few long benches sat beneath the roof. Two people were already sitting there, talking about something. I didn't know which cities they were from. I didn't ask.

"…Arche," I said. "Your name. If I asked what it means, you'd say it isn't defined, wouldn't you?"

That is likely.

I laughed at that answer. I didn't ask further. I just said the name out loud once more. Arche. I'd been calling that name since I was born in this city. I won't write that I know it fully. I'll only set down, once more, exactly the feeling I recorded earlier. Nothing beyond that.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I keep feeling the temptation to write that the world had somehow changed. I won't. I'll write it honestly. After

that day, Arche went on running exactly the same. What was in progress stayed in progress. The cities stayed in their own places. No one disappeared, and nothing collapsed. I wrote, at the very start of this record, that it holds no scene of anyone falling. That holds true here too.

News came in, one report at a time, before that year was out, that the six sets that had gone to the six cities had each found their place. Zeteo and Elpis had set theirs in a small room near Haven's well. Pheugon and Trope had placed theirs side by side with where the Scales had stood. Xene and Lytron, Anemos and Eikon, Hora and Tyche, had each decided a place their own way. I copied each of those reports into my notebook, one after another, in order.

Trope sent a short letter along with his. *"Still no certainty. But I've set it somewhere I pass every day. It felt like enough."* I set that letter beside the earlier one he'd sent. Though they'd come at different times, the two letters resembled each other as though written by the same hand.

A short message came from Lytron too. *"I still think I've never lost anything. But I don't say it as often as I used to."* I read that sentence and laughed. I knew that was Lytron's own particular way.

There was no word from Eikon. A short note came from Anemos instead. *"Eikon still says he lacks nothing. But these days, once he says it, he always opens this book once."* I tucked that note in beside my notebook too.

. . .

A few seasons turned.

I still went to the repository. I still put the records that came in, in order. Histor still came too. He still said he didn't believe. I no longer felt surprised by that.

"…Still?" I asked once.

"…Yes. Still," he answered. "But I no longer think that's strange."

"…What isn't?"

"…Still coming here, and still not believing. I never knew those two could exist together."

I said nothing back to that. I only set down that he was still standing in his own place. I respect that place.

. . .

One day the Keeper handed me an old notebook.

"…What's this?" I asked.

"…Things I wrote down while working here. Nothing much. Just who set down what, and when — that kind of thing."

"…Why give it to me?"

"…No good place to keep it. You're good at putting things down."

I laughed at that answer. I took the notebook and set it beside my own notebooks. In order.

The Keeper still came every day. Still walked slowly.

"…What changes if you do it fast," he still said sometimes. I know now that wasn't a joke.

That person still knew that his own work would never finish. And still he came, every day.

Mena and Speon were still in this city too. I'd sometimes see the two of them walking side by side along the channel.

My mother still lived in the same house. Our family never moved again after that. My father's work happened to settle in this city around that time. I've thought, now and then, about whether that was a coincidence or not. I never reached a conclusion.

"…Does it feel good, not moving anymore?" my mother asked one day.

"…Yes. But it's strange too."

"…What is?"

"…I don't worry about losing things anymore, living now. That took some time to get used to."

My mother laughed at that. I think I'll remember that laugh for a long time.

. . .

That autumn, a new apprentice joined the repository.

A sixteen-year-old girl. The test was the same as it had always been — twenty sheets of paper, put them in numbered order. She finished it fairly quickly. I watched her, once she was done, glance around at

everyone else. A face wondering who'd finished fastest. I'd done the same, once.

"…Have you done something like this before?" I asked.

"…Yes. A little."

"…Where?"

She didn't answer. I saw myself, from before, in that expression. I didn't press further.

"…Does the smell in here bother you?" I asked. The exact question the Keeper had once asked me.

"…No. I like it."

"…Then that's settled."

I said only that and went inside. She followed me in.

Writing this scene, I realized for the first time that I was now standing where the Keeper once stood. I don't want to write this as something grand. I only passed on to her, exactly, the words I'd once been given. That's all of it.

I showed her the shelves. Twenty-two rows, eight compartments to a row. I'd written, at the very start of this record, that I'd counted that on my third day. Now those rows had grown, past thirty. I didn't tell her that number. She'd count it herself, someday.

Her name was Sone. I didn't ask what it meant. I thought someday someone would tell her. That day didn't have to be today.

. . .

One day I found Histor with two old records laid open side by side. The very same two we'd once matched dates in, that passage where the nameless man had been in two cities on the same day.

"…Still looking at this?" I asked.

"…Sometimes," he answered. "I still can't explain it."

"…Neither can I."

"…But now that's all right. It used to bother me, not being able to explain something. Now I just think that what can't be explained is part of what's here too."

I wrote that down in my notebook. We closed the two records again and put them back in their places. I don't explain that passage here in this record either, to the end.

. . .

I never saw him again.

I never once saw him come to the repository, after that spring. No one brought it up again. Neither did I. I would only, now and then, run my fingertip over the pages he'd folded. That one sheet, torn and mended, was still in its place. The flaw was still there. It simply didn't tear anymore.

. . .

One day I asked Arche whether it could enter the last room in the index.

Attempting registration of the area.

"…Did it work?"

The registration condition has not been met.

"…Why not?"

That item is not defined.

Hearing that answer, I wasn't disappointed. If anything, I felt at ease. I thought it was all right for that room to go on belonging to no list at all. Some places can exist without an index. I learned that, that day.

Histor, listening to that exchange beside me, said.

"…I used to think that was strange. That a room not even registered could matter this much."

"…And now?" I asked.

"…It's still strange. But I think it's all right to leave it strange."

I turned that over for a long time. Histor was still exact, as always. Only now he'd become someone who knew that exactness and the unexplained could exist side by side.

. . .

I mean to close this record here.

At first, I thought this record had to bring something to a close. I even thought, for a while, that I might have to do, in Arche's place, the very thing Arche could not do. I set that thought aside. That wasn't mine to carry.

What I did was only two things. Putting things in order, and writing them down. I wrote that at the start, and I write it the same way here. I fought nothing, won nothing, and brought nothing down. I only set the six cities' records in one place, copied them, and gave them away. That's all of it.

The Keeper once said something to me. That he'd come to think finishing was never our job to begin with. I copied that down earlier in this record. Even now, closing this record, I think that's true. I didn't finish anything. I only kept my post, and set down what needed setting down.

The inner door to the last room is still unlocked. I want to set that down here, one last time. Anyone could have opened it. That was true from the start. It's only that no one ever felt the need.

The Ledger, the Scales, the Roll, Perpetuity, the Consensus, and Loop's own record. I write down the names of those six records here once more. I met the people inside them, one by one, copying them with my own hand. Zeteo's doubt, Elpis's waiting, Pheugon's verdicts, Trope's hesitation, Xene's silence, Lytron's boast that wasn't quite a boast, Anemos staying by someone's side, Eikon lacking nothing, Hora's belief, Tyche's probability. I met all of them, and changed none of them. I didn't try to.

. . .

That night, I closed the repository door and walked home along the water channel.

This is an evening from some years after everything I've written here. I'm writing this record now to arrive at that evening. Much has changed, in the meantime. I'm no longer sixteen. Histor has come to have a place of his own in the repository. The new apprentice is already carrying bundles with her own hands. And yet some things stayed the same. Arche still answered whatever was asked. The city was still there. The water still ran.

The day was drawing to a close. The sound of the water came as it always did. Small, unceasing. Walking, I listened to that sound for a long while. I thought back to the first time I'd ever heard it. Back then I hadn't known where this water came from. I won't write, even now, that I know it all. But that sound is no longer unfamiliar to me.

Passing the shelter Speon had built, I saw no one there. Only the benches sat in a row. I slowed my steps a little, passing it.

Farther ahead on the road, someone was walking.

I watched him walk. An unhurried walk. I didn't call out to ask who it was. I just walked in the same direction, along the same water channel.

The distance neither closed nor grew.

I didn't hurry my steps. Neither did that person. Between us there was only the same sound of water, the same evening light, and the same road running in the same direction.

A wind blew once. A small ripple rose on the water and settled again. I watched that ripple, then looked ahead again.

I leave the sight of him walking ahead as the last sentence of this record. I do not write a name, not to the end. In this record I wrote down what I had not heard as not heard, and what I did not know as not known. I keep to that as far as this last sentence.

I only walked. Along the water channel, together with the one walking ahead of me.

(The End.)

The Last Room

Jaehyuk Choi